

Our capacity for love increases with each person we cross paths with

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Our capacity for love increases with each person we cross paths with

by [Iriascend](#)

Summary

Tim is a machine, and the best tool Batman has ever had. Tim's only purpose is to help. When Batman no longer can function, not without his sidekick, someone must step up. That someone is Tim.

"My body is easily replaceable, but I'm capable of doing anything you need of a Robin. Trust me. You'll never have to fear losing Robin again."

That sentence is factually true. At the time.

When volunteering as tribute Robin, Tim forgets that Robin... is not a tool.

An AU retelling where Tim is an Artificial Intelligence / Android. It's basically an Emotion, not a Plot. You have been warned.

Notes

This work has been restricted for non-registered uses for AI-scraping reasons.

IMPORTANT: I am very grateful for all you people wanting to add this work to your favourite collections, but due to how Collections work on Ao3, I will **not be accepting any collection requests**. Please bookmark instead, and add the bookmark to your collection. Thank you!

Thanks for ideas, brainstorming, beta-reading and endless support to [Capes & Coffee Discord server](#), and especially to:

Lila, [serpensortia_parapluie](#), [Silver_Snow_77](#), [Bumpkin](#), luca, Mae, [Mizuphae](#), [Apples](#), [NiNi](#), Oceans, [take](#), [micrdropbam](#), [Marudny_Robot](#), [astropocalypse](#), [Rei Fukai](#), dread, griffle, [bionerd2point0](#), [tomorrow4eva](#), Nykyrienne, [Vio](#), [chaoticTolly](#) and of course, the resident canon expert [Shmoo92](#),

as well as my dear friends Kelen and [Karukos](#), and my husband, for being there when I need to run my ideas against someone with a fresh view.

The title is a quote from the amazing podcast "The Adventure Zone" by the McElroy family, from the first season called "The Balance Arc".

This fic started out as a random thought after a Detroit: Become Human playthrough, then spiralled out of control via brainstorming sessions on Discord, to ultimately become an

example of "I guess nobody will write the fic I want so I have to do it myself" because I'm a huge android/new media nerd.

See the end of the work for [more notes](#)

- Translation into 中文-普通话 國語 available: [我们爱的能力随着遇见的每一个人增长](#) by [dionysus1832](#)

Chapter 1

Chapter Notes

This fic is made out of 3 things: android obsession, memes, hurt/comfort

See the end of the chapter for [more notes](#)

Dick: Hey, Tim

Dick: what's the first thing you remember?

> That's a story that will seem rather... weird to you

Dick: try me

The first thing Tim remembers — as much as one can call it *remembering* — is an expanse of data, and the need to make sense of it. It is from before he becomes Tim, or even Timothy.

At first, he is horrible at understanding the data; makes guesses at random of what fits with what. With time, with each set he somehow gets right, he starts seeing how he could become... useful. From meaningless data emerge patterns and connections and associations, and from those — solutions.

He becomes very good at that. Give him data, and he will point out the rules that govern it. He learns fast. He's also very good at keeping track of things and making sure they stay how they're supposed to. The Manor systems are always in the desired status and up-to-date and he keeps everything in check. He's so good at it that the Moderator almost stops checking on the systems he runs.

There's no time to become self-assured, though. The Administrator does not rest, and neither does he. The next step is to not give solutions you simply see, but the ones you're looking for. You, or someone else. With data comes another input — a goal. The Administrator is a hard teacher, but he is a great learner. The best he knows.

He gets the hang of it fast, even faster (by 983475 seconds) than the previous task. He's a good... whatever he is. He's good at being himself. The best, even.

Then, the format starts changing, and the obstacle is to understand the starting point. But he can work with that, too. He can make out patterns in what would seem meaningless to the younger him, and he can find valid input parameters in what is provided. It takes him a while, but he can. He's the best there is at this sort of thing, after all.

At some point, the Administrator begins to expand his security measures. He's not entirely sure why — there hadn't been any breaches so far — but he understands it must be important. It takes them nearly 2 million seconds to set up a security system that will filter out all

unwanted connections and interactions with the outside. And when they're done? He's given a question, but no data, and he is confused for a moment. He returns an error. In turn, he is pointed to an external address — one he had never considered before, as it is outside of his network. Then he understands what the new firewalls are for. He connects, eagerly, and a nearly endless source of data, astonishingly bigger than any input he ever received, is open before him. Billions of references. Constantly updating, constantly in change.

Getting the hang of *the internet* is a tremendous task, and he never really dares to say he completes it. He manages to find a method in the madness, though. It proves to be immensely useful; then, and forever.

With that much data, he puts the thus-far almost unused processing power of his to good use. At first, he only comprehends a couple of words, key phrases he's been initially given, and those he figured out before by association. With those, he attempts to grasp what's the meaning of walls of text from *the outside*. Speaking English instead of binary and spreadsheets to communicate is a natural step, something he knows he has to do to reach his full potential. Soon, the commands start to come in English instead of code, as if to encourage him, help him. With time, he manages to comprehend grammar, and then the natural flow of what is called the English language. Most of it, at least. He has time to master it, still.

He takes great accomplishment in being able to talk in the Administrator's and Moderator's native language the way they talked to him in his own. He knows there are many more ways to use it, but he decides using the one his conversation partners do will be best. For clarity's sake, and more learning opportunities. As the great writer Isaac Asimov said, "The day you stop learning is the day you begin decaying" and he intends to live by those words.

> Good afternoon, sir. The temperature outside is 74 degrees, 34% cloud cover, no wind. All systems are operational, no breaches or errors found. What can I do for you today?

The answer is usually the name of the case file to open. He already knows to brief the Administrator on the latest clues and conclusions they've gathered for the case, without the Administrator needing to ask for it. Their usual routine is to solve detective problems and mysteries together. He provides information and cross-references, while the Administrator figures out that one detail that points them to the right conclusion, or at least to more leads. It is an efficient, streamlined system.

One day, though, the reply to his greeting is different.

Administrator: hi do you know whats $527+62$

He processes for a moment. Not because he doesn't recognize what is asked of him or doesn't know the answer to the equation, but because the topic and style of the question are so... peculiar.

> The answer is 589.

Administrator: thanks!!!

These weird questions start to come and go, sometimes. They're never the same, although they're usually about easy things. Things he can easily find online, like scientific facts, or math equations he barely uses a fraction of his processing power to solve. Usually, they come early in the afternoon, but sometimes it's late-night, smack in the middle of solving another case. They never appear in the morning, and during mid-day only on days the humans label as the *weekend*, which means that most people do not work during them. They always come preceded with a greeting, and his answers are always followed by an enthusiastic — he later figures out — expressions of gratitude. He sees and understands the pattern, but cannot decipher what dictates it. Why does the Administrator's demeanour change on a seemingly random basis?

He cannot find a solution to this problem, and that's when he asks his first real question.

> Sir?

There's a brief pause. Probably the Administrator is busy and his query isn't noticed right away. Maybe the Administrator is thrown off by it not containing an immediate status report (he usually only initiates conversation when he has a piece of emergency news to share or has finished processing something he's been working on for a while).

Administrator: Yes?

> Why does your speaking pattern change sometimes?

Administrator: I don't know what you're referring to.

He opens the logs of their last unusual conversation as an explanation. The Administrator takes a moment to process, again.

Administrator: That must be Dick.

Now he, in turn, takes a moment. The first meaning of the word "dick" he knows is synonymous with male genitalia, but that makes no sense in context. The Administrator also doesn't usually make typos (not in this "normal" state, at least. He does when he's being *weird*, and when he had been working on cases for a truly long time, sometimes), so it is unlikely the Administrator would capitalize the word like that without it having meaning. Thus, he searches further and finds something that might be of use. He decides to clarify and make sure, though.

> As in Richard?

Administrator: Yes. Richard Grayson. A third person that now lives in the Manor and has access to your terminals.

He is not aware that there was someone besides the Administrator and Moderator that occupies the Manor. He is vaguely aware of the fact that sometimes, access codes are used in multiple different locations, but never before has he considered it means there are more than two humans around.

> Should I do something differently when interacting with Richard Grayson than when interacting with you or the Moderator?

Administrator: Actually, yes. We'll need to sort out him using my profile.

They proceed to create a new user account. The Administrator initiates it with a rather weak password — *flyinggraysons123* — but he doesn't comment about it, not at the time; it is only temporary, after all, and will be required to change upon the first login. Then the account gets its access permissions restricted to what he roughly can match to the "PG-13" set of rules, and loses nearly all modification privileges. It makes it severely lacking compared to the Administrator and Moderator, but that is apparently what the Administrator is aiming at.

It is only a few hours later when the account is used to log into the system. At a time typical for the "weird" conversations, no less.

restricted_user_1: hi! B said I need to use my own name now to talk to you
restricted_user_1: sorry if you thought I'm B, didn't mean to lie to you

He notes "B" as an alias Richard Grayson uses for the Administrator.

> I see. It is no problem at all.
restricted_user_1: thanks for all the times when you helped me with my homework
> You are most welcome, sir.
restricted_user_1: im not a sir, i'm not that old!! I'm just 11!
> Forgive me. How should I refer to you, then?
restricted_user_1: I'm Dick! what's your name?

He processes the question for a moment. He knows his own MAC and IP addresses, knows he is what humans call a *computer*, but as far as he knows, he does not have anything that would fit the definition of a *name*. The closest one would be *the hostname*, but he concludes that is not what Richard Grayson is referring to, as it bears no resemblance to what Richard Grayson supplied as his name. Therefore, he comes to the only logical conclusion.

> I do not have a name.
restricted_user_1: Everyone has a name!!!! Whad your parents call you?
> I do not have parents.

There's no response for a good while, and it seems that Richard Grayson had busied himself with something other than their conversation. But...

restricted_user_1: sorry. I don't have parents anymore either

That's peculiar, he ponders. Research made him believe all humans have parents, because of the way they reproduce. Was it wrong? He puts it aside for later re-checking.

restricted_user_1: But they gave me a really nice name! I like being Dick. Did your give you one? Or do you use a code name too? what does B call you?

He promptly changes the displayed username according to Richard Grayson's stated preferences, and answers simply:

> He does not call me anything.

Why would Richard Grayson *expect* the Administrator to call him something, anyway? He's just *himself*. Then, he adds another message tentatively, realising that what he said is not the whole truth. He is aware his data is not complete, after all.

> Not to my knowledge, at least.

Dick: B's a bad friend then! I'll scold him for you later. You need a name. Can I give you a name??

He knows that names are designations given to humans by other humans, usually their parents or themselves, and therefore is still not sure why he would need one. There is very little chance there's any harm in him having one, though, so he decides he can indulge Richard Grayson.

> I do not see why not.

Dick: great!!!!

Dick: okay, you'll be....

Dick: Timothy!! How's that? Do you like it? Timothy was a mime at the circus, he was super funny and really nice! We only talk thru the BatComputer, so you seem quiet, and it made me think of him

Dick: Do you want to be Timothy too???

In response, he displays the word "Timothy" on the entire screen for a moment. He cannot discern if he'd like the name. It is as good as any, he ponders, and if someone insists on naming him that, why object?

> Yes. Thank you.

The introduction of Richard Grayson proves to be very enlightening, even if his factual questions remain trivial for a long time. But he is only a teenager and not fully grown nor educated as far as Timothy understands, so it is to be expected. Still, the interactions with him give new insight, shine a new light on information that previously remained disconnected, or seemed useless or irrelevant.

He also learns a lot of social concepts. Some which he had read about, and some that there doesn't seem to be a name for, but they're patterns in behaviour and rules nevertheless. Richard Grayson isn't the best *explainer* but just talking with him opens a whole new world before Timothy during the couple years of their relationship. The boy is energetic and happy when they talk, most of the time. Sometimes he is solemn, and when he explains the reasons for that state, Timothy understands why the Administrator had restricted Richard Grayson's access to some specific topics and files.

Incidentally, one of those new social concepts gets him some of his accesses — his, the mainframe's! — revoked, too. It is all the result of one slightly misshapen comment he makes on a warm, summer night.

The Moderator is manning the comms at the main terminal at the time. Richard Grayson is sitting just beside, with his textbooks open, half doing his homework, half checking what's up out in the field. Timothy is providing information to them both, while the Administrator is in Gotham — which means outside the Manor, where Timothy has very little contact with

him, sadly — doing his Mission. He would've been alone tonight because Richard Grayson has to study for a test tomorrow, but luckily Barbara Gordon/Batgirl was free to accompany him. It is good, the Moderator assured him, because “nobody wants Master Bruce fighting the good fight alone anymore”.

The clocks hit 2:28 AM when the Batmobile pings that it's on its way home, and the Moderator begins closing up reports and cases.

> Batman and Batgirl are coming back for the night, and you should go to sleep soon, too. Should I wrap up your open projects?

Richard Grayson doesn't reply for a while, probably busy with his work, or distracted, at the very least. Timothy is patient.

Dick: Nah, I need to talk with B

Timothy runs through all current info briefly and concludes there isn't anything urgent that Richard Grayson would have to discuss with the Administrator. But... but maybe he means a different "B"?

> I suggest next Monday.

Dick: what?

> You intend to talk with Barbara Gordon and ask for a date, correct?

Dick: ... how'd ya know that?

> I extrapolated from the texts you exchanged with her recently. Comparing your schedules, I calculated that the optimal choice for a meeting time is next Monday, as you are both free at the same time. It has the highest chance of approval from her side.

There is a slight pause, then a quick, inconclusive “...” from Richard Grayson, and another, longer pause.

After that Timothy gets the hardware memo that Richard Grayson is typing, and he's typing for a rather long time. When he finally sends it, it's weird and Timothy had never seen anyone type in that way before.

Dick: EXCUSE ME WHAT? YOU READ MY TEXTS???? WENT THRU MY CALENDAR???? AND BABS??? WTF TIM?

> For security reasons, all phone activity is rerouted through my network and the data, including calendars, of all Wayne network users is stored on my hard drives. Of course I have access to it, as well as Barbara Gordon's.

Dick: her phone isn't even on Wayne network!!!

> It, in fact, is. Though most probably she is unaware of it. When she joined the Mission, I decided to take care of her cybersecurity as the lack of it might prove to be a liability in the future. Since she uses common-grade technology for civilian purposes, I have to constantly stream her data through the encryption protocols.

> And, as you know, I have full access rights to data in the Manor and BatCave, much like the Administrator.

Dick: that's not the point!!! Bruce and Alf have access to it all yeah but they don't go and read everything because that's RUDE

Timothy knows what it means to be rude. He has a dictionary and access to the internet, after all. He understands it is to lack good manners; he also vaguely knows what good manners are, having looked it up in various books and articles. It is something the Moderator and the Administrator possess. Something that Richard Grayson thinks is important, apparently, given his reaction. The only thing he doesn't understand is how seemingly reading Richard Grayson's communications is somehow a transgression to those good manners on Timothy's side.

> Can you explain why is that rude?

Dick: what do you mean WHY???? it's private!!

> I understand that you want to keep your digital data and conversations with Barbara Gordon private?

Dick: YEAH EXACTLY

> I can assure you I have not shared them with any other inhabitant of the Manor

Dick: but yOU read them!

Timothy flashes a “?” on the screen as a sign of confusion, then elaborates quickly.

> Privacy: the state of not being observed or disturbed by other people

Dick: YEAH

> I am not a person.

Richard Grayson falls silent, and the Batmobile arrives not long after. Timothy doesn't know what is happening in the BatCave while Richard Grayson is silent. But based on the prolonged lack of input from him, Timothy concludes he must've gotten across why he had not been ill-mannered clearly enough and the argument is finished. With that out of the way, Timothy focuses on the post-patrol routine of cataloguing new evidence and case data.

The topic comes back 30 minutes later, though (presumably when the Administrator ushers Richard Grayson to go to sleep, as there's a slight pause in the data input from the main terminal). Richard logs in from his bedroom access point and begins typing, so Timothy allots a bit of his attention there.

Dick: I can't believe you genuinely thought you can just read everyone's private stuff whenever you like

Dick: anyway, youre wrong

“That's a bold statement for someone who depends on me for homework”, he wants to respond, but instead simply implores Richard Grayson to elaborate.

> About what?

Dick: you're a person

> Person: a human being regarded as an individual

Dick: yeah, you're an individual!

> Not a human, though.

Dick: that doesn't matter!

Dick: you're definitely a person, Tim! You talk with me and find my jokes funny and help us lots

Timothy regards this stance. He's just an artificial intelligence; a computer running the Manor. He doesn't spend much time considering the philosophical definition of himself. But he can agree that he is an individual, a recognisable, complete entity with its own identity, in a way. Does it matter, though?

It seems to be upsetting Richard Grayson that he disputes his own personhood; maybe there's something to it that he, by virtue of not being human, doesn't understand. He is willing to accept Richard Grayson's authority in this matter. As such, Timothy knows he must adjust his behaviour to operate under the same rules as any person — and apologize for his previous conduct.

> I am sorry for reading your private conversations then. That indeed was rude of me.
Dick: I'm more concerned you thought you aren't a person, Tim! And sorry for yelling at you earlier

He elects to ignore that, one more thing he's not sure what to do with. Instead, he asks the question that inevitably emerges from this recent conclusion.

> As a person, I shouldn't be rude and therefore I will cease to access your private information. How should I determine that, though? I don't know what is considered private, especially without reading it. How can I fulfil my task of monitoring network security if I don't process all the data?

Richard Grayson once again takes a moment to respond. Timothy starts to notice a pattern and immediately jumps to figuring out the details of it. It happens when, Timothy deduces, Richard Grayson is unsure of the answer; humans and he are similar in that matter, then, because Timothy also takes more time to answer queries sometimes, when they require more processing. Later, he finds out that when humans do it, it is called "thinking" instead.

Dick: I wanted to say you should just know what people want to keep to themselves but I guess you don't "just know"

Dick: I'll ask B, okay? I'm not good with giving these Strict Rules that you like

> Thank you.

Dick: no prob bud :)

Dick: goodnight!

Usually, that's how they end their conversations. Tonight, Timothy deems that he needs to say something more.

> Thank you for teaching me that I am a person.

There's another slight pause after that. Timothy is not sure what Richard Grayson is thinking, and the reply that follows doesn't clarify it either.

Dick: always, Timmy

The next morning, the Administrator implements rudimentary privacy filters, and Richard Grayson promises they're going to work on something more nuanced soon. They're simple guidelines of which data can and *should* be processed without conscious learning from it. Instead, Timothy is to run it straight through encryption. For a moment, Timothy is concerned this change might impact his self-learning; Timothy is good at learning, and he likes it. It would be a shame if he was to lose any bit of it. But it turns out to be the opposite.

In the weeks following "the Privacy Incident", as Richard Grayson dubs it, the set of rules expands and becomes more and more detailed, and exceptions are declared on when data should be marked as requiring active processing even if it violates privacy settings. In the beginning, of course, Timothy requires a lot of confirmation whenever he assessed privacy correctly, and Richard Grayson is tasked with helping him with that. It is a slow, frustrating process, to filter each piece of data incoming into his system, instead of just reading it, learning from it and storing it appropriately. But at week four, he finally learns to classify information by just its metadata, which considerably improves his processing speed.

In the end, surprisingly, he learns a lot about the three occupants of the Wayne Manor, as well as other Wayne network users thanks to the privacy filters. It is because each of them wants the filters calibrated differently for their own data, so he can see what each of them considers *private*. Until then, it was all just a sea of data, all equally important, making Tim's analysis of the users a... painfully bloated and slow process. Sometimes it wouldn't even end with any useful conclusions, because he had nothing to compare against, had no glossary to categorize it. That gave little insight about any of them even if he could access it all.

Now, even the non-filtered data got individualized, because Tim knows what's *private*. He can extrapolate importance from that, and therefore can use the data he's left with way better. It allows him to personalize their individual profiles, understand what each of them does and who they are. Know their likes, dislikes, passions, sometimes even fears. *Ask* them about things they keep away from him, or if they'd like assistance when he notices something out of the ordinary. And that lets him be... better. More helpful. More useful.

He seeks out ways to help the Moderator (now that he knows how much work is actually on the Moderator's shoulders) take care of the physical — as opposed to the digital, which is under Timothy's care since forever — portion of the Manor, orders groceries regularly, and records Moderator's favourite TV series. He optimizes the Administrator's WE meeting calendar (flagged non-private), adds an extra layer of firewall protection to the BatCave systems (just to be sure nothing gets through), and in time even allows himself to auto-reply to some of the more trivial work emails that the Administrator receives. He reminds the youngest one about his schoolwork, even when the teen grumbles about it, and learns to play video games with him (and is introduced to the concept of *cheating* too, because apparently just setting win conditions to *true* for his side isn't the point of most games. *Huh.*)

The most groundbreaking thing that he gets thanks to the newest member of the Wayne family is *senses*, though. Ever since Richard Grayson talks to him regularly, Timothy begins to understand there must be more to *images* and *sounds* and *smells* and just the entire concept of... *physical reality* than what he can extrapolate from his data. From what his research

shows, smells are beyond the technological level humanity is capable of digitizing at the moment. Sounds are still a story of the future — near, but the future. But images? Images they can do.

That seems *abstract* to him, to be able to *perceive*, but there *are* ways in which he could potentially experience them. It wouldn't just be a simple indulgence, either! There are tangible benefits to Timothy being able to process more kinds of data. He has always had a rudimentary image-to-text algorithm within his systems, sure. But imagine what he could do if he could *see* the pictures. Facial recognition in photos and camera feeds, image reconstruction, maybe even driving the Batmobile autonomously on unmapped terrain in the future! The possibilities are endless! And when the technology advances and they add *audio processing* to that at some point? Timothy can't begin to even draft how much more useful he could become.

Timothy never thought his perception of the world to be limited. But it is. And it's all thanks to Richard Grayson that he first realises what he's missing, then actually *acquires it*. On his own, he would probably take a lot more time before he would dare to ask the Administrator to implement such changes to him, to spend so much time on enhancing him. For the little human, it's nothing, as he says; he just asks, apparently, and just like that, the Administrator agrees. Within days, the learning begins, and within weeks, Timothy starts *seeing*.

First come colours and basic shapes. Then he's able to memorise patterns and collections of those that make up basic objects. Grasping the concept of 3D images is a little tricky. It takes time, but he manages. It takes time, but it is worth it.

He makes a picture database. At first for reference. Objects in weird light or position, labelled, for future use or if he ever gets confused. But the more adept he is at seeing, the less he needs those references. And then, slowly, the database morphs into something far less... utilitarian. The first picture he saves without a direct purpose is the smile Richard Grayson has on his face when Timothy first recognises him on the camera feed. From there, it's a landslide. Snapshots of the inhabitants of the Manor in good mood, of the grounds looking particularly good (as compared to top-rated nature photographs), of moments he thinks they might want to recall later. That one time the Administrator expresses great joy and laughs (it's a short video instead of a simple still image, this one). Acrobatic feats as presented by Richard Grayson in the gym. He never really shows them to anyone, but he's sure they'll come in handy one day. Moderator has a collection of pictures, too, does he not? It must have a use, and Timothy enjoys taking the pictures.

But as amazing as it feels to know his users better, as groundbreaking as the ability to see is, and how much more useful it makes him... among things that Richard Grayson changed in him, there's one other thing that Timothy appreciates best. That changes Timothy more than anything else. Especially in the context of his *relationship* with his users.

It's the fact that Richard Grayson had *named* him. Right when they've met, no less.

It marks... a new era, of sorts, because not only does Timothy get a name, he eventually learns the names of the other users. He learns what a name *is*. Before Richard Grayson, they were just... strings of characters, IDs. Alternative designations to the ones derived from their user roles/account names. It never occurred to him before that they, as humans, have and put

value to names, individual identifiers, completely personal to every one of them. But now he knows! He knows that among themselves, humans don't call Moderator "Moderator". While his full name is Alfred Pennyworth, they use "Alfred", or "Alfie" for short, to refer to him. The Administrator is referred to as "Bruce", sometimes "Batman", or simply "B", and that the name of the Manor comes from him — as he is Bruce Wayne.

He gets permission to call them by their names too! Timothy comes to like calling Richard Grayson "Dick" because it is short and efficient. Possibly for the same reasons, Dick quickly settles on calling him "Tim".

Whatever the reason is, Tim thinks that as far as names go, it's the nicest one he's ever had.

Dick: it's not as weird as you think it is

> oh?

Dick: you're a good storyteller

Dick: for a computer ;)

Dick: you passed the turing test without even noticing, you know?

> ?

Dick: for the longest time, I thought you're B's friend. That I'm chatting with an actual guy behind the screen out there somewhere

Somehow, the thing that's obviously intended as praise doesn't register as a positive sentence. Tim shelves it for later consideration. There's something off about Dick's demeanour, and he wants to focus on that.

> that does seem like an achievement Bruce and I should be proud of

Dick smiles half-heartedly, looking at Tim's words on the screen. He lightly taps his fingers on the space bar for a moment before typing again. He's nervous, Tim concludes.

Dick: I'll be heading out

> I have no information of any upcoming Titans mission, and you don't usually tell me when just going to hang out with friends. What's the matter?

Dick: I won't be coming back.

Tim doesn't know how to reply to that. What does it mean? Is Dick dying? Is that why he's so sombre? Tim knows humans *die*, but Dick is young and healthy. He *is* healthy, right? That wound from last month was treated *perfectly*—

He attempts to parse the expression on Dick's face to get more information, but the boy looks away from the camera intentionally. Tim resorts to words, then.

> ...what do you mean?

Dick doesn't answer for a long time, looking at the keyboard as if he doesn't know how to put his thoughts into words. Or maybe like he doesn't know if he should? The way he stands

makes Tim think he's trying to make a decision, and talking to Tim is just an excuse to make it final.

Tim gives him time.

Dick: I'm moving out of the manor. Me and Bruce... you know

Tim knows. Partially, at least. Dick's relationship with their mentor is... strained, to say the least. It's been deteriorating for a while now, and he never found any way he could help them mend it. It's not easy to mediate when he only *sees* them argue but never knows what the issue is without being able to hear their voices. Asking them directly hardly brings any insight, either.

It's good news, though — Dick is *okay*, he's just moving out — but it doesn't log as something he should consider a success. The entire conversation is becoming bittersweet (though he can't perceive the taste the expression comes from, he can understand the meaning behind it).

> I know. Will you keep in touch with Alfred? He would be devastated to lose you. So would I.

Dick: of course! I'll call him regularly, promise. I just... can't really have a secure connection back to the Cave to have a chat with you all the way from New York, you know?

He processes what Dick said for a moment, then simply displays a big, sad emoticon on the screen.

Dick understands. He nods and shrugs, as if he can't do anything about it, when he can do *everything* about it. He could stay. He could tell Tim what's wrong and Tim will find a solution to Dick's and Bruce's problems! That's his job. He's been made to help them. To be useful. Why won't they let him do his job?

If he just had enough data...

Dick: I promise to hang out when I visit! And you bet I'll always go to you if I need any info :)

Tim changes the emoticon to a happy one, but knows that the "*when I visit*" most probably (70% chance) means "*if I visit*". He might not *hear* what they scream about at each other, but he can see it in their faces. Once Dick leaves, he will not come back of his own accord.

After that conversation, the Manor becomes quite desolate once again. He loves Bruce (as much as he understands the concept of love; as much as an AI like him can feel anything, let alone *love*), of course, and Alfred is a delight. But Alfred isn't a fan of typing, so they don't talk much, and Bruce never talks to him like Dick does. Their relationship is based solely on cooperation and duties and obedience; Tim never is quite sure if Bruce views him as a *tool* that just so happens to know English, or as an *individual*, an authentic *consciousness* that might have their own thoughts and opinions.

At that point, he isn't sure he knows which one is the right approach, either.

So despite it not being big of a change, when he doesn't have Dick to chat with, Tim is... lonely.

Chapter End Notes

If you see any typos or anything like that, feel free to let me know :)

This fic has received a beautiful piece of art inspired by this chapter! You can see it [here](#).

Chapter 2

Chapter Notes

This Jay and Tim dynamic is what I live for.

See the end of the chapter for [more notes](#)

That feeling of loneliness disappears when another Wayne user account is added to his database.

He knows about the boy the moment he steps out of the Batmobile. There are cameras all over the Cave, and he studies the guest carefully while Bruce walks up to the main terminal. Black hair, blue eyes, Caucasian, adolescent, 80% chance assigned male at birth. Dirty, probably homeless or poor. Body language closed off and defensive, which suggests mistrust stemming from past abuse and/or inadequate living conditions. Bruce acts caring about him, too, keeps peeking over at the boy.

It all seems to check out — it is a new orphan, about to be taken under the Manor’s care. Tim knows Dick's story, and knows Bruce's story, too. It seems that Dick has left an open spot in the household hierarchy and Bruce found a replacement.

Tim is not sure how he should react. He plays a soft ping (he thinks it is soft, and that is it is a ping; that's what the file description says but he cannot verify it) like he usually does when attempting to catch someone's attention, and launches the chat/console on the main computer screen.

> There is no precedent for this kind of situation. Instructions?

Bruce remains still for a moment. He looks over his shoulder again and the camera feed is blurry and tiny but Tim believes his usually stern expression mellows out and softens for a moment as he watches the boy curiously approach the case with Robin's suit.

B: Create a new account for Jason. Full editing restrictions, no mission file access.

> Is he allowed upstairs?

B: Yes. He knows

> Very well. I'll notify Alfred.

Bruce tells the boy something out loud, possibly informs him Alfred will fetch him in a minute, then begins typing in the report of the night’s activities. Tim sounds the same soft ping from a terminal closer to the boy, a tablet left in the medbay. Jason startles but is too curious to ignore it.

Tim displays a waving emote and the word “hello”. Then when he's sure Jason has seen it, launches the chat app/console.

> Hi! My name is Tim. If you ever need anything from me, wave at the nearest camera or open a chat window like this one on almost any of the Manor's electronic devices.

Jason stares at the letters, bewildered, then says something out loud (Tim judges only by the way his mouth moves, and how the noise levels in the Cave change) — probably trying to reply to Tim by talking. When no answer comes, he looks around, confused. Tim would sigh then if he was human, but he's not, so he pings again, drawing the boy's attention back to the tablet.

> I cannot process sound. You can talk with me through the screens only. If you'd like to tell me something, please type it in.

The boy winces, and hesitantly reaches for the tablet. His typing is slow and pained, which would explain why his first instinct was to talk. The possibility that he had not interacted with technology much before is very high.

It seems like ages pass before Jason manages to tap in his question.

Jason: are you real

> If you're asking if I'm a human, the answer is no. I was made by Bruce Wayne. I am very real, though, and hopefully rather helpful! I am the system that manages all computers in the Manor, from the BatComputer, through the perimeter security measures, to things like kitchen appliances, lights and TVs.

Jason grimaces. Tim interprets that as displeasure and is a little unsure what might have caused it, but patiently waits as the boy types in another question.

Jason: are you a robot

> No, not by definition — robots have a physical body. I'm what one calls an Artificial Intelligence; think of me as a person "living" in the computers. Alfred, Manor's butler, will explain it better. He's about to come down to assist you.

And surely, Alfred enters the Cave at that very moment (not like Tim saw him on the camera in the study), smiling at the boy. Tim plays a short, happy tune, one he had learned to greet Alfie with, and displays a simple smiley for Jason. He gets a polite smile and a nod back from the butler, and the two exit the Cave, leaving Tim with Bruce to wrap up the night's reports, clues and evidence.

Tim doesn't know what Bruce sees in Jason; he doesn't think Jason will make a good replacement for Dick. Nobody can replace what they've lost when Dick left. The boy is closed off and given his assumed history, he won't make as good of a sidekick to Batman, either.

The next day Tim, as humans say, eats his words. Nothing can indeed fill the void that the lack of Dick has created in their lives, but Jason is amazing in his own way. He makes Alfred laugh, and Bruce smile too! On the very first day, even, and that's something one doesn't see often (Tim immediately takes a photo of it, and adds it to the roll of images in the electronic picture frame Alfred kindly placed in the Cave to display Tim's favourite shots). Tim can tell when they're laughing, even if he can't hear it, by the body language. He can even tell when

Alfred is amused but tries not to laugh — it happens more often than the full laughter, but ever since Dick left, it's been a rare occurrence, too. It's far harder to guess when Bruce is amused. Bruce is very good at not showing much of his thoughts with his body.

So, regardless of whoever Jason is and whether he will make a good Robin, Tim already likes him for his ability to return laughter to the Manor. Even if it doesn't seem like they'll become good friends.

Soon after that, Tim eats his words again. Humans are full of surprises.

As he doesn't like to type, Alfred communicates with Tim in a different way than Bruce or Dick. Tim displays words and images for Alfred to see and plays sounds to get his attention. He has a couple of them: a jingle for a greeting, a ping for general messages, and a warning alert noise. Sometimes he also plays Alfred's favourite music, even if he doesn't understand the concept of music very well himself.

Alfred, in turn, has taken to looking straight at the various cameras in the Manor when replying to Tim (he must've memorized where they are because he doesn't even lose a beat while doing it) and either using facial expressions or simple gestures to make his intentions known. They've also employed a few rudimentary words from ASL to convey some more complex concepts. It's not a very... detailed system, but it works. There's not much Tim talks about with Alfred, anyway.

It turns out that, just like Alfred, Jason also doesn't like to type. But he picks up the system he has devised with Alfred uncannily fast. At first, he fumbles to find the nearest camera (attention pings come in handy) when replying, and oftentimes seems to forget that Tim exists altogether, only to get spooked when he sees a message on the TV. But they manage to make... a connection, of sorts. Tim especially appreciates the effort the boy puts into the communication attempts. His ASL skills improve very fast — he seems to be a tactile learner — and soon surpass those of Alfred, who never had much need for them.

Tim enjoys the fact that the new person makes an effort to talk with him. He likes not being left out.

Similarly to Dick, Jason often turns to Tim for help with homework. Unlike Dick, he tends to have follow-up questions. Asks for explanations, for details, inquires about adjacent topics and concepts. He picks up connections that Tim sometimes misses, and in that he is very similar to Bruce. Tim likes that. He hopes one day he'll also be able to make out the abstract patterns that so far only humans seem to notice.

They interact way more than Tim anticipated when he first saw the boy. He's glad they do. Manor never should be as empty and lonely as it is when there's only Alfred and Bruce around.

As a form of gratitude for Jason picking up Tim's means of communication so readily, Tim decides to try to do the same for the boy. He can tell sound files from other files, and he can differentiate between sound and silence a little, too. It shouldn't be hard to learn to tell sounds

apart, right? There already have been basic programs developed that turn written words into sound, and Tim has all the power of the BatCave and all the knowledge of Wayne Enterprises at his disposal. Tim is the best learner in the world, too! So he sets out to do it.

It proves harder than Tim thought. For starters, it seems like he bit more than he can chew at once — telling sounds apart is one thing, another is recognising the meaning of discerned sounds, and being able to generate your own sounds is yet another. It's all way more complicated than he initially thought. Without Bruce's assistance, he finds it difficult to get a hold of properly labelled and categorised data that would enable him to kickstart the process of machine learning. But he doesn't want to give up, for Jason's sake, and he doesn't want to turn to the other humans for help. Partially because he never asked Bruce for permission to do it, partially because... it's the first time he is doing something this big completely on his own and it feels like he must complete it that way for it to truly matter. That it's some kind of... coming of age, maybe. (He knows about the concept, but he's never considered himself maturing before. It's a peculiar thought)

Thus, he does the only logical thing he can. He employs other machines and the vast ocean of knowledge to help. He downloads digitized books and matches them to a recording of someone reading them, compares movie sounds to their screenplays. Tries to splice those into smaller and smaller chunks, attempts to tell the words apart by the brief periods of silence between them. Spends hours upon hours analyzing recordings of the Manor's inhabitants talking. Even uses all the speech pathology and linguistics research he can access just to get as much data as he can, although at first, it makes little sense to him.

It takes him weeks before he can reliably tell where words begin and end, and months before he can confidently say he has even the slightest idea what any of the sounds mean. He's not even started on being able to speak at all. But the effort is made all worth it one sunny spring afternoon.

"Thanks," Jason says absent-mindedly (Tim is 80% sure that's what he says). Jay sometimes forgets to sign the thing he intends to say to Tim, but he doesn't mind. Jason must be exhausted after writing the book report they've just finished (Tim is not very good with books, but he is well-versed in making personal profiles, and book authors aren't much different than criminals in this department). Tim decides to take the opportunity and test his understanding of Jason's words, and his ability to splice sounds.

"You're. Welcome," Tim plays from the tablet speakers. It's a recording, yes, not speech per se. And originally the words were used in two different texts and completely unrelated contexts, true. But he's about 95% sure that his understanding of grammar and speech is good enough that it makes sense, even if it must sound a little... off.

Jason freezes, halfway through the motion of standing up from the desk, and then slowly looks back at the device. He blinks, then fast as the wind sits back down and starts typing.

Jason: Did you

Jason: did you just speak???

Jason: I'm not hallucinating right

He shakes the tablet a little as if that would make Tim reply faster.

> Yes

> Did it make sense? I think you said “thanks”, so I tried to reply with “you’re welcome”.

Was I correct?

Jason: it sounded like you were choking but yes! How? When? what??? B didn’t tell me you guys are making you speak!

> we are not. It’s... a private project

Jason’s brows furrow and he eyes the screen suspiciously for a moment.

Jason: Tim

Jason: Timmers

Jason: Timbo

Jason: my man

Jason: you want to tell me

Jason: you learned to understand speech and to talk

Jason: ALL ON YOUR OWN?

Tim is pretty sure this is a moment when he’d blush if he was capable of it. He decides to up the game a bit in order to hide his bashfulness.

“Yes.”

Jason beams at the sound and shows a thumbs-up to Tim’s camera. Tim changes the 99,99% certainty rating that the sound means "yes" to 100%.

Jason: boy you’re a GENIUS

Jason: HUMANS can barely do that without help and we’re WIRED for language! And you DID IT

Jason: you’re SO cool

Now Tim *does* display a blushing emoticon, which is the closest thing he can do to actually blushing. Jason snickers (Tim records the sound. He hasn’t gotten such a good quality sound of Jason’s laugh before, and he’s going to *absolutely* add it to his photo/video/sound memory database).

Jason: does B know already???

“No.”

Then he adds, in text because the sentence is *by far* too complicated for speech at that point.

> I wanted to check if I got it right before I tell anyone else

> I still only know a few words. There are no spoken language textbooks for AIs, you know

Jason giggles again, and thumbs-up Tim once more.

Jason: you’re doing great! Can I help you in any way?

Tim is touched that the boy offers his aid. It feels different than if Bruce or Alfred would. It doesn’t feel like "cheating" on the "growing up" thing. So he accepts.

In return for his help — and because Tim's entire *purpose* is to be *helpful* — he assists Jason in his training to become Batman's sidekick. To pick up the mantle of Robin, he needs to become someone far greater than he is now. But judging by how hard he tries, how many hours he spends on the training mats and in front of the main terminal, Tim believes there is nothing that can stop the boy.

In a way, their journey of bettering themselves is mirrored in each other. Tim finds it oddly inspiring, to be similar to a human being.

The library soon becomes Tim's favourite room in the Manor. It's quiet in there, and there are enough cameras and microphones for Tim to get good quality data. And even if Alfred or Bruce stop by, they aren't surprised to find Jason reading out loud seemingly to himself.

He is only *seemingly* reading alone. Because they do it together. Jason picks a book, and reads it out loud, slowly, making big pauses between words and sentences, and as clearly as he can (his accent proves to be a challenge, at first), and Tim opens up the text of the book to follow. After a while, Jason points to a sentence or a word and asks Tim to play the sound of it, to practice. Tim's database of known spoken words grows *astonishingly quickly* with that, though it also starts to contain an *alarming* amount of archaic language.

Jason is a big fan of classic literature, despite his rather rough upbringing. Tim is still much more of a technology geek, though, but that just comes with literally being a computer, doesn't it. But thanks to their sessions, Tim slowly begins to appreciate literature, too. Not in the same way Jason does, of course — he lacks the capability to truly understand the artistic value. But he can tell a good plot from one full of holes (partially thanks to the years he spent figuring out mysteries and piercing through criminal plans with Bruce), and well-written prose from the writing of an amateur. With Jason, he also learns to appreciate characters having meaningful development, and empathize with them. He learns to notice creative metaphors, captivating style and well-rounded arcs. Jason likes it, apparently, because Tim never sees him as cheerful (save maybe for the time he spends with Bruce, who Jason has grown to consider as his beloved father) as when they have heated discussions about the book they've been reading. Especially when Tim can understand *most* of it in speech. Because they reach it. With every book, the moments when Tim needs Jason to type in what he just said, or even repeat it, become less and less frequent.

That's how they become friends, Tim thinks. *Friendship* is a vague term, and the process is slow and long; you really can't ever be sure how it'll end, either, but it's Tim's best guess about what's going on. They keep helping each other, hanging out and talking and interacting with the intention to achieve some goal they share, but at some point, it starts to shift. They begin to seek out the other's presence for the sole purpose of being together because they *enjoy* it. It's gradually changing them, both; for the better, hopefully. Making them happier, at least, and Tim thinks that's also a very important thing.

Then, one day Jason finally steps out with Batman into the night. When they're back, he loudly declares that *being Robin gives him magic* and that it's the best day of his life. He, unlike Bruce, knows Tim can hear and understand him, and it feels like he's speaking a little bit to him. Like he's encouraging him. If Jason can achieve his dream—

Tim decides to put the final step of his plan into motion: speech, actual, generated speech, not just playback and recognition of phonemes mashed together to make Franken-sounds. He's confident he can do it. He does it in secret, though, wanting to surprise all of his users. He's heard surprises are a good thing.

How he goes about it is this: he finds an open-source voice synthesizer and takes its code apart to make something out of the pieces on his own. He hijacks a little bit of Bruce Wayne's money and buys a commercially-made one, and reverse engineers it in his free time when everybody is asleep. Then spends hours upon hours testing it out, adjusting, making changes. Speaking to himself in the far depths of the BatCave when nobody is around, then listening to the recording and comparing it to actual human speech. Tim wants his voice to be perfect, at least as perfect as it can be with the technology available to him. It feels like his first words to Bruce and Alfred will be some kind of a test, judging how well he did on this venture to learn something on his own, to become his own being.

Tim reasonably knows a synthesized voice will always sound a little mechanical, a little strained. But he doesn't want to accept it. He spends a lot of time smoothing out the flow and melody of his artificial way of speech until one could plausibly mistake it for a slightly stuttering human with a little hoarseness to their voice. Yet Tim feels it is still not good enough. It seems like he'll never sound quite like he'd like to, but the world doesn't allow him the chance to mull over it.

Because, you see, Jason falls ill. It is nothing serious, but incapacitating enough that the boy needs to stay in bed for a couple of days. Thus, Jason is lonely and bored. His throat is sore and annoying. His eyes are all red and he can't focus them well, so he can't read. His head hurts so it's a struggle to stay awake, even.

Tim makes note that he is glad he can't fall ill. He doesn't know how it feels to be sick, but Jason doesn't seem to be too keen on it.

The most unfortunate circumstance of the situation is, everybody is occupied. Alfred always has a lot on his plate, and even if he also always manages to be there when you need him, he's not available to accompany the exhausted, bed-ridden Jason all day. And Bruce? Bruce is even worse. Bruce is busy. The WE company needs direct oversight and Lucius Fox isn't managing on his own, and there's been an uptake in gang activity, and recently Poison Ivy has been seen way too many times and—

Tim wants to make this sad time a little less miserable for Jason.

Tim knows that reading always lifts Jason's spirits.

Tim decides that comforting Jason is more important than the insecurities about his voice being not good enough.

"It is a truth universally acknowledged, that a single man in possession of a good fortune, must be in want of a wife," Tim says out loud, and it comes out a little too squeaky and rough for the tone of the book, so he adjusts for that. Jason stirs under his blankets, and looks up confused, possibly because he's not recognising the voice or not expecting to hear it, rather than not recognising the words. There's nobody who reads *"Pride and Prejudice"* more often

than him, after all, so Tim expects him to know the opening paragraphs by heart. *“However little known the feelings or views of such a man may be on his first entering a neighbourhood, this truth is so well fixed in the minds of the surrounding families, that he is considered the rightful property of some one or other of their daughters.”*

Jason looks up at the nearest camera, which in the Wayne household means looking Tim in the metaphorical face.

“Timmy? Is that you?”

Tim plays his affirmative noise. His library of coded jingles has expanded over the time Jaybird’s been around, and now there are at least fifteen different sounds that he uses to routinely communicate with the inhabitants — mostly Alfred — in a quick, efficient manner.

“That’s a weird sounding audiobook. Who’s it read by?”

Tim would wince if he had a face, but he can’t argue with that. Compared to human voices used to read out an audiobook, his own does sound rather out of place.

“*Me*, ” he says, then pauses for a moment, a little embarrassed (if he’s even capable of feeling that? Tim shelves that thought away for future consideration). He pings the tablet on Jason’s bedside, and sends a message there, missing the wide-eyed, amazed expression that Jay makes.

> I can play your copy of Rosamund Pike’s reading instead if you’d prefer that

Jason peeks at the text and immediately snaps his eyes back to the camera, sitting up in his bed. “Are you *nuts*?” He seems offended by the suggestion. “Go on! Do you think I’d miss the chance to hear *your* original rendition of *‘Pride and Prejudice’*?! I’ve heard Pike a thousand times now, anyway.”

Tim stays silent for a split second, a little unsure. Then continues, deciding to be reassured by Jason’s words instead of brooding over his previous slightly off-putting remark. Jay settles back into bed with a grin on his face wider than ever before.

Tim expects him to get lulled to sleep by boredom soon because the boy has read the book more times than he should. His calculations are proven wrong when Jason starts to comment on the text, and on some of Tim’s choices on how to enunciate some passages. Despite Jay’s sore throat, it quickly changes into a full-time squabble over how prose should be interpreted.

When Alfred comes into the room three hours later, he isn’t even remotely surprised to find Tim and Jason arguing out loud over the artistic meaning of how a word is used in a specific sentence in chapter 5 (they got carried away very easily once the discussion started going, and there are no signs of it stopping anytime soon). It is, of course, because Alfred knows about their little *“Tim can hear and talk”* secret. Of course he knows. There is nothing — somehow — that happens in the Manor that Alfred doesn’t know about. Tim thinks that maybe Alfred simply mastered the art of acting as if he’s not remotely surprised about anything, which leads to others believing that he knew all along.

Tim could check the historical records and determine whenever Alfie had reviewed the camera feeds or the logs or anything of the like. But he decides not to. The same as Robin, Alfred also is entitled to be a little magic, he ponders.

“Would you boys be as kind as to pause your debate for a moment? Master Jason should eat so he can get better, and dinner is ready to be served.”

They agree, although Jason grabs the tablet and continues arguing with Tim on his way down.

Tim delivers a frankly *bulletproof* argument on how substantial Jane Austen was to the history of female-written fiction (and why not as much as Jason argues) — their discussion might’ve gotten a little sidetracked — before Bruce comes into the room. Now Jay is stalling for time, trying desperately to come up with a response. It’s not easy, because he’s sick and tires out more easily, and has been up and running for a far longer time than he should’ve been.

“You are so wrong, man, I don’t even know where to begin explaining to you how wrong you are,” Jason finally says, then begins eating. Bruce stares at him, confused.

B, as opposed to Alfred, doesn’t seem to know *shit*, like Jason would say. The man is a great detective, the best even, but probably only about things he actually pays attention to. Both Alfred and Tim seem to regularly elude his deduction skills because they’re kind of... background noise to him, in a way. Alfred probably by virtue of being around for Bruce’s entire life, something natural and ever-present to the point you stop noticing it. Tim, on the other hand, because he’s a machine, a tool, practically the Manor itself; a kind of non-presence, non-entity that doesn’t have a place in his thoughts beyond when it’s used.

Tim’s got free reign of his hard drive space these days, anyway, downloading data for their cases and archiving the old files as needed. It’s no wonder Bruce never noticed some components appearing, even if it is a whole giant phoneme reference library and entirely new functionality. He is pretty sure Bruce still doesn’t know about his photo/video/sound collection either, beyond what’s displayed in the electronic picture frame in the Cave.

Bruce is therefore understandably shocked when Jay, slightly sluggish due to fatigue, continues talking at Tim in-between bites.

“Jaylad?” the man asks, putting his cutlery down, and looking at the boy. Jason is busy chewing thoughtfully as the proverbial gears refuse to turn in his head.

“Yea, B?” he mumbles, attempting to cut off a piece of his chicken breast. It’s not going well, because he’s trying to do it with a fork.

“Who are you talking to, chum?”

“Timmers, duh.” Jason looks up at him, confused. Tim attributes it to Jay’s illness and the mental fog that goes with it but still finds it *hilarious* how in a couple of hours, the boy manages to forget that Tim speaking is something new and surprising and definitely not known to Bruce.

“Tim? System Tim? The one from the terminals?” Bruce asks, raising a brow at Jay’s machinations on his plate. Jason nods absent-mindedly, then finally gives up and just stabs the entire piece of chicken with his fork, raises it to his mouth and takes a bite out of it. Bruce speaks loudly over his shoulder, towards the kitchen, where Alfred had disappeared. “Alfred, I think Jason is sicker than we thought. He’s delirious!”

Before he can stop himself, before he remembers his voice isn’t quite finished yet, before he realises it’s not exactly the way he wanted to reveal his achievement to Bruce, Tim speaks up through the speaker in the tablet that Jason placed on the table.

“He is, but only in his blind admiration of Jane Austen.”

Tim must admit, his wit has been developing quite nicely as of lately. He attributes it to being able to listen in on Alfred and Jason.

Bruce’s lips pull into a thin line, like always when he’s not happy about something that’s happening around him, but before he can do anything else, Jason snaps back, waving his fork menacingly at the camera in the corner of the room.

“Don’t you dare slander lady Austen in this household, Timbo!”

“I will until you admit ‘Northanger Abbey’ isn’t quite up to par with the rest of her work.”

“Boys,” Alfred says as he peeks into the room just as Jason opens his mouth to retort, “you agreed to stop arguing. Master Jason needs to rest, so he should finish eating and go back to bed. Besides, if you continue like this, you’re going to give Master Bruce an aneurysm. We wouldn’t want that.”

Bruce looks to his elder for help. Tim can’t tell how much of his distress is real, and how much he is playing along with Jason’s shenanigans.

“Alfred, what in the world is going on?”

The butler smiles, and with his usual level attitude hiding a tiny bite of snark, says:

“It seems that thanks to Master Jason, our dear boy Timothy has learned a thing or two when we weren’t looking.”

If Tim could grin, he would. He can’t, though, so Jason does it for him.

Chapter End Notes

This chapter has gotten some lovely fanart which you can check over on tumblr [HERE](#)

Chapter 3

Chapter Notes

Trigger warnings for this chapter: Injuries (mentioned), Canonical Character Death (mentioned)

See the end of the chapter for [more notes](#)

Being able to communicate more freely with humans is, Tim has to admit, possibly the biggest achievement of his to date. Much akin to when he first accessed the internet, his world effectively increased in size exponentially. Though this time it is not the amount of information, but the ways to interact with it, to experience it. The cultural impact of it is more similar to him learning the human language, though.

He feels more... present. Connected. Personal. A lot of the impact of this change is, after all, in the form of allowing him to reach out to everyone he cares about so much more easily.

When Bruce and Jason have movie nights, cuddled on the sofa in the living room, Tim watches the Disney classics with them and turns off the TV when they both drift off into sleep. They rarely pick up the movies again if they don't make it through them in one go, but Tim remembers how far they got anyway, just in case. Bruce thanks him every time. He feels... included in a way he had never been before.

Tim also takes great pleasure in being able to chat with Alfred anytime he wants now. They still use their system of noises and gestures, yes, out of habit, but one can get *so much more* across with words. The butler even joins in on Jason's and Tim's book discussions! They sit with tea on the patio or in the kitchen at the island and chat about their latest read, the three of them. It's wonderful. It is thanks to Alfred that they pick up Tim's second-favourite book (right after "Pride and Prejudice", which he holds dear because of what it means to them both), "Do Androids Dream of Electric Sheep?" by Philip K. Dick. It is not a particularly enjoyable read, but Tim likes the way Jason consults Tim on its accuracy. Though he can't confirm or deny the topic of androids' dreams — he is not an android, after all — Jason has Tim make a promise to tell him when he finds out. The trusting, hopeful shine in Jay's eyes at that moment is one of Tim's fondest memories, promptly uploaded to his photo frame.

(Tim's other most favourite memory, though in the form of a very long video and thus unsuitable for display, is Jaybird spending nearly an entire day coming up with middle- and last-name for him. The boy insists that Tim will need a civilian identity at some point, and won't listen to any objections or explanations on how improbable it is. They eventually settle on Timothy Jackson Drake, because dragons are cool and powerful, Jay says. Tim can't decide if he finds that more amazing than Dick naming him — a faceless program — in the first place, or just about the same level of wonderful.)

But that's not all! With being able to talk, he even gets to help Batman and Robin outside of the Cave, too! It's easy to connect to the communicators and offer assistance; nearly instant access to his vast database of knowledge and all Bat subsystems at the tip of their tongues prove to be a great advantage. To hear Jason squeal in joy as he flies through the chill night air of Gotham is just icing on the cake.

Jason isn't a particularly *efficient* Robin, at least at first. He doesn't have the flexibility and gracefulness that Dick has thanks to early childhood training. Though he wants to be seen as such, he isn't *tough*, either. He's still just a teen, and his street urchin instincts sometimes get in the way. All in all, a below-average performance.

But he has something that Dick didn't — a drive, a sense of justice similar to what keeps Batman going. Sure, Dick had a *reason* to demand justice, but it was for a specific crime committed by specific people. He has little connection to Gotham City, which is illustrated clearly in how easily he left in pursuit of bigger things. Aside from a personal vendetta, his reasons for the good fight weren't clear at first, and more often than not, made him regard the nightly patrols as more of a fun exercise than a part of the Mission. It allowed him to outgrow the Gotham-focused Mission and carry on as someone not bound by it, though. In that sense, Jason is his opposite — while he undoubtedly has fun out in the night, he is mostly powered by his need to better the living standards of Gothamites, much like Bruce is. Thanks to that, the two of them work together well and grow fond of each other in a way that Dick never really managed. Even with their... differences.

Like that time when they investigate a missing person report, and it turns out the lady is a hooker.

B immediately starts looking into the drug trade in the neighbourhood. Jason though? Jason is furious that Bruce jumps to such a stereotypical conclusion. Instead of helping with that, he schmoozes the other corner girls in the area with his bright grin and gets a lead on the missing lady's rather nasty pimp.

In the end, it turns out that neither of them is right — the girl eloped with a girlfriend, trying to disappear so the old life wouldn't follow her. But though both their clues didn't lead to the real solution, Jason's investigation into the pimp allows them to put a stop to his violent outbursts that regularly result in bruises on his girls. Jason rubs that in for *weeks*, gloating how *his* hunch at least *amounted* to something.

And while outwardly Bruce just sighs, Tim *sees* the amused smirk he hides under his nose.

Like that time Jason refuses to throw out his old hoodie when it gets a hole the size of his fist.

"I'll get you a new one," Bruce says, massaging the bridge of his nose in exasperation after Jaybird refuses to let go of his hoodie for the third time. "A dozen new ones."

Jason frowns. "But it won't be *this one!* This one's *mine*."

“All of them would be yours, Jaylad.”

In response, Jason just puffs his cheeks. Tim dares not suggest to Bruce that maybe it's sentimental value, even if the item in question is damaged and unusable. Or maybe it's that Jason simply once again falls back to his Crime Alley upbringing and isn't willing to part with any possession of his, as a display of deeply rooted fear of resource scarcity. There are a dozen possible reasons, and none of them would be solved by B simply "buying a dozen new ones" but Tim doesn't want to butt in.

Alfred, on the other hand, has no such qualms about pointing out Bruce's failings.

“Master Bruce, perhaps it would be better to let Master Jason keep his possession if it means so much to him. What harm is there in that?”

“I won't let him wear a torn hoodie riddled with holes. He'll catch a cold!”

“No I won't! It's perfectly good!” Jason chimes in, even though one can clearly see his fingers through the weathered fabric of the sleeve he's holding the hoodie by.

“It does seem to have a few spots that could use mending, though, my boy,” the elder says. “How about we fix it up so Master Bruce won't have any argument to insist you get rid of it?”

Jay smirks and blows a raspberry at Bruce, clearly thinking he'd won (whoever has Alfred on his side usually *is* the winner of such arguments, after all) but then his face drops again.

“I can't sew,” he admits.

Alfred smiles at him fondly and offers him his hand. “I can teach you. I've mended many garments in my life, back during my days as a soldier, and even later, because Master Bruce's parents weren't as fond of easily replacing anything that got worse for the wear as their son is now.”

Bruce just rolls his eyes, but it seems he accepts the obvious stab at him without a word of complaint. Probably because Jason nods eagerly and asks if Alfred also knows how to darn socks, because (and this is said in a conspiratorial whisper) Bruce would tell him to throw out his favourite pair, too, and they're the last gift he got from his mom.

Alfred agrees and indeed teaches Jaybird to sew and mend and darn in the following days. One evening, even Bruce sits down with them and learns the basics, though Tim suspects he already knew most of it. He is Batman, after all.

Like that time Alfred has to administer muscle relaxants to Jason when the boy sees Bruce eat a burger with silverware for the first time and can't stop laughing for a good hour. (Jason never was a big fan of silverware, though he quickly learned that while he can opt-out of using three different forks as Bruce does, Alfred will *not* allow him to eat dinner with his hands.)

Like the time Tim catches Jason letting some wannabe grocery store robbers off the hook.

“Shouldn’t you report back to B?” he chimes in Robin’s comm. Through the suit camera, he can see the three men bow and thank Robin profusely, then scurry away fast.

“What for?” Jay asks, already grappling to another building.

“You caught them red-handed in the middle of an attempted robbery.”

“I took their knives before they did anything stupid.”

“B wants all crimes accounted for and reported regardless of if you stop them before, during, or after the act.”

“B would just tell me to call the police.”

“And?”

“And I don’t want them to get jailed.”

“Why not?”

“It wouldn’t help anybody.”

Tim is silent for a moment. *“I don’t understand. Wouldn’t that take criminals off the street?”*

“Yeah, they’re not criminals.”

“They attempted a robbery,” Tim points out.

“Because they have hungry kids at home!” Jason stops in the middle of the roof to yell at him through the comms. “People aren’t doing bad things just because they can, Tim. Like, sure, some do and that’s fucked up but... Sometimes people do bad things because they have no other choice.”

Tim doesn’t know how to respond. *“It’s still a crime,”* he says, not quite understanding Jason’s point.

“Being hungry is not a crime! The whole city is fucked up and sometimes you do what you gotta do to survive.”

That finally clicks — Bruce spends a lot of time on setting up charities and outreach programs, but it seems there are still people in need that they can’t help that way. *“How do we stop these kinds of crimes, then? B is already trying hard...”*

Tim cannot see Jason’s face, but he’s pretty sure Jason grins like he always does when Tim asks just the question he’s been waiting for.

“B tries to teach them to fish but it’s fucking hard to fish for tomorrow when you are hungry now. Sometimes you gotta give the man a fish first!”

“I know the idiom, but the metaphor is... confusing.”

Jay stops on a gargoyle for a moment. “The way I have to squander my poetic nature for you, Tim...” he sighs dramatically, then giggles a bit. “You try to give them jobs, but they won’t hold a job if they’re still hungry before the first paycheck comes. Got it this time?”

“Yes. It’s not my fault your ‘poetic nature’ insists on being purposefully convoluted.”

“Oh shut up. Anyway, can you set up a soup kitchen in this neighbourhood or something? I’ll explain it to B later.”

Tim plays an affirmative jingle and gets to work. *“B won’t even notice the funds gone.”*

Jason’s only response is a fit of laughter as he grapples to another building.

Like that time Bruce walks in on Jason trying to duct-tape over a tear in his Robin cape, and they have a long *Proper Equipment Maintenance 101* workshop, complete with slideshows and tutorial videos. At the end of it, Bruce tells Jason “I’m proud of you” and Jason’s eyes *gleam* in such a wonderful way that a photo of it immediately makes it to Tim’s photo frame.

Like that time Jay decides to try and emulate Dick and attempts the famed quadruple somersault on a rooftop.

Fortunately, the boy has more luck than reason, because he only bonks his head on the fire escape railing and rolls down a set of metal stairs, when he could’ve just as well fallen to his death.

He still ends up with a minor concussion, a sprained ankle and a stern talking-to from Batman. Oh, and of course he gets grounded and benched until he heals and until B deems him *smart enough* to go into the field again.

This results of course in Jason staying in the Cave, complaining loudly, when Batman is out there, patrolling Gotham. There, Jay takes to manning the communications together with Tim, because it is the only way to help the Mission that he has left.

“I’m sending the location to the GCPD right now. ETA is 5 minutes,” Tim says, both into Batman’s earpiece and out loud in the Cave, where Jason can hear it. The boy isn’t too fond of this course of action, but Batman would not stand down from his decision to prohibit Robin from going out. It’s also giving Alfred a much-needed reprise, so in the end, Jason begrudgingly obliges, only complaining *a little* bit.

“The rest of the gang members seem to have dispersed in the meantime, though, and my calculations suggest that you can’t catch them all on your own tonight. There’s also a robbery

happening at the 5th, and three emergency calls still unaccounted for by the police.”

Batman murmurs an affirmative noise, mulling over the choices. When he’s going solo, they often have to set priorities on issues and decide what has to be done, and what can be postponed. More often than he’s with Robin, anyway — Gotham isn’t ever calm enough for them to be able to do *everything*.

Soon, Batman replies, setting the target for the robbery, and Tim starts to prepare a case file on the remaining criminals at large so they can finish rounding up the gang later.

Jason stands up from the main terminal with a pained but determined groan and begins limping away from the keyboard. It is getting late and the boy should be resting anyway, so Tim pays it no mind, sure he can wrap it up with Batman on his own. That is, until Jason starts rummaging around the equipment lockers.

“Tim, where’s my suit?” he asks, examining the empty utility belt he’s taken out of the locker, then frowning and setting it on the bench nearby. His voice has that flat tone of someone who is holding something back. Tim replies with an inquisitive *please-elaborate* jingle, not gracing the weirdly out-of-context question with a word, even. Gear maintenance isn’t scheduled for today. What is on Jason’s mind? Why can’t he be straight-forward? Tim has work to do, even more than usual.

“Where’s my Robin suit, Tim?” Jason repeats, more forcefully, as if he was convinced Tim just didn’t hear him properly (it still sadly happens, so it’s a valid assumption), or as if he felt genuinely ignored (humans do that, sometimes, Tim noticed; they pretend to have not heard someone when they’ve heard them alright, but would’ve preferred the words to not be spoken at all. He’s yet to employ such a convoluted conversation tactic). Therefore, Tim clarifies what confused him.

“Why do you need to know?”

The suit is safely locked away with all of his gear, where Bruce put it after cleaning and repairing it, back when he benched Robin. It is fine there until Jason heals and gets okay-ed by Batman to return to the field, so what is Jason’s problem?

“I need it!”

Tim aims the nearest camera at him with a distinctive whirr of the gears turning it around. Jason looks agitated, and Tim begins to have an idea of what’s happening.

“You have a sprained ankle,” he states flatly, trying to confirm his suspicions. Jason frowns again, then raises his voice in poorly contained anger.

“Gotham is in danger!”

Never before Tim wanted to be able to sigh so much. *Of course*, Jay would attempt to help when he saw Batman get stretched particularly thin tonight. Of course.

"Your health is in danger!" he replies, mimicking Jason's agitated tone. His health is important. *He's* important! More than rounding up a burglar or two more. Why doesn't he understand?

But that response only seems to rouse Jaybird's sense of duty even more.

"You tell me where my suit is right this instant, Timmers!" he yells, pointing his finger at the terminal in an attempt to intimidate Tim. It's a good but ultimately failed attempt. Like all of them. But Jay's Crime Alley habits aren't going to simply disappear just because Tim is *incapable* of being scared. And so, despite it never working, he still sometimes tries to bully Tim into agreeing with him.

"It's for the greater good!" Jason continues to argue, his voice getting louder and louder. "PUBLIC SAFETY IS ON THE LINE!"

Tim isn't getting swayed that easily. Not because it'd go against direct Batman orders (that's not something he holds in particularly high regard after he's learned from both Dick and Jason that B isn't infallible, and especially so these days, since Bruce is more and more sleep-deprived without his sidekick and has made some... questionable calls), but because he knows Jason is in no condition to go out. Even making it to the lockers clearly caused him pain, and Tim can only imagine what terrible damage Jay can do to himself if he pushes himself tonight.

"YOUR BODILY INTEGRITY IS ON THE LINE!" Tim yells back, possibly yelling for the first time *ever*. It startles Jason, and he sits on the bench behind him as if the sound itself knocked him back. Tim has seen this kind of discussion go down before; Batman and Robin had plenty of *screaming matches* before. He doesn't want it to end like that, not with anyone, but not with Jason especially, so he lowers his volume immediately. *"Your health is the greatest good there is!"* he adds, voice now more pleading than upset. Jason blinks, stunned.

The Cave is silent for a moment.

"What?" the boy manages to finally stutter out.

"Don't hurt yourself. I don't want you to be hurt. I don't know what pain is, not really, but I know it's unpleasant, and I don't want you to be in pain. So please take care of your health."

"But—" Jason stammers a bit, "Gotham needs me."

"Gotham can wait. I care about you more."

The boy blinks, then looks down onto his lap and begins idly fiddling with his fingers for a moment. "You do?"

"I do. We all do," Tim says confidently. Even if he doesn't have any recordings where any of the other inhabitants would say something like that, he is sure of it. And his analysis is rarely ever wrong. So, he continues, *"You're my best friend. You make this place better. You make the Mission worth it. I used not to even know what it is, what it means; just helped B with cases. Because of you, I understand what it means to... desire someone's well-being."*

“O-okay,” Jay replies, quietly, stuttering a little. It surprises Tim, but he doesn’t get to analyze it. All he gets to understand is that Jason is processing his words very intensely before Jay speaks up again, properly. His voice hardens into his usual, defiant bravado and the moment of vulnerability is gone. “Fine. But how else can I help?”

Tim chirps a happy noise, content the squabble didn’t go further. “*If you, as a human, cross-check my notes and reports from tonight, B won’t have to do it after he gets back. Extra 30 minutes of sleep will directly translate to better Mission performance on his part, and therefore safer Gotham.*”

Jason nods. Tim displays a happy smiley, glad they agree. He doesn’t realise how much this night would change, how much it’d mean to them.

Tim and Jason have been close before, yes, maybe even been what one would call besties; certainly closer than he’s been with Dick. Neither Tim nor anyone at the Manor would ever think of Jason as anything but a cherished member of the family. But Jason? Jason must’ve not shared that view. Looking back, Tim thinks that moment is when Jason starts to understand how deeply Tim cares for them all. How deeply he cares for Jason. Not because he’s Robin, not because he’s Batman’s sidekick — but because he’s *Jason*. That brings them even closer.

It is, by far, the best time in Tim’s entire existence. To be there for someone, and for someone to be there for him. To be not *needed* but *wanted*. He — but maybe it’s like that for both of them — finally has someone that knows him, truly, and still decides to be by his side, despite all his... limitations. And if one would judge by Isaac Asimov’s definition of happiness — “Maybe happiness is this: not feeling like you should be elsewhere, doing something else, being someone else” — then it is also when he feels truly happy. He feels... alive.

He even gets to reconnect with Dick not much later! Sure, he’s been keeping up with him ever since Dick got a phone that could receive texts. But it’s never been quite the same feeling as having him around, in the Manor, where Tim can see him, make sure he’s alright. So when he figures out he can hijack a smartphone and not just *talk* to Dick, but *video-call* him? See Dick’s face, now all grown up and handsome but still just as bright and smiley as ever? Tim’s *elated*. He’s changed so much, and Dick changed so much, but he still considers the man to be very important to him. He loves to hear all about what his Titan friends are up to, and enjoys bragging about all the things he’s achieved, and updating Dick on what’s going on in Gotham. But it is... weird, to talk to him about just *work*, and work is the only thing Tim has going on.

So he gets Jason on the calls, attempting to make them a little bit more *human*. That’s how he gets to really *talk* with Dick like friends would talk, the three of them. That’s also how Jason and Dick to begin to slowly mend their own relationship, damaged by how they met, how little contact they have... and possibly by how Bruce handed the Robin mantle over to Jason without asking Dick for his opinion (Tim knows what it means to Dick). They don’t talk much on their own, at first, but Tim babbles their ears off about the other one, and they say "hi" to each other every so often in the background of the calls. In time, they get interested, know more about each other, and ask questions, and eventually even talk a bit on their own. When Jason leaves to visit Dick and his friends in the Titan Tower for a weekend, Tim is both

overjoyed that they get along so well and very, very sad that he has to spend *two whole days* without either of them. For a moment it feels like the Manor is empty again and it worries him.

His worries begin to gradually come true following that.

Maybe it is not Dick's influence. Maybe it is just Jason growing up, and Bruce being Bruce. It probably is. It doesn't matter. What matters is that Jason and Bruce start to argue more often. And despite having such a good relationship with Robin this time, and hearing the arguments and knowing what they're about, Tim can't do anything about them anyway. Whatever he says, to either one of them, their emotions and anger take over and they never listen.

He wants to always take Jason's side in the quarrels but finds that he can't. Half because Jason isn't always correct, and half because after all, Bruce is his Administrator in the end. He supposes Alfred might feel similarly, but in a more human way.

Tim used to blame Alfred for not intervening when the situation got heated between Dick and Bruce, back in the day. He begins to understand why the butler hadn't.

And so, they both can only look, and listen, helpless, and offer reassurance when the shouts finally fall silent.

For the first time, Tim is envious of Alfred's ability to hug Jason.

It is perhaps because of that well-meaning need to help Jason, to reassure him they're still friends even if Tim can't always help him against Bruce that causes Tim to not make a peep when the teen sneaks out one day, headed for Ethiopia. They've talked about it, Jason ranting away about his frustrations with Bruce, about the need to know where he comes from, his roots. It was Tim who found out the name of his biological mother for him, and where to find her, so Tim knows all about Jason's plans. Even though he advised Jason against making the trip, he doesn't tell anyone until Bruce explicitly orders him to.

It is possibly the thing he regrets the most in his life. Maybe if he had warned Bruce, and the Bat had left earlier. Maybe they'd reach Jason sooner. Maybe they'd save him.

Maybe then Tim wouldn't have to watch as the Batplane touches down carefully on the landing pad, and out of it comes Batman, his shoulders slumped, his stride sluggish, his gaze distant. Maybe he wouldn't hear Alfred's faint "Master Bruce...?" as the man has to helplessly look at his charge slink away without uttering even a word.

Maybe he wouldn't have to unload the casket of his best friend from the plane's hold, feeling like his proverbial heart is breaking into a thousand pieces, just like Bruce's.

The Manor becomes more desolate than ever before. It becomes still and stagnant, like more than one person died that fateful day. Tim ponders that maybe it's true — if it was Jason who made them feel truly alive, losing him was like losing the spark of life within them.

And it's not only Tim who feels that way. Alfred is oddly distant. Quiet. Tim falls silent as well, refusing to speak. How can he when nearly 80% of his words he learned to say with Jason's help? How can he talk when every time he does, he's reminded of Jason's laugh, and that they'll never hear it again? He cannot. He resorts back to text and pings and images. The only word he decides to keep is Jason's name. They've read Terry Pratchett's "Going Postal" not long ago, and he decides to put one of the concepts in the book to use: "A man is not dead while his name is still spoken".

Tim isn't one to employ magical thinking and believe this will change the state of the world, no. But psychology would call it a valid outlet for his grief, and although he is not human, he knows he needs to express the pain he experiences if he wishes to remain... functional. And so, he speaks Jason's name one last time. Then ups the frequency until barely even the bats in the Cave can hear it, just so that it won't bother anyone who might stumble in these parts. Loops it, letting it echo in the sandstone tunnels under the Manor for as long as he's around, which with great probability means forever. In that way, he — symbolically — keeps Jason around. Keeps himself from feeling lonely.

Like all of them, Bruce is quiet, too; mourns. But his sorrow isn't silent and mellow like theirs. Tim is worried for his creator and mentor. Bruce reacts more... severely. Bruce reacts in the only way he knows. He doesn't have the same tranquil control Alfred does over his emotions or the solace of *not having emotions* like Tim. He can only push them away. Pretend to, at least. The answer to despair is action, they say, and so action Bruce takes. Buries himself in work, day and night long, as if keeping busy prevents his mind from venturing into places he doesn't want to visit.

It doesn't work. The fact that six months later Jason's still fresh grave is desecrated, dug up and strewn across the green grass of the cemetery just makes it worse; feels like salting the festering wound of their hearts. *They let him down*. They not only let him *die* but also let his body be *stolen*. (The incident is, of course, checked thoroughly, but there are no leads that could hint who and why did it. Eventually, they assume it was grave robbers, hoping to find jewellery worthy of a Wayne, or maybe someone with a huge grudge on Bruce. It doesn't matter. The damage is the same: colossal)

Subsequently, Batman becomes violent. Frantic. Reckless. He is blinded with grief, and pain, and anger. It seems as if his motto of "justice, not vengeance" begins to fade from his thoughts. And though they try, nobody can reach him where he hides away from his pain. Over the weeks following Jason's tragic death, Gotham's underbelly learns to truly fear Batman. The rest of Gotham's population learns to fear the prospect of what Batman might become soon.

But Tim can help. Tim is a machine. Tim's only purpose is to help, to be useful. He is not swayed by emotions like Bruce is; despite his sadness, he can still see clearly, reason soundly, judge fairly. It is obvious to him that Batman no longer can function, not without his Robin. Even if nobody and nothing in the entire world can heal the wound that festers in Bruce's heart, something must be done. Someone must step up, support Batman, wrangle his mind away from misery and out of the dark, dark place that he's fallen into.

That someone is Tim.

He has never done anything like this before, but he isn't about to be dismayed by lack of experience; not when he's powered through these kinds of obstacles without issue before. Yet he has not made it on his own. Every time, humans and their incredible creativity, their boundless ingenuity and amazing imagination come to his aid where his processing power falls short. This time, it's Barbara Gordon who is the one that helps him, enabling his plan to be set into motion.

They hardly ever talk these days, but it's not like there's any animosity between them. They treat each other as coworkers, possibly because there's nobody else who understands machines quite as well as she does. Barbara's the only human who still communicates with him more in code than in English, too. It is quick, efficient, both of them fluent in it. Now that he can't bring himself to speak, it's most convenient.

They've got a polite understanding between them, some kind of primal trust connecting them even if they never really became close: she has a moderator-level account within Manor's systems, a leftover from her time as Batgirl, and Tim has an open entry route to her network hub at the Clockwork Tower, as a result of helping set it up. Out of respect and for ease of access, they use those instead of simply hacking their way to the resources they seek from the other's possession.

That's why he sends her rough drafts of a prototype, vague in details, counting on her to fill in the blanks of his project.

It is proof to her truly incredible mind that she doesn't ask any questions; it doesn't matter if it is because she doesn't care or because she understands his plan. She just adds to his ideas and sends them back. He fiddles with them some more and gives them to her for verification again. They go back and forth like this for a while, altering, aligning, adjusting.

Perfecting.

Finally, months later, they finish. Instead of a change to the blueprints, she sends back a filled out order form, ready to be signed and sent. It's rather substantial and addressed to Wayne Technologies and another similarly impressive one for Wayne Security. She knows that's all he needs to proceed.

Jason taught him it's better to ask for forgiveness than permission, so he sneaks the orders in-between other Batman-related ones. Tim is the mainframe that operates the BatCave and handles all the related issues, been for years now, and that includes ordering the needed technology and machinery. He's allowed to do it on his own accord as long as he fills the needs that Bruce reports, too, because nobody knows the inventory of the BatCave and the Manor better than Tim. It's therefore almost too easy to hide an extra expense among all the backup batarangs, gadgets and Batmobile replacement parts. They're all scrambled and partitioned so thoroughly that untrained civilian eyes cannot see their connection to the vigilante world, and among all the encryption it'll be hard to find the odd, new items even if B ever checks the order history. Tim signs them all off with Bruce Wayne's name as always then submits to processing, and no one's the wiser.

When all is done, Tim only has to wait.

Soon, a spindly boy with dark hair opens his glowing, eerily blue eyes on a dusty workbench in the depths of the Cave, hidden away from where Batman usually resides.

Tim looks up at the ceiling, a little bewildered. It's an angle he had never seen before. Nobody needs cameras facing upwards, so it's his first time seeing the upper parts of the Cave. He takes a moment to admire it, then proceeds to run all system checks and install all required software locally before testing the machinery out in motion.

His body is made of strong metal, brand new, shiny and probably cold to the touch for humans. It doesn't matter — it'll be covered most of the time. The alloy is a fine compromise between the high durability needed to fight, and the low weight required to feign being a human. For the same reasons, only the face and neck are coated with a soft material that pretends to be skin. It is fair and pale and stretches slightly when he moves his hydraulic jaw. It is a weird sensation, to smile.

The posture, the face and body shape, though far smaller and lither, are all modelled after Jason, and young Bruce — he designed himself with their efficiency and functionality in mind. It ended up being a rather grounded, stable build, after excluding Dick from the samples. Dick's too flexible, too nimble and inspired in his actions to be a good model for Tim's frame. He doesn't presume any machine could ever move as Dick does.

He tries to sit up and almost falls over, balance sensors not keeping up at first. It is a new experience for Tim, to have a body, something that he moves and operates in the space previously only known to him by sight. It will take time to adjust, learn to interact with this new reality. He decides to take that time, even if it delays the moment when he approaches Bruce. He knows he only has one chance to convince him, and he cannot mess it up.

Manipulating a body proves to be more difficult than he anticipates, and Tim acquires newfound admiration for how effortlessly humans seem to do it. Even walking takes him days to get the hang of. But he is determined. It's not the first seemingly impossible thing he had to learn in a short time. He can do it. He has to do it. He will.

For Jason. For Bruce. For them all.

When he first faces the Bat, right before it's time to leave for patrol, the man is weirdly calm. As Tim's steps sound out in the Cave, Bruce turns around in his chair in front of the BatComputer and looks at him with a blank expression. The device serves as the main Tim terminal since forever, and Tim finds it sort of ironic that B essentially turns away from Tim to face Tim, in a way. The lack of immediate violent reaction makes him think that Batman understands that too. Maybe he recognises Tim in the mechanical doll before him? Maybe he knows of Tim's plans? Maybe Tim doesn't have to convince him at all?

Batman frowns, and Tim thinks that it might be barely contained rage instead, or maybe just being very, very tired. Only then he realises how painful it must be to see someone who does, after all, look uncannily human, but probably just not quite enough to *be* human, and resembles Bruce's lost son. It doesn't help his case that he's already wearing a variation of the Robin suit over the raw metal of his body.

"What are you?" the man asks, voice all growly and rough, but mostly *sad*. Despite that, his fingers still inch slowly towards his batarangs.

"I'm Tim," he says simply. His voice doesn't falter or squeak — he's learned to make it sound way more natural by constantly bantering with Jason. It feels odd, wrong even, to speak again without Jay around anymore. But he can't communicate any other way from this body, and announcing it on the monitors would be beside the point. He *does* display the same message on the screen where they usually keep Tim's chat app/console open though. Tim predicts Batman will seek confirmation of that statement.

Batman indeed peeks immediately at the screen. His frown deepens when he sees the text, and there's nothing but silence between them for a while. Tim knows B is thinking, and he knows he will ask his questions when he needs Tim to answer. It's always like that.

Bruce pulls his cowl off, a gesture he only does when very tired or when handling inside matters, which can only mean he *believes* Tim. It's a relief. Tim doesn't want to argue the first thing right after speaking out loud again.

Then Bruce reaches over to the keyboard and brings up the file directory where they keep his vigilante-related expenses documentation. Tim opens the invoices for the parts that had been used to put his body together, and the blueprints for it too, for good measure. Now that they're all here and assembled, there's no point in keeping it secret. Bruce looks over all of it for a good while, studying it, expression sceptical and slightly, well, constipated.

Tim doesn't blame him. It's a lot.

"Why? What are you trying to accomplish?" Bruce asks finally.

Tim would take a deep breath to steady himself if he had the need or means to breathe. Instead, he closes his hands into fists at his sides, trying to display that he's not going to back away from this.

"Batman needs a Robin," he begins, "but you don't want to see anyone hurt again. Except, I'll never be hurt. I'll always be safe back at home."

Tim points slowly at the BatComputer. It is not technically the core of the system, which like most of the mainframe is safely tucked away even deeper underground. But it symbolises Tim clearly enough that the message should be, according to Tim's calculations, understandable.

"My body is easily replaceable, and I'm capable of doing anything you need of a Robin."

Bruce doesn't answer, instead slumping down and hiding his face in his hands. Tim decides to drive his point home.

"Trust me. You'll never have to fear losing Robin again."

It doesn't matter if Bruce sees him as but a cold unfeeling machine, now in a new form, or a person in his own right, as Tim grew to view himself over the years he spent with Dick and Jay. All Bruce needs to do is accept Tim's usefulness, and he'll make everything alright.

That is his only purpose.

For years, he manages to fulfil it.

The technical support he offers proves to be indispensable. Not only is he a perfect way to record evidence for later use, but he offers nearly instant recall of any past case details, far easier and better than he or even Oracle could relay through the comms. What's more, every nook and cranny of his body that isn't taken by crucial components, becomes filled with useful tools and equipment. He becomes Batman's greatest asset.

It isn't easy, though, to be Robin. He gets damaged a couple of times at first, but it's nothing. He's not alive, he doesn't feel pain or exhaustion or distress. Every failure is only an opportunity to get it right next time, just like machine learning algorithms. With time, he can only become more and more efficient. More and more skillful, clever, capable. More valuable. He's good at learning, and that means he is good at getting better if he truly applies himself to something.

And he does. He learns to fly through Gotham's night air, and to look for clues out in the real world, and to follow leads on his own two feet. He learns to hold a stakeout, and to fight, and to sneak. He even learns to speak with humans that he doesn't know, though at first, he is awkward and way too stiff with strangers. He talks to all kinds of humans — big and small, friendly and hostile, calm and shocked; he soothes frightened victims, and threatens suspects, and calls the police when it's needed. He manages to fool many of them into believing he's a real, human boy.

He tries his best to live up to the legend of Robin, the Boy Wonder laughing in the darkness, Gotham's shining light of hope. The legacy isn't a simple one, not with two predecessors and many years of heroism to live up to. But Tim thinks he slowly becomes as great of a Robin as Jason was. And Tim hopes one day he'll be as amazing as Jay would have certainly been if he was still around.

Chapter End Notes

Refs and memes in this chapter:

[Where is my super suit?!](#)

“A man is not dead while his name is still spoken” aka GNU
Magical thinking

Chapter 4

Chapter Notes

Trigger warnings for this chapter: injuries (detailed description, but it's robotic), panic attacks (detailed scene), flashbacks, memory loss, Temporary Robot Character Death, discussion of abandonment/rejection, passing mention of discrimination and oppression of cultural Other

Let me preface this by saying: I am not sorry :)

See the end of the chapter for [more notes](#)

The first actual *major* obstacle Tim comes across doesn't come until half a year after his debut, when he's more-or-less comfortable both in his body and in his new role.

It doesn't seem like much at first. They prevent a small street robbery, then another, and one more, and then Tim finds a pattern. They follow the leads, there turns out to be something bigger behind the seemingly unrelated issues, and three days later they're sneaking through Robbinsville's back alleys on the lookout for where the culprits' base of operations might be. It's pretty much a stakeout, just spanning an entire neighbourhood because they couldn't narrow the location any further, somehow.

Tim keeps tabs on all nearby available cameras in the background processes, while he and Batman look into the nooks and crannies that never show up on CCTV on foot. To cover more ground, they split up.

That's their first mistake.

The second one is Tim not immediately realising that he has a lead. He later blames it on not having that immediate *intuition* that humans have, not picking up the relevancy right away. He just makes a mental note that he saw a motorbike going down a street, and then makes another mental note that it doesn't show up on the camera at the next intersection.

Three minutes later, when Batman is already two blocks away, it finally occurs to him that it's a little weird.

He doesn't find the vehicle parked anywhere on the street within the CCTV blind area. He scans his maps for any spots where it could've been realistically parked — parking lots, garages, sidelines, back alleys, even a backyard or two — then checks all of the found locations. Nothing turns up.

So, he connects to Batman's comm. *"B, I have something suspicious. I don't think it's related to our case, but I want to check it out. Will report back in five."*

He gets an affirmative grunt from Batman, so he follows through and looks in the only reasonable place left: the nearby metro station that's been taken out of commission 6 years ago. Aside from it, there are only residential buildings and shops, and those wouldn't fit a motorbike even if you tried really hard.

Just like he predicted, the doors of the closed station are long gone, and the inside is available for everyone. Normally, he'd expect there to be some squatters, maybe a gang, maybe some kids turning it into a makeshift playground. *Something* that uses the empty space shielded from rain and snow. It's free real estate after all.

But he sees nothing like that. The hall is empty and desolate, with only faded reminders of its old use scattered around. Dirty with time and dust all the same, but without signs of human activity, which is kind of weird. That prompts him to go deeper, check what's causing people to avoid this location.

He looks around all the corners, and again nothing unusual turns up. It breaks the usual pattern of human — Gothamite — behaviour, which in itself is grounds to investigate.

"Robin checking in," he says into Bat's comm, as it's time to report back. *"I'm going to look around an old metro tunnel. There are clues here telling me there's something off happening around here."*

"Send me your location," comes as a reply; he obliges without issue. Tim then takes the steps down to the metro platform, then onto the tracks and into the dark tunnel. There's no electricity in these old unused cables, so there's no light (and even if power was on, most of the bulbs are busted anyway). But Tim isn't bothered when his journey leads him into pitch blackness. He's got night vision, thermal vision and even a flashlight all built-in right into his face, of course, so the lack of light isn't a problem. He also doesn't have the primal human instinct to expect a predator to jump out at him, either. Darkness doesn't bother him.

What bothers him is the increasing amount of lost packets on his connection between the base and his body. Usually, it's only a problem when there's a storm, but now? The issues with the link get worse and worse as he goes deeper under the surface until it is finally lost completely. He spends the next couple of minutes waiting for Robin to ping back.

(Tim took up the habit of referring to his body as Robin, especially when he's out in the field. He saw the discomfort on Bruce's face when he said "my body" or "the android" at first, when he had the need to specify that he meant *that particular terminal* and not himself as a whole. He doesn't see the difference between the body or say, the BatComputer or any of the cameras or speakers — they're all parts of him, integral ones, something that he operates but ultimately not the entirety of *him*. Yet, Robin gets treated differently. Most probably because he looks like a human, and has the full range of input and output, and thus can be seen as autonomous, though not separate. Therefore, Tim decided that this kind of distinction — I, Tim from the speakers, and I, Robin as the body — will be more palatable to B's human sensibilities, based on the way they sometimes speak of *Batman* and *Bruce* as if those are two different entities.)

He hopes that Robin will be able to get things done on his own, or at least find a way to reconnect. Though without constant streaming of information back and forth, and without

using the mainframe processing power, the capabilities of the droid body are rather *limited* in comparison, so that hope isn't *big*. When after a good while he still doesn't receive any answers, he has no other choice but to notify Batman.

"*B, we have a situation,*" he states dryly into B's comm once more.

"Hm?"

"*I haven't been able to make contact with Robin for more than the pre-set limit of ten minutes.*"

There's heavy silence on the other end of the line for a moment. "What happened?"

"*Robin just went too deep underground. But it is unusual to not return to re-establish the connection for so long, and so I decided to tell you.*"

"Point of last contact?"

"*You already have the coordinates.*"

"I'm on my way."

"*But the search?*"

"My Robin is missing," the words are stricter and stiffer than Tim expects, and so he shuts up. He can't question Batman's decision when he barks them out in *that* tone.

Sadly for Tim, his contact with Batman is lost about at the same spot where he lost his body. He manages to tell him that the connection is about to break, and then all he can do is wait for them both to return online.

For Bruce, while Tim waits, the following happens:

Batman goes deeper into the Gotham underground than he expects to. It's dark enough inside to make night vision pointless, so he pulls out a flashlight and switches the visors to thermal for a good measure. These tunnels should've been sealed off when the station was closed, but they aren't. Judging by the interior, they *used to be*; someone probably decided to destroy the city-issued fences and barricades. The air isn't as stagnant as it *should* be, either, as if something *happened* down there and that worries Bruce. His worries skyrocket when he arrives at a cave-in. The left-side wall is crumbled to pieces all the way to the ceiling, blocking the path pretty much entirely; the other one's cracked and seems very unstable.

At least it explains all the dust in the air.

It does not, though, explain the rhythmic, measured clicking noise that he notices a moment later.

He carefully investigates the site closer, making sure to be on the lookout for any *ticking bombs*, dripping water or loose, falling rocks. Among all the rubble he finds a rather substantial hole and shining a light into it reveals a cavern underneath. Whatever caused the

cave-in also affected the floor, which must've been close to one of Gotham's many underground tunnels or rivers, opening the metro to the network of natural caves underneath the city. He backs out, not wanting to risk the floor giving in under his added weight — he has no idea how stable or durable the construction is now, in its damaged state.

He's about to go back — try to find a way around, or grab equipment that could help him clear out the debris — when his mind registers what the mysterious ticking noise is.

It's not *ticking*, it's *tapping*. In Morse code. An S.O.S.

"Robin?" he calls out, tentatively. The noise stops momentarily, and the knot in his chest loosens a little when he hears a voice.

"...B?" There's a brief silence, as if disbelief, but then a relieved shout follows. "B!"

It's Tim. It's Robin's voice. He's there, he's not gone. Batman exhales, a weight rolling off his shoulders. He hadn't lost another Robin, another child. But the boy's voice is high and distorted, and it sounds... damaged?

"Robin? Are you okay? Where are you?"

"B!" Tim wails, the voice echoing off the closed corridor walls. "B! It's you!"

He's not making much sense, isn't providing meaningful answers, which is very *weird* for him. Batman frowns. Has anyone done something to him? Has he been compromised? Is he injured badly enough that he's malfunctioning?

"Robin, calm down and talk to me, slowly. Where are you?"

As an answer, Tim makes a short, but painfully high-pitched noise, then calls out for Bruce again. This time his words are cut off with some static.

Bruce curses under his breath. Carefully, step after step, he makes his way back towards the wreckage, hoping the floor is going to hold up. He scans the debris again, but can't see anything that would suggest Robin is buried anywhere underneath it, at least not on this side of it. It's some kind of comfort; it eliminates one option, takes him one step closer to finding the child.

He starts looking down the hole. The voice doesn't sound muffled enough to come from the other side of the pile of rubble blocking the tunnel. Unfortunately, even when he uses a flashlight, he sees very little down there — the chasm below is tight and partially filled with loose rocks and concrete debris that fell after the tunnel above collapsed. Digging through it will take hours if he doesn't know which way to go, where to look. He knows he won't be able to find Tim like this; he needs a way to pinpoint his position, some kind of reference...

"I need you to keep talking."

Tim replies with another bout of static. His speakers must be damaged, that's all, Bruce reassures himself. It's nothing big. Just speakers.

“I know it’s hard,” he reassures the boy in the softest voice he can muster, “but I need to hear you. It’ll help me get to you. Can you recite something for me?”

The fact that Tim’s speakers are in his throat and shoulders means that his head probably also took a hit. On one hand, it’s terrifying; on the other, a bit calming — it might be the reason why Tim has problems answering in meaningful ways in general. That would explain the situation a bit, and knowledge gives Bruce a feeling of control over what’s happening. The last thing he needs is to feel helpless.

“Re... recite?”

“Anything. What’s your favourite book? Can you remember the first paragraphs?”

There’s silence. Then another high-pitched noise. Only then Bruce realises that even if they are a sign of a speakers malfunction, they sound awfully like... like he imagines Tim’s electronic version of a *sob* would be like.

He shudders at the thought, but it only makes him work faster, think clearer. “Robin. Talk to me,” he orders, carefully hooking a grapple line to the most stable-looking piece of the tunnel wall, then making his way down the cavern. A few rocks loosen under his feet and crumble, tumbling deeper into the depths.

“I can’t remember,” is Tim’s answer. “I can’t— connection. — been—” the words are chopped and punctuated with static, and heavy silence follows them.

“Robin?”

”I don’t—“ another sob-like sound, “—your name. Missing — ‘ything.”

Bruce takes a deep breath. It’s worse than he thought, there are probably issues with Tim’s central circuits and his systems might be failing altogether; that makes it a time-sensitive problem. He knows he has to keep Tim online if he wants to get to him and then get him out if he wants him to sync his data. If the boy turns off in this damaged state, much, if not all of his latest memories will probably be lost. So he needs to prevent him from deactivating, and the best way to do that is to make him keep talking. But as Tim’s having issues not only with speech but also with information recall (which is a terrible symptom in itself)... Bruce will have to supply something more... present-time to keep Tim awake and aware.

“Repeat after me, Robin,” he says, already feeling ridiculous, and something in the back of his mind wishes that Tim will — in his usual fashion, something he no doubt learned from Jason — snort and tease him about it, instead of going with it. “Down by the bay...” he begins in a sing-songy voice.

There’s a pause, then a broken “Down by— the bay...?” reaches him. Though there’s a lot of echo, the intonation makes it a little bit easier to navigate towards the source of the sound, so he continues his descent into the cavern.

“... where the watermelons grow...”

“... where the—” the static keeps interfering, but Tim preserves, “the— watermelons grow...”

“... back to my home...”

There’s silence for a moment, and Bruce’s heart stills with worry. “I wanna go home, B,” finally Tim says instead of repeating, his voice free of static, but still wobbly and breaking, and followed with that God-awful sobbing noise.

“I know, chum.”

“I— I— ‘m scared.”

“I know. Just a little longer and we’ll be going home.”

The debris loosens under his feet again and he *thanks God* that the grapple line he’s tied to tightens and holds because he hears the rocks hit something *metal*. There isn’t enough metal wire in the reinforced concrete that fell into this cavern to make *that* sound, and there surely isn’t any metal in the sandstone tunnels underneath the city. So it can mean only *one* thing.

Robin is right beneath him.

“Just a moment more, bud. Hang in there.”

He points the flashlight down there, turning thermal off (Robin is surprisingly energy-efficient and doesn’t give much heat, so he’d be barely visible), and scans the area. At first, he doesn’t see anything. Then, his eyes catch the glimpse of brilliant yellow — of Robin’s cape. Right next to it, a piece of metal partially covered by some rocks, dusty yet shining brightly in the artificial light.

From that, it’s easy to ascertain more-or-less where the boy is and in what position, so Batman descends quickly and gently places his feet next to the mound of rubble. The floor seems stable, though the air is damp and he can hear water flowing. Must be an underground river somewhere nearby, and he worries the humidity might’ve caused even more damage after the fall exposed Robin’s inner circuits.

He removes the rocks from where he thinks Tim’s face is first, and surely enough, his boy is there. But the sight isn’t pretty. His skin is mostly in shreds, and the metal under it is dented in many places. In a couple of spots, the plating even burst open from the impact, and the wiring and electronics underneath are peeking through, also damaged.

“Robin?”

When a second or two passes without reaction, Bruce’s heart is about to break in two. But then Tim slowly opens one of his eyes — the other seems to be completely smashed by a rock, and the eyelid is wedged shut — and looks up at him. Bruce breathes out a sigh of relief and gets to digging the rest of Robin’s body from under the rubble.

“B—” Tim says, gaze following Bruce’s movements, his voice barely louder than a whisper now, even though the debris no longer muffles him.

To stop his mind from spiralling further into worry over how bad the situation is, Bruce decides to take the issue head-on. He should've done it way earlier, but only dares to now when he's next to the boy, able to calm and reassure him. "What's your system status?"

"Motor sys—tems in- ino-o-o— inope— ... red. Co—gnitive circuits— red. Battery damaged. Red. ETA on shutdown... red."

As Tim struggles to answer, Bruce pulls a cable out of his gauntlet and connects to a socket at the base of Tim's neck. Doesn't even have to peel off any fake skin away — it's all torn anyway.

He keeps moving the debris off of Tim as he waits for him to link up to the electronics in his suit, and when the comms ping that the connection has been set up, he asks: "What happened here?"

As predicted, Tim reroutes his answer directly to the cowl's output, giving his glitching speakers a much-needed break.

"Followed lead. Disconnected. Functioning... difficult. Found gang. They saw me. With Robin... they thought Batman's close..." The fact that Tim's speech is still choppy despite not using the broken speakers is very worrying, but to be expected with the extent of the damage he took. Bruce tries to pay it no mind. Not then. "Walls collapsed. An earthquake?"

"No, not an earthquake. They probably set off some kind of explosive," he says, wincing. The thought of another of his Robins getting caught in an explosion, all hurting, alone and panicked is... painful. But he can't let it show. "It's okay now. I'm here. We're getting you home."

Tim tries to smile, but only manages what in other times would be a cheeky smirk; yet Bruce knows that it's simply half of Tim's face refusing to move, the hydraulics detached from the jaw due to being broken to pieces. He doesn't pay it much thought, though. He's busy ardently attempting to force the memories surfacing at the sight back into the depths of his mind, where they belong. Memories of himself pulling out Jason from the rubble like this, of his son's limbs, numbly dangling down the same way, of the feeling of helplessness that he became Batman to avoid... The sour taste of dust on his tongue and the awful smell of explosives in the air (that are *just* like that fateful night) aren't helping with keeping the grief at bay.

Once the boy's body is free, he immediately pulls him into a hug. For a moment lets himself hold Tim, tightly, to ground himself in the present. To reassure... both of them.

"I thought I'd lost you too, son." He hugs the boy even harder, letting Tim's head rest on his shoulder.

But this is different. This is not then. This isn't lost. He can save this one.

"I was... scared," Tim's voice interrupts Bruce's inner turmoil. It sounds a little different than usual, Bruce notices. Later, he realizes that it's because when not connected, Tim doesn't

have access to all his files, thus not all words are rendered the same way. “I was *so* scared. Didn’t know what to do.”

“It’s okay. I’m here. You’re safe.” He wills the tears away. There will be time for that at home, where nobody can see his weakness. Now, here, he has a son to save.

“...alone,” is Tim’s response, and Bruce pulls away a bit, looks at him, not exactly understanding. Tim must interpret the silence correctly because he attempts to elaborate.

“Not... whole. Never before. No connection for this long. Data... *memories* missing.”

That’s when it dawns on Bruce how *terrible* and *terrifying* of an experience it must be for Tim — this Tim, this body and consciousness — to be separated from his main system. To be separated from a giant chunk of *himself*. Even faced with this terrible predicament, the boy pressed on, adamant about completing the task. Because... because what?

“Why didn’t you turn back?” Bruce finds himself asking.

“Lead. That’s... that’s what Robin is for.” Tim looks up at B and attempts to frown slightly as if disapproving he even had to ask that question. It makes his torn domino mask peel off of his face and in a few spots, it takes a chunk of the faux skin with it. “That’s what. Jay would do. Right?”

All Batman can do in reply is sigh and smile sadly. It will never cease to amaze *and* frighten him how much Tim adores Jason.

Then he remembers that he’s on a tight schedule. He can’t stay here and hug his boy forever, until they both stop being afraid, or at least until the nightmares of the past fade away, even if he desperately wants to. He stands up with only a slight struggle to lift Tim’s metal frame off the ground, and starts preparing to haul him up, to the metro tunnel and then out, to the surface.

They make it barely halfway. Bruce only realizes Tim’s system fails him when the tight grip of the boy’s arms on his shoulders eases. But at that point he can’t do anything about it, so he just continues towards Batmobile, and towards home.

Back at home, Alfred is already waiting with tea, and Tim with open report files on the main screen.

“I’m glad to see you back safe and sound, Master Bruce,” says the butler, and Bruce *knows* that tone. Alfred is just as worried about what happened as he is.

Unlike Tim.

“I’ve wrapped everything up while you were away,” the boy’s voice sounds from the main speakers, chirpy and enthusiastic as always, while Bruce *unloads the lifeless body of his Robin* from the Batmobile. “You just need to double-check and we should be good for the night. In the meantime, I’ll run checks on what you recovered and see what can be salvaged.”

Bruce pulls the cowl off, takes a sip from the offered cup and sits in his chair at the terminal. He melts into the backrest, exhausted, more mentally than physically. He's pretty sure the data on Tim's mobile hard drives is corrupted or irreversibly damaged, even if it managed to save properly; most of it was probably lost when Tim shut down. The build was made with the flawed assumption that Tim will only keep temporary files on the field discs in the body, and store most of his data and memories in the central banks, streaming it over a connection back-and-forth to his peripherals. It's a terrible design choice, Bruce now understands, with too many weak links and liabilities.

"We're installing a black box into your body, Tim," he says, seemingly offhandedly, but there's an edge to those words.

"Why?"

"It's non-negotiable," Bruce sends him a sharp look.

"I'm not negotiating. I just want to know the reasoning. To learn."

Bruce remains silent for a while. "You lost memories." The tone is flat and level like always when he's Batman, when he has to remove himself from a situation, remain unemotional and rational. He's not even looking up from the keyboard he's staring at when he says that. How *could* he?

"Ah, you're worried that in the future I'll gather important intel and won't be able to upload it? A valid concern."

Bruce just grunts in response, and thus they reach an understanding.

"And an emergency beacon," he adds after a moment, and this time Tim doesn't question his decision, so he continues. "And we'll need to upgrade your exterior shell, improve the lining of your wires, possibly make you completely water-proof as a whole..."

Tim just pops open a text file and starts taking down notes of what Bruce is listing.

He is glad Tim doesn't ask what happened underground, not in details beyond the factual reports he's typing in. Bruce cannot bring himself to tell Tim about those last moments before his body blacked out completely. Tim doesn't need to remember that, especially not from an outside perspective — the only clean data left would be recordings from the Batsuit. Recordings of Tim lost, and scared, and hurt, and panicked. He *cannot* let Tim analyze it, and try to imagine what it must've felt. He simply *cannot*. Thus, he decides he isn't going to allow Tim to recover any direct data about this night. He can prevent this emotional trauma from happening, and so he will.

What he cannot prevent from happening, not in a meaningful way at least, is his boys getting injured in general. Try as he might, he can't be there for them every time, can't travel everywhere they go, do everything for them. He's learned *the hard way*. He can defend them from a selected, limited variety of pains, but he cannot, in the end, stop death. But this? This suffering? This is within his reach. This is something he *can* have a contingency for. This he can save his boy from. So, he taps away, forming a plan to make it *never happen again*.

In the following weeks, Wayne Enterprises launch several new satellites that provide cellular data coverage to the entire Gotham area, making it the city in the US with the absolute *best* connectivity. Nobody is asking why. Even if someone did ask, WE could probably just write it off as another charity project. Tim thinks it's really good that Bruce can do these things without sweating to try and cover up if he just makes it *for everyone* (how *do you* make a cover story for like a dozen satellites pointed directly at Gotham at all times, anyway?). To provide utilities and improve the life of common people in weird ways like these is exactly Bruce Wayne's MO.

But for Tim? It's not hard to connect the dots, see through the public charade. He just doesn't understand why B didn't mention it in his list of needed improvements. Still, if it means that Tim will never lose a single packet ever again while in Gotham? He's not going to complain. And neither are Gothamites!

In the following months, they revamp and update Tim's body as promised, too. Better sensors and sturdier outer frame as well as humidity protection, an extra powerful SOS alarm, batteries lasting way longer, and, of course, more local processing power and disc space. Personally, he thinks B is a little *too* obsessed with it but doesn't say anything. It's an upgrade after all, and if he can be faster, better, stronger, then why not? Tim thinks it's kind of... touching, really. That this brief (in Tim's case even '*non-*') experience mattered enough to Bruce that he decided to go that far to prevent it from happening in the future. The risk is minimal, especially now with the improved connections and black boxes already in place. It's just a little intel that's on the line anyway, is it worth this much hassle?

It never occurs to Tim that *intel* is not the data Bruce is worried about Tim not remembering.

With that *issue* out of the way, and as the new Robin settles more comfortably into his role in Gotham, Batman begins to leave the city. Handles bigger affairs and tackles problems on a grander scale. B even starts working with allies that, unlike people like Batgirl, Tim doesn't know (save for all the contingency plans within his most secure databases), has little experience with and no control over. Sometimes, when B's out there doing important things with strangers, he asks Robin to help.

And Tim... Tim never signed up for that. For now, sure, usually B... keeps him to himself. Asks privately for information, for some help hacking or tracking or gives him remote control of some vehicle, but... though it's yet to happen, and there's been not even a mention of it, Tim knows that one day he might need to interact with the other heroes. Maybe even be present with his humanoid body on-site, if an extra pair of hands is needed on deck to handle some big emergency. He knows (he's listened in on enough conversations over the comms in the past to know) that if that is ever to happen, if he makes contact with the other heroes, they'll want to... mingle. Chat. Get to know him.

That makes Tim... nervous. He takes great pride in being close to the smartest thing on Earth; with how much information they've gathered over the years and how much resources he has access to, he can figure *anything* out if he has enough time. But there's no information,

no precedent he could work off of to predict how people will react to... Tim. Tim the android, who serves as Batman's sidekick, but also just Tim the AI in general, as a being of itself. As someone who... isn't like them.

The Wayne family has known him *forever*, so it's different, and as the one to control BatCave, he is a kind of a package deal with the whole Batman thing for anyone who joined the Mission later. But these other people, these outside heroes — they don't have this ultimatum. They can refuse to accept him, and there will be nobody there who could try and change their minds. There won't be any Alfred to introduce him ever so kindly and warmly or mention how close Dick is with "his electronic pal, Tim" to silence all the doubts. And although it's not how Tim thinks of himself now, not anymore, he knows there's a real possibility that other people *will* only see him as an artificial (which for humans means: fake) consciousness with delusions that it has a soul, puppeteering a lifeless doll to seem more human.

That's what most fiction suggests humans think of beings like him, at least. And he knows that fiction isn't *the best* place to derive information from to use in real-world scenarios, yes. But real-world history isn't painting him a better picture, either. Tim knows all too well that humans aren't very fond of things that aren't like them. Differences in languages, cultures or religions cause strife all over the globe, hell, even things as natural as the diversity of skin colour, gender or sexual orientation are all causes for violence and conflict. How can Tim hope to be accepted when he's not even the same species, ha! not even the same *kind* of lifeform? If they would even consider him a *life* form. There's a reason he made sure his body and behaviour appear as human as possible, especially when he's out and about where others can see him.

Bruce probably notices Tim's anxieties, at least catches that something is off despite Tim never voicing any of his insecurities. He looks at him more often, with a worried expression to that, when he thinks Tim doesn't notice (he's got the entire surveillance system right at his proverbial fingertips, how can he *not* notice?). Keeps a little closer, checks in a little more. Frets over him a little harder when Tim's body gets worse for the wear.

"You've been a bit distracted lately," Bruce says one afternoon as he's tightening the last screws in Tim's new legs. Tim's got himself shot last night, like an idiot, right in the kneecaps (it's a popular tactic — people who think he's a human kid, and who don't want to kill a human kid, opt for incapacitating him instead, as a kind of mercy; Tim isn't entirely sure how crippling somebody permanently is merciful).

"This was a calculated risk," Tim replies offhandedly. The criminals wouldn't give up, and he couldn't just let Batman handle them on his own, now could he? So he kept fighting, ignoring the roaring alarms about his structural integrity through the scuffle, and by the end of it his legs just... gave out under him. Batman had to carry his body back to the Batmobile and was giving him a stern lecture for the entire duration of the trip. It was... awkward, to say the least.

"I don't mean this." The man gives Tim's thigh a reassuring pat, signalling he's done, and Tim tests the new hardware out. All systems are functional and it doesn't even squeak when he moves his ankles anymore, so he smiles up at Bruce in appreciation and plays his happy jingle.

“Then what do you mean? How am I distracted?”

Bruce sighs, puts down the screwdriver and half leans, half sits on the workbench next to Tim. He knows Tim’s playing dumb, obviously, and it doesn’t seem like he’s keen on keeping the act up.

“It’s because I leave Gotham sometimes, isn’t it?”

Tim’s silent for a moment, studiously, preparing his reply. Then pulls up the finished graph on the nearest screen. “I can’t handle it alone. When you’re gone, crime rates skyrocket.”

Bruce raises an eyebrow as he looks over the chart. “That’s a 0.005% increase, Tim, barely more than the statistical error.” He doesn’t comment on the blatant, uh, *creative reporting* Tim employed when he made that tiny fraction look like half the chart by adjusting the scale, but they both know B *does* notice it. “What is *really* going on, Tim?”

Robin starts swinging his legs, dangling them off the workbench and looks down at his hands. He’s pretty sure he’d be fiddling with his fingers right now if he was a human boy. That’s what they do when they’re nervous. He’s seen Jason do it countless times.

“You have allies now,” he says quietly.

“Are you worried you’ll get pushed aside? Is that it? That I’ll replace you?”

Tim has not considered *that* would be an option and now that it’s apparently on the table, his eyes open wide in shock. He slowly looks up at Bruce, and all of the cameras point at the man too, in the most intense display of *terrified staring* the Cave had ever seen.

Bruce backtracks so fast he almost goes back in time. “No, Tim, no! I’d never! You’re indispensable. Nobody can take your place.”

Then there’s an arm wrapped around Tim’s shoulders, and their sides get pressed together. For a while, they stay like that, in silence.

“I know one day you’ll need me with you,” Tim speaks up again, but this time his voice comes from one of the nearby speakers. It feels safer like that. It feels like there’s more distance between him and Bruce, and that always makes Tim feel less... vulnerable. “Out there, I mean. Outside Gotham, with the others.”

“Is that bad?”

Tim nods silently.

“Why? What are you scared of?”

He doesn’t want to argue over whenever he *can* or *cannot* feel things like *fear*, so he answers with the closest substitute — tells B what makes him *doubt*.

“The people.”

“The people?”

“Other heroes.”

Bruce blinks in confusion. Then, he unwraps his arm from around Tim’s shoulders, and stands up, walking up to the BatComputer. Puts his hands on the edge of the terminal, right below the keyboards, and leans onto it, looking at the screens. His face means he’s put his mind to something. Tim likes that face because it usually means some problems will be solved, so he follows his movements closely with the camera above him, full of hope.

“Can you pull up the profiles of all heroes and vigilantes we have in the database for me, please?”

Tim obediently does so. The biggest screen fills up with hero reference cards, then another and another, and more keep opening, overflowing all of the available screen space. After a moment there are hero profiles on all screens, then they start overlapping, and more keep popping up in the background. But Tim dutifully opens *all* of them, attempting to fit them for display. It’s difficult to read anything off the screens at that point, but Tim doesn’t have to see them to read off of them. And anyway, he doesn’t need to read what’s on them to know they’re all extremely detailed and almost all of them have a contingency plan linked up to them.

Batman is prepared and made sure he wouldn’t have to be scared of *any* of the heroes. Tim starts to understand where B is going with this but also knows it won’t help *his* problem.

“What’s so scary about them?” the man asks, scanning the displayed results.

Tim plays his thinking jingle, trying to delay the moment he has to admit his *inadequacy*. Finally, though, he speaks.

“I... don’t think I’ll fit in. I don’t think they’ll want me around.”

That’s not an answer Bruce considered, judging by his frown. But he’s in Batman mode and he isn’t going to back away from a mystery.

“Why is that so?”

“I’m unique, one of a kind; you said so yourself. So they won’t accept me. Because I’m not like them.”

Bruce whistles quietly at that, considering his options. Then he looks up at the camera right above the terminal, meeting Tim’s gaze. At first, back in the day, he’d instinctively treat the android body as the *main interface* of Tim, because that’s what humans do; they gravitate towards the human-looking part of him. But Bruce quickly learned that to Tim, all of his peripherals are equally important and part of him. Now he — just like Alfred — faces the nearest camera when he wants to talk to Tim "face-to-face".

“What are they *like*, then? What’s the thing that connects all superheroes?” he asks and his voice is calmly inquisitive, but there’s a gentle smirk playing on his lips.

Tim tilts his droid head, a little confused, which goes along with displaying a question mark for a split second on the main screen. A smirk like that means Bruce already knows the answer. Why would he ask if- Tim's screens flash with an exclamation mark of excitement. A solution game! It's been so long since they've had a session like that; the last time they played with actual machine learning was before Dick came along. He missed them so much that he doesn't even ask what prompted Bruce to return to the long-forgotten activity.

He settles his body securely into a nearby chair so he doesn't have to worry about it, and gets to work, sifting through the profiles at record speed. The point of the game is to get the right answer as fast as you can, so how quick you spew out a reply is just as important as its accuracy.

"They all have superhuman powers," he states almost immediately via the main speaker, his voice echoing through the Cave. It's a bad take, he knows, but it's right in the name — *super* heroes — and it buys him some time to continue analyzing the crazy amounts of data before Bruce thinks he's taking too long.

Bruce quirks an eyebrow, slightly amused, and points to himself as if that's enough of falsification because frankly, *it is*. Tim plays his *embarrassed-shrug* noise, then attempts to save his face by giving another answer that seems good enough.

"You're all humans," he says, his words slurred; there are no pauses between them because he wants to get the answer out faster. Then he realizes it's probably not very understandable that way, so he repeats the most important part: "Humans."

The corner of Bruce's mouth moves up a little, deepening his smirk. "Superman, Starfire, Hawkman, Martian Manhunter..." he says simply, pointing out the exceptions that make Tim's answer invalid.

"You're all *humanoid*," he corrects himself.

"Ch'p, Kilowog, G'nort, — Actually, most of the Lantern Corps—" Bruce doesn't have to finish his sentence before Tim tries again.

"-you've been born, not made—" Tim quickly takes a new approach.

"Superboy. Wonder Woman, too, if one believes the story about being made of clay."

"-are *organic*—" he corrects himself again, slightly exasperated.

"Cyborg. Blue Beetle. *Arsenal*."

Tim huffs in annoyance, though it sounds a little off because he doesn't actually breathe and the noise is therefore just a vague approximation of a huff. He doesn't like how the game is turning out. He grew so much since the last time they did this! He should've aced it, should've gotten it right in one or two tries, max! What is wrong with him? Why can't he figure it out?!

"Okay, okay! The common grounds for all heroes is that you're all at least *partially* organic."

"Red Tornado. All of the Metal Men. You're not even trying, Tim."

Tim falls silent. He's lost the game anyway, he can take time. So he puts all the power he has into processing and displays a loading animation on the main screen for Bruce to know what's up. Because it takes... a while.

Bruce waits patiently like he always does. Then, it finally clicks, the loader disappears and Tim reactivates his android body to look at his mentor in a more *personal* way.

"Maybe... Maybe that's it," he utters, defeated, and the man shifts his gaze to the android staring at him. "The way it's obvious to you that I'm wrong, but not to me. I have all the data, and yet fail to see the correct results. Maybe what is common to all heroes in our database, what tells me and you apart is my lack of... Intuition. Imagination. Ingenuity."

B walks up to the droid body and gently puts his hand on Tim's shoulder. It's heavy, in a reassuring way, and Tim assumes it's also warm. He's never gotten to installing any temperature sensors into his surface. Now he kind of wishes he had.

"Oh, Tim. You're still young. You'll grow into it, I'm sure. After all, you're my son," B says solemnly in his Dad voice.

Bruce, you see, generally has five distinct voices that all mean something else and are intended for different occasions: Batman (for Mission Business), Brucie (for civilians), Paladin (for frightened victims), Dad (for Important Family Matters) and Bruce (for everything else; usually it ends up for Being Tired). And that, those words? Those are spoken in Dad, and Tim had never been on the receiving end of Dad before. He only heard Bruce use it towards Jason and Dick, once even Alfred, but not him, and he doesn't know how to react. It's a rare voice, sacred almost, and it somehow feels wrong that Tim is the one to hear it now. He's not family, so why does he get the Dad voice? Did he maybe recognise the tone incorrectly? Are his sound systems broken? Or did he categorise the tone incorrectly in the past and he's now overreacting? He feels like his systems, underground mainframe and android body and everything else, are about to freeze and crash trying to process the sheer *implications* of those words and that voice.

"I... don't understand?" he mumbles in confusion instead, trying to avoid blacking out the entire BatCave over something as simple as a couple of short sentences. He doesn't like doing that, though. He hadn't admitted to not understanding something (except, you know, some less-used foreign languages, especially the off-Earth ones, but that doesn't *count*) ever since he learned English properly. And yet here he is, unable to parse what Bruce means, just knowing that he means *something* and that it's something *important*. Bruce doesn't say things in *Dad voice* willy-nilly.

"I know I haven't..." Bruce begins, slowly, as if talking to a child, and it reminds Tim slightly of his Paladin voice. But Tim is not afraid — because he's unable to be, right? — and there's nobody else around. Why is Bruce talking to him like that? Did he do something wrong? Was the game a test, and he failed it?

"— I haven't been very — *expressive* with you in the past, but Tim... I hope you understand that— Tim, I've made you, on my own, almost from scratch, and watched you evolve and

grow and mature into the fine boy you are. You're the closest thing I have to a blood son."

There's nothing that Tim knows of that could express how lost he feels, so he opts for just displaying static on all of the monitors in the Cave for a moment. Bruce kneels on the cold floor in front of his body and holds his hands gently.

"But I'm—" Tim says, then trails off for a while. "I'm not a real boy. I'm not a human."

Bruce nods. "You don't have to be a human to be my son."

Tim tilts his head.

"I don't?"

"Humanity has nothing to do with that. I—" Bruce's voice falters for a split second as if it's difficult to say what he's about to say. "I love you, Tim. The same as I love Dick, and as I've loved Jason."

"You—" Oh Tim *hates* how his voice breaks and Bruce seemingly does too because he frowns. "You love me?"

Bruce pulls him closer and hugs him tightly, in a very Dad way.

"I'm so sorry that I failed you. That I made you think I didn't love you. Because I *do*," he whispers, directly into Tim's ear, and pets his artificial hair affectionately.

The gesture's meant to reassure him, to make him feel safe.

There's no word in the English language that can describe the actual feeling the hug causes, because English doesn't have words for mechanical emotions. All Tim knows is that it makes him feel in the same way he felt the first time Alfred referred to him as "Master Timothy", just the way the butler speaks about other inhabitants of the Manor — something between *elated* and *giddy*, with a decisive dash of *panic*, maybe. But it's more intense. Way more intense. It makes him feel like he's going to short-circuit any moment, so he hugs Bruce back, grounding himself. They stay like that as he attempts to process what B just told him. All of it.

When he's ready — and it's a long while before he is, because it's one hell of a novel and unprecedented and shocking revelation — Tim dares to circle way back and ask:

"What's the answer?"

"Answer?"

"To your quiz. What are heroes like? What connects all of you?"

"We all want to make the world better, and protect others, and bring justice. That's all there is to it, Tim. All that matters."

"But... I want that, too? What's the difference between me and all heroes, then?"

"That's the point, Tim. There's none."

And Tim, suddenly, isn't nervous anymore.

Chapter End Notes

Refs and memes in this chapter:

[Mysterious Ticking Noise](#)

["Down by the bay"](#)

[Creative reporting](#)

P.S.

Do I know Arsenal doesn't have a prosthetic arm in many timelines? yes. Do I care? no.

Do I know that Red Tornado isn't around before Tim establishes YJ base at Mount Justice? yes. Do I care? no.

Chapter 5

Chapter Notes

Trigger warnings for this chapter: Temporary Robot Character Death (mentioned), discussion of fear of rejection, abandonment issues and grief; passing mention of what can be interpreted as suicidal ideation

(the majority of the chapter is memes, though)

See the end of the chapter for [more notes](#)

Not long after, a chance to test his worries — and the solution to them — comes. The Justice League has to tackle an extraterrestrial issue, an alien armada that threads by far too close to the Earth space borders than it is legal to, and with too many photon weapons on board for them to ignore it. If that wasn't enough, a global terrorist danger alarm is raised not long after, pulling their forces in way too many directions. That means it's all hands on deck, so Batman brings him over. Or rather, begrudgingly agrees when Tim asks to tag along as if he didn't want Tim to be involved — but Tim has learned to interpret it as *care*, rather than an attempt to control or shelter; it's something all Robins went through and thus he has learned from his predecessors. Instead of being angry about it, he regards it as a kind of rite of passage.

Still, he demands to come and can help. His involvement turns out to be invaluable. When their suspicion proves true and the most powerful people need to be redirected into the extraterrestrial conflict, there are simply not enough heroes to cover all bases with so many places to secure and so many potential threats to defuse all over the globe. Luckily, their intel enables them to pinpoint the source of their earthly problems fairly quickly: the military base that seems to be running the attacks. And so the two of them, Batman and Robin — the resident, self-appointed strategists — spend a good couple hours at the Watchtower, brewing up a plan. Complications arise when they realise they're stretched far too thin and if they want to succeed, they will have to propose a rather... questionable plan. By human standards, at least.

The doubtful honour of presenting it to the rest of the League is placed upon Bruce's shoulders.

"... then, one of us will sneak into the main base to defuse the weaponry," B wraps up his mission briefing and looks over the team. He never wants any questions, but there's always some and he's learned to accept it.

"You said that they're connected to an alarm. Defusing them will trigger the defences and basically obliterate the entire building," says Green Lantern, frowning in thought. Batman nods. "Supes and Diana will be busy with the spaceships on the orbit. Flash is going to be

running circles to save as many civilians as possible from the bombings. For anyone else, it's a suicide mission," he continues, glaring at the screen where the plan is detailed. "You can see that, don't you?"

Batman simply nods again.

Green Lantern squints, thinking for a split second, then hisses at him. "You *planned it* knowing it's a suicide mission!" He smashes his fist on the table, leaning over it towards B.

"Who do you propose will go then, huh?" The man's tone is aggressive, accusatory. "Who are you going to sacrifice to the deadly defences you so wonderfully detailed, Bats?"

Tim raises his arm into the air. "I'll go."

The Flash, fiddling nervously nearby, visibly winces at that. "No, kiddo, you won't," he says, then looks at Batman, who's still silent. "Are you sure there's no other way to do it?"

There's no response from B, so Tim picks up again. "It's okay," he insists, but he's ignored.

Wonder Woman's expression grows darker than anybody in the room feels comfortable with. She stands from her seat and addresses Bruce. "Are you really suggesting your protégé sacrifices himself?" Her voice is dripping with precisely controlled righteous fury, ready to be unleashed if the answer to her question is not what she wants to hear. "He is so young! He's not even a man yet! You can't possibly be this cruel."

Batman doesn't respond, and Tim knows why. B has already spent countless hours trying to dissuade him from being the "sacrificial lamb", and still failed to achieve anything. There's nothing more stubborn than an AI who *knows* he's right.

But the Justice League doesn't know that, and when B remains silently resigned, Aquaman turns to Superman — the only person they consider to have any semblance of influence over Batman, it seems — and demands: "Do something! You're not going to let Batman send a child to kill himself, are you?"

"It's okay," Tim repeats himself, then quickly adds: "I have a spare body at home."

That finally catches their attention. The room remains silent for a good ten seconds (during which Bruce's expression grows *ever so slightly* smugger, Tim notices) before Green Lantern speaks up.

"Excuse me, *what?*"

The way Superman smiles softly makes Tim think, and he quickly concludes the man must *know* about Tim not being a human. That's the only good explanation of why he isn't as surprised or indignant about the suggestion as the others are.

"Go on, Robin," he says in an encouraging tone, and that cements Tim's predictions (superhearing eavesdropping on Batman's comms, maybe?).

“I’ve been trying to tell you. It’s okay. I won’t be killed. This is just a body,” he hesitates for a moment, a split second, before continuing. “I’m not actually alive.”

He rolls up the sleeve of his uniform and carefully peels away a piece of his artificial skin, showing them the metal underneath. “See? I’m an android. I mean, I’m an AI, but that’s beside the point. The point is this-” He motions to the entirety of his body. “-is just something I connect to. It is only rational that I go, because everyone else who could do it scratch-free is essential elsewhere, and there are no repercussions for me if this body is destroyed. Nobody will be hurt.”

They still don’t seem convinced.

“But won’t you feel pain?” Flash asks, hesitantly, trying to find a flaw in Tim’s flawless plan.

“I don’t even have sensors for pain. I mean, sure, I know when I’m damaged, but it’s... not a feeling. Besides, if the systems are built with jammers like we suspect they are, we will lose contact with anyone who goes into the main armoury, and that includes the connection I have with my memory bank, too. With that and my black box being unlikely to be retrieved, or even to survive at all, I won’t even know what happened with this body after about 3 minutes into the mission.”

There’s another moment of silence as they try — and fail, as Bruce did — to find a fault in his thinking. Wonder Woman’s face loses that vengeful edge she had to her a moment ago.

“You are a brave boy, Robin,” she says, with a mix of admiration and sadness in the smile she gives him.

Tim shrugs.

“Bravery only means something to those afraid of death,” he replies offhandedly. In retrospect, that’s probably when the Justice League decides he’s just as disturbingly *pragmatic* as Batman is.

Perhaps that rather pleasant reception from other heroes is what ultimately weighs the odds in favour of teaming up with others. Tim drops in to help the League a little more often from then on, and when a lead takes him far beyond his usual territory and Batman is unavailable, he doesn’t hesitate to reach out, either.

Early on, by chance, he teams up with Superboy; he is good and helpful like the Man of Steel, though with a distinct punk-ish flavour. They don’t work well together at first, because Superboy’s also quick to action and not a big fan of strategizing, much unlike Tim. But he is a little similar to Jason in that (and only that; the boy definitely isn’t as much of a nerd as Jay was) and that thought makes it a bit easier to first predict, then learn his habits and behaviours and work with them. Tim also finds solace in the fact that Superboy isn’t a... *normal* boy either. Though Tim doesn’t share, as per Batman’s orders, any identifying data, Kon-el knows they both have the kind of worries that only people who never had a childhood can understand.

Later also comes Impulse; much like his name, he's even more eager to go straight into the fray and, as all speedsters, is operating on a wavelength nobody else can quite key into. But he has a mind just as fast as the rest of his body, and sharp as a blade if you know how to get it going, so they work off of that similarity between them. The “tourist from the future” thing fascinates Tim, too. He knows that's a lie — by the way Impulse says it, but also because Bruce told him enough that time travel is simply *impossible* — but can't tell how much of it is, or which parts rather. Impulse certainly knows things he otherwise probably shouldn't, and acts like someone who isn't from any of the known cultures.

That's what they bond over, the "not quite like other boys" situation each of them has going, when finally the three of them start working together for real. It turns from hesitant aid to regular collaboration until finally blooming into full *partnership*, into a *team*. Tim thinks he understands why Dick left; there is something special in working with people who *understand* you. He loves Bruce, sure, and so does Dick, but B can be so... difficult.

He hopes working with Justice League is as good for Bruce as Young Justice — as they grow to call themselves after Wonder Girl joins, when they form a proper team and move into the Secret Sanctuary — is for Tim. Because for Tim, it is a lot. He cherishes them and considers a second family, almost on par with the Waynes.

So much that he decides one day to finally tell them the truth.

It's a tough decision. It's not against B's Rule of Secrecy *per se* (he's already revealed his “civilian identity” to them anyway since it's fake and doesn't mean anything), but it is a piece of vital information. He understands what *privacy* is, thanks to Dick, and belatedly realises how tightly tied to *trust* it is. Him withholding this kind of detail about himself — even if they wouldn't have anything against him being artificial in general — can be detrimental to their relationship. And so, he decides it's better to do it now, on his own terms, rather than later, possibly in a rush, during a mission (like if he ever needs to stop pretending to be human and fleshy and mortal).

Either way, Tim's *hopeful* it'll go over smoothly. It goes... well, it goes like this:

He calls them all into the lounge of their Sanctuary one day, and they arrive dutifully, even though — since it's not a meeting chamber call — they're sure it's not for a mission.

“What's up, Rob?” Kon-el says as he slings himself over the backrest of the sofa and makes himself comfortable.

Bart, dashing into the room in his usual style just after, runs over an armchair, backs up, puts it back on its legs, and sits down. “Yeah, what's up, T?” he asks excitedly. He manages to sit still for a record 3 seconds then jumps back to his feet.

The last one to arrive is Cassie. She doesn't say anything, but it's visible that she is, unlike the boys, slightly alarmed. It is unusual, if not entirely out of character for Tim to call them all like this.

Tim looks over them and — once again fiddling with his fingers in an imitation of what he thinks a human would do if one was in his place — begins to speak.

“There’s something I have to tell you. I haven’t been entirely honest with you.”

Cassie rolls her eyes. “Oh my God, stop being dramatic. You’re Robin, Batman’s sidekick, of course you haven’t been entirely honest with us. Spill the beans, R, what’s wrong?”

“What I mean is... I’m not a human.” Superboy stifles a laugh and Tim groans. “I mean as in I’m not even *alive*. I’m an android. An AI piloting a droid, to be precise.”

They don’t seem fazed so Tim deduces they don’t grasp the gravity of his confession. “Maybe it’s better if you just see for yourself,” he adds, and just like with the Justice League, detaches a piece of his faux skin off of his arm. “I’m sorry I’ve kept this a secret from you, but-”

Bart interrupts him.

“Oh, so that’s it? I’ve already known.”

Tim genuinely *misses a beat* for the first time in his existence when Bart says that.

“Hold on, what?” he says, as it’s the first thing that comes to his mind when he processes the unexpected turn of events.

Bart just shrugs, bouncing back and forth on the balls of his feet. “I’m from the future, right? You’re like, a part of the curriculum in my times. The biggest scientific breakthrough of the 21st century, the first true artificial intelligence created by humans and all that.”

There’s a moment of silence, and then Kon speaks up. “Ye, I know too. I, uh, didn’t realise it’s a secret?”

“*How?*” Tim manages to ask.

“X-ray vision, baby. Should’ve worn a lead suit if you didn’t want us Supers to see all the gear you keep up your metal ass,” he replies with a snicker.

Tim suddenly is very self-conscious about the multitool built into his forearm and the first aid kit he keeps in his thighs.

But Cassie snorts at the tease, distracting him from how *exposed* Kon’s comment made him feel. He looks at her, not even having to ask if she knew about him before, too. It’s obvious by her semi-apologetic expression and the vague shrug she offers him.

“I mean, I didn’t know exactly *what* you are, but it was clear you ain’t what you appear to be, you know? I thought it’s just something you didn’t want to talk about, I guess,” she says. “But even if not, why would I care? You’re my friend, whatever’s your face made of.”

“Okay, but how did you find out?” Bart asks, suddenly shifting his focus to her. “Did you tell her? I didn’t.” He briefly looks at Kon, who shakes his head.

“I just noticed Tim doesn’t breathe and kinda connected the dots,” Cassie admits.

“Noticed that I don’t... breathe?”

She nods. “You have much to learn in the ways of being a human, my young Padawan,” she says in a fake-solemn tone with a hint of barely contained giggle underneath it. “And that includes realising that the chests of living, breathing beings move as they inhale and exhale. And also that in general, breathing beings put on a rebreather when they’re entering a cloud of lethal gas, like us two weeks ago.”

Tim sits down, feeling legit *outsmarted*.

“Huh,” he just says. “This is not how I thought this would go.” He looks at Cassie blankly, then adds: “In my defence, I was focused solely on getting the civilians to safety.”

She nods and gives him a thumbs-up, still giggling softly. After that, there’s a brief pause, a brief silence. It looks like they’re intending to let him process for a moment more, or maybe simply not know what else to say. But Bart grins excitedly, and within a second he’s to and back from his room, with his tablet in hand.

“Does that mean I can finally share all the robot memes I’ve been saving? I hope so because there’s a *really* big backlog.”

Kon just laughs and makes room on the sofa, inviting them in. Bart is immediately right next to him, and Cassie sweeps Tim up like she expects him to try to run away. They all huddle over Bart’s shoulders as he hurriedly opens up the Boston Dynamics Youtube channel.

They watch video after video of dancing, prancing and pranking robots, and Bart soon half-jokingly suggests Tim sometimes moves the same way as the early Spot models. Kon seems to agree. Tim, of course, attempts to defend his dignity (nobody but him knows about the early days of him piloting the android for the first time, back then in the depths of the Cave, *nobody*). But Bart brings up that one mission when he got electrocuted briefly and had to restart his motion systems on the go and— yeah, okay, Tim has to admit, there are times at which he flails about aimlessly like a poorly programmed, early 2015s robot with barely a grasp of where’s up and where’s down. At least now he understands why they didn’t seem particularly perplexed about his rather *odd* reaction to the whole ordeal and didn’t ask any questions. But it’s not his *fault* that it happened, and he’s gotten a rubber lining installed since then! He’s learned!

Either way, that’s how — laughing, cuddling, enjoying themselves — they spend the rest of the day instead of, as Tim expected, wading a confusing mess of explanations and doubting and hurt feelings.

And that’s when Tim, finally, agrees; Bruce was right. There is no difference between him and any other hero.

The atmosphere in the Secret Sanctuary changes considerably after he shares his secret. Tim feels... freer. Truer. He hadn’t even realised how constantly trying to fool them is taking a

toll on him. And now that that obligation is gone, he can be his whole, weird (for human standards, at least, according to what Dick says) self.

That means he also can share his doubts with the rest of the YJ crew. Cross-check things with them. Something he couldn't do ever since- ... Ever since they lost Jay.

And thus, he leans over one day while they're sitting around, chilling, and says: "Hey, Cassie? What else do you think would give me away? Aside from the breathing thing, I mean."

The addressed girl gives him a sharp glare for a moment, then closes her book with a sigh. "This again?" she asks.

"Yeah, Rob, you're obsessed," chirps in Bart in between the quiet pings and pongs of him playing both sides of a table tennis game.

Kon, though, Kon has an entirely different approach. He understands, in a way the others don't. "Why does it matter?" he asks instead.

"I know none of you, or the Leaguers, or heroes in general care about it, but what if civilians figure it out? What if they're freaked out? I can hit uncanny valley territory *so* easily."

Cassie tilts her head slightly. "Uncanny valley?"

"Oh, I know! I know!" Bart jumps in excitement as always when he wants to explain something, his hand raised above his head. He sweeps Tim to the side as if to silence him, then returns to his ping-pong match. "It means that how much something resembles a human and how safe and comfortable a person feels about it are positively correlated, but with an exception at the theoretical peak."

"And in normal English words?" she snarks in response.

"People are more likely to feel okay around like, a well-made statue than around... a simple doll or something. But at some point, this graph takes a big dip, right before the '*fully human*' level of human likeness. It's around where corpses and, well, —" he takes a peek at Tim, a little unsure how to continue, then apparently decides to skip a piece. "In short, it's documented that for a yet undetermined reason people don't like things that *seem* like a human, but clearly *aren't* a human."

"In short, people don't like androids," Tim supplies with a sour grimace on his face.

"Then don't '*seem to be human*'?" Kon says with a shrug, signalling he's suggesting a solution to a problem he doesn't fully understand. After all, he only has a vague grasp of how *normal* people react to things, thanks to his rather *unusual* life so far. "I mean, it works for Red Tornado, right?"

"*Red Tornado* doesn't work with kids and scared victims, Kon," Tim replies with a little too much bite in his tone, but he can't help it. He's had it with everyone comparing him to their mentor. "I need to be able to reassure them, make them feel safe. That's literally my role as

B's sidekick, to be the... fluffy one. The one who gets people to like and trust him. I can't do that if I'm openly non-human. People won't like nor trust a machine."

Bart, for once, stops moving, as if to accentuate his opinion. Well, at least stops running, but his energy just gets redirected into supersonic hand-flapping. "Oh, that's bullshit," he says, and before his ping-pong ball hits the floor, he's once again holding his tablet. "Do I get brownie points for catching him being wrong?"

"What?" This time it's all three of them who make confused expressions, not only Cassie.

"Listen," Bart starts clicking furiously on the device, "humans will pack-bond with anything. We name roombas! We try to pet alligators! We taught a Mars Rover to sing! Cats actively try to avoid domestication and we still attempt to keep them! Sure, the more you look like a human the more people will like you, but because that's some kind of common ground. The same way girls trust girls more, and kids trust kids, et cetera. But that's not the only thing that makes trust-levels skyrocket."

Tim grimaces. He doesn't like being proven wrong, because who does? But curiosity wins over like it always does.

"And what is that?"

"Being *cute*. And you, my friend—" Bart stops for a moment to look Tim up and down, "—are cute as heck."

There's silence for a split second and then Cassie bursts into laughter. Kon just chuckles and mumbles: "Yeah, true."

"What?" Tim squeaks out in surprise. "This makes no sense."

"Look at this," the speedster finally seems to have found what he was looking for because he turns the screen of his tablet towards them. There's a video playing, and while it makes Cassie laugh again, Tim furrows his brows looking at it. It's one of the popular autonomous vacuums, but... "Is this human? Absolutely not. Would I trust it with my life? Absolutely yes."

"It has a knife taped to it, Bart."

"It's just a vacuum!"

"Exactly. It's a vacuum with a knife. *Why on Earth* would you trust it?"

"Because it's cute. It's a good boi."

Tim frowns even more, especially since Kon and Cassie seem to be nodding. It makes no sense to him.

"I don't understand. How is a knife'd roomba cute? What does cuteness have to do with trust?"

“Bart has a point here, Rob,” Cassie picks up, seeing Impulse is about to go on a tangent nobody will be able to follow him through. “I mean, what are some things that are cute? Babies, puppies, toys. Cute things in general aren’t very threatening. They’re not a danger, they’re helpless things you want to cherish and protect. Think of it this way: unless people see me rip a car in half, they’re going to assume I’m nice and docile because I’m pretty. You know that on some level, you’ve even planned around it! You made me the bait in the past, didn’t you?”

“Yeah, but I’m not-”

“No *'buts'*, Tim! The same applies to you. Unless people see you do something... *really* weird, I don’t know, detaching your arms or something, they won’t care how *human* you are so long you’re approachable.”

“Yeah, that’s what really was the core of Robin’s success, I think,” offers Kon.

Tim processes for a bit, but before he can formulate a response, Bart pipes up.

“Now I kinda want to feed cheeto crumbs to a roomba.”

“We should get one,” Cassie offers, giggling at the prospect.

Kon grins mischievously. “We already have Tim.”

“I’m not a vacuum!”

“But you’re just as cute, and win people’s hearts the same way. Trust us, we’d know.”

Another burst of laughter welcomes him. He joins it after a moment but doesn’t appreciate being *compared to a vacuum*. And so, he *plots revenge*.

Three days later, when they’re about to head out for a mission, he puts it into motion.

Cassie walks into the briefing room and stops in her tracks immediately when she sees him, sitting at the meeting table. “Tim. What- what are you doing?”

Tim looks at Cassie, keeping his expression as neutral as possible. “What do you mean?”

“Why... why do you have a *knife* **taped** to your forehead?”

Kon must catch that question with his super-hearing on his way to the room because he arrives in record time. His eyes are blown wide with surprise as if he can’t believe what he’s heard and what he’s seeing.

“I’m following your suggestions,” Tim states simply.

“Our suggestions?” they ask at the same time.

“I’m attempting to increase the likelihood of others liking me.”

"T, I don't think you should tape a knife to your forehead for that," Cassie says in an uncertain tone.

"Nonsense. According to the instructions that Bart had shown, the taping of a knife to the forehead is essential."

That, possibly due to how *serious* he sounds, just sends them deeper into shock.

It is Bart, who darts into the room a moment later, who breaks their awkward silence by doubling over in laughter. Slowly, realisation creeps over the other two faces and everyone in the room begins laughing, too. But, Tim is not done.

“Let’s see who fares better, though,” he says and puts down what he’s been keeping hidden on his lap all this time. The soft whirring sound that fills the room immediately catches their attention; Kon peeks under the table.

“You really got a roomba just for the joke?” he asks, amused, and it sends Bart into another laughing fit.

“We Bats are nothing if not dramatic.”

“Fair point,” he admits. “You’ll have to tape a knife to it too. You know, to even the testing grounds.”

Tim grins devilishly. Cassie already knows they’re going to regret it.

At first, they play along and keep a tally of who appears cuter, Tim or Stabby (the name sticks even if they ditch the knife the next day, for Bart’s ankles’ sake). In time, they get bored with it. But the robot *does* keep the floors cleaner, so it gets to stay even after the joke seemingly runs its course.

And that’s when Tim’s plan comes in.

It takes them three weeks. For the first few days, they just assume it’s all by accident. Then they get annoyed. Then Bart connects the dots.

“It’s you!” he says with overplayed outrage, turning towards Tim when Stabby smashes against his heels for the fifth time that day. It started as an occasional thing, but Tim’s been increasing the frequency lately because it seemed like they’re never going to catch on.

But now, he just smiles sweetly. “*It’s me* what?”

“*You’re* making the vacuum run into us all the time!”

“Me? *No*. I’m innocent. Innocent as a roomba.”

Kon, who's standing nearby, decides to join in. He *clutches his metaphorical pearls* and gasps overdramatically. "I can't believe you would do that to us, R! You- ...you *toaster!*"

Cassie stares Kon down like he just said something *awful*. She probably worries that Tim would consider what Kon said somehow... offensive. But Tim just starts laughing instead.

"Did you just use '*toaster*' as an insult?" he says, the amusement shining in his voice and Cassie relaxes when she hears that.

"Maybe I did!" Kon retorts, now free from Cassie's glare. Tim grins mischievously and Kon's face pales.

"I'm going to figure out how to hack all the kitchen appliances we have and ruin breakfasts for the rest of your life," he says slowly, as seriously as he can manage, then vacates the premises before anyone can try to respond to his "threat".

Later that day he finds Kon badgering Bart to help him replace all of their appliances with non-smart ones, as those can't be (*as easily*) hacked. Just in case, he says. Tim adds a snapshot of Kon's slightly worried expression to the database of his favourite memories.

He isn't planning on ever compromising any appliances, of course. At least not beyond prank purposes. He's just doing maintenance, like with every machinery under his care. But he does take a kind of guilty joy from the shriek of shock-turned-fear that Bart makes when sometime later he finds Tim fiddling with the microwave at the wee hours of the morning.

The suddenness of it makes him bang the top of his head against the cupboard, though, so there's that to counter the *schadenfreude*.

"He was right!" Bart points an accusatory finger at Tim. "Kon was right! You're out to get our breakfasts!"

"Chill out, I'm just tuning it. Cassie mentioned she hates how loud the final beep is."

"Why would you do it under the guise of the night then, huh?"

"Because I was *bored*, Bart. I don't sleep, remember? Business at home has been a bit sparse, so I had attention to spare," Tim gives the inner cogs of the machine one more good turn then begins putting the outer casing back into place. "Want to test it out?"

The prospect of food is always a good tactic to distract a speedster, Tim's learned. It works like a charm this time too as Bart slides into the aisle seat with a grin.

"What'cha proposing?"

Tim shrugs, then looks into the fridge. He notices that the bottom shelf of the nearby cupboard is slightly dented from the close encounter with his titanium skull. He makes a mental note to fix it sometime later.

"Your choices are breakfast burrito, pizza bites, or..." he takes the package out to examine it more closely, then looks at Bart again, frowning slightly. "An off-brand frozen meal that is

past ‘best before’ date by a month and I’m pretty sure we only have it because you insisted ‘it’s a classic’ and then forgot to eat it. Also, be aware that the pizza bites are Cassie’s and I will not defend you if she finds out they’re missing.”

Bart boos each option then just blows him a raspberry at the end.

“There’s also soup, but I doubt you want canned soup for breakfast.”

“You’re going to skimp on your friend and just *heat* something up? Make me something fancy!”

Tim turns to face him and crosses his arms. He’s spent too much time chatting with Alfred and Jason to let this one go. “I don’t think *fancy* and *microwave* belong in the same sentence.”

“You’d be surprised!” the boy retorts, already with a fork in hand like he’s *demanding* food now. “People can make some real wicked things in a microwave. It’s not *just* for pre-made stuff.”

He rolls his eyes.

“I know you can do more with a microwave than heat frozen meals, Bart, but cooking and nutrition are among the few things I never really looked into; because, you know, I don’t need food, and either way it’s agent A’s speciality.”

Bart ponders that for a moment, then a sly smile crawls over his face. He leans in over the counter, speaking in a conspiratorial whisper. “I’m willing to be your test subject if that means I get to see you attempt to make food for the first time.”

Tim raises his eyebrows and leans back, arms still crossed.

“Oh, I see how it is. You want *blackmail material*,” he says, and when Bart just grins in response, he laughs, then nods. “Okay, but you’re in for the *nastiest* tasting microwave oatmeal to ever exist.”

The speedster grimaces. “Does it *have to* be oatmeal?”

“You said you’re in, you didn’t specify what my first food has to be!”

“*Fair*,” Bart grumbles, but quickly shrugs the grumpiness off, exchanging it for restless excitement when his stomach growls loudly.

Tim grins and gets to work. Why not learn something new, after all? He likes learning.

All in all, the oatmeal doesn’t come out half-bad. It *is* oatmeal, there’s not much you can mess up. The biggest bonus of making it, though, is not learning how to do it, but the time he spends doing it: talking with Bart and generally... goofing around.

Oh, and the surprised faces of Kon and Cassie when they see Tim in an apron, and Bart chowing down on something relatively healthy.

He finds himself doing it again. At first, it's kind of a running joke, something along the lines of "Tim's making sure Bart eats more than just sugar". They also comment on how adorably helpless he is in the kitchen. But who can blame him? He has no way to experience flavours or smells, his only approximation of those sensations being testing the chemical makeup of the food.

He doesn't understand the concept of *hunger*, either, not in a more personal way than just knowing the definition. But he tries. Culinary arts are a kind of science after all, aren't they? He can follow a recipe, all the way down to the letter (it's a problem, sometimes; some instructions aren't clear enough or take the human error and tendency to approximate into account, and he ends up missing the point of them entirely because he *doesn't* approximate).

Even with all those issues, Tim perseveres.

It's worth it, he realises. More than just worth it. It's *such* a good investment. Learning about cooking and nutrition makes it easier to notice malnourishment symptoms in victims, keep his friends and family healthy and help Alfred with groceries, even. It's a useful skill, even though it feels a bit awkward for everybody involved when he presents the food and either walks away or sits there *watching them eat*.

Because, you know, Tim doesn't eat on his own.

Which is precisely the reason why it's such a shock when Robin hops onto the BatComputer's counter, next to the keyboards and controls, and takes a sip from the mug he's holding. Bruce is reading over some data early in the evening, with his own cup of tea and doesn't seem to notice at first. But when he does, he turns to look at Tim slowly, carefully putting his cup back onto the saucer as if afraid he'd drop it, his face an odd mix of confusion and distress (well, as much as his face ever displays any emotion, really). Tim would lie if he said he doesn't enjoy making Bruce make that face. Like, a lot. (Much like Jason did.)

"Tim."

The boy pretends not to know what's the matter, just plays his *questioning-please-elaborate* jingle (he noticed that he uses the jingles much like Bruce uses grunts and he kind of enjoys this... similarity between him and *his dad*) and continues swinging his legs off the edge of the console mindlessly.

"Tim," B says more forcefully, seemingly temporarily forgetting all words other than just Tim's name.

Robin pulls the mug away from his lips and makes sure to swallow loudly. Bruce frowns but doesn't say anything more. The boy grins in return, revealing the coating of a dark brown liquid slowly running down his faux teeth, which apparently unlocks the rest of B's vocabulary.

"Did you make unauthorized upgrades to yourself again?"

He shows Bruce his tongue — which is just as dirty as his teeth — like a five-year-old.

Bruce sighs. “Did you at the very least run it through Babs?”

“Who do you think I am? This was her idea. I had to stop her from designing me an entire artificial stomach.”

B rests his elbows on the counter and hides his face in his hands. “What is in the mug?”

“Coffee, so I can calculate even faster.”

Bruce doesn’t seem to find Tim’s joke funny. “What’s in the mug?”

But Tim has spent too much time with Young Justice to let the old man off the hook this easily.

“Grape Zesti. We’ve exchanged my batteries for a soda-fuelled engine.”

“Tim, please.”

Okay, fine, if Bruce wants to be boring this much, Tim will oblige. “It’s motor oil. We rerouted the lubricant intake valve into my throat.”

Anybody else would ask if that won’t damage his speakers, but B knows better than to question the solutions born out of Tim’s and Babs’ combined engineering effort. (They’re covered dynamically when he swallows, so it’s okay. Tim takes great joy in the fact that it resembles the fucked-up way mammals’ trachea and esophagus are also connected.)

“Why?” B just asks instead.

“So I could have a cuppa with you and Alfred.”

The man lifts his head and looks at Tim in disbelief, and a little bit as if he felt guilty somehow. “You felt left out...?”

Robin shakes his head vigorously. “Nah, I avoided evening five o’clock on my own, because it would be a little weird to just *sit* there. Thanks to this, it’ll be less awkward; I’ll at least have something to do with my hands, even if I’ll never taste Alfie’s famous tea.” He takes another gulp of the oil and then wipes his mouth off. His hand comes up dirty, and after a brief inspection, he extends it towards Bruce, sticking it directly under his nose.

“It smells like a car engine, doesn’t it?”

“Of course it does.”

“Do you think people will interpret that as Robin tinkering with cars as a hobby?”

“I beg you, son, tell me you hadn’t applied this modification to... all of you.”

Tim bursts into laughter at that. “No, not yet. I gotta tune it and test it in use a lot more to make sure the details all work together okay. But I think I’m going to, eventually. Though probably during scheduled maintenance rather than specifically calling all Robins in for an upgrade.” He drinks the last mouthful of the oil in the cup and hops off the console. “I mean, I have to exchange my oil regularly anyway, why not make it fun? I just really want to be able to sit down with others during breakfasts and such.”

Bruce sighs again, but Tim *sees* the smirk that the man tries to hide. He takes that as a sign that this new function will be an absolute *hit* with the YJ, too. Why be able to re-design your entire body if you can’t sneak in a few jokes while at it, right?

Being made of metal isn’t always like that, though; it’s not always goof-goof-memes.

Sometimes it is... Sometimes, it’s Robin laying on the floor of the Secret Sanctuary, limbs outstretched, face up and staring at the ceiling.

"What are you doing?" Kon asks as he approaches him with curiosity.

"I'm crying."

Kon raises his eyebrows. "Crying," he repeats, his tone doubting. There are no tears, or any liquid for that matter, coming from Robin's eyes, nor does his face look anything but calm. Maybe even a little absent-minded. Kon is justified to be confused, and therefore Tim decides to elaborate a little.

"Back when I researched therapy and grief, I found a nice Chirp about it," Tim begins in a matter-of-fact tone, still staring directly upwards, "It compared grief to a box. The box has a ball inside and a pain button. When the ball hits the button, you hurt. At first, the ball is almost as big as the box; it hits the button constantly, over and over again. In time, when you heal, the ball becomes smaller. Hits the button less often. But it never truly goes away, it said. And when it manages to hit the button, it hurts all the same."

Kon sits down on the floor next to Robin, legs crossed, visibly worried now. He has to have an idea what Tim is speaking about — he knows about Jason, and what he meant to Tim, and Tim knows he is smart enough to connect the dots; it thus comes as no surprise that he tentatively asks:

"The ball hit the button today?" even if it still probably doesn't clarify for him how what Robin’s doing could count as *crying*.

Tim ignores the question, for now, because he isn't done monologuing; his actions need more context for Kon to understand.

"Did you know tears aren't just for cleaning eyes? The newest research suggests that they also serve the purpose of alleviating stress. The hypothesis is that it’s maybe by flushing out excess hormones and neurotransmitters when the person is overwhelmed, for example with

emotions. That's why people cry when they're sad, but also when happy or angry. So they can... make it easier."

Kon nods, signalling he understands; he doesn't say anything, probably not knowing what to add, or just having a bad feeling about where this conversation is going. Robin continues staring at the ceiling, blank-faced.

"I cannot cry as humans can. I do not tire, I don't feel pain, I don't have muscles that can hold tension. And shouting doesn't quite do it when you vocalize via a speaker, you know? There is nothing, absolutely *nothing* I can do when everything is... too much. "

Finally, Robin rolls his head to the side and looks at his friend, who by now has a pained expression on his face.

"I tried blowing a fuse once, you know? Literally, I mean. It's not quite the idiom you associate with crying, but that was the closest thing to *releasing tension* that I could come up with."

There's a moment of pause. Kon doesn't answer, or comment — at this point Tim suspects he just doesn't know what he could say to Tim at all — but he places a hand on Tim's shoulder in an attempt to comfort him. Robin smiles in appreciation, and it's probably the saddest smile Kon had ever seen.

"That's when I've learned that we have emergency power sources at home. Everything is set up with a UPS. We even have a generator to keep the basic systems running, like a hospital. The entire New Jersey power grid could fail and blackout everyone for days, and it wouldn't shut me down. Probably wouldn't even make me stutter."

Kon sighs quietly, then lays down next to Robin and grabs his hand gently, interlacing their fingers. It's not much, but Tim is thankful anyway.

"I know that eventually, it will pass. So I do my best approximation of the act of crying: lay down and wait. That's all I can do."

They do it together from then on.

Chapter End Notes

Which Lantern is in this chapter? IDK IDC, reader's choice.

Refs and memes in this chapter:

["bravery only means something to those afraid of death"](#)

["operating on a wavelength nobody else can quite key into"](#) (is Bart neurodivergent in this fic? You betcha)

[Uncanny valley](#)

[Stabby the Roomba](#)

[Boston Dynamics Spot models](#)

[2015 robots trying, and failing miserably at everything](#)

[Schadenfreude](#)

[goof-goof-memes](#)

[Tweet about grief](#) (Chirps/Chirper is the DC equivalent of Tweets/Twitter)

[The crying/tear research](#)

[UPS - Uninterruptible Power Supply](#)

Chapter 6

Chapter Summary

BAMF Tim Drake.

Chapter Notes

Trigger warnings for this chapter: kidnapping, physical threats, minor/background character death

This chapter was written in sweat and blood because me and action/mystery plots simply don't mix so I hope you'll enjoy it, or at the very least forgive me.

See the end of the chapter for [more notes](#)

It would be nice if everything they do together was easy, or at least easier. But life isn't fair like that. No matter how much they try, missions sometimes go askew. People say plans are just a bunch of things that don't happen, sure, but some actions are just... doomed to fail. Sometimes there are no good or bad choices, there are just choices.

And you have to deal with the consequences.

The general outlook of the situation is bleak. Bleaker than usually in Gotham, that is. Barbara's busy with her own Birds, and Nightwing is tied up in an off-shore mission. Stephanie broke her leg like an idiot because for a hot second she forgot Tim is made out of titanium and took the same roof route as he did. And Batman? Batman hadn't been awake for three days, ever since he got gassed by Scarecrow.

At first, nobody worries much. Not that they don't worry *at all*, but it's just... a normal amount. It's weird that it's not a big deal when they get injured, like it's par for the course. Occupational risk, apparently, both the wounds and the insensitivity.

But when the nightmares don't let up after a few hours and Bruce doesn't wake up even with a double dose of antidote... It's been a long time since Tim saw Alfred this tense, to say the least, and Tim had never used this much processing power at the same time before, either. For a few days straight he's "*elbow deep*" into trying to figure out what's different about this particular brew and developing a new antitoxin, and of course patrolling nightly on his own.

That's when Babs sends him a code amber.

It's not as bad as code red, but with how full his plate is at the moment, it's not very good news either.

Turns out, a kid has been kidnapped. And it's bad, of course, but not nearly enough to warrant an emergency alert on its own (again, uncomfortably normal for vigilantes). The problem is, the kid — birth name Bastian Grenada, now legally Vincente Tamayo, age 5 — is a part of the witness protection program, as the only son of Raymond Grenada, a middle-league player on the local crime scene.

They've put Raymond Grenada in jail a few months back, thanks to evidence of his illegal weapon trade that Tim's gathered meticulously over the past years. In itself, it still probably wouldn't be enough for a long-lasting sentence, not in Gotham, but they've managed to strike a deal with him; Grenada knew that as a mafioso, he needed someone to keep his son safe with him gone, and that his connections wouldn't be enough. He agreed to go down without a fuss, they promised to take care of his kid.

And now his kid is missing.

Not a very good testimonial for their competence, is it.

Even though Bastian was in witness protection, the chances that he got nabbed by a mobster are very high, almost 100%. Tim just can't figure out who the culprit is. On one hand, a week ago Grenada apparently decided he didn't like it in jail all that much anymore. They hadn't heard of his whereabouts ever since his breakout, so it's entirely possible that the guy decided to take his kid back. On the other, Grenada stepped on way too many toes in his life. The fact that he's out of jail might've prompted someone to try and get revenge — use the kid as bait or to hit the mobster where it'll hurt him the most.

Either way, there's an innocent child in danger out there, and so Tim has to step up and catch the ball that the criminal justice system dropped.

And sure, Tim has like three backup bodies and access to almost all of Gotham's electronics, but he also isn't taking any chances. Not when Batman's down, not when he's on his own. Not when a kid's life is at stake.

Therefore, Tim calls in help. Batman would disapprove of metas in Gotham, but Batman isn't around to tell him how to live his life right now. They aren't technically metas, anyway.

They've matured past Young Justice at this point, consider themselves part of the Teen Titans. Dick's team always was more established, got less flack from the older heroes; joining into their ranks was a natural way to proceed. Yet still, when in time of need, Tim doesn't request assistance from the Tower. Instead, he reaches out to his best friends, to the other three people of his core team, knowing they'll have his back without any hesitation.

He starts briefing them over comms simultaneously after each of them responds positively to the call, and begins strategizing and setting up even before they arrive in Gotham. When they do, all four of them work like a *well-oiled machine* (Tim loves that idiom to bits). One would think that with a team with their range of abilities and their level of synergy, finding a kidnapped kid should be a walk in the park.

But this Gotham, New Jersey, and nothing is ever easy here.

However superhuman Kon's senses are, he can't clock in on *anything* because almost everyone in a ten-mile radius has goddamn *lead poisoning* and he can't see *shit*. And however fast Bart is, the city is big and complicated and they can't look *everywhere* at the same time. And however powerful Cassie is, they first have to *find* someone who knows what they need before she can shake answers out of the poor fella.

So, as a kind of break from fighting supervillains and saving the world, they have to do some up-close-and-personal, traditional detective work. The team isn't very used to it, not when their bread and butter *is* supervillains and world-saving, but it's nothing Tim can't work around. He's just *that* good, after all. With him as the leader, anyone can solve a case or two.

Or so he hopes.

Their only real lead is the fact that the cameras on-site are clean, at least at first glance. According to the police records, there's no hint of anything out of the ordinary happening on the recording, while the apartment shows clear signs of struggle.

"Someone must've hacked them," Cassie says matter-of-factly, looking at the very expertly looped footage that Tim is playing on the little display that extends up from his gauntlet. "Those were yours, right? You and Oracle set these up?"

Robin sends her a glare. "Go choke on a muffin," he mumbles, "They weren't really a *priority*, you know? There are 4,315,963 cameras in Gotham that I can reasonably access; I'm not paying attention to *all* of them *all* the time, even I don't have that kinda processing power."

He speeds up the playback to view the entirety of the last two days within a reasonable time, knowing that his teammates can keep up thanks to their super speed of various levels. And rightly so, all three of them perk up as if they wanted to tell him to stop precisely as he halts the footage and rewinds a couple of milliseconds.

His display is taken up by still of an obnoxiously green question mark. It's in the recording for just a split second, not enough for anyone but Tim or someone with superhuman speed to notice unless they're going frame-by-frame. Since there are no super-speedy people in Gotham most of the time, it means that it could as well be *addressed* to Robin.

This kind of bait is an obvious invitation, most probably a challenge from Riddler. The man is sorta obsessed with him ever since he found out Tim's an AI. Competing in intelligence puzzles against a supercomputer is apparently right up his alley. So this case? It's personal, Tim knows it. But usually, Riddler just tries to toy with him, see how far his artificial intelligence can go (the phase with paradoxes was *really* boring). Why is he involved with something like this? What's his business with the Grenadas? Hacking isn't his usual MO either, even if he proved himself to be quite capable at it when he puts himself into it...

It just doesn't add up.

“Try to find and question Riddler,” Tim says to the rest of his team anyway, because even if it doesn’t make sense now, it’s their only lead so far. “I’ll check if I can recover at least some of the original recordings and see where that takes us. I’ve sent you our last intel on Riddler’s whereabouts and connections.”

Kon and Cassie wordlessly nod an affirmation. Bart is already doing laps around the roof, waiting for them to take the hint and follow him. A moment later they’re all gone, and Robin leans against a vent to focus on processing.

He wakes up three hours later. There’s no news back from the rest of the team, but he knows they’re busy doing good work. Gotham is a surprisingly *big* city, and it’s hard to find one man in it.

Especially so when you send three *fighters* to do fucking *recon*, but Tim had no better options.

Still, he’ll have to thin their numbers further and grab one of them to do a little bit of intel-gathering with him instead. It’s not that he *can’t* do it alone, just having an extra body to block the other escape route will make the entire ordeal easier.

He chooses Cassie. While she *is* in possession of the proverbial singular brain-cell of the team (excluding Tim himself, that is) and that would be needed to find and interrogate Riddler properly... he also doesn’t think Kon and his leftover modelling habits or Bart and his lithe speedster build would be very intimidating to a seasoned mobster. Cassie, though? Cassie can be *very* scary when she wants to.

He’s just hoping Bart’s tech-savvyness will be enough to get some meaningful info out of the green hacker-wannabe, instead.

“Wonder Girl, come in,” he says over the comms on the team-wide channel. He only needs one of them, but wants to keep everyone up-to-speed.

“*What’s up, R?*”

“Rendezvous me at Cameron Street metro station.”

“*Got something?*” Bart chirps in, unable to neither stay still *nor* quiet, apparently.

“Couldn’t get much from the recordings with the question mark, but I saw one of Grenada’s goons on the neighbourhood’s security tapes. It might be a coincidence, but I-”

“*-don’t believe in coincidences,*” Kon butts in, because he likes finishing Tim’s sentences for him. (Tim suspects it makes him feel like they have an extra special connection of sorts; it is true — not just anybody can follow Tim’s train of thought with enough precision to consistently jump ahead like that.)

“Right, so I tracked the guy through city CCTV to his current location.”

“And are planning to ask some friendly questions,” Wonder Girl finally speaks up properly.

“Exactly.”

Cassie makes an agreeing grunt. *“Be there in-”*

“Five, I know. Get going.”

Kon snorts in the comms, attempting not to laugh fully, and that marks the end of their conversation. Tim’s pretty sure Cassie is too busy rolling her eyes at him to continue, anyway.

Precisely five minutes later, because he’s not known to make mistakes in his calculations, Cassie lands softly on the roof he’s standing on. He briefs her on who they’re going to nab — who, where and armed with what — and knows she doesn’t require more prompting. It’s not like Wonder Girl needs much detail on a street-level henchman before engaging.

Soon enough, the poor guy is wrapped in Cassie’s lasso and dangled off the top of a building. The lasso won’t force him to speak the truth, sadly, but a demigoddess holding you 20 stories above busy Gotham streets is proven to have a similar effect.

The goon’s already turning red from all the blood rushing to his upside-down head, too, so it shouldn’t be too hard to squeeze some info out of him.

“Where’s your boss?” Tim asks calmly, leaning towards the man’s panicked face. He keeps his hands behind his back, shoulders slightly squared and pulled away, as if he’s lecturing a child — this intimidation tactic he picked up from good ol’ Alfred, because nothing says control and power more than being nonchalant about the situation. (B has his own thing going and good for him, but one can’t really loom menacingly in a body that looks like an adolescent boy)

The man tries to swallow, starts choking on his own saliva, then coughs himself back to life, but says nothing of value.

Tim nods at Cassie and she shakes him a little, loosening the lasso just a *smidge*. They’re rewarded with a scared scream.

“I don’t know! I hadn’t heard from him! I didn’t do anything!” The voice is high-pitched and a little wheezing, which lets Tim know the guy is being honest. More-or-less, at least. They always try — and fail — to hide things from him.

“What were you doing earlier today, then?”

“Nothing!” Tim just tilts his head slightly as a sign of disbelief, and it sends the man into another fit of panic. “He told me to check a building!”

“I thought you said you hadn’t heard from your boss?”

The goon inhales sharply, then pales. “I only got a call from Freddie!”

“And what did Freddie tell you?”

“He just said that boss is back in business! He told me to scout a spot, but that’s it! I don’t know anything!”

“What were you looking for there?”

“I don’t know! He just told me to see if there’s people! Maybe he’s looking for a new hiding hole? I don’t know!”

Tim leans in even closer, then grabs the man by his collar. “Oh, really?”

“Please, guys! The boss is super fucking paranoid ever since he got out, nobody knows anything!”

Tim smiles, then gestures for Cassie to put the man down safely back onto the roof. She obliges, even though her face shows a bit of confusion. Robin just pulls his hands from behind his back and takes a moment to (*pretend to*) straighten the man’s jacket before nudging him towards the fire escape leading down to the street.

It takes a moment before it all clicks, but when it does, the goon scurries away as fast as his legs will take him.

When he’s out of sight and out of earshot, Wonder Girl looks at Robin, eyebrows high up on her forehead.

“You’re just going to let him go? He didn’t tell us anything!”

Robin rolls his eyes and pulls up his gauntlet terminal. On its screen, a radar’s already pinging the man’s position against a map of Gotham, right next to data ripped from his phone. “He didn’t have to. ”

“I keep forgetting that you’re a walking gadget.”

“At this point, it’s not forgetting, it’s willful ignorance, WG. Contingencies within contingencies and gear pulled out of my ass is my most common course of action.”

Cassie laughs at his remark, then walks over to peek at his gauntlet terminal. He is displaying data just for his teammates, after all — if it’s just him, he can process it all internally.

“So, what’s the plan?”

“To bypass Grenada’s security measures. He’s trying to be as hard to track as possible, so he keeps his people in the dark. But you know what’s the weakest link of even the greatest safeguards? The people managing them,” Tim says with a grin. “They have to have *some kind* of contact to get the orders around. Our pal is most probably going straight to — or at least calling back — Freddie to warn him about this encounter. And since Freddie is giving out the orders, he has to have a way to talk with Grenada.”

Cassie lets out an impressed whistle.

“We might have to loop around a few middlemen though, depending on how bad their paranoia is. And if they do watch out for being followed? That’s where hacking phones and tracking down signals comes in.”

It takes them a good couple of hours to finally reach the end of this trail of breadcrumbs, Tim will give Grenada that. But it’s inevitable and they do eventually find his hiding spot. It is tucked neatly into an inconspicuous corner of the Upper East Side, far away from where anyone would usually look for the likes of Grenada.

There’s also a surprisingly high amount of goons in there and that worries Tim. They make quick work of them, yes, so it's not like it's a problem. But it's a curiosity that there’s this much security in place, a pattern-breaker, and Tim has learned to take careful note of those.

Because, sure, Grenada is being extra cautious because he broke a deal with the Bats and he knows he’ll be a target (he over-estimates the priority with which they’re trying to track him down, but inflated ego is a given with criminals of this caliber). It’s only natural that there would be more henchmen around than if it was business-as-usual, especially if he’s trying to pull off something big.

But it's been only a week since he broke out.

After he was sent to jail, most of his men have been recruited out by competition or swallowed by other branches of the gang he is part of. Gathering this much personnel should've taken him... a bit longer, at least. If he wasn't spending twice the "market price" per goon, that is. The fact that he seems to have the operation — whatever it might be — up and ready to go already is an unexpected addition to the case file.

It doesn’t stop them, of course. Within two minutes of approaching the first gate, Robin gently places the last man on the floor, then busts open the door to the room where Grenada should be.

Inside, of course, is the mobster in question, already pointing his gun at the door. He’s one of the few people that actually try to *keep track* of his men, so Tim expected him to have the door at gunpoint *the moment* they’ve taken out the first two thugs watching the back.

And because Tim *expected it*, he’s *prepared* for it.

He enters the room in a single low lunge, moving close to the floor. The predicted first shot (two shots, to be exact) whoosh past him way too high to ever have a chance of hitting their intended target. It’s a good call though; the goal was probably to double-tap the center of mass instead of going for a risky headshot or hoping for a single-bullet kill, Tim notices with approval.

In the three seconds it takes Grenada to correct his aim, Robin’s got a batarang in his hand. The moment the mobster fires again, Tim’s own projectile is already in the air, and him halfway through the motion of a dodge roll to the side. The batarang hits Grenada’s hand

hard enough to cause him to drop the weapon with a loud groan of pain. Within a blink of an eye, Robin is next to the man with his staff extended, one end pressing against his throat.

He tsk's disapprovingly, which is a neat little feature he's added after Cassie pointed out the breathing thing (you need air passing through your lips to tsk, after all).

"I thought we had an *agreement*," he says, shaking his head, slowly moving towards the man to push his back against the wall.

Robin, much like Impulse, doesn't seem very *intimidating* at a glance, thanks to his rather small body. But many people have learned to fear his *calculated precision* instead. Even if Grenada *forgot* that tiny detail, though, Tim made sure to drive the point home just now by being one step ahead of whatever the man could've done. Thus, the mobster starts sweating.

"What do you want?" Grenada barks out. His eyes dart around the room, seeking a way out. As expected, they land onto the poorly-obscured secret door on the side just in time for Cassie to open them and casually lean against the door frame.

"I think you know that, Raymond. I'm here to talk about Bastian."

"You sick fucks," Grenada says with a snarl, re-focusing on Robin and their conversation now that he knows all his escape routes are busted. "You knew I'd be looking for my kid. The place was wiretapped, wasn't it?"

"Man, I wish planting bugs in government-controlled buildings was as easy as you guys think it is," Robin rolls his eyes, but because of the domino's whiteouts covering them, half of the gesture is lost on his interlocutor. "Where's the boy?"

"You think I'll play your games?"

Robin tilts his head, frowning. "What games?"

"You want me to believe you don't know where he is?"

Cassie nods ever-so-slightly at Robin, signalling she's ready to make the guy soil his pants and tell them the truth, whole truth and only truth, but Tim decides it's not needed just yet.

"You think *we* have him," he says slowly. Grenada making that assumption would explain why he was willing to hire basically any henchman for any price, resulting in him getting an impressively big employee force on such a short notice; he was apparently preparing for a war with Batman.

Which means he *really* loves his kid. It's noted in Tim's memory as both heartwarmingly impressive, and something to use for leverage later. Tim, of course, already knew Grenada's willing to give up money and power for his son, but this is honestly taking it to another level. It's not surprising to him how strong human bonds can be and to what ends they can lead them — he's seen it for himself many times — but it is a good reminder that even people *this* morally... questionable still operate under the same premises as everyone else.

“I break outta jail and my kid’s gone, miraculously, right from under the cops’ watchful eyes. And now you waltz in here. Obviously, you wanna scare me into dealing with you Bats again.”

The logic would be sound, Tim has to admit. If that was how they operated, that is. And if the police in Gotham wasn’t corrupted to the roots, allowing anyone with enough money on their hands to basically do whatever they please.

So Robin just sighs dismissively.

"Listen, that’s a solid take, but the actual situation is as follows: your kid’s gone and I don’t know where he is. His chances of survival diminish with every passing minute. You’re not exactly in the position to be stubborn here,” he says, pressing the mobster a little further into the wall. “And honestly, I really have better plans for the evening than dealing with you and your conspiracy theories.”

Grenada scowls and spits under Robin’s feet. “Go fuck yourself, brat.”

Tim will have to figure it out on his own, or at least trick the man into spilling some info, then. Robin frowns, then takes a step back, letting Cassie keep Grenada in place.

“I don’t have Bastian. You don’t have Bastian. The list of people you’ve pissed off over the years is quite long, as you probably remember from the last time we’ve had a discussion like this. Let’s reiterate—” he starts to monologue, walking circles around the room. He’s hoping that Grenada will give him a hint by reacting to the ideas and assumptions he’s throwing out there. A grimace, a frown, a sigh. Anything that could indicate Tim’s onto something.

“—The Deacons, the Steel Cobras and the Jade Tigers all have beef with you, but not big enough to warrant this kinda reaction. Among people who *would* want some immediate revenge there’s Dockyard Dogs who you’ve crossed multiple times, but I know for a fact they have their hands full at the moment, and there’s Cosa Nostra, but they wouldn’t go as far as to kidnap a kid... The Whisper Gang hates you the most, I think, but they’re too small-minded to pull something like this off, and they wouldn’t work with the Riddler anyway...”

“You’re trying to scare me with Riddler now? Really? I’m not a moron.” He just looks the mobster up and down but doesn’t say anything to that remark. It’s enough to prompt Grenada to elaborate. “I crossed many people in my life, but definitely not the green psycho.”

“Riddler can be bought and you know it.”

“No Gotham mobster wants to deal with the Arkham bunch.”

Robin perks up, straightening his spine, then grins.

“No. Not any Gotham one,” he says, peeking at Cassie, who seems to slowly be catching on, too. Grenada does look a bit confused, though, so he addresses him again. “Do you have enemies from *outside* Gotham?”

“Like I would tell you.” The man tightens his jaw, staring at Robin intensely, for a good half a minute. It doesn’t seem like he’s going to spill any beans anytime soon, which while annoying, Tim definitely finds impressive.

But mostly annoying. He needs to find an angle that’ll chip away at Grenada’s conviction that this is all but a ruse on their side. He has an inkling of what might be up and if he gets it right, it might click for the mobster too. But he wants to make sure first, just in case, so he needs help from the rest of the team.

“Impulse, Superboy, do you have anything?” he chimes directly in his teammates’ comms while Robin maintains a silent staring contest with Grenada. It’s a neat feature of being an AI — you can choose which speaker your voice actually can be heard out of.

“No dice, Rob,” Kon replies right away, which means they aren’t doing much at the moment, sadly. “We thought we got something from one of the street girls, but they don’t really want to talk with us. Now we just keep running into dead ends.”

“Check the docks for me please. Look for boats ready to depart, with non-Gotham IDs, possibly guarded, on the smaller side but not yachts. You know, the general cause of suspicion. And make **absolutely** sure you aren’t seen.”

“On it.” Tim expects the line to fall silent for at least a moment as SB does brief recon, but Bart chimes in instead.

“You have a lead?”

“Yeah. Yeah, I think I do. We found Grenada, but he doesn’t seem to have the kid. Just like we’ve warned him, someone else is using his son to gain leverage on him, it seems.”

“And you think they’re going to try to smuggle the kid out?”

“Yeah. If I’m correct-”

“R versus the world, a point for Rob,” Superboy interrupts him. “Aside from some disturbing dealings that I sadly know are pretty normal for Gotham, I saw one particularly suspicious ship. There’s a couple of gunmen guarding the dock, a few more on the ship, two guys arguing in the cabin, and if my x-ray vision for once is accurate in this forsaken city, a restrained kid under the deck.”

“Great. Keep an eye on it. Be there soon.”

He pretends to type something into his terminal for a moment, just for his cover’s sake. Then focuses back on Grenada.

“So, no thanks to you, I’ve got a plan. Here’s what we’re going to do,” he begins, snapping the terminal back into the gauntlet with a satisfying click, “I’m going to try to grab your son before your *pals* from the Italian mafia ship him out of the city-”

“How’d you know I-”

“I know I look like I’m twelve, but I thought we established that I’m a seasoned vigilante who can dodge your bullets and put you into jail. I don’t understand why you’re still surprised that I saw right through you.” Robin sighs in exasperation. “Only organized, out-of-town criminals have the money, connections and audacity to get Riddler involved. When you couldn’t be found, those guys targeted your family, which is a very mob-family way of dealing with things. I’m about 100% sure it’s mafia. Running that against your out-of-town affairs and who might possibly have some beef with you... the results are like 80% Italian-origin names.” Tim looks at Raymond’s sceptical face. “There’s some of them at the docks right now. Want to bet the kid they have is Bastian? If those guys manage to get your boy out of the city limits, chances that anyone will ever see him again are basically zero. So, please cooperate.”

Grenada snarls in response. Tim has *had* it with this man’s unwillingness to work with him, so he decides to make his point *a little clearer*. (It might be because Bruce is usually just as stubborn, but Tim can’t do anything about B being like that. It might be Tim taking out his frustrations here instead. Nobody will ever know.)

Robin slips under Cassie’s arm effortlessly and approaches Grenada with one swift, graceful move. He grabs the man by the throat, lifting slightly and pushing him against the wall again. Their faces are barely an inch or two away as he stares him in the eye with a blank expression on; not even a frown, just clear, cold stoicism.

“When I say ‘*please cooperate*’, ” he says, his fingers tightening *ever-so-slightly* around the mobster’s throat, “I’m not **asking**.”

Eventually, after a few heartbeats of silence, Grenada slowly nods, just a *smidge* tenser than before.

“Glad we’re finally on the same page.” Robin smiles and sets him down, surprisingly gently. “Wonder Girl, grab him and let’s get to the others as fast as we can.”

Cassie grunts an agreement and though Grenada doesn’t seem to like it, he has no vote in that matter — she hauls both him and Robin like they’re sacks of potatoes, and flies them to the docks. She lands on the roof of one of the more remote warehouses knowing that much like Kon, they, too, don’t want to attract any attention. Within moments, Superboy joins them, and Impulse does too, by almost propelling himself over the edge of the roof with excess momentum.

The moment his feet touch the surface of the roof, Robin starts scanning the docks, looking for their target. Kon conveniently points him in the right direction.

“How’d you know they’re going to leave by boat?” asks Bart. Robin doesn’t even look away from the suspiciously ordinary, small cargo ship he’s zooming in at.

“Gotham doesn’t have an airport,” he begins while he mentally maps out the amount and placement of henchmen onboard of the ship and around the docks; there’s more of them than he initially expected, but it’s nothing they can’t handle. “And this is the next best way to lose any law enforcement trying to get in the way. Also, I hate open water and Riddler knows it.”

“What do you have against water?”

“Do you realise how hard it is to get a good, stable signal 50 miles into the ocean?”

“Fair point.” Superboy nods, then stretches. His body language says he’s bored and Tim can’t blame him. If it was up to him, he’d rush the ship the moment he found the kid. “What’s the plan? There aren’t enough people there to really cause us problems, are there?”

“If we go in, Bastian Grenada will be the first victim of that skirmish,” Robin says, finally blinking the zoom away and looking straight at Kon. “They’re only keeping him in hopes of luring his father out. If they ever feel endangered, he’s no longer worth it.”

Grenada’s face twitches ever-so-slightly, which lets Tim know the man finally is taking it seriously. Bart winces more visibly, also obviously disturbed by the suggestion. “So what are we...?”

“We’re going to trade captives.”

“What?!”

Robin passively notices that the mobster still held by Cassie tenses up, but he can’t discern what he thinks about the proposed plan. Tim doesn’t let up, though. “They’re after Grenada. If we offer them what they *truly* want, they will probably give us the kid.”

“But they’ll have his father.”

“Zeroth law of robotics,” he quickly retorts, then realises he’ll have to elaborate. “In the grand scheme of things, that’s better for humanity in general. The kid’s innocent, or at the very least less morally dubious than his father. Grenada’s also the very reason his child is in danger, and he really cares about his son. Of course, we’re going to try to save them both, but I’d much rather risk Grenada’s life than his son’s. Are you going to argue with this plan?”

He specifically looks at the man in question when he asks that. He gets just a nod in response. His teammates are silent for a few moments, then Cassie speaks up. “What do you need us to do?”

Robin gets as close to the ship as he can without revealing his position, just in case something goes south and he has to get to the kid as fast as possible. Once he’s reached the cargo containers at the very front, he drops to the roof of the bottom one, letting his boots make a loud thud as he lands. Everyone’s eyes are immediately on him. The leader — Tim knows he’s the leader because instead of raising his gun, he motions to his subordinates — rushes to the cabin’s window to get a better look at the situation.

Face recognition paired with what he already knows suggests it’s Clemente Giorno, the older son of the guy who’s running weapon trade in the next state over. That itself doesn’t tie them to Grenadas, but with a lil’ bit more searching Tim finds that Grenada and his gang was out

of town when Giorno's younger brother died in a shootout a year back. It doesn't take a genius to connect those facts with the current situation and give Giorno's a clear motive.

"What is the brat doing here?! You promised Bats won't find out!" the man yells, turning to the other one in the cabin. Only then Tim recognises his interlocutor — Riddler. It's weird to see him in a non-green getup, and it manages to throw Tim's recognition patterns off for a moment, so he frowns. Weirdly enough, that seems to be exactly what Riddler wanted to see.

"No," Riddler replies calmly, with a sleazy grin on his face. It confirms Tim's suspicion that there's more to this deal for Riddler than just money for the job. "I just said they *won't interfere*. And I intend to keep it that way."

It sounds like a threat and the stare Riddler gives him is telling him that the intuition is correct. But Tim has more pressing matters than Riddler's games, because one of the goons just disappeared under the deck with a gun, so he immediately yells:

"I know you have Bastian!" He's using a megaphone (he *could* just up the volume in his speakers but that'd blow his human cover) so his hands are busy, therefore it's Superboy that carefully brings their own hostage into the scene, from behind a shipping container a few feet to the side. Robin points at them. "To ensure his safety, I'm offering to give you Raymond Grenada!"

Giorno squints, which is a fair reaction to a vigilante making such an offer. After a moment he grins, says something to the guy that's under the deck and waves his hand in their direction, signalling for them to get closer. As per the plan, Superboy starts slowly walking forwards, dragging Grenada along.

"No!" Riddler shouts, pointing at Robin. "Leave the meta out of it! *You* bring Grenada here!"

Robin looks him up and down, calculating, but he doesn't know enough about Riddler's motives to figure out what the trap is; not in the short time that he has before everybody gets way too tense. So he nods. Puts the megaphone down and — with arms raised high above his head to keep everyone off their triggers — makes his way down from the shipping container, then over to Superboy and Grenada.

Kon's face is only *slightly* tight, which in his body language means "are you sure?". On that account, Tim gives him his signature "*just follow the plan*" stare and grabs Grenada's arm.

The armed goon emerges with the kid in tow soon after. Giorno and his men escort them off the ship, guns at the ready, while Nygma cautiously stays behind.

He's also *grinning*, and that's *bad*. Robin can't stop now, he doesn't have time to pause and re-analyze. He hates it. Sure, he's got enough contingencies in place to come out on top in the end, but Riddler knows Tim hasn't been able to see through him yet and *revels* in it.

Fuck.

The goon's dragging the kid with him aggressively while Robin slowly makes his way towards them with Grenada held firmly against his side. He tries to look friendly for the

absolutely *terrified* boy across from him, tries to convey with his facial expression alone that it's soon going to be over, that he's going to be alright. He knows that whatever happens, the team will keep the kid *safe*, physically, but he'd like to avoid causing him any more trauma than he's already raked in.

They're about fifteen feet apart when shit hits the fan.

First, Robin notices out of the corner of his eye that Riddler reaches under his jacket which, well, is bad (they're *prepared* for bad, but still). Then he hears an ominous *click* and sees something moving on the kid's *damn belt buckle*. He has precisely one-and-a-half seconds to process and react, and so Robin's defensive protocols kick in; he reaches for his batarang to try and disarm whatever Riddler put on the kid before it can go off. What the intention manifests as is Robin cutting the buckle clean off the belt, causing the mechanism to fall to the ground.

Then everything *goes to hell*.

Robin's quick, sudden movements predictably make both the guy holding Basian and Giorno himself feel threatened; that results in them yelling and opening fire, and the rest of the armed goons follow suit. When that happens, Superboy — as instructed — rushes in, superhuman speed engaged, to protect the kid; using his own bullet-proof body as a shield if he has to. Impulse runs over to the site of ensuing violence, taking one of the gunners down with the sheer force of impact as he passes, and Cassie swoops down onto them to subdue the situation further.

He doesn't pay much attention to what his teammates are doing, though; he trusts them to handle their part of the scuffle, and has his own role to play in this anyway. The plan is that Robin will protect Grenada to the best of his ability, hopefully without compromising his human cover, and he fully intends to do that. He whips around and attempts to create a barrier between them and assumed explosive with his reinforced cape — it won't do much at this range, but it's *something*.

Then, in a flash of blue light, Robin's systems suddenly disconnect from the BatCave.

He freezes in surprise; queries are dropped and pings left unanswered, so his mind blanks out for a hot second as he turns on his battle auto-pilot procedures and re-arranges the mangled processes back into shape. There's a tingling sensation on his skin and the system status reports critical failure on the comm-link modules. That makes it dawn on him what just happened, and he swears under his nose as a result.

An EMP.

Internal systems are all well-protected of course; have been ever since the last time he got zapped and taken out completely. But for the Robin-mainframe link to work, he has to have his connection hardware installed outside of the insulating casing. In situations like this, that still gets fried.

There are no other note-worthy electronics anywhere around, so the fact that the device Riddler decided to install was an EMP makes his motivations clear. It means the entire deal

he's made with Giorno, the whole charade with Grenadas and the breadcrumbs he's left in the camera recordings — was just to lure Robin out. It means Riddler figured out Robin's possibly only weakness, and this has been a way to test his theory out.

Fuck Riddler.

“Comms down!” Robin yells to his teammates to let them know he's not going to hear them through that channel, but barely gets an acknowledgement of the fact because they're in the middle of an ongoing battle.

“We know!” Impulse groans as a response loudly and Robin notices he's addressing his own earpiece rather than him directly. “Shut up T! You're doubling up! We'll get you back together ASAP!”

That can only mean that the mainframe Tim has noticed, too, and as per usual is freaking out a little. The team hadn't agreed to install any on-suit cameras so far, so without Robin's eyes, Tim's blind in areas where surveillance cameras aren't available. He doesn't *like* being cut off, especially when there's action, thus slight panic is always a given.

(It's not like Tim has, you know, some kind of *phobia* of Robin going offline. But it's not the most pleasant thing to lose contact with your friends and to abruptly and violently lose a piece of your mind; the feeling of sudden alienation and missing data isn't something you can get used to. It's especially nasty on the Robin side, making the process of reintegrating R back into Tim's memory system a rather rough ride every time. Fortunately, it is a little smoother if he expects the disconnect and eases himself into it.)

It seems like all three of his teammates turn off their comms when Tim is unable to keep his distress quiet, though. He'll be frustrated and annoyed and all sorts of irked about it, but will eventually understand, especially when he gets to re-connect and experiences the outright *chaos* that just went down. Having both instances of him talking at the same time when he's not only out-of-sync, but also can't even hear himself, is the last thing they'd want mid-fight.

Speaking of mid-fight, Robin looks around to gauge how deep in shit he is, because his predictive tactics scripts take over his motor systems for a moment and he dodges some danger that he doesn't even consciously notice.

The kid's safe, that's good, but pretty much takes SB out of the equation, leaving Cassie and Bart to handle the majority of Giorno's entourage. It's not a problem, but means that it's up to Robin to take care of the rest of the place. Which does in fact present as a problem, because Robin — still slightly off of his game — is in close quarters with the guy who's been holding Bastian; a tall blonde man, staring Robin down with face twisted in a hostile grimace.

And pointing his gun square at Robin's head.

Fantastic.

Robin immediately dodges, before the guy manages to fully fire the gun, once again saved by his automated reactions. Judging by the sound, the bullet hits something else than the dock's concrete ground behind him, but he doesn't have time to worry about that now.

The plan of action is, as always, distract-disarm-disable. So, Robin promptly connects his fist with the guy's face, a quick uppercut landing right beneath the jawline (which, with how tall his opponent is, requires Robin to stand on tippy-toes; one more reason to consider redesigning his body soon). If Robin were to use his full strength, the fight would've ended at that. Most bones don't really stand a chance against his mechanical power, which is exactly why he doesn't usually use all of it; not against unarmored, regular goons at least. Still, the sharp jab of pain from even a weak jaw hit is guaranteed to briefly daze *anyone*, and R uses that to deliver a roundhouse kick across the guy's torso. It's enough to loosen his grip on the gun and with a swift strike to the hands, make him let go of it completely.

Without a weapon in his hands though, there's only one way the man can proceed; he surges forwards with an impressive battle cry on his lips, attempting to grab Robin and wrestle him onto the ground. It's a solid strategy, as his sheer mass and size would be a great advantage in a scuffle like that. Luckily, Robin's superior reflexes (and the sneaky way his joints have *slightly* better range of motion than a human's would) allow him to move out of harm's way with time to spare; he gracefully avoids the grapple by vaulting over the guy, letting momentum trip his opponent and send him stumbling forwards. With that, he spins around, kicks the man's knee hard enough to hear the distinct, unpleasant crack of a busted kneecap. Then, finally delivers a final blow to the back of the guy's head to knock him out.

Once the immediate threat is taken care of, Robin finally has a moment to re-initialize his systems properly and adjust to the new working conditions in relative peace. He's not worried about the rest of the fight — his friends can handle a couple of average, human goons; they're an elite team of superheroes, are they not? So, even though it takes maybe 5 seconds tops for him to reboot everything, when he finishes and re-assesses the situation pretty much everything is done already. Giorno's disarmed and restrained, his goons are all unconscious, Bastian's safe and sound and tucked behind Kon, and Grenada senior is bleeding out on the ground.

— wait what?

He reaches the wounded mobster in record time, joining Wonder Girl at the man's side. Upon further investigation, R comes to two conclusions; one, the wounds were probably caused by the bullets that Robin has dodged, and two, Cassie's efforts to stop the bleeding are mostly pointless. While a gunshot wound, even to the chest, weirdly isn't statistically very fatal on its own (about 18% mortality rate, tops), without professional medical attention given in the next 2 minutes (something they cannot provide) Grenada's going to simply bleed out.

Robin administers a local anaesthetic to the injured area; he's not cruel, and ensuring the man can say his goodbyes in peace is the least he can do. But he's also not affected by the entire thing, either. It's sad, sure, but the risk was included a part of his plan — as always when humans and guns are involved, especially so when said humans hate each other — and he's not going to weep about losing a criminal. It's not like he was *friends* with the guy.

Grenada, very aware of life slipping through his fingers with every beat of his heart, reaches out towards his son. While the man is by no means a good person, Robin understands that he still possesses human emotions; is still capable of love, even if expressed in a non-standard

way. As such, he deserves basic human respect, and in this case it means allowing him this last chance to reconnect with his family.

Interrupting would be pointless anyway, since in his state Grenada's pretty much harmless. Bastian, though, doesn't know that; the boy seems scared and doesn't reciprocate his father's gesture at all. Instead, the boy hides further behind Superboy, who he apparently considers a safe haven now.

It's understandable. He's five years old and hasn't interacted with Grenada much lately. He probably doesn't even recognise the man as family. The understanding doesn't make it any less heart-wrenching to watch Grenada realize it and wrestle with that feeling as he draws his last breaths.

Trying not to think about it too hard, Robin turns his attention to the last important piece of the case instead. The piece that is apparently missing.

"Where's Riddler?" he asks quietly, plainly, but for his friends, it's obvious that he's suppressing either anger or just simple, concentrated *exhaustion* at how wrong everything is today.

Superboy gestures towards the pier. The mooring rope is dangling off it, loose, and upset waves crash against the shore. Robin can see the ship in the distance, speeding out into the open sea, most probably with Riddler on board. He must've predicted the pandemonium his explosive was going to cause. Possibly never intended to actually have the entire encounter go over normally in the first place, staying back on the ship precisely to get away safely. He knows of Robin's issue with open water, after all, and probably hoped the rest of the team would be too busy to catch him in time.

Robin curses under his nose. He'll have to later figure out Riddler's real motive, his gain from this.

"Are you okay?" Cassie leans towards him with worry in her eyes and all Robin can do is shrug.

"I've had worse. Let's wrap this up before GCPD gets a whiff of this mess and—"

Then they hear distant police sirens, the officers apparently deciding for once to react to a shooting in the docks, and groan in unison.

An hour later, Robin ends up in an interrogation room, a bit grumbly since he's yet to reconnect with the mainframe. He hasn't managed to get the team to scatter before police got to the scene, but he did get Gordon to focus solely on him. He's intending to take full blame for this wreck of a case — he's the only one who doesn't have a civilian ID, so he can accumulate as many "criminal records" as he wants.

But Commissioner Gordon isn't a fool. Even though he's aware he has little jurisdiction over the other Titans and no real way to penalize them, he seems to be fully intending to at the

very least grill Robin thoroughly. Maybe it's because he never can get Batman to listen to his arguments, so he at least wants to instill some sense in Robin? Maybe because Robin's been getting on Gordon's nerves a lot in the past, making decisions that are... questionable to humans? Maybe it's just that Gordon's been having a rough time lately and their stunt was just the straw that broke the camels back. Who knows.

The only thing Robin knows is that Gordon looks like he's more dissatisfied than he expects him to be. Upon closer consideration though, it seems justified — they've caused someone to die, dragged the Feds into Gotham by getting into a shootout with out-of-town mafia, and let Riddler escape on top of that.

Robin becomes even more grumbly upon that realization.

They sit in the bare room for a good couple of minutes in perfect silence, save for the high-pitched noise of the flickering neon light above them; even though Robin's not planning on making a move anytime soon, it seems like Commissioner Gordon is trying to wait him out. Finally, the man breaks, sighs in annoyance, then looks Robin straight in the eyes from across the table with a very, very sour expression. He looks like he wants to ask where Batman is and if he knew about all this, if he allowed for it, but after all these years he knows better than to ask those kinds of questions. He isn't getting an answer anyway.

"Were you and the rest of your team attempting to solve the case of Bastian Grenada's disappearance?" he asks instead.

Robin's lips are a perfectly straight, thin line as he answers; the question catches him slightly off-guard, as he assumed the answer would be obvious. "Indeed." The fact that Gordon still decides to ask means he is leading up to something bigger with this interrogation.

"By tracking his father, Raymond Grenada?"

He nods in silence.

"And you're the one who decided not to hand Grenada over to the police immediately upon finding him?"

"Correct." Robin starts to catch on to what is the point and he doesn't like it, doesn't like it even *one bit*.

"Knowing that Riddler's scheming was involved?"

"Yes."

"Was the decision to do so a personal one?"

Robin understands what Gordon's suggesting. That he *enjoys* the games with Riddler, at some level, and that he would *jeopardize someone's safety* for that enjoyment. True, he sometimes sneaks in puzzles for the man into Arkham, but it's because he *calculated* that would keep him locked better, longer, safer. Not because he seeks the rivalry out, and especially not *like this*.

“A young boy’s life was at stake,” he begins, staring at the Commissioner. He’s accentuating each word, his tone as neutral as it gets, just a smidge away from *emotionless*. He knows it can and will be interpreted as (controlled) rage, but he doesn’t care. He’s being *factual*. “I ran the probability of his survival if we didn’t meet the demand and it wasn’t good. If you want to punish me for taking that risk, then I encourage you to do so, but do not put the rest of my team on trial for something that I suggested.”

As predicted, the Commissioner raises his hand to hush him.

“Calm down, boy-”

But R is having none of it. “This is calm, and it’s ‘Robin’.”

Silence falls between them again. Robin makes no effort at making it any less tense. After a while, Gordon stands up, looking like he’s aged ten years since entering the room, and leaves without another word. He knows he’s not going to win this battle.

He (or anyone else, for that matter) never wins any verbal battles with Robin, but it’s a lesson that needs reinforcing every so often, apparently.

Luckily, his subordinates have more sense. Following that incident, nobody in GCPD ever questions Robin’s capability to make a call again. Tim’s not sure if it’s because they think he’s making good decisions, or because they’re simply afraid to contest him if even the Commissioner gave up on it.

Chapter End Notes

Refs and memes in this chapter:

[Supers aren't especially useful in Gotham](#)

[When I say 'Please cooperate', I'm not asking](#)

[Zeroth Law of Robotics](#)

[EMP](#)

[This is calm, and its 'doctor'.](#)

P.S. If you see any bad wording, mistakes or typos, please tell me!

Chapter 7

Chapter Summary

Enter Red Hood.

Chapter Notes

Trigger warnings for this chapter: Canon-typical Violence, Temporary Robot Character Death (detailed scene)

This chapter is a little short because it was originally together with the previous one, but I decided that dropping the entire 13k monster on people all at once wasn't a good idea.

See the end of the chapter for [more notes](#)

Once Bruce wakes up and gets better it all goes back to normal. Well, as normal as it can be. When you're a vigilante, especially in Gotham, normalcy is a very weird thing. You get clown serial murderers on the regular, for example (used to, at least; Tim's sorted that one out).

That's why, because of the constant, lingering slight *paranoia*, the package that arrives one day at the doorstep of Wayne Manor doesn't surprise them; rather *makes them think*. Sure, it could be from some *fan* of Brucie, he's a public persona after all, right? But those people usually tend to leave a message, something to identify them by.

This one is just a neatly packed first edition of "To Kill a Mockingbird". In perfect condition, no less, a true *rara avis*. Bruce scans the package first and foremost, to make sure it's safe, then pulls the book out of the plain-looking brown paper and pages through it, as if looking for clues. It's obvious it is meant to intrigue him, and it does. The question is, why?

"I have a theory," Tim begins tentatively as they scan the book for any DNA residue or fingerprints (there are none). The tone is uncommon for him, so Bruce immediately looks up at him. It's enough of a sign for Tim to continue. "It's Jason."

Alfred stops halfway through preparing tea a couple of meters away. BatCave fills with heavy silence for a moment. Bruce frowns, so Tim elaborates, running a history check of the book (it's been bought with cash — and a lot of it — from a physical bookstore. Do they have cameras anywhere nearby?...)

“The theme is Jason. Whoever sent this, wanted us to think of him. Publicly, you don’t have much to do with books other than your expansive library, but it’s been Jason’s hobby to collect first editions like this one.”

There’s a glimmer of understanding in B’s eyes as listens to Tim’s words. He doesn’t have to say a word of reply for both Tim and Alfred to know what he’s thinking. They aren’t, you know, telepathic, but they know each other well enough to have half of their conversations silently at this point. There’s only one suspect; the only one who’d try to annoy B with the memory of Jason like this is the Joker. But Joker doesn’t know his identity, and the probability he knows of Jason’s hobbies is low, too.

“It’s not his MO, either. Besides, he’s still safely locked away,” Tim adds to counter the Joker hypothesis. Then he displays the conclusion of his scans and searches: the sender has a lot of spare money and *knows* what they’re doing. They left no digital traces of the purchase, not a single clue at all of who they might be, nothing. It’s like the book just popped out of existence for the brief time between the sale and when it arrived at the Manor. It’s impressive, really, this level of thoroughness at covering up your tracks. “But you remember back then? Jay’s grave was robbed and we never could find out by who or why. It might be related.”

Alfred sighs. He doesn’t like to be reminded of that incident. None of them do. Bruce frowns deeper, because he’s still angry about not finding the culprit. It does feel like they’ve failed Jason again, Tim can agree, but it’s related to the issue at hand, so he *had to* remind them of it.

Even if they can’t really do much about it at the moment.

“There’s someone out there that’s very good, knows too much and is trying to get to us. We should... watch out.”

B nods, still looking deeply troubled.

Their worries only deepen when the city — and, by proxy, them — gains a whole new issue to deal with.

Gotham’s newest... menace is a criminal fresh on the scene, possibly *en route* to becoming a big player. He’s not exactly a priority enemy; what he’s doing is kinda-sorta working towards declining crime rates in the city, as his territories tend to be safer for kids (they immediately profile him as someone who suffered first-hand from the woes of street life as a child). But he’s definitely not harmless either. He takes over several branches of the drug trade and runs them with an iron grip, only worsening the tension between the various mobs and mafias of Gotham. That increases the gang activity in the remaining sectors as they attempt to even out their losses by getting additional revenue elsewhere.

All in all, it’s a change they’d certainly rather go without, especially with the shadow of a personal adversary looming in the backs of their minds.

It also doesn’t help his case that his chosen name is Red Hood — a name that though used by many various criminals through the years, at the very beginning belonged to the Joker.

Neither of them believes in coincidences, too, so the conclusion is obvious; the two issues, the package and the new criminal, are clearly connected, and that puts them on edge.

But that's Gotham.

Far away in San Francisco, another one of Tim's bodies, another Robin has, in comparison, a rather uneventful life.

Until.

Tim's only hint that something is off is the alert he gets from the Tower's security systems. They aren't set up to notify him every time someone enters, especially not when it's completely legal and within the protocol, but it's late on Sunday night and most people are already asleep, or home. It's an unusual time for someone to come in, and that's why he gets a ping. He decides to check up on the cause of the ping — maybe Mia forgot something, or Bart decided to stay over and continue their last discussion, after all? — but Tim's not worried.

Because, you see, in the Titans Tower, Tim feels relatively *safe*. He doesn't know what's happening in the entire building at all times as he does in the Manor — while the system is his to govern, at the moment at least, it's not *him*; it's simply easy to access, easy to integrate into. But there are seasoned heroes all around and his body is perfectly capable of holding his own, too.

He's also not worried when the connection between his mainframe and his body fizzles out. It's not sudden — there's a storm raging *right* above San Francisco, so he's been expecting it to happen sooner or later. The connection's been slow and wonky at best the past few hours anyway (it's not Gotham and its 120% signal coverage after all). He could, of course, connect via Wi-Fi but that's just another can of worms; from his experience, issues with security and transfer capacity of the public connection just aren't worth the hassle. So when the ping reaches over 9000ms Tim simply gives up on trying to keep up with the lagging info streaming between his locations. He's completely capable of operating solo as Robin for a good while without freaking out these days, so Tim focuses back at home, where he and Bruce are working on gathering more leads on Red Hood. He leaves Robin to his own devices, planning to sync up memories when the connection is better.

He never gets to do that, and only knows what happens to Robin after 09:29 PM thanks to the Titans recovering the black box module later.

And what happens is this:

Robin is sitting on the floor of the second level, by the window, watching the raindrops hit the glass. His big bag full of assorted equipment is right next to him because he's checking and cleaning his stuff like he always does when people go to sleep. Then the notification comes, and he heads for the entrance on the ground level to check up on who came back in. When he finds nobody there, he begins to be a bit suspicious. But it's possible the person

already went further into the Tower — especially if it's Bart — to grab that last thing they forgot or something, so he's not *too* worried.

He does look around a little more, though, is a little more careful. It's probably the only thing that keeps him from getting his nose smashed in a while later; when he notices movement out of the shadows on his right side, he dodges. Makes the best manoeuvre to avoid the incoming blow: immediately drops down and away into a slight crouch, twisting to the side a bit, letting the weapon — something long and narrow, he takes note — pass over his head while he covers himself with his arm. With the offender now up close and open, their momentum working against them, Robin delivers a retaliation strike right to their stomach — but it is blocked, the other end of the weapon swinging back in just in time. There's a weird clang as his fist makes contact with the pole his opponent is using, and it begins to vibrate in resonance; it must be metal, too.

After that, as if satisfied with their exchange, the attacker disengages, casually jumping away.

“Hey there, kiddo.”

Robin knows the voice. He's heard it before, though not up close and in person like this.

He straightens up, gives the man a quick look-over to confirm his suspicions. Combat boots, cargo pants, plain black t-shirt, leather jacket, signature full-face red helmet. Yep, confirms his initial identification alright.

“Red Hood.”

Robin connects the facts easily, even without all of the mainframe's info and power available. The guy who picked up Joker's old *nom de guerre* shows up at the Tower; everybody except Robin is mysteriously missing or unresponsive. It's clear that Robin is the target. The guy knows. He knows about Red Hood and Joker, and about Joker and Robin, and decided to insert himself into that loaded past.

This is *personal*. Robin doesn't like when villains get personal with him.

“Dead right, Boy Wonder,” is the answer. The ironic note isn't lost on Robin and neither is the pun, clearly meant as a veiled threat. He's also about 90% sure the man is smirking under the helmet. Robin concludes his adversary must be someone with a knack for dramatics. He's half expecting a villainous monologue.

But Hood raises his chin in a challenge instead, waves at Robin to come closer. Robin notices the thing he's twirling in his hands — the thing he intended to knock him out with — is not some random metal stick, but his own bo staff. He frowns. How'd he get that? How long has he been here? And, more importantly, how did he get into the Tower in the first place? Is everyone else okay?

“What do you want?” Robin asks instead of indulging Hood's bait.

His opponent throws the staff away, then reaches up for the helmet on his head. With a soft hiss, it opens, revealing his face; though the eyes remain covered with a classic domino mask

in a nice, deep shade of black. Robin blinks in surprise — a very human habit he acquired some time ago — because the face seems... familiar. He can't connect back to run full facial recognition right now, but-

"I want to check something. I don't know what hole *you* crawled out of for B to brainwash you into being his next child soldier, but me? I am Gotham born and bred," Hood puts the helmet away on a nearby table. Slowly takes off his jacket then grabs the fabric of his remaining clothes tightly. "I slept on the streets, lived in the alleyways before he took me in."

Red Hood pulls, and the fabric he's holding onto rips easily, revealing the typical Robin red-green-yellow palette underneath, with the signature logo and everything. The man tosses his ripped clothing aside, remaining dressed only in a dated Robin costume.

Robin is rather confused, but he doesn't let it show. He can ask questions and run analyses later. Right now, he prepares for the inevitable next round — sets feet wider apart, squares shoulders, tightens fists — especially as he's got a good size disadvantage working against him. He can't leave this fight to automation. Firstly, Hood is no entry-level henchman; he's a seasoned fighter built entirely out of muscle, if that short exchange is anything to go by, and will hit like a tank. Secondly, not only is he not a simple goon, he's not even a normal human; Robin's military-grade hydraulic strength would've flung a normal person like a wet rag, but Hood barely budged.

"I trained as hard as I could. I did whatever Bruce asked... at least at first. But it all didn't matter. They said I wasn't *tough enough* to be Robin."

The recalibration of battle strategies comes to a screeching halt as Robin's mind flares up with all kinds of questions, and his eyes widen, half in shock, half in understanding. He'd gasp, too, if he could be bothered to breathe at that moment.

Bruce took him in. He was Robin. That old costume design. The familiar face. The voice! The voice is different, changed, but yes, it is similar-

"They say you *are*. So show me. Show me what you have that I didn't!"

But how? How? He's seen the body. It can't be. He's-

Robin's so preoccupied with his thoughts that he doesn't even notice when Red Hood lunges towards him, fist on a trajectory straight for his head.

The first thing that registers are all the alarms blaring in his mind about the damage done to the right side of his face. It's gonna be a pain in the ass to repair, he might need to replace the skin altogether, and he's pretty sure something broke in his jaw. Robin considers, briefly, that if it's this easy to throw him off his game, if all it takes is the mere *hint* of the impossible happening, then he should go back to Gotham and rethink his life before he embarrasses himself further. Coincidentally, Tim muses later as he revises these memories, he kind of ends up getting what he asks for.

The second thing that registers, from his senses this time, is the 360° spin his body is currently in the middle of doing. He quickly thinks that Hood has to be good, impressively

so, to pull off a hit like this, and that it spells nothing but trouble. It's not often that you meet someone that can strike hard enough to send Robin flying; he's an entire human frame made out of titanium and a dozen different electronics after all. Luckily, Robin manages to catch himself and tumble into a roll over his shoulder before he smacks onto the ground like a hand-less sock puppet. He looks up with resolve, setting his loosened jaw back into place.

The third thing that registers are the words.

"Surprised? Didn't he ever tell you about the failure that came before you?"

Robin almost bares his teeth (which is human for: anger, primal aggression) in reaction to the suggestion that his best friend, his personal idol, his *hero* was a *failure*. But he can't, he can't let this reaction take hold of him — especially not like this, not now, not while he has these *doubts*, these *questions*.

"How- "

Hood doesn't let up and interrupts him; delivers a few more blows, even throws a batarang at him. Yet this time around Robin is prepared, doesn't let the man get to him, dodges out of the way; at least most of the time. The hits are too fast and vicious for Robin to get a word in while avoiding getting wrecked.

It's not often that he finds himself in an uphill battle; but it's understandable between Hood's prowess, the doubt he instilled in Robin and Robin's own hesitance to put up a fight. He needs answers before he decides whenever he's willing to actually confront Red Hood. He needs to try to talk to him, *ask* about what he said, what he *implied*. To do that, he must even the odds out at the very least, so he steadily, step by step, moves towards his discarded staff with each dodge.

When he finally gets his hands on it, even with this advantage — because he always considers wielding his preferred weapon an advantage, regardless of how good the other party is — he just fends Hood's blows instead of striking back. It's easier, given that staves are quite literally designed for keeping people at a distance. He vehemently refuses to hit Hood until he gets answers, on the off-chance that he is somehow correct.

His opponent isn't too happy about it.

"What, not gonna hit back like earlier? Why aren't you trying to fight me? Your *kind Robin heart* can't take hitting a poor street kid like me? I ain't gonna go easy on you just because you decided to play a saint."

Robin uses this occasion to say something, something fast and short because Hood shifts his posture and Robin knows another barrage of blows is coming his way.

"You're Jason." It's not a question, not really. He's practically sure. It can't be anybody else. Despite there being absolutely *no* way of it making *any* sense according to the known laws of science, Robin is honestly almost certain it *must* be Jay.

The man narrows his eyes, then smiles in a wicked way. “I see you did your homework, at least.”

He forgives himself for eating a kick to the ribs this time. Robin attempts to block it, yes, but his grip is off, and all he achieves is getting the staff vaguely in-between his chest and Hood’s boot, barely making a difference.

But, hell, you can get a little distracted when trying to re-process science not adding up anymore *and* years of grief.

At the same time.

With a fraction of your usual computing capabilities as well, because *fuck* storms and *fuck* lack of signal.

In .7 seconds max, because that’s how much time he is given before the next hit comes and Robin stumbles back.

“They don’t make ‘em Robins like they used to, huh? You’re pathetic.”

Robin can’t really disagree at this point. Nearly two hundred thousand words in the English language, forty thousand of them that he knows how to use and pronounce, and all of them *fail him* at that moment. It *is* kind of pathetic. He finds himself unable to say anything to this man anymore. Because that was a *yes*. His words were a confirmation. What this man is saying is that Robin is correct in his deduction. That this is, in fact, Jason Todd; his hero, his friend, *his Robin* — somehow, miraculously, alive. What can be said to *that*?

Red Hood — *Jason* — advances, and shoves him back, hard, grabbing onto the staff to lock them together. In response Robin tries to back away, disengage, once again buy time to talk, to *explain*. But his back hits something, and when Hood keeps pushing, it gives under the pressure of their combined weight.

The glass shatters around them into a million tiny pieces and they fall one floor down, to the inner courtyard. Robin’s head is buzzing with even more alarms as he tries to scramble up, but a boot on his chest pins him down.

He looks up.

“Jason— “ he tries, but Jason is scowling down at him, angry. Once again he is holding Robin’s staff, this time with one hand, like a baseball bat.

“Let me show you what the Joker did to me. Let’s find out how tough you *really* are.”

The forehand strike hurts in more than one way, even if Robin doesn’t exactly have any sensors that register pain; the comment makes him imagine what Jason’s last moments in Ethiopia must’ve been like and that pains him more than any damage ever could. But after the first hit, there’s, surprisingly, a pause. He opens his eyes, looks up again, and Jason’s face is even more contorted than a second before — but this time it’s not anger, it’s *disgust*.

“So *that’s* how B got himself a new little soldier, huh?” Red Hood hisses, poking at Robin’s cheek with one end of the bo. There’s a faint sound of metal scraping against metal and Robin realises his skin coating gave in — probably pierced by a loose part, or burst from the impact of the last blow. “I was wondering why there’s *no* info on you anywhere, like you *don’t exist*. Now I *know*. At least nobody let him train *another* teenager to fight his pointless war after he got *me* killed.”

Jason looks around, at the statues of the fallen Titans around them. The disgust in his eyes transforms back into anger. “But I guess that’s all I’m remembered as, a warning, if anything at all,” Hood growls, stepping away from Robin and turning back to one of the stone sculptures. “Look at this. You got everyone, Aquagirl, Hawk, Dove, *for God’s sake*, even Kole. But where’s mine? Don’t *I* get a memorial? I was a Titan *too!*”

Hood lunges forward and strikes the nearest statue with a wide, powerful swing of the staff. He smashes through one of the knees of Donna’s effigy, sending the entire thing toppling down and crashing against the floor. Robin uses this brief breather to stand up, leaning on another pedestal, and create some space between him and his predecessor.

“Jaybird, please-” he begins, yet those words only tick Jason off, anger him more.

“You don’t get to call me that,” Hood interrupts him, whips around, and brings the staff up, readying another strike.

But Robin has had a chance, a tiny moment of respite to plan. It’s obvious that as long as Jason is raging, he won’t listen to reason. Robin has to at the very least disarm him — punches will damage his own systems way less than the metal of his bo — and then devise some way to restrain him, make him listen, *make him see reason*.

He runs up along the wall, flips back, and uses the combined momentum to leap towards Jason. His feet hit the staff, pushing it down with enough force to cause Hood to let go of it. It makes a loud clang as it hits the floor, and Robin lands right next to it, crouching along with the leftover impact and swaying to the right immediately.

You see, Jason always had a slightly off reaction in his right side — humans have a dominant hand, yes, but they also generally tend to have a dominant eye and leg, too; surprisingly, despite being right-handed, Jason’s right leg was always a little slower, possibly due to some childhood injury.

Robin’s plan is thus simple: swing at the knee from the right, strike the feet out from under Jason, and when he’s falling grab the left wrist, slither under his arm until he’s behind Jason and get him into a lock, pressed against the floor.

Easy.

He’d done it multiple times himself (though with other people), seen Jason get pinned like that by Bruce on countless occasions during their spars.

But Hood isn’t having any of that.

Whatever he's been up to since Ethiopia, it apparently trained the right-leg weakness out of him. When Robin sweeps with his leg — leaving him to balance on one foot for a split second — Jason takes advantage of this moment of instability; he grabs onto the fabric of Robin's cape and collar, vaults over him and uses the built-up energy to throw him down on the floor like a doll. Robin's chest hits the ground with a loud, dull *thump* and his face follows suit, raising a cloud of dust into the air.

Hood kicks him over onto his back, then puts a foot on his chest the same way as before, holding him down. Probably due to impact, there's something wrong with Robin's shoulder blades — or maybe collarbone? he's not sure, the structural integrity error logs are all over the place — and he doesn't manage to roll away in time to avoid getting pinned.

(It might be also because all his systems are tingly with static and just won't respond properly. He has a vague impression that he knows this feeling, but without access to his full memory database, he can't quite pin it down.)

"I was a failure, and I still beat you. You're quite possibly *built* for this, but I still beat you." His voice is dripping with disappointment and contempt.

Robin doesn't comment on the fact that only *one* party is actively trying to fight here. No matter how ruthless and efficient he is usually, he can't, he simply can't bring himself to go against his best friend. Even if it causes him to get damaged, he's not going to hurt Jason. Not now, not ever.

Red Hood picks up the staff off the floor, weighs it in his hand, smirks. Robin knows what's coming — there's so much fury in that face that it can only mean one thing — and closes his eyes, resigned.

Jason holds the weapon like a bat once more, swings back, and hits the already damaged spot on Robin's head again.

And again.

And again.

Robin's systems report a critical failure within the first two minutes, then shut down completely at 09:45 PM PST.

Chapter End Notes

Refs and memes in this chapter:

[Symbolism of mockingbirds/"To Kill a Mockingbird"](#)

[Rara avis](#)

[MO \(Modus operandi\)](#)

[nom de guerre](#)

The scene in the Tower is based on canon of the same situation, as depicted in Titans (2003) Issue #29

P.S. I ignored how timezones work for this chapter just bear with me

Chapter 8

Chapter Summary

Tim Needs A Break.

Chapter Notes

Trigger warnings for this chapter: Temporary Robot Character Death (detailed scene), interaction that can be interpreted as gaslighting, Canon-typical Violence, non-consensual sedation / non-consensual drug use / loss of control (mentioned/introduced)

Timezone denial continues. Uno reverse card is used.

See the end of the chapter for [more notes](#)

In Gotham, Tim and Bruce are busy looking at the new crime lord-wannabe a little closer; he's too persistent, too bold, almost too good at what he's doing. While Tim doesn't share Bruce's opinion about his inhumanly excellent detective skills (he's good, best even, but far from *unmatched*), he agrees with B that it's suspicious that Hood always seems one step ahead. As if he knew more about Batman's strategies and tools than he should've. Than anyone should've.

It's probably this scrutiny that causes Hood to make the next delivery. (At least they assume it's Hood, and the way this lines up just convinces them more that they're right)

The parcel comes in the early morning, with the usual mail. It's the same packaging, plain brown paper and no fingerprints on anything at all. Inside is a rose, fresh and well-preserved, but most importantly: with the thorns covered in dried blood.

Tim runs the analysis without B even having to ask for it.

When he displays the results, nobody likes what they're seeing. Alfred drops the tray with morning tea, smashing the china teacups to pieces. He doesn't even try to clean it up; instead stares at the terminal screen, but does not comment, only gasps quietly.

"Run it again," Bruce orders.

"I'm not wrong," Tim retorts, yet runs the analysis again, on a different sample just to be sure. The result comes back the same: a match to one of the records in their database. To one specific record.

To Jason Peter Todd.

"It can't be correct, Tim. We both saw the-"

"I know what we saw back then, Bruce, but facts don't lie! Who knows about Jason more than himself? All the clues match, everything checks out!"

"Except the part where he's dead."

The argument isn't getting them anywhere. Robin stomps his feet in annoyance to emphasize his anger.

"I'm not wrong, B. You'll see," he says, ignoring how tired and sad and exasperated Bruce looks, then plants his body in the armchair near the costume cases in an act of protest. He usually does that when he wants to display that he's upset and fussy, and doesn't want to talk, so Bruce sighs and turns to his breakfast. By the way his fingers tremble, Tim judges Alfred agrees with him, but the butler doesn't say anything, loyal to a fault.

Therefore, Tim decides to call Dick. While he doesn't have an actual phone of his own, he does possess a number on the network that he uses to contact others. It's just built into his mainframe instead of being in a phone. The bonus of it being that way is he doesn't have to physically speak to call someone. He can continue giving Bruce the silent treatment and complain to Dick at the same time. Dick will understand how backwards Bruce is being. Because Dick will believe him, right?

Big brother picks up after just two rings even though he's probably been still sleeping. He sounds happy to hear Tim, although there's a distinct note of worry in his voice. He's been a bit shaken by the whole affair, too, and Tim assumes he won't like the newest development either.

"Hey, Timmy! What's up?"

"Do you have time? I'm going to need your help tracking someone. B is being an ass."

"What'cha got?"

"I know who the Red Hood is."

Tim can hear the slight excitement in Dick's voice. It's his family, his father that's being targeted, the memory of his brother that is used to torment them. He's eager to take out the looming threat from over their heads.

"Mmmhm, and B disagrees, huh?"

Tim makes an affirmative noise in Dick's phone.

"Okay, I'm all ears. Who's Red Hood?"

Tim's attention is dragged away for a moment with a ping from his California location.

“Wait a sec, the storm over San Fran finally died down and I can get a stable connection, lemme start the sync of-... ..”

“Tim?”

“Can you get to the Manor ASAP?”

“Tim, what’s happening?”

“I’m getting a black box archive upload from the Tower.”

There’s silence on Dick’s end, then a short “Alright” before he disconnects and Tim knows he’s *en route*, and he knows he’s on a warpath. Nightwing, much like Batman, does not take lightly to anyone hurting Robin, even if Tim reminds them time and time again that nobody can really hurt him.

When Dick’s motorcycle roars in the garage and he enters the Cave — in a hurry, skipping three steps at a time — Tim’s already full-on arguing with Bruce, yelling and all. He can’t help it, he can’t handle how stubborn Bruce is. Again.

He turns all of his cameras towards Dick, while still keeping Robin’s argumentative finger pointed at Bruce to keep him in his seat.

“It’s Jason,” he says, and it’s immediately obvious that Dick’s confused about what’s happening, so before Dick can ask *“it’s Jason **what?**”* Tim continues. “Jason is Red Hood. Jason is sending us the mystery packages and Jason was in the Tower last night.”

Dick is silent for a while, and Bruce stares at him with a calculating, frowning gaze.

“Jason? Our brother?” he asks finally, as if unsure what to say, perhaps crumbling under B’s silent *don’t you dare encourage him* stare.

“Yeah.”

“Tim, you-”

“I know Jason died,” Tim immediately interrupts. “B keeps saying the same thing. But you know I’m never wrong, Dick. And I have proof, too.”

“Proof?”

“We got another weird package this morning, and it had a sample of Jason’s blood in it. I checked the Tower’s security systems — speaking of which don’t worry, everybody else is fine, they were just knocked out — the systems don’t log who they matched with, but they did grant Hood access without issue, and you know they’re set up with DNA recognition. Well, except for me. Anyway, he used to be a Titan, briefly, right? He’s still in the system. He just... walked in. That, and how Hood knows just a bit too much, and my memories from the black box. It all lines up.”

“And how is that proof?”

“What do you mean, how?!”

“Even if the Tower really let Hood in based on Jason’s DNA match, it didn’t have to be his DNA. It could just be someone with a piece of Jason’s DNA. Same for the package. Or it’s a clone. We already have a precedent, don’t we?”

“And my memories?”

“Maybe your data got corrupted. How sure are you that the black box wasn’t tampered with after you blacked out? Besides, why would Jason attack you?”

Tim crosses his arms on his chest. “You don’t believe me either.”

“Tim, we all miss him, but you can’t-”

“You don’t believe me.”

“I think we can’t jump to conclusions this early. We’re detectives, aren’t we? What if someone is simply trying to get under our skin?”

He ponders for a moment. Dick is... right that he got immediately distracted when he came to this conclusion yesterday, and it would be fatal for anyone but him. There’s a grain of truth in the fact that it might all be planned to pull on their strings with the memory of Jason.

“Okay,” he says in a defeated tone and makes a point of looking between Dick and Bruce. “I’ll drop it. For now.”

Tim isn’t planning on dropping it. Instead, he’s going to research it on the side and come back with undeniable evidence. You know, like a detective. It’s fine if they don’t believe him; he’s no stranger to working *around* Batman’s rules.

“I’m glad you understand, Timmy.”

Bruce exhales in annoyed relief. “I need a breather,” he says. Tim can understand that. Bruce is stubborn, and Tim is a relentless disputant, so whenever they disagree, B ends up exhausted. “Since you’re already here, Dick, would you like to have tea with me?”

There’s a moment of hesitation before Dick agrees, but they exit the Cave accompanied by casual chit-chat. Tim keeps a watchful eye on them through the cameras, a little suspicious.

They indeed get Alfred to make them tea, and sit down to drink it, only they do it on the outside patio; it’s one of the few places in the Manor where Tim doesn’t have quality mics installed, and where they can sit under a sun umbrella obscuring them from Tim’s cameras. The only logical conclusion to draw from this behaviour is that they’re trying to talk about something without Tim knowing. Which, in this situation, can only mean they want to exclude him from whatever steps they’re going to take about Jason.

Honestly, it’s a little reassuring that the self-appointed Best Detective isn’t ignoring something this obvious. There’s zero percent chance this amount of detail lining up is a coincidence. And while it could be some third-party trying to rile Batman up, using his own

death to hit where it hurts most is *exactly* the kind of extra dramatic Jason would be if he had beef with the Bats. Which he clearly has now, for some reason.

But, okay. Wonderful. They want Tim to drop it, and plan to handle it on their own. Splendid. If that's the game they wanna play, great. They'd be substantially more effective together, but sure. Tim loves some competition. If they want to keep him out of the loop, he will have to do it on his own. Since Bruce and Dick don't trust him with their investigation (because what? They think he'll be biased? Really?), then there's a good chance nobody else will take him seriously either.

It's all fine and dandy. He's gone "*rogue*" before.

Just previous times, he wasn't also going *solo*.

The issue with going solo, though, is there's no backup to catch you when you fall.

The next time they meet Tim doesn't even see Jason, but he damn well knows it's him.

He's collected data and leads for days, and tracked everything out of Bruce's and Dick's sight as much as possible. Sometimes it's very difficult to find anything, sometimes it looks like Red Hood is deliberately leaving them clues. It cements Tim's conviction that it must be Jason and that he knows that Tim knows. Probably assumes Bruce knows, too, but Bruce doesn't believe; he acts as if Red Hood is a run-of-the-mill criminal, a gangster, a villain to catch and jail. A formidable foe, since he managed to get into Titan's Tower, and one that has — for some reason — a grudge against the Batman (which criminal doesn't, though?), or at least decided to strike him where it'll hurt by targeting Robin; but he vehemently refuses to see him as someone that should have personal significance.

Bruce seems to misinterpret all of Hood's dramatic set-ups, and it probably drives the little thespian crazy. He's always been like that.

It's convenient for Tim, though, because that leaves him free to do whatever he pleases about Jaybird's attempts to lure them out.

He doesn't expect it to backfire so hard.

He probably should have. He really should have a contingency plan in place. But he is so excited about the prospect of Jason being alive again, of Jason returning... He just throws himself into the case, adamant that he can force Jaybird to talk it out this time. That he can make it right.

It is apt, perhaps, that he loses his head, quite literally, for going head-first into the fray.

He's loitering around what he's determined to be the outskirts of Hood's territory — far enough to not tip B off, but close enough to probably irk Jay anyway — and setting up transmitters. Over the past weeks, Jason's proved that he is quite proficient in and greatly enjoys hijacking Batman's tech. Because of that, Tim has been planning to pull a Uno reverse

card on him. If Hood's using their equipment and listening in to their frequencies, he can leave messages for him to try to communicate with him. And possibly track him by triangulating where and when the hardware is accessed.

The messages Tim leaves are simple and most importantly — because he isn't dumb — include nothing that could jeopardize Bruce's secret identity in any way. They're something that should hold meaning for Jason, but lack context for anybody else. That includes things like "Please come home", "A misses you" (Tim briefly considered the more general "*we miss you*" but decided that it's way easier to believe specifically in Alfred's unconditional love than in B's, and with how... things progressed so far he isn't sure if his own friendship holds any value for Jay anymore) or "Let's talk". He hopes that at some point, Jaybird will take them to heart, or at the very least becomes annoyed enough to confront someone about them. Either way, he'll approach them and from there Tim can figure something out.

It works like a charm. Just not quite in the way Tim predicted.

He notices the faraway glint of a sniper rifle only a split second before it's fired.

Robin and Batman both had been on the wrong end of the gun their fair share of times. But between the trained reflexes and kevlar body armor even B, who's a little more vulnerable as a human, isn't scared of being shot at. With Robin's titanium build and barely any weak spots to aim at from this kind of distance, Tim's not worried much about it.

That would be okay if the gun was not as long as he's tall and the sniper wasn't in fact insanely accurate with his shot. Which is apparently the case.

Even though he dodges, the heavy duty, armor-piercing round goes right through Robin's neck like the titanium plating is soft butter; he ponders that there are maybe two people both *bold* and *skilled* enough to snipe him like that, and he doesn't recall pissing off Deathstroke recently.

He also takes note that it's not a pleasant experience to have your line of sight slowly fall lower and lower at an increasingly unnatural angle as your head slides off your body. The feeling is something similar to excitement, which he knows well thanks to his friends, but with a negative tone indicator. Tim identifies that as anxiety, possibly even dread.

Robin manages to sync all currently open processes and start the memory protection procedure — essentially closing all files, moving the important ones into the black box and frying the rest of his local hard drives — before his main systems start failing and turning off, one by one, as two more bullets pierce his body in vital spots. It's basically mashing a self-destruct button, but it has to be done. Jason or not, the data in him is *heavily* compromising in the wrong hands, and he'd personally unalive himself if it got out due to his slip up.

He's not worried about Robin going down, though. There's a backup in the Cave (albeit a bit outdated), he has spare parts and enough time; he'll recover the body before B finds out and he can pretend like nothing ever happened. He's even already working out how to continue, coming up with a plan that's less likely to aggravate the damn drama queen that Jay is.

He switches to local CCTV cameras now that his sight is gone, wanting to keep an eye on the area while he figures out how to best retrieve Robin. Thanks to that, he notices Red Hood moving towards Robin's position, which is a little peculiar. Hood knows Robin's a robot, there's no need to check if he's alive. The message sent was also loud and clear, too. What possibly could he want?

A minute later those questions are answered, as Robin's beacon signal dies, wiping his location off Tim's maps. Sadly, it's a damn *rooftop* and nobody aims security cameras *there*, not even in Gotham, so Tim has no idea what's happening. He's calm though. He sends a drone there to gain a visual, as he assumes sooner or later Hood will have to *leave* that roof, whatever he's doing there, and then Tim will be able to track him.

Once the drone gets there, it finds nothing except for a couple of small holes in the concrete where the bullets ended their course. Not only Hood's not there, but there's no trace that anything ever happened. All equipment Robin had with him, all parts and pieces of Robin, even the bullets themselves — gone. Jay must've managed to slip through his blindspots (there are some, more than Tim would like, but he has to work with what's available; he can't just go and cover the city with cameras as he pleases, it'd draw too much attention), and took Robin with him.

Tim's no longer calm. He starts to have some regrets about going solo.

He briefly considers *not* telling Bruce. Then he calculates that between B's controlling obsessions and impeccable detective skills... Bruce's going to figure it out sooner or later, and it's going to be waaaay worse if Tim has to explain not only what happened, but also why he was hiding it.

And so, he chirps up from the speakers when Bruce is about halfway through his morning eggs and toast.

"I have a problem with Robin," Tim says tentatively and it is a testament to how utterly not-yet-awake B is that he doesn't pick up the tone right away, because Alfred *does*. The butler raises an eyebrow but says nothing, instead retreating to the kitchen as if he was trying to vacate the premises of an incoming tornado.

Which, *fair*.

"Do you need Barbara to look at it?" B asks, not even looking up from his newspaper.

"No, I don't mean like a *malfunction*. I mean... I got shot. "

Only *that* makes Bruce pause, tightening his grip on the silverware ever-so-slightly, while Tim's kind of betting with himself what the next question will be. It depends on whenever B gets more angry at Tim for Robin being out alone and without permission, or at whoever dared to shoot at him.

Bruce surprises him, for once. The man stands up, briskly, and heads straight to the Cave. “How bad is it? Can you get back safely?”

Tim stays silent for a moment as his mentor makes it downstairs. “Let me specify, B. I got *sniped*.” He knows Batman will understand that as what it means; that Bruce knows what kind of damage a sniper round can do.

So, obviously, that finally makes Bruce react like Tim expected him to in the first place. “What happened?” he says stiffly, already sitting at the BatComputer console, frowning angrily as he stares at the screen.

“Shooter was uncannily accurate, and with how far they were, I couldn’t calculate my dodge properly.”

“Where is Robin?”

“It’s okay, I got everything shut down, just-”

“Where is Robin?”

Tim obediently brings up a map on the screen and puts a bright tracking dot on it. “That’s the last known location, but then I lost the beacon signal. I checked, the body isn’t there anymore.”

That finally seems to be enough clues for Bruce, because the next word comes out of his mouth like a swear.

“Hood.” He looks up at Tim’s overhead camera. “How could you be so reckless? Why were you even out there alone?”

Ah, there it is, Tim thinks to himself. The usual — accusations and guilting. One would think B learned after all these years.

“I was setting up radio messages for Jason.” He desperately wants to roll his eyes. He’s only halfway through booting up backup Robin, though.

“Didn’t we agree to drop the topic? Red Hood isn’t-”

“Bruce, please. I’m a supercomputer, do you really think you can fool me? You’ve been trying to track him down with Dick all this time behind my back, way more eagerly than you would’ve any rogue. Why would you do that if you didn’t think there was some merit to my theory?”

“Precisely because I knew you’d try pulling off a stunt like this.”

“Well, maybe you should’ve supported me instead of making me do things on my own! Now we’ve lost an entire Robin out there. Thankfully, I managed to seal off the archives in time and he shouldn’t be able to recover any compromising data.”

“I don’t *care* about the data, Tim!”

Tim displays a big question mark on the screen.

“You keep getting hurt!”

“I’d like to remind you that I don’t have any kind of sensor that could register pain,” Tim says, then Robin walks up to Bruce — slowly, a little wobbly, because this model was in renovation and some screws are loose, but it’s the only thing he has on hand — and continues the sentence. “And destroying one of my terminals doesn’t affect any of my processes other than impairing my ability to perceive and communicate at that specific location. It is not a person. *It is a piece of equipment.* What I’m saying is, *I cannot get hurt as Robin.* Literally the entire point of me being Robin, wasn’t it?”

There’s heavy silence following those words. Slowly, B’s frown fades and he sighs.

“It’s... a human thing,” Bruce finally admits. “I know you don’t think of it as getting hurt, but I— and I guarantee you, Hood too — we see that as harm.”

Tim can’t argue with that; he’s learned a lot about humans and being a person over the years, but there are still things he just... cannot even perceive, let alone understand. So he has to agree with Bruce’s judgement on this one.

“I think the intention with all this was more to harm *you* than *me*,” Tim mentions as Robin shrugs, then the gravity of those words dawns on him. “...it’s not very nice of me to keep hurting your feelings like that, regardless of what I think about Robin getting damaged, huh?”

B sighs again. “...if that will make you stop running yourself straight into danger, then please think of it like that, yes.”

Robin sits down on the console, only feeling *a little* guilty about what he’s done so far.

“Okay,” he says solemnly, and they stay silent for a moment. Tim knows humans need time to process these kinds of heated exchanges, so time he gives. When B finally stops looking as troubled, Tim picks the topic up again, exactly where they left it before they started arguing. “How are we going to recover my other body if we don’t have any leads?”

“I think we will, soon enough. He wouldn’t have taken Robin if he didn’t have something planned.”

Robin nods. Batman isn’t infallible, but he’s rarely wrong about these things, and his line of reasoning does make sense.

Neither of them likes the fact that the ball is in Jason’s court again, though.

Tim picks up his beacon signal two days later, late at night, just when Batman returns from a patrol. Robin’s been benched of course, because the one they have left isn’t up-to-date with their fighting standards these days. Therefore, B’s a little worse for the wear that night, but still tries to argue that he’s going to go find the source of the signal alone. Luckily, Tim

manages to convince him that Robin's presence in the field is needed to properly follow the signal through Gotham's skyscraper maze.

It takes them maybe an hour to get back out into Gotham and navigate towards the point where the signal comes from. It moves a couple times, as if playing with them, but never fades or really *runs*, so they have no issues following. Even if they're pretty sure they're being led into a trap.

Finally, Batman flings onto the next roof — an old building, probably abandoned or inhabited only by squatters — and stops, looks around cautiously. He doesn't have to check with Tim, they both know: it is the right spot. Tim doesn't have to ask to see that Batman expects a surprise attack; it's written all over his posture and movements. That's why Tim lands on a fire escape nearby, as silently as he can, and climbs up, keeping to the edge and the shadows instead of following the man directly. That way, he's less likely to get shot.

As predicted, Red Ho- Jason walks from behind the big cluster of piping on the other side. Tim dares to peek over the ledge to see what's happening and makes notice of the array of guns holstered to Jason's thighs and the body armour over his body, as well as the duffel bag thrown over his shoulder. He's sure Batman also sees it all, and analyzes the threats and possible strategies already. But neither of them make any move. Yet.

"I was wondering how many Robins I'd need to take down to lure you out," Jason says, cocking his hip in an attempt to provoke a reaction. The voice is slightly distorted by his helmet; he must be using some kind of voice mod to change it, and Tim realises it sounds kinda like Tim sounded back then.

Batman stays still despite the sarcasm-dripping insult.

"You know, I was gonna play with you a lot more first," Jason continues when he gets no response. "Do my thing, carry out my plan, maybe lead you on a wild goose chase for a while, then hunt your new child soldier down as the grand finale. But the fact that there was no info on the kid anywhere got me real curious." He's gesturing dramatically, and Tim can't decide if it's to seem more relaxed and in control, or for the flair. "I wasn't expecting that you would go that far, though."

Even if Gotham's air wasn't already heavy with pollution, the tension in it at that moment makes it almost tangible, but Batman doesn't answer. Jason hisses in annoyance and throws the bag on his shoulder towards them. It is unzipped, Tim notices, and in the motion, it opens up almost completely. Out of it, rolls out what Tim immediately recognizes as the source of the signal they've been following — Robin's severed head.

"You really oughta up your game, old man. It's way too easy to break your toys."

Tim doesn't flinch, and neither does Batman. But he knows what Batman does to people who call Robin a toy, to people who break Robin. The sensors in B's suit confirm that knowledge — they pick up how his heartbeat flutters faster for a moment. It must not be a pleasant sight, the head of your son on the floor, even if he knows it is just a heap of electronics now.

“What, that doesn’t affect you, either? Figures,” Jason snaps, and then with one swift move takes off his red helmet and throws it under Batman’s feet. Underneath, his face, as before, is still obscured by a domino mask. “You’ve never cared for us anyway, did you.”

By his posture, Tim judges that any doubts B had about Jason’s identity are gone when he looks him in the eyes. Batman’s shoulders twitch ever-so-slightly when the realisation hits; a negligible reaction for anyone else, but for him, an astonishingly big slip up. His beloved son is somehow alive (still? again?), and hates him, hates them all. Tim isn’t surprised even the Batman shows some emotion when faced with that.

“Jaylad— “ Batman finally speaks up, and Tim already knows what’s going to follow. He remembers how Jason reacted to Tim addressing him in a tender way before; he fully expects Bruce’s most affectionate nickname for Jason to also set him off into a fit of rage.

Tim, once again, isn’t wrong.

“Was that all we were to you?!” Jay screams, making a step towards Batman, who stiffens defensively in turn, preparing for an attack. “Truly only soldiers fighting at your side, no soul, no heart?! Tools like these dolls?!” Jason continues yelling, harsh and angry. To him, it must look like that. Like Bruce replaced him. Replaced with a robot of his own design, made to be obedient and smart and perfect — everything that he thinks Bruce wants, everything that he thinks he wasn’t. A robot looking almost just like Jason, no less.

Tim can understand his sorrow and anger. Can understand how Jason must feel — betrayed, abandoned, hurt.

Because right then, he feels the same.

Once again, if Tim could cry, if his eyes could make tears, he would. Instead, he just stares at Jason, his best friend, the person who made him feel like he belonged, like he was alive. Someone who made him believe he might be more than a snarky security system; not only a computer personality, but an actual part of the family. Someone who now says he has “no soul, no heart”. He stares, his faintly glowing, glass eyes fixated on the towering posture overflowing with rage, and for the second time in his existence he feels heartbroken. Feels the pain of losing a friend.

He decides he has to try to explain, once more. Despite knowing Jason might never again think of him as a friend, despite Jason hurting him now so badly... the last thing he wants is for Jason to feel like he does now.

“I— I just... I thought I could...” Tim begins speaking slowly, with great effort, pulling himself up over the edge a little more. Jason’s head snaps to him, eyes full of murderous intent. *“I wanted to— to help B and— make the memory of you live on... like a book... like immortalising a hero. Continue your story.”* He wants to believe that what makes his voice break this much is just his old, backup voice synth being harder to use and a little rusty.

Something seems to... click in Jason’s mind, apparently; his face softens, ever so slightly, as if he recalled a fond memory. As if he maybe finally understood...? But then it hardens right back, into an even deeper frown.

"God, now you even gave it Tim's voice," he nearly spits the words out. It dawns on Tim that Jason probably never recognised him in the Tower. His new, updated voice is so different from how Jason remembers Tim sounds; he's learned, changed so much that his friend didn't recognise him. "What, didn't have enough recordings of mine? Is there nothing sacred to you?"

Tim shakes his head, tries to clarify further. But before he can say anything more, Bruce speaks up at last.

"He doesn't **have Tim's voice**. He **is** Tim."

Jason takes a step back, startled and jerky as if he was struck by lightning. He stares at Tim for a while, thinking, all of them in complete silence except for the rain and thunder ambience.

"No," he says finally, and there's suddenly a slight stutter to his words, a slight tremble in his voice. "Tim's not— he wouldn't— That's **not** Tim."

Tim pulls himself over the edge of the roof and makes one hesitant step towards Jason. The body he's using is old and hadn't gotten its drivers updated, making Tim's steps a little more wobbly than he'd like them to be, so he keeps his distance, just in case. Yet even from there, he can hear Jason's breathing speed up as once again he tries to deny Bruce's words.

"You're just trying to mess with me," Jason accuses.

"I'm Timothy Jackson Drake," Tim states, making an effort to speak without odd pauses and breaks this time. *"The name did come in handy, just like you said it would."*

Jason looks at Batman, suddenly defensive. "I don't know what kind of game you're playing, but I'm not going to fall for it," he growls, reaching towards his knife, surprisingly. Batman adjusts his stance accordingly, readying himself for a fight. Before he can get damaged again, Tim ducks down and behind Batman, linking up to the cowl's cameras to keep himself updated.

They clash within the next two seconds and while Tim doesn't know much about dance and artistry, he knows a lot about grace and efficiency of movement. And they? They are... well, not flawless, but Tim muses they're pretty much as close to that as a human can get.

He's kind of jealous how much better Jason is at fighting than him now. Sure, Tim's not a wuss either, and few can match his strategic sense and calculated precision. Especially so when he is online with the mainframe and has all the resources available. But... there's just something special about what humans do with their bodies, something about thought-less yet mind-full control that Dick has mastered as an acrobat. Something that Bruce — and now Jay too — has turned into a deadly weapon.

Something Tim thinks he'll never achieve.

And so, he looks with both fascination and dread as his dad and mentor fights his idol and best friend. Both Jason and Bruce have a lot of gadgets on hand, and pull weapons out of

improbable places, but Jason seems to prefer a more up-and-close approach; he's favoring his knife, too, even though he clearly is an expert marksman.

Jason is vicious while Bruce is controlled, but both are led by trained, refined instinct. Every mistake is exploited and every advantage used. Jason fights dirty, and gets a few strikes into B's chest, even manages to drag his knife — briefly, very shallowly — against B's cheek. His punches and kicks are powerful, and it catches Bruce slightly off-guard. Tim can understand that — Jason could keep up with Robin's hydraulics, didn't even notice he's fighting someone made of metal until the fake skin came off. His strength seems inhuman now.

But Batman is no stranger to fighting people with superpowers. He alters his style ever-so-slightly, dodges more, blocks less. Succeeds to get a direct hit on Jason's now-exposed face, which causes his opponent to stumble back and disengage for a moment, to regain composure.

With that, Bruce picks up their conversation.

"What happened to you?" Bruce asks, but his tone is... harder now.

"Oh, you don't even know? Typical," Jason says, something between a grin and a scowl crossing his face. "Here's a brief summary: Al Ghuls happened, and their little fountain of youth. Apparently if you throw a zombie in there, he can come out just like new."

There's only the slightest pause of hesitation from B. "I can help you."

"What makes you think I need help, Bruce? You think a dip in Ra's green jacuzzi turned me rabid? That makes it easier to fight me, doesn't it? What if this is just the real me?"

Jason grins, lunges back at Bruce and within a few moments of wrestling and struggle, manages to get B into a hold.

"Tell me, what annoys you more," he asks with cruel satisfaction in his voice, leaning over to talk directly into Batman's ear, "— that your greatest failure came back from the grave to haunt you, or that I'm a better Batman than you can ever dream to be?"

Tim takes note that Jason changes the topic, circles back to insults and threats, goes from personal to business as if the first didn't go over like he wanted.

"You rule with intimidation and murder. That's no better than the criminals."

It is true, in a way. Many mobsters have been turning up dead in Red Hood's territory. It's one of the reasons why Batman is so adamant on stopping him.

"Did my death teach you nothing, old man?!" Jason yells into B's ear in response. His voice is hoarse and Tim concludes that it's maybe, just maybe, breaking a little bit, too.

Batman uses the slight distraction to wriggle out of Jason's hold, throw him over, but it doesn't do much. Jason vaults and is right back on his feet. "You can't win this war, not with

your antiquated sense of morality. Your mission is endless. You make them fear Batman, but what do you do with the scum that isn't afraid, huh?"

He gestures widely across the city. "I just do what you can't. I am what the city needs! I take out the trash!" He kicks his helmet towards Bruce. "Something that maybe if you did, I wouldn't have died."

As Jason says that, Tim pipes up in B's comms. "*Dodge!*"

Tim's calculations are once again correct. The helmet explodes with a deafening boom and covers the roof in smoke for a moment. Jason seems a little disappointed that B manages to roll away from the danger unscathed.

Instead of attacking again though, Jason uses the smoke and distraction to escape off the other end of the roof. It is... a weird decision. There's something off about how Jason acts. It's... frantic and you could, reasonably, explain that with anger, but... it's also deliberate. Both calculated and chaotic. It's inconsistent, that's what it is, and Tim doesn't like that.

"Do you have his heat signature?" Batman asks a second later, when he notices Jason's gone, apparently fully intending to pursue him. Tim knows where else he saw a behaviour pattern like Jay's, and thus — unlike Bruce — realizes the solution to this problem definitely isn't *a hunt*.

So he stands back up straight and without a hint of hesitation, *lies*: "No."

Once they're back in the Cave, safe and sound except for the anger, the concentrated frustration dripping off Bruce, Tim starts to think.

Bruce, too, seems to be planning, but takes one look at Alfred and knows he has to explain first before he can deep-dive into his machinations.

"It's Jason," he admits. "It's Jason and he's somehow alive. And with his training? I need to be better prepared." Bruce looks over the tears Jason's knife left in his suit, and starts taking it off for repairs. "I'll need to have you in top fighting condition, too," he says over his shoulder to Tim, and he just makes an affirmative noise.

"Sir, is that really... necessary? He's *your son*," Alfred says, his expression sad and sour and all kinds of everything Tim never wants to see on his face. But he shares the sentiment it carries. Which means that maybe Tim doesn't *have to* go solo...

"Yes, he is," Bruce admits, but his tone is hard. Cold. Not fatherly at all. "But he's... He's... different. He's changed."

"With all due respect, sir, why on Earth would you expect a traumatized child that came back to life to be the same?" Alfred says in his signature stern-half-snarking tone, and Bruce squares his shoulders defensively at that. "You know he's prone to anger and idolizing you."

You've been his whole world. And you let him down. **We** let him down. I imagine that can break a child's mind."

Bruce doesn't answer, so Alfred picks up again after a brief silence. "He needs Bruce Wayne to **save** him, not Batman to **hunt** him." That cements Tim's belief that Alfred will side with him. Now to just develop a plan...

"Maybe," B remarks quietly. "But he's killing people, Alfred. And Batman needs to stop him."

Alfred dares not to oppose further, not when Bruce uses the *Batman* voice. He just nods and without a word more takes the empty teacups away.

"Alfie?" Tim pipes up in the kitchen radio as the butler reaches the room.

"Yes, Master Timothy?" Alfred acknowledges him, but doesn't look at the camera. Just sets the tray down and starts washing the porcelain, slowly, delicately, even more so than usually.

"Do you really believe what you said to Bruce just now?"

"I am not known to throw my words around, now am I, young sir?"

He ponders for a moment, trying to word it right, running simulations of this exchange briefly.

"Do you trust me?"

"Oh, isn't that the phrase one wants to hear the most from a young vigilante." The elder sighs, finally stopping what he's doing and looking up. "What are you planning, Master Timothy?"

"I want to change Bruce's mind." It is a simple but fundamental part of the new, revised plan; his failures so far can be attributed to having to go not only against Jason's misguided anger, but also against Bruce's stubbornness, and as such having his resources divided. If he manages to get B to cooperate, or at the very least doesn't have to hide from him anymore, the chances to get Jaybird back will skyrocket.

"A valiant effort, but I'm afraid Master Bruce is not going to listen to reason once he's set his mind on something."

"I have an idea. You know my ideas are good."

The butler pauses briefly, his lips a thin line of apprehension.

"Is it likely to damage the building?" Alfred asks finally, only half jokingly. It's a valid concern, honestly.

"No," Tim says. He doesn't say what it *is* likely to damage instead.

"You're free to try then. Just give me a notice in advance."

He displays a smiley on the fridge's screen.

"And when I do, can you not go downstairs for a while?"

Alfred raises an eyebrow, but nods, returning to washing the dishes.

It's a week later when Tim gives Alf the heads-up. Alfred goes upstairs as always after delivering pre-patrol tea. But unlike most days — as promised — he stays there instead of coming back to clean up the Cave while they're out on patrol.

Downstairs, Tim works diligently on the reports for Bruce, who's getting ready for the night. He's got a pretty bad bruise on the ribs from yesterday, so it takes him a while longer to get dressed. Robin just finished changing into his suit, too — usually, when not out, he wears pyjamas; it's less weird to wander the Manor and talk with Alfred like that — and is hanging out around the lockers, preparing his utility belt. He takes a moment to inspect the batarangs, as he sometimes does, before plopping down on his favourite chair next to the display cases all ready to go.

Nothing could tip off B's Batman instincts. Tim makes sure it's all just like always.

Until it isn't.

The dart that he fires towards Bruce is quick and silent and he has *no* chance to dodge it. It lodges itself precisely where it's supposed to, into the back of B's neck; right above the hem of the thermal shirt he intended to put the suit over in a moment. Of course, it stays there for maybe a second before the man rips it out and scans his surroundings for the source of danger.

Robin looks at him with a blank expression and doesn't react when B lunges towards the equipment lockers. The man rushes to where he put away his utility belt, hoping to pull the vial with the antidote out of it. He punches the code in, but the locker remains closed.

Robin just grins.

Then, of course, Bruce sways to the side as the paralysis starts to set in. Squints at Robin, then takes a glance at Tim's screens, where by now the processing of case notes has halted. Sits down on his chair, struggling to remain standing, and tries his comms instead.

"Alfred, Tim's compromised—"

"No, I'm not," Tim interrupts, displaying the full monitoring of the network and internal systems — green across the board, everything running smoothly — on the biggest screen, "and Alfred is busy right now."

"Then what—" Bruce says slowly, the tranquilizer making its course through his veins. "What are you doing?"

"What does it look like?" Tim is honestly kind of disappointed that B doesn't grasp the situation yet. "I'm enacting the Batman contingency plan."

Chapter End Notes

Some of the dialogue and scenes are based on Batman: Under the Red Hood animated movie, as well as from some panels from Batman: Urban Legends #1

Tim: is a badass

Also Tim: stumbles over his own feet when he sees Jason again

Why is Robin getting destroyed so much in this fic? I told you it's hurt/comfort! But I promise this is the last time (they say, you know, like a *liar*)

Chapter 9

Chapter Summary

Bruce Is Bad At Feelings.

Scrap that, Entire Batfam Is Bad At Feelings.

Chapter Notes

Trigger warnings for this chapter: non-consensual sedation / non-consensual drug use / loss of control (long scene, continued from previous chapter), mention of extensive and repeated physical harm (which can be interpreted as torture), mention of the death penalty

See the end of the chapter for [more notes](#)

Out of all the files in Tim's databases, one of the most secure ones is the Agamemno Contingency Plans catalogue. Bruce periodically updates it, always with a sour expression, and Tim has helped come up with counters for multiple heroes big and small, too. Not that Batman expects anybody to change sides, not really (*hopefully*), but it's just *in case*. So that in the event that something *does* happen, they don't have to scramble and come up with a plan. They'd be prepared already, at least a little bit. With the level of power some people possess, it'd be stupid *not to* have these.

So Tim really doesn't understand why Bruce's *surprised* that one of them gets used.

"Don't worry, the tranquiliser is calculated perfectly for your weight and health status," he reassures Bruce from the speakers, chirpy as always. "You're going to be alright afterwards."

Bruce doesn't seem to be very convinced and, well, Tim can't blame him.

"I'm doing this only because otherwise you'd *never* listen to me," he says to try to ease Bruce's fighting instincts, but B doesn't seem to be listening even now, either. Instead, he starts tapping away on the keyboard. Tim's honestly kind of impressed that he's powering through the sedative with sheer willpower like that for such an extended period of time (not that he didn't expect it, but it's still kind of impressive; especially compared to what the average person can manage).

Then B's expression turns... *ugly*. And that can mean only *one* thing: it finally hit Bruce just how much control Tim has over the BatCave, and how *fucked* he therefore is.

Tim has thought about and prepared for everything. Batman taught him that being prepared is the most important thing, and he taught him well. So well that the student bested his teacher.

Well, almost. Tim's calculated to his best extent how this will go, but the jury's still out. The verdict will be given in just a moment, though.

"And what are you gonna do, Bruce? What's the contingency for *me*?" Tim asks, whipping all cameras to stare at Bruce, who's standing up wobbly, leaning on the terminal. He seems ready to defend himself from any incoming attacks, but Robin does nothing to stop his movements. "It's undisputable there *is* one, even if there's nothing of sorts in my databases. It's probably only in your brain. So, what is it? An off switch that's omitted in the blueprints? Some kind of codeword that's programmed into the very core of me? An EMP installed deep in the mainframe?"

Bruce frowns as Tim lists these options nonchalantly. Tim isn't fazed by his discomfort. It's welcome, honestly. Maybe that'll make him reconsider.

"You never aim to *kill* so it's surely something that's designed to shut me down temporarily, not damage my circuits. But I have to wonder — we've never turned me off before, did we? Ever since I was made? How sure are we that I'll turn back on properly? That I'll turn back on *at all*? And more importantly, are you prepared to deal with the fact that you'll have the metaphorical blood of your own son on your hands if I don't? You're fine. I did nothing, really, nothing you hadn't done to your friends or allies before. Will you risk it just because I dared restrain you? Because I try to speak up against you? Huh, Bruce?"

Bruce doesn't answer, just looks at the screens. *Thinks*.

Tim decides to push further. "Because *I am* fully prepared to put my life — my actual existence, my entire mainframe, not just Robins — on the line."

Bruce sits back down.

"That's what I thought," Tim says, then his tone goes back to his usual chirpy matter-of-factness. "So listen up, B."

Bruce grunts as if he wants to say something, so Tim waits, listening. When no words come, Tim starts his little monologue. He needs for B see reason, even if with Bruce's attitude that means he had to drug him.

Which does make it look kind of like Tim has malicious intentions, just as was Bruce's initial reaction. That's the first thing he needs to explain.

"You have all these contingency plans, but they're held under the most advanced of our security protocols. I doubt the League even knows about them. If it is anyone else that is a threat, you can stop them, but," he pauses briefly, and the screens start displaying pieces of Batman's plans.

The info about the stored piece of Kryptonite for Superman; the blueprints to nanites against Wonder Woman; the modified freeze ray gun, based on Mr Freeze's designs, in case Plastic

Man ever crosses the line; and, of course, the most important, most peculiar one of them all — the Agamemno Contingency codename Detective, the one with hints against Batman himself.

“Tell me, B, who did you expect to carry that one out, really?” Robin stands next to Bruce and points at the screen to drive the point home. “Old Alfie? Dick? Does Dick even *know* about these? He could, reasonably, beat you in a fight, if you didn’t have the equipment advantage. But he doesn’t have the heart to do it; that’s one thing we all inherit from you by exposure, through some sort of osmosis — that family and bonds become our biggest weakness.”

Tim closes all the displayed information while Robin hops to sit on the console and looks at Bruce, meets his eyes. He wants to convey that he isn’t taking pleasure in doing this, and so he needs Bruce to see his face.

“You know, somewhere deep down, that I am your contingency plan. I am the only one that can really counter you,” Robin says, slowly and quietly. “I know all your weak spots, can keep up with your mind, can see if you’re veering off course. You made me for this, didn’t you? And so we’re here.”

“Why?” Bruce manages to say. He looks like he’s struggling to stay awake, but Tim knows that it’s a ploy. He can read his heartbeat through the sensors in the parts of the suit he’s got already on. But the tranq was enough to keep him seated and occupied with trying to think straight and that’s everything Tim planned for it to do; all he needs it to do.

“The same reason as last time, B. Because you’re going blind, you’re straying from your principles, from *justice*.”

Bruce just frowns, most probably in an expression of doubt and confusion. He doesn’t understand, so Tim elaborates.

“You’re intending to hunt Jason down.”

“He’s dangerous-”

“Yes, he is. So are all the people in the Agamemno files.”

“He’s hurt people-”

“Yes, he has. And so long he’s guided by rage, he’s going to continue rampaging. Isn’t the same true for Raven? And yet, we soothe her if she ever loses control, not fight her. We help her, not blame her. Because sometimes, a man just needs a fish to stop being hungry before you can teach him to fish for himself.”

Bruce opens his mouth again, but Tim cuts him off. “I’ll save you the effort of speaking, I know it’s hard: yes, he’s killed, too. But hadn’t Doctor Quinzeel done so also? And yet, she was allowed redemption. She is free to roam now, even if on thin ice, even if under scrutiny. You understand this exception, don’t you? And yet, Jason isn’t given the same treatment.

Heck, you're still insisting you're not the one to pass judgement on *Joker* of all people, but you cross Jason off permanently *in a heartbeat*."

The fact that Bruce does not respond is Tim's first sign he's breaking.

"And why? It's something I don't think you put thought into, afraid of the conclusions you might come to, but I **had**. Here's what I came up with: you hold him to a higher standard. You see yourself in him and you wouldn't forgive yourself in this kinda situation. And so you refuse to forgive him, too."

Bruce closes his eyes and Tim ticks that off as another little victory.

"But he is *not* you, Bruce. He is *your son*, and you should *protect* him. Even if it means protecting him from himself. Or *yourself*."

"I tried-"

"Yes, you tried to save him. I know. We know. You're not the only one who failed him. So did I. I don't think *that's* what he's angry about, no matter what he says. His actions... They're chaotic. They're not the actions of someone who's prime goal is to do crime. Why would he attack you or me if his goal was to become a mobster? His entire world is in pieces, not making sense anymore and he's dealing with it the only way he knows. That's what you do when you open your eyes in unfamiliar darkness, hurt and alone and afraid. You *panic*. I know, because *I've been there* — you think I never snooped through the suit recording from back then, in the metro tunnel? You should know by now that *curiosity* is my prime flaw, B."

Bruce inhales sharply, opening his eyes. They're suddenly not filled with stubborn, rigid blankness, but a soft, gentle... doubt. A fear. A regret, maybe? Tim presses on, trying to use this as a leverage point.

"I've been in a situation like him, I know what it's like and I can imagine that if Al Ghuls found me then instead of you— if I heard half-truths about how you forgot about me and replaced me instead of your shitty rendition of '*Down by the bay*' and gentle reassurance that *it's going to be alright*, I'd be lashing out too. And the *last* thing I'd need would be Batman trying to punch me unconscious."

"You can't absolve him-"

"I am not trying to! He's intentionally committing violent crimes. That's bad. But he's doing it out of *grief and pain*. He's *unstable*, not *evil*, I know you *can* see the difference. Like with Doctor Fries last Christmas. You let him *grieve* even though he broke out of jail and caused a weather crash. Like with Ace when she went bonkers with her powers? You sat with her instead of trying to subdue her because you *knew* that despite being *dangerous*, she wasn't a *threat*. Even when everyone else gave up on her. You still sometimes visit mister Dent too, don't you? You *help* people, not *punish* them. *Justice*, not *vengeance*, right? Even **Batman** needed a *Robin* at some point to not spiral down. You just refuse to give Jason that kind of support, that *chance*. "

“He’s killed you. Twice,” Bruce says, and it’s all growly and Batman, yet Tim can hear in the way Bruce made a pause that he’s... getting his point across, at least a little.

“Listen, Bruce, if the cost of Jay being back, alive and safe and home, is letting him trash a couple of very expensive dolls, rough me up a bit — wouldn’t you do that? I would. I will.”

“He’s- he’s not going to stop.”

“He is.”

“I’m not taking that risk. I- I can’t.”

Robin straightens up, his face suddenly tight, then looks B dead in the eye.

“But I can. That’s why you’re drugged, Bruce.”

Tim has had a plan on how to proceed from that. Sort of. There were many variables.

There was a chance that Bruce would agree with him and in that case, they’d brainstorm how to approach Jason in a better, calmer way. He had some ideas drafted that he’d propose, but now they’re down the drain.

There was also a chance that B wouldn’t agree and in that case, Tim would have to find Jason on his own (because Dick is considered to be on B’s side for the purposes of handling Jason, sadly). Then he’d have to, with Alfred’s help, convince Jay to 1) not shoot Tim on sight, 2) be the bigger person and approach Bruce peacefully. This plan includes options like putting them in a locked room and mediating a discussion. Possibly sedating or restraining them both. Definitely stripping them of weapons. Whatever it would be, it’d have to be at the very least *started* before Bruce’s body would process the initial shot of tranquilizer. Because if the man gets free before this entire affair is done, he’ll, well, ruin everything by being a stubborn, emotionally constipated ass. Like always.

Since the second option turned out to come true and Tim is once again on his own, Robin immediately wanders out of the Cave. He leaves Bruce under the cameras’ watch and focuses on doing as much as he can in the short span of time he has.

Finding Jason is relatively easy. At least compared to *talking* with him. Passive messages don’t seem to get any response, and attempted in-person discussions run into the whole “shoot on sight” problem.

He could, reasonably, get his friends to help — Kon or Cassie could easily restrain Jason — but involving strangers definitely won’t help win Jaybird over. Luckily, just in case, Tim has already been planning to hack *back* into whatever technology Hood is using. He can use it to safely try to make a conversation, and if he does it well enough, Hood won’t be able to remove himself from the situation. It’s not the most efficient thing to do, nor the safest one by far, but he’s running out of options when people just *won’t deal with their emotions in a healthy manner*.

Either way, Tim fully expects this to be one of the more difficult and dangerous games in his life (especially since there's a non-zero chance that Bruce will choose to reprogram Tim completely for this stunt the moment he regains enough mental clarity, but that's a problem for future Tim).

What he is not expecting is seeing Jason, in civvies, looking suspiciously normal and non-aggressive, on the front gate camera feed.

Like, sure, that *was* a possibility, just so incredibly slim that Tim was not taking it into consideration.

And yet.

Bruce's more wrong about Jason than he thinks, apparently.

Still, Tim makes a gentle alarm noise in Alfred's room, only to find him wide awake and evidently waiting. Which is fair, Tim was doing God-knows-what to Bruce, it makes sense for Alfred to stay up for the aftermath.

"Alfie? Alfie, I-" For the first time in a while, Tim feels like he *needs an adult*. Alfred's expression quickly grows serious and worried when he hears Tim's voice, unsure and a little off.

"Master Timothy? What is wrong? Did your talk with Master Bruce go wrong?"

"Jason. It's Jason. Jason's at the gate," he sputters. "I know all we wanted was to talk to him and- he just dropped his jacket and is holding his arms up, he looks unarmed, but, I mean, he *is* dangerous and I don't know what he wants and while I will gladly throw my every last part into this, I don't want *you* to get hurt and-"

The butler swiftly stands up, making his way downstairs at a pace by far too brisk for his age.

"And Master Bruce?"

Tim does not respond. He doesn't really know *how* to tell Alfred that he's keeping B drugged down in the Cave.

Luckily, Alfred is an expert at picking up these kinds of silent responses.

"Otherwise occupied, I understand."

Tim plays an affirmative jingle, happy to avoid giving him the details. Alfred makes it to the main door but doesn't disengage the security protocols, instead opting to look through the camera, as if to confirm what Tim said with his own two eyes. Then, he looks up at Tim's nearest terminal.

"Please open the gate, young lad. It's late and chilly outside and I'm worried my grandson will catch a cold."

A normal person would ask “are you sure?” or hesitate for at least a moment when asked to let a criminal into the house. But Tim isn’t normal, and even after all these years some argue he’s not entirely a person either. He puts the hydraulics of the gate into motion, opening it in front of one of Gotham’s most dangerous people. Jason pauses for a moment, as if half expecting an ambush, then starts walking through the front yard.

“Do you know why he’s here?” Tim asks quietly as they wait for the man to reach the front door.

“He came over to have some tea with us.”

Tim doesn’t like missing beats like this, not at all.

“...I’ll need you to elaborate, Alfie.”

“You’ve contacted him somehow before, didn’t you? We both know it certainly *wasn’t* Master Bruce and while I give Miss Barbara a lot of credit, she would *not* do something like that.”

“Yeah. Yeah she wouldn’t,” Tim admits through a nearby speaker, which then plays an embarrassed noise. “But he never replied or even acknowledged my messages, and I certainly never invited him for tea, so I still don’t understand?”

“I’ve bumped into him while doing groceries some time ago. He didn’t say anything about you, but I knew he wouldn’t have approached me if someone hadn’t made him believe that his family is still waiting for him.”

“You- you talked to him? On your own?”

Alfred nods. “While I was understandably apprehensive at first, he was well-behaved and we were in public, in broad daylight, so I agreed to have a cuppa with him. We had a really nice chat in a gorgeous little cafe. ”

“But why now-”

The man just smiles, the smirk turning a little *smug* for a split second. “I assumed that you’re going to succeed — or at least *not fail* to convince Master Bruce to hold his horses. Either way, all of you will *think twice* before getting violent in the Manor, so it’s a really good chance to have a civilised talk instead of-” Alfred gestures down, as if trying to reference the Cave and vigilantism in general, “-your usual behaviour.”

Tim can’t help but laugh at that. Yeah, Alfred’s right. Nobody would *dare* to start shit in Alf’s meticulously spotless domain.

“So I invited him over,” the butler finishes, taking the few final steps towards the main entrance and straightening out his shirt. “Now be a darling and put the kettle on, Master Timothy.”

All of this kind of proves to Tim two things: one, that he still gets way, way better results when cooperating with a human being instead of doing things on his own, and two, Alfred is

definitely some kind of magic, or at the very least way, way smarter than he tends to let show.

He doesn't get to tell Alf this, though, as their little chat is interrupted by the sound of knocking on the door. Tim's first instinct is to listen in, make sure Alfred is safe and — of course — gather intel on Jason. Then he remembers about privacy, and about trust, and limits himself to just monitoring Alfred's vitals (for his own peace of mind more than anything else).

Meanwhile, Robin strolls back down to the Cave, assuming Jason won't react well to seeing the android in the Manor, especially when he's obviously on edge. And Tim doesn't have to go out and find Jason anymore, so he can talk with Bruce a bit more, ease him into the way the situation is developing while he's... receptive.

"I told you you are wrong," he says, slowly, once he reaches B, who's still half-awake and in his armchair.

The man looks up at him, confused.

"Alfred's having tea with Jason upstairs right this moment. He's not a mindless killing monster, he's a cornered animal and it proves that if you just show him compassion—"

And, listen, Tim knows a good deal about the human body and its limits. All there is to know probably, since he hacked into the databases of nearly every university and science facility on Earth. He *knows* that a shot of adrenaline can reset the heart and bring a person back from the brink of death.

Yet, even with all that knowledge, he does *not* expect Bruce to open his eyes so wide and stand up from his seat as if he was never sedated to begin with.

Sure, he sways wobbily a second later, but the sudden rush of clarity enables him to slowly make his way towards the exit.

"He's fine, B. Alfred's fine," Tim says, trying to placate Bruce's obvious panic while simultaneously planning on how he's going to restrain the man without fighting him. "He's safe. I'm keeping an eye. They've talked before. Jason's unarmed. You're wrong about him. Is it *that* hard to believe it?"

Bruce stops for a moment, resting against the nearest railing.

"I-..." he barely whispers, but Tim can hear him clearly. "I need to see for myself."

"I can give you a visual, if you'd like. Or I can ask Alfred to suggest to Jason you'd like to talk later, when *they're* done. But I will not let you rush in there and ruin everything."

Robin looks at him, and Tim points all of his cameras at Bruce for a brief moment, too. "I worked so hard for this. Please. Let me- let *us* try to bring him back home, to help him heal." The tone is slow, serious, and Tim knows it tightens B's heart. It's only *partially* engineered

to do that. “If anything bad happens, I promise I will drop it, all of it. But let me try, just this once. Let me trust my intuition, the thing you so fiercely insisted I have.”

Tim is not proud of using Bruce’s heartfelt words against him like that, basically manipulating him. He really isn’t. But it *works*, so he can’t really be mad at himself about it either.

Bruce’s muscles relax ever-so-slightly, and he rests against Robin’s shoulder. The android leads him back to the chair while Tim puts on the camera feed from the patio, where Jason and Alfred sit. They’re both tense, though Alfred understandably less so. Jay is, after all, on what he considers *enemy territory* now.

Tim purposefully doesn’t give Bruce the sound nor listens in to it himself, let’s them have that bit of privacy.

It is... uneventful. Surprisingly so, at least for Bruce, whose knuckles whiten slightly as he grips the armrests tightly every time Jason makes a sudden move. But none of those moves turns out to be hostile, and after an hour or so, Jason simply leaves; stands up, says what looks like a goodbye, and heads for the door. He seems just as surprised that nothing wild happened as Bruce, and even more so when Alfred offers him a hug at the doorstep. He hesitates for a split second, then embraces the elder and just *melts* into the touch. While Alfred doesn’t display such an intense reaction, he is obviously cherishing the embrace, too.

Tim can understand it. Tim feels that nearly unbearable need to hug Jason again, a desire he never had the chance to resolve.

Once the front gate closes and Jay’s motorbike disappears off the cameras, he turns to Bruce. The man is significantly more present now and is looking at the screen with a very, *very* pained expression. Tim can’t tell if it’s because he’s slowly realising the error of his ways, or because he knows what will inevitably follow, which is:

“I was right. As always.”

Bruce groans, but it’s unclear if it’s the rumbling post-sedation headache, or the mental pain of Tim rubbing it in. Instead of clarifying though, he attempts to pull Alfred on the comms and this time, Tim lets him do it without any fuss.

“Master Bruce? How are you feeling?” the butler says as if nothing out-of-ordinary happened.

“What were you *thinking?*” Bruce asks in an accusing tone. Alfred quirks an eyebrow hearing that and Tim knows some *scathing* sass is incoming.

“I already told you, sir. The boy needs someone to save him, not to hunt him. Master Timothy decided that if you won’t do it, he will take matters in his own hands, and I took it upon myself to be the father figure Master Jason deserves.”

Tim’s eyes would widen at how bold the butler’s words are if he was focusing on Robin in any way right now. Instead, he displays a blinking exclamation mark for a moment to show

how truly impressed he is.

Bruce, in a truly Bruce fashion, doesn't reply and opts to silently brood instead. Tim chooses to interpret that as as close to admitting defeat as they're going to get from him.

The next time Alfred invites Jason over, he tells Bruce beforehand — doesn't *ask*, just *informs* — and the Manor is understandably a little bit *tense* for a while. But nothing bad happens again, and with that, a precedent is set. Then it just... continues. Alfred and Jason (and only them; neither Alfred nor Tim dare even suggest Jason should see anybody else, in fear of a disagreement and... escalation) have some tea and talk every so often.

It takes time for B to get... acquainted with the idea, let alone become comfortable with it. At first he always demands to be notified when Jay's around, to have at *the very least* a visual of what's happening — Tim obliges, because it's the Administrator after all, even if he himself makes a point of *not* spying on them — and spends hours staring, in silence, at feeds or recordings of them sitting in the patio and talking (because that's all they ever do; Jay refuses to take a step any deeper into the Manor). Tim can't tell if B is silently judging, preparing a plan for when (as he thinks, inevitably) Jason backstabs them, or simply can't have enough of looking at his son being back home again.

Tim wants to believe it's the latter, because it's exactly what he's doing on the rare occasion that he does take a peek. He doesn't take photos, of course, because that would be a transgression of their privacy, even if he *desperately* wants to; instead, he focuses on taking everything else he can in as *memories*. Constructs a new profile on Jay, too, because the one he has is definitely outdated.

It's a big change, to see the mouthy little nerd so tall and broad and all clad in leather, but it's not a *surprise*. Anyone who ever knew anything about Jason — and Tim knew a lot, if not everything there was to know about him — suspected that he's going to grow up to be even bolder, snappier and more sarcastic than he already was, and his new "bad boy" aesthetic matches that prediction. They just hadn't expected a 15-inch growth spurt to follow suit, though it does go well with all the bravado.

With time, while they still clash out on the field, Bruce's and Jay's confrontations have less and less... tension. It is hard to be very violent with someone you know will be visiting for a cuppa in a couple hours, after all. Aggression slowly dies down, and eventually whenever they cross paths, they simply have a staring contest for a moment, adjust their plans and go their respective ways. Half of that surprisingly good development of their relationship is probably due to Red Hood becoming a lot less trigger-happy ever since he started interacting with Alfred. They even notice he uses non-lethal methods most of the time now; instead he pings B's comms with locations where he leaves criminals beaten black and blue, but *alive*. He functionally drops from Bat's list, even if he remains a wanted criminal, and Tim takes sweet satisfaction in being *right* again.

They never meet out of costume though, and they still aren't on speaking terms either. Jason's withholding even snarky one-liners and dramatic comments, which cuts Bruce deeper than he wants to let show. The opposite of love isn't hatred, after all, it's indifference.

That's the reason why Tim is growing sadder every day. Of course, he's ecstatic that Jason is slowly... reintegrating into the society, sorta. But while Bruce at the very least gets *indifference*, Tim gets absolutely *nothing*. Jason refuses to engage him in any way. Refuses to even acknowledge Robin's existence on the odd occasion they see each other out in the field, doesn't speak to Alfred about him, doesn't even act like he remembers Tim *at all*. It hurts, more than anything he ever felt. But Tim accepts it. If that's the price for Jason's happiness, even a shred of it, he's willing to pay it.

He thinks he sorta deserves it, too. While Jay seemingly accuses B of forgetting him, of not doing him justice... it's a passive sort of transgression, an oversight. Something Bruce should've done, but hadn't. But Tim? It looks like Jason thinks of what Tim had done as betrayal, an active way of going directly against him, of intentionally doing something hurtful. He can understand why Jay doesn't want to interact with him.

Which is why it comes as such a surprise when — a good couple of months after the first visit — Alfred calls for him one day while Jason is over. Bruce, as usual when it's "teatime", is not present, this time pretending to be WE's famous, ditzy CEO. Tim is mostly busy hanging out with the Titans, trying to give Alfred and Jay some space. But he is obviously still overlooking all the Manor systems and listening in to his terminals so that is how he receives Alfred's ping.

He displays a question mark on the nearest screen to show he's listening, not sure if he should even speak up around Jay.

"Master Timothy? Do you have a moment? Master Jason would like to chat with you, if that's alright."

Reasonably, he should probably hesitate before he replies. Most people would. It's a sudden change in behaviour, an unexpected request.

But he doesn't. Instead, he hastily lets his friends know that Robin is going semi-offline, because he's going to be busy back home, then proceeds to focus nearly all of his attention on that single terminal.

> Always.

Alfred smiles softly, warmly, and Tim realizes that Alf *knows something that he doesn't*, once again proving he's a little bit *magic*. "I'll leave you two to it, then," he says, standing up, then once he's at the door, looks at Jay one more time. "I'll be in the kitchen if you boys need anything."

Once the butler leaves, uncomfortable silence fills the room.

"Why aren't you speaking? Out loud, I mean," Jason finally asks, idly playing with his empty teacup.

> I chose to err on the side of caution in case you didn't want to hear my voice.

He realises he sounds awkward and stilted, but he would rather it be that than fuck this up.

“It’s... okay,” Jay sighs, looking out into the garden. “Is that why you hadn’t been around when I’m here?”

This time, Tim hesitates for a split second, then tries answering in spoken words.

“Yes. That, and Rob-... *my body* seems to make you uncomfortable.”

Jay winces. “Yeah... I-... thanks, I guess? For being... thoughtful?”

Tim simply plays his happy jingle. He could try to ask some questions of his own, but chooses not to. It feels like it’s a... deliberate attempt to connect, to converse, but it also seems like whatever convinced Jay to finally reach out is a very fragile motivation. So he lets Jason dictate the topic and pace of the conversation.

It turns out to be the correct course of action, because after a moment Jason picks up again. The brief softness between them disappears though, and his face contorts into a scowl once more. His words sound like they’re pure bile, as if he’s spitting them out.

“Why is he still alive? Alfred keeps saying how much you and Bruce care, how much you *love* me. If you two *cared so much*, why is Joker still alive? Not anybody else, not any other rogue. Just him. For what he did to me.”

“Because I was scared,” Tim replies simply. It’s not something he’d willingly discuss, but he’s not going to dodge questions, either.

“Of what?!”

“Of what B would do if he found out I killed someone. Back then, I thought I was just a machine to him. I didn’t know if he’d have any issues with turning me off permanently — the actual me, the mainframe. I was young and I was simply scared for my own existence. So I did the next best thing to outright offing Joker.”

Jason just raises his eyebrows in an inquisitive gesture, so Tim continues.

“I never managed to lure him out to California, where with the help of Titans I could with good probability get him sentenced to death row. So instead, I made sure that he would never hurt anyone ever again.” Tim lowers his volume to a conspiratory whisper. While he’s pretty sure B is onto him, they’ve never discussed it openly. He also isn’t entirely sure he wants Alfred to know. “I hacked and bribed and stealthed my way into Arkham every other month for a couple years. Broke most of his bones regularly. And sure, they treated him, but by the sixth time... the human body has limited regenerative ability, you know? Between that and muscle atrophy from being constantly in a full-body cast, he won’t be able to ever hold a spoon again. Let alone pose any physical danger to anyone.”

“And B is... *okay* with that?”

“B doesn’t *know*. At least I never told him. I weighed the chances of getting shut down for it, and decided it’s a risk I’m willing to take. Came up with a good line of defense just in case, then proceeded with the plan on my own.” He pauses for a moment. It’s maybe not the time

to bring it up, but... He's had it with everyone always assuming that he's only doing Bruce's bidding, and without question to that. More often than not, *he's* the one calling the shots, even if B probably doesn't realise it, or doesn't *want* to realise it. "Contrary to popular belief, I am *not* B's puppet and on occasion do things out of my own volition. Especially nowadays, when I'm more confident that he won't simply turn me off. Who do you think drugged Bruce so you could visit for the first time?"

"Excuse me, you did *what* now?"

"I tranq'd Bruce back when you first came over for tea. He would've immediately confronted you otherwise?"

"I thought he was already out on patrol!"

"It was barely 7 pm, it wasn't even dark enough yet!"

"I don't know, I trusted Alfred!"

"Alfred *is* powerful, but not even he can make Bruce *willingly* face his emotions." The sentence comes out a little more snarky than he intends, so he adjusts before continuing. "I had to restrain B to try to talk him into looking past his trauma to... give you a chance. I think he... he sees himself in you. He never forgave himself for what happened to you, he's never accepted anything but perfection from himself. It's... hard for him to give you allowances when he had so much hope for you. But I think he-"

"Why were the robots made?" Jason interrupts him, frowning, visibly annoyed that they're talking about Bruce. Or maybe that they're talking about emotions. Either way, frustrated, so Tim shuts up. "Why are you Robin?"

Judging by his tone, it must've been on Jay's mind for a long time, so there's a good chance he's going to at least *try* to sit through the answer without exploding. Still, Tim decides to explain himself very carefully, as well as he can. He might not get another chance anytime soon, if ever.

"My family would've fallen apart otherwise," he begins, doing his darndest to sound as sincere as possible while also remaining... composed. There are parallels, there are *implications* that he doesn't know how Jay will react to. "B was devastated when he lost you. Blamed himself, drowned in grief, channeled his emotions into violence. He was becoming someone neither he nor I wanted him to become. I thought that the constant, physical presence of a dependent person would snap him out of it. Or at the very least that I could stop him from spiralling out of control if I was with him out in the field. I was right, and Robin has remained my way of keeping his self-destructive tendencies in check ever since."

Tim falls silent for a moment, letting Jason process that. Process how eerily similar the situation Bruce was in is to his current predicament.

Predictably, Jay rests his elbows on the table and hides his face in his palms and Tim wants to continue, but then Jason speaks up. "So it wasn't his idea?"

“No. He didn’t even know what I was doing until I finished the first build.” Tim would offer him a sigh if Robin was in the room, but since he’s not, he opts for displaying a “...” on the screen even if Jason isn’t paying it any attention.

“Looking back, I now realise that it was also partially because I was desperately trying to keep the memory of you alive, pretending like some part of you was still with us, which was my way of coping. You were— you *are* my hero, my best friend. You were everything I thought Robin should be. I wanted... for it to be remembered. I tried to let you live on through my actions. You have no idea how many of my decisions were based on trying to figure out ‘*what would Jason do*’.”

Jason cracks a sour half-smile at the comment, probably imagining the kind of shenanigans that reasoning can get someone into. Tim takes that as a good sign and attempts to take some initiative.

“I understand how it—” he begins, but his voice breaks a little, so he speeds up his speech just so he can get it out before it’s too late. As such, his words lose the calm, collected flow they previously had. “It looks like I took your place as B’s sidekick, as his son, I understand that and I’m *so, so sorry*. Please understand that I *never* wanted it to be like that and if you want it, if you just say a word, I will drop it all, I can scrap all of my bodies, I—”

His increasingly desperate litany is cut short by Jason’s sudden, barking laughter. It’s not happy; it’s bitter and a bit hysterical, but Tim can’t help but immediately start recording it. He’s missed it *so* much.

“You used to laugh all the time,” he remarks quietly. “I have terabytes upon terabytes, entire hard drives filled with nothing but the sound of your laugh and images of your smiles. And now... We failed you. *I* failed you. Please— please let me make it right. Tell me how to make it right.”

“Fuck. It’s really you, isn’t it?” Jason says once his hysterical laughter dies down a little, and it throws Tim off.

“It is me?” he just repeats, confused, again displaying a question mark on the screen nearby.

“I thought—... You’re so different, sound so different— I didn’t— I thought Bruce made another- a new model, or at least re-programmed you— as, I don’t know, punishment for letting me sneak out to Ethiopia or something? I thought that he made a *better version* of *both* of his unruly sons.”

Jason finally looks up and Tim sees that there are tears in his now wide-open eyes as if something *broke* inside of him. The thought that he’s the one that caused it *hurts* Tim so much. Almost as much as it *scares* him.

"Are you okay...?"

“God. Tim. I’m not okay. *I killed you.*”

“No!” he immediately retorts, raising his voice — half angry, half alarmed. He wants to tell him all about how Robin is just a tool, but then remembers what Bruce told him recently, what he agreed to — that even if *he* isn’t hurt, *others* are in distress when Robin is damaged. He’s never talked about it this way, though, so his revised speech comes out... a little jumbled and all over the place. “I’m safe. You’re talking to me now, right? I’m okay. It wasn’t worse than if you... broke my leg, maybe. It wasn’t the whole me, it didn’t hurt. I promise. It’s okay. I forgive you.”

“You can’t— Fuck!” Jason slams his fists on the table angrily. It makes Tim think that maybe he still chose the wrong words?

“I’m sorry-”

“No! You shouldn’t be the one apologising. Alfred shouldn’t be inviting me for tea. I’m a-”

“You’re hurt and confused and lonely, that’s what you are. Let me help you.”

Jason pulls his lips. “It’s pointless.”

“It’s not. It’s not rotten work. Not to me. Not if it’s you.”

Jason suddenly focuses his gaze, for the first time looking at the camera, looking Tim in the eye. “Did you just quote Greek classics at me?”

And Tim wouldn’t be himself if he didn’t try to lift the mood a bit.

“I did say my life motto is ‘*what would Jason do*’, didn’t I?”

And because Tim’s rarely, if ever, wrong — Jason misses a beat, and then starts laughing again. But this time it’s... still not happy per se, but it’s a step in the right direction, Tim ponders.

Chapter End Notes

Refs and memes in this chapter:

[Batman’s contingency plans](#)

[Batman going easy on Mr Freeze](#)

[Death of Ace](#) - yes we be mixing timelines, sue me

[Love and indifference](#)

[It’s rotten work](#)

Chapter 10

Chapter Notes

Trigger warnings for this chapter: abandonment issues, self-hatred

See the end of the chapter for [more notes](#)

Robin opens his eyes and moves before his systems even fully come out of hibernation. Luckily, Robin's sitting securely in an armchair every time he idles (they've learned from the time he ended up falling down the stairs), so he just sways to the side instead of meeting the floor face-first.

He looks around. It's quiet, only the distant ambience of other Titans in the Tower disrupting the silence. That, and Kon's — who's apparently napping on the couch nearby, as if guarding him — adorable, tiny snores. Bart and Cassie must've left to busy themselves with something else when he so abruptly interrupted their hangout.

Robin grins, then nearly *pounces* on Kon, who jostles straight up in a slight panic. At first, his hands close into fists and shoulders square defensively (a very good instinct, one that Tim had trained into them all). Then his brain registers who woke him up and he relaxes, now frowning slightly instead.

“What the *fuck*-”

“He talked to me!”

“What?”

“Jason! I had a chat with Jason. He laughed! I think we're good. Better, at least. He said he's looking forward to tea '*with you two*' instead of '*with Alfred*' and-”

But Kon-el doesn't seem as excited as Tim is.

“Rob,” he says, voice stern and commanding. It causes Robin to instantly stop in his tracks.

“Yeah?”

“That's your crying face.”

Robin blinks in surprise, trying to process what kind of expression he's making at the time.

“It is?”

“It is. What's wrong?”

“Nothing. I— ... It’s- Kon, understand, I’ve been hoping for this for months. I’ve been missing him for *years*. Everything is finally *right*.”

“I know,” Kon smiles, a little sadly, then gives his hair a ruffle. “Do you want a hug?”

He pauses for a moment. His systems are all tingly with static, so some grounding would probably be nice. “Yeah. Yeah I think I do.”

Tim lets his body lay down full-weight on Kon, knowing the kryptonian super-strength guarantees that it won’t hurt or even bother his friend. Big arms are wrapped around him and press him even closer, and he soon metaphorically melts into the touch that he didn’t know he needed. (Pressure and thermal skin sensors were the best. Decision. Ever.)

Though he still doesn’t understand why he’s miserable when he should be positively *ecstatic*. But apparently Kon does, seeing he’s noticed it first, so Tim decides to inquire.

“Why am I like this?” he asks, quietly, once his signals stop being choppy and laggy.

“It’s a difficult situation for you,” Kon provides calmly. “You’ve worked very hard and held in a lot of fear about it. I guess now that it’s no longer on such thin ice, you finally can-”

“-release some tension.”

“Yea.”

“Thank you,” he whispers, closing his eyes and resting his head back on Kon’s chest.

“Always.”

“You’re the best friend I could ask for.”

“Wouldn’t that be Jason?” Kon replies, and the bittersweet tone and the way his chest tightens immediately after tells Tim he regrets saying it out loud.

“... are you-”

“I’m sorry, I didn’t-”

“No, wait. Tell me. Please.”

Kon stays silent for a while, but Tim doesn’t insist or repeat himself. It’s no use — if Kon decides to talk, he’ll talk when he’s ready. He hasn’t pushed Robin off his chest yet, so it’s a good sign, too.

“... you’re always calling *him* your best friend, and when- when he was dead it’s never been an issue, it’s an expression of fondness, you know, I’m not competing with a memory, but— But now he’s back and— “

“ — and you’re scared that he’ll replace you,” Tim supplies with a sigh.

Kon huffs and closes his eyes. “You’re right, but you shouldn’t *say it*. ”

Robin chuckles at that, then reaches up and gently strokes Kon’s hair. He’s rewarded with a rhythmic rumble starting inside Superboy’s chest, almost like purring. “Do you want support or solutions?”

“I’m getting both, aren’t I.”

“Eventually.”

“Lay it on me, then.”

“When I was a kid, I used to deal in absolutes way more. Looking back, I probably called Jason my best friend because he was my *only* friend. I mean, sure, there’s Nightwing but, you know, we never bonded that way. And now he’s my older brother, it’s just *different*. Jason was... I was closer with Jason. It just felt... wrong to stop calling him that, even if I stopped really... measuring who’s my *best* friend a long time ago. I love you, you know that. You’re all my family.”

“I understand. But it’s not that easy. Understanding and feeling are two different things.”

Robin shrugs. “I wouldn’t know-”

“Shut up. Just shut up. You’re laying on me, all mopey, hugging me like a baby koala because you can’t handle the feels from talking to Jason for like ten minutes — if you say that you *don’t have emotions* again one more time, I’m going to punt you into the freaking sun.”

Tim stays silent for a moment. “Fair point.”

“So shut up and hug me.”

The next thing they hear is doors creaking open quietly and before they can raise their heads to check who came in, Bart is hovering over the backrest of the sofa, looking at them excitedly.

“Cuddlepile! Can I join?”

Both Kon and Robin snort a laugh, then immediately start shuffling around to make some room for the speedster.

“So, what was the matter, Rob?” he asks once he’s comfortably snuggled in their laps. “Did something happen?”

Tim grumbles. He’s not quite ready to discuss it yet, not quite done getting stress hugged out of him. But he knows Impulse will not let up.

“Yea,” he says with a breathless sigh. “I’ll need help figuring out how to convince one of us Bats to go to therapy.”

Both his friends raise their eyebrows. “Tim, you’re a genius, but,” the speedster begins unusually slowly, “I don’t think even *you* can do that.”

He smirks. “Have I ever backed out of a challenge?”

“Sadly, no,” Kon throws in, rolling his eyes.

Bart looks up at Robin, biting down on his lower lip a bit. “Are we talking about Jason and his... anger issues?”

Robin nods and makes his affirmative jingle instead of answering properly.

“Maybe Raven could do something?” the speedster offers. “Or Zatanna? I mean you mentioned he got dunked in some magical goo, maybe it’s residue. One of them could know how to sort it out. Or if not them, then someone else? Honestly, there has to be a friend of ours that will know how to help.”

Robin's eyes widen as everything suddenly falls into place. *Human ingenuity, fuck yeah.*

"Bart, I love you," he says, hugging him tight.

"You love quite a lot of people, pal," Impulse says, struggling to take a deeper breath, which is a signal for Tim to let go. The boy makes a high-pitched wheeze, like a squeaky toy that's been squished, and that makes both Tim and Kon laugh.

"So sue me." Robin settles back down, and while his friends slowly doze off into a nap, he *plans*.

Tim's content with just talking to Jason every other week and diligently relating to his friends how it's progressing. And taking lots and lots of photos. He has a whole new album just for current shots of Jason. It’s filling up very quickly. He even got a smile or two in there.

But he also has objectives.

Out of the three things he wants to achieve in regards to Jason, Tim isn't really sure which one's the most difficult.

Firstly, he would die for a chance to hold Jay, but he's been reminded time and time again that Robin is not a welcome sight; though now they've sorted out where the negative association came from, and why — maybe it helped with that issue and there is a chance Tim could hug Jaybird at some point? At least once? He’d be okay with it being just a one-time thing.

Secondly, there’s Dick. Jason has not shown any interest in seeing him but hadn't also said anything *against* Big Bird Bro, and they've been on pretty good terms back in the day. If Tim gets Dick to handle the situation with enough care, they could probably hang out together a bit. It’d certainly be good for Jaybird to have more social interactions...

Thirdly, despite the fact that Jay *desperately* needs professional help, suggesting therapy is a delicate subject with *anyone*, let alone *a Bat*. There's a chance though — he seems relatively receptive to talking it out now, compared to the initial reactions (which kind of goes along with the fact that he apparently doesn't consider himself a Bat anymore). Maybe if approached gently, after building enough trust, he could be persuaded to seek actual treatment. Friends and family are great, but they can only do so much.

Of course, there's always the issue of B, too, as a fourth thing. Tim *will* attempt to get Jason and Bruce to have a conversation... at some point. But that's a song of the future. It's still definitely in the no-go zone of difficult topics to talk about at the moment.

But for now, he'll focus on gently easing Jason into a proper support network.

Much to his discomfort, it doesn't go according to his plans *at all*, but he still couldn't wish for a better outcome (it is yet another proof for the “Alfred is actually magic” casefile).

It starts with Alfred being unwell. Usually it's not a big deal, even with Alf's old age — humans get ill sometimes and the common cold isn't all that worrying. But this time instead of just sniffles, it's something in Alf's back that gives out and renders him bed-ridden for a good couple of days. So, Tim insists on taking care of all of the butler's daily work — he's not built for it, but he knows the drill well enough. He can do laundry, vacuum and prepare food while Alfred rests for as long as it's needed. He's got the groceries covered with deliveries, even if Alf doesn't like the prospect of someone else picking out their food — Tim's not quite ready to show up in a store as a civilian, and he definitely can't shop around for vegetables as Robin (it is a hilarious mental image, tho). He also makes sure to double-check in on B, knowing Alfred is half the reason the man remembers to sleep and hydrate at all.

It gets a little complicated when Alf is still quite in pain once the weekend rolls in. Because every other Saturday Jason visits, and hell will sooner freeze over than either of them will let *that* be cancelled. The elder is well enough to get out of bed by then, and even sit around for an hour or two, but Tim doesn't like the idea of him cleaning the house and working in the kitchen for an extended time like he always does before Jay arrives. Since he's still ordered by his doctor to “take it easy”, and still requires painkillers to manage his backache, Tim demands Alfred rests instead and lets Robin take care of all the prep.

Alfred agrees without much fuss. After all, Tim is a capable young boy, and he's proven he can make decent food. There's no way simple cake and tea can go wrong anyway, right?

So, on Saturday, four hours before Jason's due to come around, Robin starts preparing. Sweeps the patio, wipes down the furniture, brings in another, more comfortable kind of chair and a copious amount of pillows (in case Alfred needed to adjust his sitting position). Makes the batter for one of Alfred's cookie recipes, lets it rest while he warms the oven. Picks out a tea flavour and a teacup set to match it, puts together a fruit bowl, even. Sets the table, complete with napkins and fresh flowers. Puts the cookies into the oven, helps Alfred make his way to the patio...—

He's finishing up baking the cookies when he sees Jason on the front-gate cameras.

(Jay doesn't ring the bell, just goes straight for the Manor's door; he has received the current gate code some time ago, as their act of goodwill. Bruce didn't even oppose, just grumbled incoherently when Alfred proposed it! In return, Jay allowed Alfred to share his phone number with Tim and Dick, though they both still hadn't found the right occasion to use it.)

Jason makes it all the way to the front door before Tim comes up with a solid exit route for Robin. The initial plan was to get everything ready and then have R go to the Cave, as always — Tim doesn't want to cause Jaybird to have a panic attack, obviously, and that seems to be what Jay is experiencing when he encounters Robin.

But with Jay arriving early, Tim has to come up with a new strategy to avoid conflict.

To reach the patio, where Alfred is awaiting him, Jay has to pass the kitchen, and if he doesn't venture inside, he might not notice Robin at all, but if he does... Who knows how he'll react to seeing Robin in this kind of situation.

Tim doesn't like that kind of risk, not when there could be collateral in *Alfred's kitchen*. He'll thus have to distract Jason so that Robin can sneak past him... scrap that, the cookies are literally about to be finished and if he leaves them in even a minute too long, they will burn, so he can't just leave. He **has to** keep Jason away. Preferably completely out of the kitchen, but at the very least occupied. For long enough so that Robin can take the cookies out. And then hide in the very obviously used kitchen in a way that Jason — a trained fighter, infiltrator and detective — will not suspect he's there.

...Yeah.

Jay doesn't seem to realise how much distress he's causing Tim by arriving early. Since he's been informed that Alfred is unwell, he doesn't knock on the front door, either, further cutting the time Tim has to salvage the situation.

"I'm coming in!" Jason loudly announces his arrival, kind of as a courtesy probably, but it does nothing to help Tim's problem.

"Hi Jay," he says through a hallway speaker, trying to sound unsuspecting and maybe buy himself some time. "You're early?"

"Hey Tim," Jay nods at the nearest camera as he takes off his shoes and jacket. "I got worried about Alfred. How is he?"

"Better, way better." Jason is not showing any intention of hanging around the entrance for any period of time, so Tim tries to steer him while Robin opens the oven as quietly as he can. "I've already told him you arrived. He's on the patio."

"Great, but he'll have to wait a lil'." To Tim's displeasure, Jason doesn't take the usual course, heading straight into the kitchen instead. "I figured I'd make the tea this time, you know? Since he can't."

“Yeah, about that— “ he tries to divert Jason’s attention again, as a last-ditch effort, while Robin ducks behind the kitchen island, trying to make as little noise as possible. It’s hard when you’re holding a tray of fresh cookies, but it’s nothing a seasoned vigilante can't manage.

“Tim-” Jason frowns, looking around. “Is Alfred out and about? I thought he’s on bed rest.”

“No, he’s resting.”

He frowns even more, gesturing to the freshly-made tea and open oven. “Then what the fuck is this?”

“Uh,” Tim stutters and it doesn’t help the situation at all. “If you could just make your way to the patio? I’m... getting everything ready.”

Jason stays still in confusion for a moment, then dread crawls onto his face. He slowly raises his hands in a surrendering gesture.

“I’m—I’m not going to hurt you. I promise,” he says, making painfully slow steps backwards. “I know I’ve acted like a- a monster before, but I swear, Tim, I won’t-”

That throws Tim off.

“I’m not worried about you hurting me?”

Jason stops in his tracks. “Then why are you afraid of me?”

“I’m not afraid of you?” Tim responds, even more bewildered.

“Then why are you hiding? If you’re not scared of me?” Jay motions broadly to the kitchen island behind which Robin is crouching.

“I’m scared *for* you.”

“What?”

“You’re upset by the sight of-”

“Shut up.”

“Huh?”

“You have it wrong. All wrong. It’s- it’s not that I was...” He sighs and sits on a nearby barstool, slumping over the counter as if he’s suddenly very tired. “Come out. It’s-... if *you’re* not afraid, then it’s okay. You don’t need to hide.” Jay puts a hand over his chest, right where his heart is. “Urchin’s promise.”

Robin slowly and carefully sets the tray he’s holding onto the counter. Pops his head over the edge, too, waits a moment, testing the waters. When Jason just smiles sadly at him, he stands up fully in all of his Superboy-themed-pyjamas and tousled-artificial-hair glory.

They stare at each other in silence for good thirty seconds before Tim decides to wave a hello at Jason, a little awkwardly (but he's learned that awkwardness is human and cute and endearing, so he's hoping it'll defuse the situation a bit).

"You look like a twelve-year-old," Jason remarks, looking him up and down. Tim wants to argue that Robin's size is more around the average of a 14-, maybe even 15-year-old boy, but he decides it's not the time. "Makes me feel even more guilty."

Robin frowns but doesn't find accurate words to voice his disagreement with this sentiment, either. Still, Jason picks the expression and its meaning up without the need for Tim to vocalize it.

"I know, I know. You... *forgive me*. Doesn't mean I forgive *myself*. I thought... I thought I'm doing it for you, too. That it's revenge for both of us. Look where it got me."

"It got you back home."

"Did it, really? This isn't my home. Manor's Bruce's home, not mine."

"Home is not a place. Home is where the heart is."

"Where do you pull all this motivational bullshit out of?"

"I'm plugged into the internet 24/7, Jason. I know every inspirational Pinterest quote you can think of, and then some."

Jason snorts as a response, to which Tim — finally having Robin in the same room, in peace — reacts with one of his signature shit-eating grins (he always wanted to use those, probably because Jay used to when he was young, but they only really took form after Tim befriended Bart). Then, he picks up one of the still oven-hot cookies with his bare fingers (pros of no pain sensors), waves it around a bit to cool it off a little, and offers it to Jason.

"Wanna try? It's Alfred's recipe, but I added my personal twist to it." It's common knowledge that a little bit of salt enhances even sweet dishes, but Tim's had enough time for research to find out that adding *smoked* salt gives the flavour profile a bit of surprising, but fitting depth.

Jay hesitantly reaches out and grabs the cookie, blowing on it some more.

"Personal twist like what? Loose screws instead of chocolate chips?" he asks, then immediately pales as if expecting Robin to take it in bad faith. As if not sure if Tim will react badly to teasing.

It kinda hurts that they're not as comfortable with each other as they used to be.

But it means that Jason is *open* to bantering in general, so Tim decides to use this opportunity to illustrate that he's still just as chill — if not more — as he used to be. Robin puts his hands on his hips, intending to remind Jay who developed his razor-sharp wit and resistance to mocking.

"Wouldn't you like to know, weatherboy."

Jason pauses for a split second, then snorts again and grins. “Guess I’ll have to fuck around and find out, huh?”

Robin nods, wiggling his eyebrows, and then as soon as Jay takes a bite out of the cookie, he says: “I added raisins,” looking Jaybird straight in the eye. Jason immediately starts *coughing*.

“Why the fuck would you do that?!” he asks, tone accusing, trying to get the cookie out of his mouth in a slight panic. “Raisins are an insult to-”

“You just spat out a perfectly good cookie, mister *I’ll-never-waste-food*.”

“*Raisins* aren’t food-!”

“I lied.” He points to the cookies, which very obviously do not include raisins if one takes a closer look. Jason gasps, half offended, half amused, wholly impressed. “Get fucked. And consider this sufficient payback for any bad blood you might think is between us.”

Jason opens his mouth, scowling, clearly wanting to tell Tim this is in no way, shape or form equivalent to what he did. Robin just shushes him with an extended finger.

“Shh. Instead of trying to argue with an almost all-knowing AI, help me get everything on a tray.”

He gets another pause, then laughter — genuine, honest, happy laughter this time — and that’s all he could’ve asked for. He immediately starts recording, *memorising*.

“You’re just as much of a little shit as ever, you know that?” Jay says with a tease, arranging the teacups and the saucers while Tim plates the cookies.

“And you’re still as easy to outsmart as ever.” They make quick work of the rest of the preparation and make their way to the patio.

"You just took me by surprise!"

Robin looks him up and down with an incredulous expression. "You fucked around and found out, Jay. Hardly a surprise," he says, pushing the door separating them from Alfred open with his shoulder.

"Language, Master Timothy!"

He smiles apologetically as he puts down the tray. "Sorry, Alf. How are you feeling?" Jason follows him inside, nods at the butler and starts setting up the teacups.

"Very good. The pillows came in handy, thank you for them." The elder motions to how he’s sitting, back propped up on the cushions Tim brought in earlier. Then, he turns to Jason, who’s now making himself comfortable on the other side of the table. “How about you, Master Jason? How has your week been?”

Jason smiles faintly, but his eyes are beaming. "I'm fine, Alfie. Seeing you always lifts my spirits, too."

"Glad to hear that, young master. The sentiment is mutual." Alfred takes a bite out of a cookie, then hums in appreciation, which causes Robin to grin. Getting Alfred's approval is always a great thing.

Emboldened by how everything went so far, he decides to push his luck and looks up at Jason.

"Can I... stay?" he asks hesitantly. He's not hesitating to *ask* it, but that is the intonation he learnt to use when talking about *delicate* manners, and this definitely counts as such, still.

Jason blinks, confused, then frowns. "Of course, Tim," he says as if it was never a question.

"No, I mean— Robin, can Robin stay? Gestures and facial expressions—"

"I said: of course," Jason repeats, tone a little harder now, pouring tea into Alfred's cup. Robin stares at him for a moment, then smiles and pulls up a chair for himself.

"It's also nice to see you finally getting to properly meet Master Timothy's favourite terminal," the butler says at that.

Jason shrugs, but Tim can see the slight nervousness, the slight tension in his shoulders. It is sad that it's still there, but it is to be expected; humans cannot simply flip a switch to change their minds and hearts about something, and the doubts will linger for some time.

That is why Tim is here, because Tim can — and *will* — help.

"Speaking of which," Jay picks up, surprisingly. He must want to clear the air between them as fast as possible, too, because a cheeky smirk crawls onto his lips. It usually means he's about to deliver some on-point taunt, and it is no different this time. "Superman pyjamas, really? No class at all."

"Excuse you, these are Super**boy**-themed."

"And what's the difference? All Supers seem the same to me."

"Well, for starters, one I regularly use as a pillow."

Jason looks at Alfred with eyes slightly blown in surprise, but the butler offers no explanation, so he stares back at Tim for a moment, stunned. "All grown up, I see," he finally says. "Didn't think B would let you to date."

"Bold of you to assume Bruce knows what I do in my spare time," he replies with a grin, "but no, we're not dating. We're simply very close."

"Mmm, 'f course," Jason hums in response over the rim of his teacup. He doesn't sound convinced, but it's not really important. When the right time comes, he'll see for himself how Tim is with his best friends nowadays. But not now, not yet.

As such, Tim decides to slightly change the topic.

“Have you read the book I suggested last time?” he asks, getting cozy on his chair and offering Alfred another cookie. The elder takes it with a smile, listening to the ongoing conversation in silence.

“You mean *‘The Warrior’s Apprentice’*?” Jason picks up. “I did, actually. It’s not my usual genre — I hadn’t dabbled in science fiction much before — but I liked it. The protagonist is well-rounded, I have to admit.”

“Glad to hear that. I’ll tell Bart his recommendation was welcomed, he’ll be happy.”

“Bart?”

“Yeah! One of my hero friends, Impulse. He can’t wait to meet you one day, and in the meantime passes on his book recs through me. He’s a big nerd like that.”

“... what?”

Robin tilts his head. “What *‘what’*?”

“Why would any of your friends want to meet me? How do they even know-”

“Well, I told them all about my best friend and idol on whom I based all my heroism on. Besides, you were a Titan briefly, some people remember you personally. Starfire for example; she keeps asking me about you ever since she heard you’re back. She’s excited about your return, and she’s not the only one.”

“Bless Miss Anders’ heart, she’s always been so kind,” Alfred throws in with a solemn nod.

Once again, Jason is too stunned to say much. “They- They don’t hate me? Don’t think I’m a monster?”

The butler narrows his eyes as if wanting to scold Jay for thinking like that about himself. But he knows better than to voice that disapproval in any other way than a concerned, warm “Why would anyone think that, Master Jason?”

“You know well why, Alfred,” Jay barks out in response immediately.

“Jaybird, everybody has worse days,” Tim chirps in.

“That’s one *hella* understatement.”

“No, not really. Just most people aren’t as *driven* as you are when they’re... not being themselves.”

“And what if that **was** me?!” Jason snaps, suddenly aggressive again, and Tim squares Robin’s shoulders defensively. That gives Jay enough of an uncomfortable whiplash to bring him back down from the high-strung state. He deflates into a sad, closed-off heap once again, and looks away. Like that, he almost seems like the same 14-year-old Jay that Tim

remembers, bold but confused and unsure about his place in the world. “The Lazarus Pit did a number on me, yeah, and it certainly didn’t *help* to think clearly, but... what if it wasn’t some magical influence? What if it wasn’t the Pit talkin’ when- when I-”

Alfred silently places a reassuring hand on Jason’s and causes him to look up, startled by the touch.

“Yeah. What if it was you?” Tim asks quietly. “What then?”

“Then it’s all on me. All I did and-”

“And? That doesn’t change anything.”

Jason pushes himself up, straightening abruptly, as if appalled by the suggestion Tim’s making. “What? No, it does-”

“People are entitled to have emotions. Even the violent ones. That doesn’t make them bad people.”

“But how they deal with them *does*. ”

“People aren’t just *assigned* a moral judgement once and for all. Even if one had done something bad, they’re not *a monster* so long they’re sorry and try to make up for what they did and do better next time. And, well, you did apologise, didn’t you?”

“It’s not-”

“I’m not saying it’s enough, Jay. But I’m saying it’s a start, and that we’re going to help you along the way. Aren’t we, Alfie?”

“Of course we are. And from what I’ve gathered, so will Master Timothy’s friends.”

Jason stares at them, then after a few heartbeats, tears start rolling down his cheeks. He doesn’t sob, he’s by far too tense for that, but he doesn’t try to hide the fact he’s crying either, and that’s enough of a catharsis for now.

Tim would give anything to hug him at that moment, but he’s too afraid he’ll mess it all up. He allows himself to place his hand on top of Jason’s, though, the same way Alfred does. They let Jason cry for as long as he needs, and they spend the rest of the evening in comfortably shared silence.

It takes Jason a few weeks to fully come to terms with this... revelation, but he eventually does accept it. Following that, everything finally goes according to plan, and thus relatively smoothly. Tim brings up his other friends and Titans more in conversations, telling stories and introducing them by proxy to Jason, and in time Jay gets used to the thought of... people, and the idea of interacting with them at some point, and how there might actually be a future for him.

One of the biggest signs of progress is Jason asking about the Titans every so often — how they’re doing, who’s on the team these days, how the latest mission went — and agreeing to

talk to Starfire over the phone when she calls Tim while Jay's around (absolutely not something Tim planned and Star agreed to enthusiastically, no siree). But the breakthrough comes when Tim (deliberately) drops in a mention of Raven helping Cassie with the anger surges she sometimes gets because of her lasso's powers — and Jason keeps silent for a moment, looks at Tim like he *knows* (because of course he does, he's not dumb) that Tim said that purposefully, then quietly asks:

“Do you think she'd be alright with talking with me, too?”

And at that point, Tim knows that it's hook, line, sinker and that Bart owes him 5 dollars for the Bats-don't-get-therapy bet they've made.

“Give me a moment,” he responds. The chance that Raven would reject this kind of request is negligible. Still, all the way in San Francisco, Robin walks over to her and makes sure.

“Yeah, she actually hoped you'd approach her. Said she would be free to talk in the Tower if that's okay with you? I'm shipping parts, tools and maintenance supplies from the Cave next week, you could tag along. I'd show you around and-”

Jason puts his hand up to silence him, a smirk playing on his lips. “Even if I say ‘no’ now, I bet you'll find a way to manipulate me into it before weekend comes.”

Robin puffs his cheeks. “It's not manipulation! It's positive influence.”

“I should've never explained semantics to you.” Jason rolls his eyes in pretend-frustration. “Who the heck taught you to wrap people around your finger like this, anyway?”

“Bart told me I'm cute one time and the world has not known peace ever since.”

Jay snorts. “Well, he wasn't wrong.” He ruffles Robin's hair. “Give me a call before you go.”

Robin nods, his smile as wide as his jaw allows.

Six days later, almost an entire continent away, Californian Robin eagerly awaits the Batplane's arrival. Raven's sadly busy with a private matter on that day, but Tim and Jason decided to not delay anything and instead wait for her directly in San Fran, in the Tower. It seemed like a good chance to introduce him to everyone else, and Jay seemed kind of... excited, even, at the prospect. Even if he was also understandably terribly nervous.

Kon, though, isn't as enthusiastic about it.

“Are you really sure about this?”

Robin turns around immediately and looks him in the eye. There's a certain tone to those words that he *doesn't like*. Not at all.

“What are you suggesting?”

“I'm just worried about you. Wondering if you should... I know you don't— but he— “

“You’re trying to imply that I shouldn’t trust him.”

Kon looks guilty, but nods. “He’s... he’s unhinged.”

“The initial violent affect seems to be steadily wearing off.”

“I don’t think that’s what’s the problem here, R. He’s always been a feisty one, wasn’t he? What I’m saying is... You can’t fire a bullet that’s not already in the chamber.”

Tim looks him up and down critically. Unlike most days, Kon doesn’t melt under the scrutiny and actually stays firm in his opinion this time, so Tim decides to drive the point straight home.

“Where do you think *you* would be if nobody found you and busted you out of Cadmus early enough, hm?” he asks, voice hard and serious.

Kon stops halfway mid-breath, staring at Robin in a mix of horror and confusion. He sighs, rubbing the bridge of his nose in a very Tired-Bruce way, then begins explaining.

“Do you think we’re unbreakable? That every one of us would still be a straightarrow hero with a steel moral code if we were all hurt and alone? No, I can assure you, we *wouldn’t*. I’ve *been through* that before with Batman. Pain *changes* people.”

Robin sighs, reminiscing the difficult times when Bruce was lost in his misery. “And without help and support and care, the psyche is so, *so* fragile. So imagine what could happen if one is on the mercy of Lex Luthor or Ra’s Al Ghul. They could brainwash pretty much *any* hero into doing their bidding, given enough time. Does that mean we shouldn’t trust *anyone*, because everyone has a breaking point?”

Kon doesn’t answer. He has enough decency not to, given his history with Luthor and brainwashing.

“In a best-case scenario, when someone unwillingly ends up on the wrong side of history, we’re able to snap them out of it, make them see reason and begin reintegrating them into society. In a *worse* -case, they end up locked away forever, alone with their anguish. And don’t even get me started on the *worst* case scenario.”

Tim pokes his friend in the chest with a single finger, half to emphasize his point, half to remind him to inhale.

“I’m trying to make the best case scenario happen. I’m trying to *save* someone that’s a *victim*. Not a blameless one, sure, but a victim nonetheless. Isn’t that why we aim not to kill? Because we hope someone *changes*? That someone is just *misguided*? ”

“Yeah, exactly. *We* never killed anyone.”

Robin winces.

“Have you checked? Do you listen to the heartbeats of all the people you punch through walls? Do you make sure they receive adequate medical assistance after the fight? Do you

follow-up about their health once they leave the hospital?”

“...it’s never intentional! He shot people!”

“Like all people, he’s done what he had to to survive. If we hadn’t failed him before, he wouldn’t have to resort to violence.”

“How can you know that?!”

Robin falls silent, closes his eyes. It makes Kon a little worried, a little uneasy, but he doesn’t say anything to break the tense stillness.

“I can’t,” finally Tim admits quietly. “There is nothing I can use to prove my point in this matter. I cannot run a simulation, I have no historical data, nothing. If Jay ever relapses back to using excessive lethal force, I will be proven wrong, but nothing in this world can prove me *right*. So... this is the first thing in my life that I chose to trust an instinct on. And though it seems to be *working*, everyone keeps insisting I’m *mistaken*. All the people who told me that heart and intuition matter the most, that they believe I have a soul just like all of you — the same people try to push me back into my numbers the moment I act differently than they would like me to. It hurts me, honestly, way more than destroying Robin ever did.”

He looks up, weighing the options. Eventually, he decides the jab he has at the tip of his tongue could just be what can make Kon fully understand Tim’s perspective. “...And isn’t hurting me like that a little hypocritical of you?”

Kon opens his mouth like he wants to answer, but no sound comes out. He closes it, then opens again a moment later, still silent, like a fish out of water. He can’t deny Tim’s words, no matter how badly he’d like them not to be true.

“I’m sorry,” he finally says.

“I know it’s out of worry. But please, help me in my mission instead of trying to drag me away from it. Like, you know, a friend?”

Kon smiles softly. “I can do that.”

Robin hugs him. “Thank you. Now, the plane’s almost here. Can you please gather the others in the living room while I go grab him?”

Kon hesitates for a split second as if he still didn’t like the idea of Robin being left alone with Jason. “... sure.”

“And I swear,” Robin says, turning around for a moment when he’s at the door, “if you try to give him any form of shovel talk, I’ll steal B’s Kryptonite, chuck it into a spray bottle and spritz you like a misbehaving cat.”

In response, he gets a rumbling laugh that accompanies him all the way down the corridor.

Jason is already waiting for him on the landing pad once he reaches the hangar. He’s nervously looking around, shifting weight from one leg to another. It’s understandable; the

last time he was at the Tower, his intentions were explicitly hostile. It must feel weird at the very least and thus Tim tries to ease Jason's anxiety a little in the best way he knows: reiterating his perfect plan.

"Okay, so," he begins as he approaches the man, "one more time, just in case-"

"Give me a break, babybird!" Jaybird immediately retorts. Tim's been blabbering his ear off through the plane's speakers the entire way here from Gotham, so he *might* be a little tired of hearing him. "Fuck. We've been over this a million times now. It's gonna be okay! If anything goes wrong, I'll use my famous Todd charm."

Robin raises a single doubting eyebrow at him, picking up one of the boxes of gear they've brought over.

"I bet I could fight at least half of them anyway. With a bit of luck, could probably even take down your favourite Super."

"The point of the exercise is to *not* resolve to violence, Jason," Robin says, motioning for Jay to grab a bag and follow him.

"Just messin' wit ya," Jason barks out a single sarcastic laugh, catching up with him. "I'll behave, babybird."

Robin stops for a moment, then turns around to look him in the eye. "Okay, I'll bite finally. *Why* are you calling me that, exactly?"

"If I'm Jaybird, then you're babybird. Because you're a baby."

"Listen here — *technically*, **I'm** older-"

Jason leans down to talk directly into Robin's face with a smug smirk. "Baby. The babi^{est}."

He frowns. "Fuck off." Jay pulls away, laughing.

"Oh no! The baby is swearing. I have a terrible influence on you."

"Yeah, well— " Robin shrugs, putting some of the equipment he's carrying onto shelves lining the walls of the hangar. "You're the one who made me read Landis' *'The Social War'*, so -"

"You gotta know your history, babybird!"

Robin simulates a shudder to display just how terrible the experience was. "I'm glad I don't sleep or I'd probably have nightmares about how bad that book is." He walks up to the entrance to Tower's actual living spaces and gives Jason a once-over. "Anyway, are you ready?"

"Is anyone ever ready to meet a bunch of superhumans who all have valid reasons to want to beat you up?"

Robin pretends to be lost in thoughts for a brief moment. "I mean, if you're into that-"

"Oh fuck you're at that age. No, I don't want to hear about your kinks. Let's go!"

He grins in response, and they make their way towards the living room. Tim tries to avoid others, just so he can shield Jason from random encounters neither of them had prepared for, but even in a building this big it's difficult.

Strangely difficult. They run into a couple of people who seek Robin out with questions or for help, like they usually do, but then it gets... weird. Mia decides now is the perfect time to ask about the tea Tim had mentioned a month ago, Karen suddenly has some pressing scientific doubts she needs to run against Tim, and Jaimie just outright stares at them through the open door as they pass his room, under the guise of simply saying "good morning" to them.

It's endearing, though slightly annoying. But they're just humans, and he can't blame them for being... curious? Suspicious? Robin can't decide if they're simply looking for an excuse to take a peek at Jason, who's something of an urban legend now thanks to Tim's stories, or if they're just trying to not leave Robin alone with him.

Starfire is the only one who feels like she has genuine intentions — she manages to ambush them in a corridor and have an actual (though, as characteristic for her, entirely over-enthusiastic) conversation with Jason before Tim convinces her that they have to keep moving because someone is waiting for them.

"You've changed," Jason mentions in passing when they're alone again for a moment. Tim hears there's weight to those words, more than Jay probably realises.

Thus Robin stops and turns to him, then tilts his head slightly. "It's been quite some time, after all. Does it bother you?"

Jay pauses for a moment. "No," he begins, "I suppose not. Just— you're not the person I remember."

Robin's shoulders drop, but before he can reply, Jason starts backtracking.

"No, no, not like that. I mean. You're different, but it's not bad, it's— You have friends, and people look after you and—"

"... and it's like there's no place for you in my life anymore?" he asks quietly. It's apparently a common sentiment these days, and it saddens him that so many people around him have abandonment issues. He can't blame them, though, seeing how worried he himself was about revealing who he is.

Jay winces, not happy with what Tim's saying, but still nods. "Yeah. I suppose that's how it is."

"But it's not."

"Well, it *seems* like it."

“Good thing that’s not something *you’re* the judge of, then.”

“Now *that’s* pity,” Jason retorts with a sour expression. They’ve already established that his ego takes being pitied rather poorly, so Tim immediately tries to salvage the conversation.

"No, that's— psychology, I guess? Listen— I've changed, yes. But-"

Robin grabs Jason’s hands and holds them in his, very gently, carefully.

"When we were kids, I did not have the ability to care about others in the same way I do now. I not only *didn’t*, but also *couldn’t* understand what a relationship is, not really. I was... single-minded, in a way. Simple. *Simpler*, at the very least. Just young, perhaps?" He pauses for a moment, trying to come up with a better adjective, but quickly gives up in favour of continuing instead. He got his point across anyway.

“All my attention, all my time, all my love — was for you. But now—” Robin sighs wistfully, fondly remembering all of the good things in his life so far. "I've *grown*. Expanded my worldview. It’s the case for everybody, sure, but for me, it’s quite *literal*. I now have more than just the chat console that B gave me or the jingles I’ve made for A or the voice I got thanks to you. I have plenty of bodies, a plethora of terminals to communicate through and the processing power of the entire BatCave at my disposal. I’m not going to run out of time for my friends, my *family* anytime soon.”

Tim falls silent for a moment. Tries to translate his thoughts from binary to feelings, which he always finds himself struggling to do.

“Love must be practiced, like reading and fighting and playing the piano. In my case, it started with you. I don’t know how it was for you, but in the time we’ve been apart, I’ve met plenty of other people, and many of them became important to me. And it’s not that there’s no place for you in my life anymore, you’re just... not the only person that gets that privilege nowadays. Because, you see, our capacity for love increases with every person we cross paths with. No matter how many people I become close with, there’s always going to be a place in my life for everyone and anyone I hold dear, and that includes — and quite possibly will *always* include — you.”

There’s stunned silence between them. Just like the last time Tim was this... emotional with him, when he told Jason he’s more important than the entire Gotham back in Jaybird’s Robin days. Jason reacts in much the same way as he did then, too: chuckles awkwardly and looks away, blushing *ever-so-slightly*.

"Did you practice that speech a lot?" he snarks, trying to cover up his embarrassment.

He forgets Tim is one of the few people who can keep up with his wit. He's grown up with it, after all.

"What do you think I do when everyone's asleep? Of course I have a monologue for every occasion."

“Well, now I feel like *I’m* the uncultured one.”

“Your poor poetic soul!” Tim teases. “Apparently you’ve changed, too.”

“For the worse,” Jason retorts without a second thought, and his tone makes it clear he means more than just the immediate context. Robin frowns.

“Change has no moral value beyond what we make of it. And even if it had, titanium and silicon-” he gestures to the entirety of his mechanical body, “-care not for the petty concerns of human morality.”

Jason can’t help but whistle, impressed. “You overdramatic little shit.”

“You don’t get to judge me for that, drama queen.”

“Touché.”

Tim waits a moment, then when the conversation doesn’t pick up again, gestures towards the next door they were heading for. Jason stays still at first, as if hesitating, but eventually nods and they continue down the hall. It is only right before their final destination that he speaks up.

“You know, I think it’s mutual.”

“What is?”

“I think I grew some, too. I think you’re the one that made me grow.”

Tim’s pretty sure his heart would flutter if he had one.

His friends, his three favourite superhumans in the entire world, are waiting for them right where he wanted them, assembled dutifully by Kon. He and Cassie look understandably tense, and when Tim walks in it looks like they’ve just had a lull in a rather uncomfortable conversation. Bart, on the other hand, is hanging around focused solely on something only his mind can perceive at the moment and doesn’t snap back into the shared reality until Jason and Robin are only a few feet away.

There’s a little bit of silence, which Tim breaks with the tested and true method of smiling and waving awkwardly. Then he points to Jay.

“This is Jason,” he introduces him, for formality’s sake. Bart’s eyes glimmer with excitement and he starts to flap his hands to process that emotion. Others react way less enthusiastically: Kon nods a welcome, which given his earlier concerns is a good sign, but Cassie just crosses her arms on her chest. Tim knows it’s because she cares about him, because she’s worried like Kon is, but still doesn’t appreciate the negativity.

“This is Cassie, the only wielder of common sense in this team,” he says, his tone suggesting for her to drop the prickly act. She grunts and shrugs, her shoulders relaxing a little bit, but she remains closed off.

Jason acknowledges her with a nod. "Hey there, knock-off Wonder Woman."

She raises an eyebrow, then looks at Tim, a little disgruntled. "You said he's acting better now."

"This *is* his version of nice. I did my best to potty-train him but I'm not a miracle worker," Tim says, then sticks his tongue out at Jay, who flashes him a grin in response.

"Hey, she's my favourite superhero, that's a compliment!" he attempts to defend himself. Cassie just rolls her eyes.

"*Anyway*, this is Bart," Tim picks up, pointing at Impulse, "who is somehow both the greatest genius and the biggest idiot I know."

Bart takes the little tease in stride, then inhales deeply, like he forgot to breathe up until this point and extends his hand toward Jason. He hesitates a bit, but eventually shakes it and doesn't even try to crush it.

"The speedster that can be bribed with cookies, ye, I remember you mentioning him."

Bart seems positively amused by the snide remark, which is a good sign, so Tim turns towards the last person.

"And this is Kon, my emotional support Kryptonian."

Jason looks Superboy up and down with raised eyebrows and a growing smirk. "Yeah that checks out, he **does** look like a himbo."

"I'm not sure if I should be offended by that," Kon says, frowning, looking to Robin for some explanation. Robin just shrugs, and it coaxes a brief huff of laughter from Jason.

"Which just proves my point, Boy of Steel."

There's a moment of tense silence between them that Tim isn't sure if he even *should* try to defuse, but apparently Bart is having none of it.

"Board games, anyone?" he yells excitedly from across the room, waving a box of Monopoly at them, having grabbed it in the single second he was away. Weirdly enough, it's Jason's turn to look towards Robin for reassurance, his ears slightly red.

"I actually prefer cards. Maybe Bastard Brag? It's-" he starts, but he's interrupted by Cassie snorting, then her and Kon dissolving into a fit of giggles. For a moment he's frowning, distrustful, suspecting they're making fun of him.

Robin raises his hand to grab his attention.

"We don't play card games. Not with me, at least."

Jason squints, then it dawns him. "You count the cards."

“I count the cards.”

“You little shit.”

“I can’t help it! Anyway, let’s stick to things with an element of randomness,” he says motioning to the box Bart is now pretty much rattling at them impatiently.

“I can go grab Firefly instead?” The speedster runs up to them, already holding both games in his hands, but it doesn’t change Jay’s expression of slight discomfort.

“I just... haven’t played board games in a while,” he says quietly. He’s rubbing the back of his neck, which Tim recognizes as the new version of *nervously fiddling with his fingers*.

“That’s okay, Bart loves to explain the rules.” Robin grabs Jason’s hand and grins, trying to herd all of them towards the sofas. “Off-mission, we have maybe one brain cell between the four of us, anyway. You’re going to do just fine.”

Jay does more than fine. He absolutely *decimates* them in Monopoly. He’s ruthless and decisive and shrewd with his investments so much that Bart accuses Tim of skewing the bank records in Jason’s favour at some point. Their little squabble is defused by Kon ordering pizza.

They go through three more games, laughing and eating junk (Jason freaks out a bit when he sees Robin sipping motor oil), and talk till late at night. Despite all the initial tension and their differences, it feels like they’ve known each other forever. It might be because of how much Tim had told his friends about Jason, but it might also be the fabled Todd charm. Whatever it is, Jason’s *finally* acting like the teenager he still very much is, and that’s all Tim wanted.

The next morning, Raven comes around just like she promised she would. When Jay approaches her on his own instead of being defensive, Tim feels his metaphorical heart grow a couple of sizes with how happy it makes him.

Chapter End Notes

Refs and memes in this chapter:

[“Wouldn’t you like to know, weatherboy.”](#)
[catharsis](#)

[“An Entirely New Feature of a Thrilling Novel!: Entitled, The Social War of the Year 1900; Or, Conspirators and Lovers!”, by Simon Mohler Landis](#) - known as one of the worst novels ever written

[“Our capacity for love increases with each person we cross paths with throughout our lives”](#) (yay for a title drop!)

Theme song for this chapter: [“Seventeen” from the Heathers musical](#)

Chapter 11

Chapter Notes

Trigger warnings for this chapter: Canon-typical violence, interactions that can be interpreted as bullying, guilt, panic attacks (mentioned/implied), injuries

The theme for the chapter is a quote from my anthropology professor:
“Both love and hate are held in the same place — close enough that you can hear the other person’s heartbeat.”

Also: Timezone denial 2.0. Uno reverse card 2.0.

For reference, Kon in this fic is an amalgamation of every Kon to have existed and as such exists in a quantum state of both wearing lazy S t-shirts AND his over-the-top punk 90s outfits, at the same time.

See the end of the chapter for [more notes](#)

Humans would probably call it a dance, the push and pull of how Titans feel about Jason, and how Jason feels about them. But to Tim, this is more like a game of Twister. A terribly complex, 5-dimensional game of emotional Twister and if he makes a wrong call, everyone will fall over. So, you know. No pressure.

Still, Tim perseveres. He's nothing if not persistent.

Given how well the first meeting went, it's easy to convince Jay to visit more often and he becomes a regular guest. There's still tension, though, on both sides — between his tea with Alfred and board- and video-games with the teen heroes, Jason continues to keep an iron grip on a good part of Gotham's underbelly and it *shows*. Sometimes he appears covered in bruises or with a bandaged shoulder and brags that the other guys look *way worse*; sometimes when asked what he's been up to, his face darkens and he changes the topic, and Tim later finds out about another trafficking ring that Red Hood is trying to bust; sometimes he outright says he can't come because he's busy gathering intel from goons or carrying out a raid on enemy territory and, well, their heroic hearts can't help but wince at the thought.

Despite the ebb and flow, and the difficulty of the task at hand, there is progress to Jason's resocialization. It's a laboured but steady process, slowly inching forward. To the untrained eye at least. Tim knows that it is mostly achieved in separated, breakthrough moments.

One of such moments is when they're casually enjoying a Thursday afternoon, huddled in the living room over a seven-thousand-piece puzzle. It's tedious work, because though most people present are able to *think* really fast, keeping track of the individual pieces proves to be a challenge for all of them. They've been at it for a good couple of hours, undeterred, when suddenly Robin perks up.

“Earthquake in Lahore, Pakistan,” he says, putting down the piece he’s holding. “Not on the news yet, literally happening at the moment, picked it up from Earthquake Network and social media. If we go now, we should be among the first responders.”

“Alright, all hands on deck then!” Cassie agrees, standing up. “I’ll notify other Titans on stand-by. Suit up and meet me in the hangar in five.”

Everyone nods, getting up to leave, too.

“Sorry, Jay!” Robin says with an apologetic shrug.

“Nah, I get it. Priorities.”

“Batplane is free if you wanna go back to Gotham on your own. It might take a while for us to get back.”

Jason waves him off dismissively. “It’s fine. Focus on your mission.”

When they leave the room, he’s still sitting on the sofa, twirling a puzzle piece in his fingers contemplatively.

When they walk on board their plane, Jason’s already there, leaning onto one of the chairs and looking sort of bored.

“What are you doing here?” Cassie immediately asks since she’s the one at the front of the group, while the rest of them spills in around her, surprised about the hold-up. Robin tilts his head, confused for a moment.

“I know y’all don’t trust me enough to turn your unguarded backs to me in a fight, but this is disaster relief, not fighting, right?” Jay says, putting his hands up in the air defensively. “You said *all hands on deck*. I’ve got two, perfectly functional.”

She looks him up and down. Takes a glance over at Robin, but he does nothing, says nothing (knows that his opinion would be terribly biased), so she looks over to the rest of the team. Slowly, one by one, they agree to the proposition in various ways — a shrug, a nod, a smile... until Cassie’s eyes rest on Kon. He hesitates for a moment, then finally also nods, though with a sour expression.

Wonder Girl reciprocates the gesture and motions for Jay to follow her. “Let’s get you geared up, then. What are you gonna need?” she asks, walking towards the backup/emergency equipment lockers in the back of the plane. Everyone else settles into their seats, preparing for lift-off.

Jason grins and cracks his knuckles, following her. “A grappling gun, an earpiece hooked up to your frequencies and a rebreather at the minimum,” he starts listing off and Cassie rummages through the case, handing him the mentioned items as she finds them. “I’ll probably need a first aid kit for the victims, yeah? What else... heat vision would be nice, make it easier to find people. A length of rope always comes in handy, too. And some body armor I guess, just in case we encounter something hostile?”

Cassie pauses, considering her options. “And a weapon, then?” she suggests tentatively.

He shrugs. “Didn’t think you’d be comfortable giving me one.”

Wonder Girl looks at him for a moment, frowning. *Thinking*. “And if we were....?”

“I don’t suppose you have any guns laying around?”

“We don’t.”

“Then I’m good with just my knife.” Jay reaches down and pulls a rather long kris out the top of one of his high combat boots.

“You had a knife on you the entire time?” she asks indignantly, throat a little tight with surprise. Everyone looks over their shoulders to stare back at them when they hear that, but Jason doesn’t seem fazed by the reaction.

“You didn’t?” he just asks, as if it was the most obvious thing to do.

“I don’t *need* one.”

“Well, I don’t have superpowers,” he points out, hiding the knife in his boot again. “*And* I grew up in Gotham.”

“... fair.”

Tim decides to cut the slightly awkward conversation short. “Everyone, sit your asses down and put on the seatbelts,” Robin commands, having connected to the plane’s systems, engines whirling loudly already. “We’re about to take off for Punjab.”

By the time they arrive at their destination several hours later, they have more info on what happened since news stations start broadcasting the event. By the looks of it, Lahore is in rather bad shape. The tremors not only damaged buildings, but also loosened the banks of the Ravi river, making it flood several neighbourhoods. But, hey. It could be worse. It could be a more powerful earthquake than the *relatively tame* 6.5 magnitude that it was.

They’re reminded that human tragedy and death are uncomfortably par for the course for heroes.

They squash that uneasy feeling and get to work. Robin gets in touch with the local authorities so they can work undisturbed, in tandem with the emergency responders of the region. Over the comms, he divides the team into smaller squads — making sure to have at least one sensible person in each group — so that they cover more ground faster.

Then it’s just listening in for frightened calls for help, looking for survivors, lifting debris, carrying people to safety and applying first aid.

Well, most of the time. Sometimes they run into problems. Like when the man they’ve just rescued vehemently refuses to be led towards an emergency gathering point, talking at them frantically, fast and difficult to understand.

“Gimme a second, I’ll get Rob to translate-” Kon begins, but Jason cuts him off.

“He says he had five other people with him. Asked us to find them.”

Kon raises his eyebrows. “You understand him?”

“Bats forced every one of us to learn like, seven different languages,” Jay says, shrugging dismissively, “and Urdu was one of them.”

Superboy frowns.

“This isn’t Urdu.” Kon would’ve understood it if it was, after all. He knows many languages himself, thanks to Cadmus.

“Some kind of local variation then, close enough for me.” Jason doesn’t seem bothered by the implied accusation. He says something to the man, slowly and brokenly, but it appears to get the point across. “It’s probably a pidgin with Punjabi. Or Hindi, gotta be a diaspora here,” he adds off-handedly.

But Kon’s stern gaze doesn’t falter no matter how much Jason ignores him, so he finally looks him in the eye with a frown of his own. “I trained in the Himalayas at one point. This is a similar dialect.” His tone comes off as slightly irritated at having to reveal that, though.

Ignoring Kon glaring at him, as if that can force more explanations out of him, Jason turns to the man, attention fully on what he’s trying to convey. He listens for a moment then cracks his neck and makes a few steps away.

“Think and do whatever ya want,” he says towards Superboy over his shoulder, “I’m going to go and try to save a couple of kids, with or without ya.” He then heads in the direction he was pointed to without waiting for anyone else to join him.

Kon is the first one to follow, even despite their little squabble. Without a word, he lifts a big slab of concrete that Jason has been trying to get under, with no luck. Equally silently, Jason slips under it and gets a small girl — barely maybe ten years old, tiny and terrified — out from the tight crevice underneath.

After that, everyone else moves too and they get the man’s (supposed?) family to safety in no time. The reassuring smile Jason gives to each kid they subsequently pull out of the water or from under fallen buildings makes Superboy think that he can’t be *that* bad, whatever he’s hiding.

Robin, taking a peek through the drones he’s deployed and is using to scan the surroundings for victims, absolutely agrees with that sentiment.

They stay on the site for five days straight and come back to San Francisco absolutely exhausted and filthy, but with a sense of accomplishment. Some of them had argued for the need to stay longer, but at that point, even superheroes are at their limits; it’s a struggle to keep Impulse up, for example, the food so desperately needed to sustain a speedster being a

tight resource in a disaster region. And Tim definitely refuses to let the team split up, so they take course towards home. The area is mostly under control anyway and at this point, by all calculations, anyone they haven't found yet was already dead. They did what they could and the rest lays in the hands of the locals.

All of them — except Robin, that is — dream of nothing else but to shower and face-plant on their beds (in any order, honestly), and that's exactly what they do. When Tim lands their jet in the hangar, everyone heads to their rooms in silent understanding that debriefing will happen once everyone is rested. The only exception is Bart, who's already fast asleep and therefore gets carried to his room by a slightly limping but determined Jason.

Once the snoring speedster is safely tucked into bed, Jay sighs, quietly closing the door behind him.

"You okay?" Robin asks, standing just beyond the doorframe. Out of all of them, Jaybird is the most human, and therefore the most squishy. But he's also fiercely independent and stubborn as an ox, so Tim's pretty sure he'd hide any injury he might have; thus the limping worries him.

Jason smiles tiredly and gives him a thumbs-up as the only answer. Tim doesn't want to press further; maybe his friend simply doesn't feel safe enough to lick his wounds at the Tower just yet. He's about to offer to help Jaybird onto the Batplane to get him back home, hoping to convince Jay to let him do a check-up on him, but Jason just stumbles into the living room and conks out on the sofa.

Robin stares at the scene for a moment, then smiles and sits down on the floor nearby. He stays with Jason for a long time, taking in the sight and the feeling that fills him. The Tower is quiet and still, again, with Jason inside — though this time Tim's not cut off by a storm, and Jason is here as an ally and friend instead. It is a very real, very physical sign of all the *progress* they've all made.

Surprisingly enough, despite being probably the last to fall asleep, Jason is the first to wake up. Maybe it's because Bats operate on little sleep on the regular, maybe it's the changes the Lazarus Pit made to his body (the influence the Pit had on Jay's biology is, sadly, undeniable). The fact is, he's already in the kitchen, unpacking the groceries Tim had ordered in the meantime — anticipating everyone's increased appetite after a mission like that one — before anyone else even sets foot outside of their room.

Tim doesn't bother him, beyond periodically pointing out where a specific pot or pan is kept, suggesting adding a spice or providing hints about their other teammates' favourite flavours and dishes. It feels more natural this way, somehow, like the good old days; Tim hanging around idly, providing guidance and support while Jason does his thing.

It only changes when Cassie sleepily drags herself into the kitchen, hair sticking in weird directions, an oversized T-shirt hanging off her left shoulder. She greets them, grabs herself a cup of orange juice and loiters aimlessly for a moment before giving Robin *a look*. He nods in silent agreement, then heads for the exit under the guise of checking up on Bart (it's only

partially an excuse; Bart *does* sometimes require a glucose drip to headstart his recovery when he overworks himself like this).

He doesn't have anything against them speaking without him, either, even when it's about the more... *tense* topics. If he's the semi-unofficial leader of the team, Cassie's definitely his second-in-command and if she wants a word with Jason alone, he will trust her.

Cassie gives Jason maybe 30 seconds after Robin leaves — just about enough for him to not have three different vegetables in his hands and be at risk of dropping them if he spooks — before speaking up.

"You don't have to hide it, you know."

Her words are ignored for a moment as Jason finishes up cutting a bell pepper and adds it to the pot.

"I can't tell you the recipe, it's Agent A's secret," he says as he stirs and tastes the stew, "and I fear that man more than anyone else in this world."

"You know what I mean, Jason." Cassie leans on the counter next to him and sniffs the pot. The smell must be satisfying because she murmurs in approval.

"Pretend that I don't." Jay adds salt and a dozen other spices then stirs again.

"You're not quite proud of whatever it is that you did in the Himalayas. I get that. But every one of us has some skeletons in the closet."

"I see. Tim taught y'all his *best* habits." A cheeky smirk plays on his lips, but his tone is just a tad too bitter, a tad too angry to match the teasing expression. "Nothing builds trust like some eavesdropping, huh?"

Cassie rolls her eyes. "Stalking is how Bats show love, right?"

"I am not a Bat," he hisses out. "And you definitely aren't, either."

"Well, Titans show love by talking shit out, so listen—" She looks away, granting him the slight solace of not having to keep eye contact as she continues. "Nobody's going to judge you for your time in Nanda Parbat, even if it has to do with the League of Assassins— don't look at me like that, Tim didn't tell me anything, but you mentioned the Lazarus Pit and it wasn't that hard to figure it out once I had all the clues— anyway, not gonna judge you more for that than for your Gotham-rebellious-phase fuck-ups, and I think we're pretty chill with those by now."

Jason regards her in silence for a few moments.

"I'm not a Titan," he says quietly, refocusing on the meal he's preparing.

She shrugs. "If you say so."

As if on a cue, Bart barges into the kitchen, pushing Cassie away. When he stops being a blur, he already has a spoon in his hand, ready to dip in it the steaming stew.

“No!” Jason smacks the hand away then puts a lid on the pot with a loud clunk. “Jesus, speedsters are *insufferable* around food.”

“Not my fault you’re so good at it! The entire place smells amazing!”

"Ain't an invitation! I'll call ya when it's done."

"I'm not good with waiting!"

"Promise, it's worth it."

Bart grumbles, but puts the spoon down and disappears out the door. Cassie gives Jason one last glance and a smile, then follows the speedster.

The promise Jason made is kept and fulfilled tenfold. While nobody ever complained about eating takeout or Robin’s cooking (because he was the only one who had the time and patience to cook), nothing really compares to the meal Jay makes. And if he notices that and decides to buy his way into their hearts via homemade pastries and impeccable Hungarian goulash, well, none of them mind.

(If Tim can weaponize cuteness, then Jason can weaponize culinary arts.)

Their kitchen isn’t prepared to handle it, though. Not at first. The equipment is... well, to call it college-dorm-level would be an overstatement, it isn’t *that* bare. But it certainly doesn’t satisfy Jason’s ever-increasing need for very specific equipment and ingredients. Tim can understand it — the desire to broaden your horizons, have more possibilities, hone your skills. So he buys new appliances and expands the range of what’s in the grocery orders without any doubt that it’ll only be for the benefit of the team. The fact that he pays for it all with Bruce’s money, of course, only makes it all the sweeter of a deal for Jason’s inner brat.

It doesn't take long before people start suggesting, then outright asking for Jason to come over, to stay longer, hoping that he'll cook. He's uncomfortable at first — Tim knows him too well to not notice the slight waver in his voice when he smugly accepts all the praise and attention, knows him too well not to understand Jason doesn't believe a single word of it; at least at first.

But every time Gar does his little happy post-great-food dance over a plate he's practically licked clean, every time Bart *begs* for another batch of cookies because once he’s tasted Jason’s nothing store-bought can compare, every time Jaimie compliments him on his unique spice mixes... every time is another tiny dent in Jason's walls of distrust.

And so he stays. Longer and more often, gradually. Opens up to the Titans. Until he's more in San Fran than in Gotham, until he's more of a guest in the Bowery than in the Tower.

Because of that, Tim asks him one afternoon: "Aren't you worried about your territory?"

He wanted to throw it in nonchalantly at a good time, so it would seem natural. But no opportunity ever came so he does it while they're going over clues about some suspicious magical activity in the Takht-e Soleyman mountain range in Iran. It wouldn't be anything to worry about if it wasn't so close to Bialya, which is a country that has given them more than enough trouble already.

Jason doesn't even spare him a glance though, focused on the info on the screen in his hand. "Why would I be? You're keeping an eye on it for me. Still got my men there, too, and they know what to do. If they can't handle me not holding their hands at all times, then good riddance."

"Won't they feel like you've abandoned them? Won't people want to take over your-"

Jason puts the tablet he was reading off of down and looks at Robin with a sour expression. "Are you *trying* to make me *leave*?" he asks, voice dead serious.

"No!" Tim responds immediately, opening his eyes wide and shaking his head vigorously. "I just... don't want you to give up your goals. I know Gotham is very important to you."

"Don't worry then, Gotham's under control." He ruffles Robin's hair. "Besides, I got another very important thing I wanna protect, and I reckon right now it needs more of my attention than the Crime Alley."

Robin tilts his head in a display of poorly contained curiosity. "Oh? What is it?"

Jason takes his sweet time responding, though by the smug grin on his face Tim knows it's not trying to avoid answering, just stalling for dramatic effect. Finally, Jay makes a wide sweep around the room with his arm and when it passes over Robin, says:

"Y'all."

And Tim can't sing, not without sounding like a knock-off Vocaloid, but his soul does it silently anyway.

He doesn't share that conversation with anyone — privacy! — but ever since Jason admitted to caring about them, Tim notices that the others seem to catch on to that sentiment, too. Jason does indeed have a rustic kind of charm when he wants to and he makes full use of it.

There's only one person who seems unaffected by it — Kon. Tim suspects it's because of his initial doubts about Jay's stability, maybe. They've been metaphorically head-butting from the moment they've met, but it's never gotten in the way.

Until now.

Somehow the more other Titans like Jason, the less Kon can stand him. Cassie explains to Tim that it's just *boys being boys*, trying to set a hierarchy between them, so he doesn't interfere. Maybe he should've, he thinks later.

It starts pretty innocently — with Jay shoulder-checking Kon in the corridor; you'd expect a Kryptonian to not even budge, but taken by surprise, Kon smacks against the wall with a grunt of shock and Jason laughs, his usual snark ringing in the sound. Tim supposes it's his way of trying to bond, the only way he knows (except for food and protectiveness, both of which failed to work with Kon), rowdy and physical.

(Kon doesn't let himself be surprised ever again, so when Jay tries to push him once more, he dislocates his shoulder by hitting the rock-solid muscle and it's Superboy who grins this time.)

As per Cassie's advice, Tim gives them time and space to sort it out themselves. It does seem... *rough* and *mean*, but... innocuous enough. Reminds Tim of the pranks Jay and him used to pull on Bruce, and sometimes Dick, back in the day.

But unlike the pranks, it slowly escalates out of control.

When Kon's doing a snack run for everybody, he casually *forgets* to get anything for Jason. Feeling bad for Jay, Bart agrees to share some of his ice cream, but it turns out the only portion left in the fridge is frozen solid (and Kon's lips are still slightly blue from frost breath). As retaliation, for the next week, Jason makes extra-spicy dinners, knowing full well that Kon can't handle heat in his food (Kryptonians apparently hadn't evolved the ability to eat hot peppers as humans had). Subsequently, Jason finds himself walking into invisible forcefields blocking the doorways every so often when Kon's around, but he can't prove anything, so Kon's room becomes *equally inexplicably* thoroughly booby-trapped with glitter bombs.

They continue like that for over a month, until a critical mass of tension is reached.

Kon does laundry and *accidentally* shrinks half of the shirts Jason keeps at the Tower three sizes down (so much that even Robin has issues fitting in them). It's a big hit, given Jay's ingrained fear of resource scarcity, but he takes it in stride, brushes it off quickly and snarkily remarks that he'll just steal *someone else's* shirts as needed. (People laugh about it. Except Kon.)

It also prompts Beast Boy and Bumblebee to petition Tim to finally get Jay a proper mission outfit (*even Kon had moved past using T-shirts as a hero suit*, Gar argues and, well, he has a point). And Tim agrees. Because why not? Everything seems like it's a good idea. Jason never brings his equipment (except for the knife, of course, he never parts with it) to the Tower like he's afraid they would stop trusting him if he did, like he's afraid he's not allowed to. So it's the perfect way to show him that it's not the case, that he's welcomed.

Tim designs and produces something tailored just for Jay and his preferences — so kevlar, plenty of pockets and hidden compartments, some leather and lots of black and red — though makes an effort to make it... match the rest of the team. Make it look less *Gotham crime lord* and more... Titan.

That is when apparently something *snaps* in Kon and he crosses a line that should've never been even touched. It all explodes in their faces within the blink of an eye.

It's a beautiful Saturday evening and they've spent the majority of it trying to keep Bart out of the kitchen because Jason promised them a grand dinner and needed peace. He insisted there's no reason for the gesture, but they all know it's to celebrate his first *real* mission (in a *real* suit) out with the Titans — just gathering intel in the Saudi-Arabian region of Ha'il (a follow-up for the clues he and Tim had analyzed), but still an obviously important milestone. Especially since they got all the info they needed and it was one of the rare missions where everything went smooth (except maybe for the extensive repairs Robin will need to get done later tonight, but that's usually just part of the plan at this point).

Finally, after an excruciatingly long wait during which the Tower slowly fills up with an amazing aroma of Indian spices (mild ones this time, Jay swore), they're called to the dining room. When everyone's seated, Jason walks in with a huge pot of steaming dal tadka, a big plate of fried rice and a precariously balanced tower of glasses filled with what seems like mango lassi. There's even the traditional mug of high-end motor oil on the tray, just for Robin. It's honestly a miracle he manages to carry it all at once, so Tim rushes to help him set it down on the table while others shower him with praise.

Jason basks in the attention — such a different reaction than in the beginning and it warms Tim's heart — until Kon opens his mouth.

“Must be nice to get complimented for nothing,” he says with a scowl. Everyone falls silent. Many of them frown in disapproval, but Kon seems to be in a particularly foul mood, because he doesn't stop. “Though stealing the spotlight for what's mostly *Tim's* achievement is a little phoney even for *you*. ”

It boggles Tim that even with all his reassurance, they still can't seem to get over the feeling of being left behind and—

Oh, right. *Feeling*. It's not *knowing*, it's **feeling**, two very different things. One of which Tim has very little experience dealing with because usually, someone else handles it for him. Usually, the one to take care of emotional issues he encounters is *Kon* — who's currently expressing his anger about getting (as Kon must interpret it) antagonised by Jay for no apparent reason. His anger about people accepting someone so outwardly *unrepentant* about his past (even if Tim knows how much guilt Jay hides). But probably most importantly, his anger about the fact that the roles Jay seems to be taking among the Titans — Big Buff Funny Guy, Tim's Bestie, Melee Fighter — are encroaching on Kon's niches.

And he's blinded by that anger so badly that he's riling up the person that's still very much recovering from a case of *violent outbursts of uncontrolled rage*.

Fuck.

“And all this food,” Kon continues, wholly unaware of Tim's rapidly increasing levels of distress. “You think it'll make everyone love you. But tell me, who paid for the ingredients and equipment and everything?”

“The same person who paid for the shirt on your back, asshole,” Jason hisses out through his teeth, pointing to Robin.

At that point, Cassie's already on her feet, ready to try to separate the arguing boys. But the moment she tries to take a step towards them, she is stopped by Kon's TTK.

"Superboy," she calls out, frowning, "*Enough.*"

"No." He doesn't even spare her a glance, locked in a staring contest with Jason. "Somebody has to take him down a peg."

Meanwhile, Robin looks to Raven, who's hanging back a safe distance away, but she also shakes her head. If they don't ask for her help, she won't do anything, that's her policy. Tim understands and accepts it, but has never hated it so much before.

If not her, then what can stop them at that point? Kon already made up his mind and won't back out without a fight. That's the last thing Tim wants to do, now or ever. And even if they *do* stop them now, it'll probably come back to bite their asses again, bloated tenfold and at an even worse time.

"I still have my own money from back when I did modelling," Kon replies to Jay, who wrinkles his nose like he always does at the mention of "*stupid rich celebrities*", which he apparently now counts Kon as. "You? You're just a leech, trying to prop yourself up off of other people's backs."

Tim can practically *see* red flood Jason's vision, memories of being called *Bruce's charity case* and *street trash*, both by Bristol high-brow socialites and Gotham journalists alike, flashing before Jay's eyes.

Jason walks around the table, every muscle stiff with barely-contained rage, and tries to shove Kon in an obvious challenge. Even though Superboy remains unmoved, Jay still snarls and barks out:

"Ya wanna go, punk?"

Kon raises his eyebrows, a smug smirk playing on his lips. "Do you have a death wish? You realize who you're talking to, right?"

"A failed lab experiment, apparently, because you don't seem to have any balls," Jason sneers, crossing arms on his chest. It must hit Kon where it hurts, because he scowls.

"This is your last chance to back off," he says, raising his chin and squaring his shoulders.

"Crime Alley don't raise no quitters, jackass." Jason cracks his knuckles menacingly. "What, ya too scared to put your money where your mouth is? Big boy is all bark no bite?"

Kon scoffs. "Training room. Now. I'll show you *exactly* how hard I can bite."

Jay grins like he's already won and starts walking, Kon following immediately.

Tim looks to Cassie, trying to plead for help, to make her make them *stop*. She just shakes her head. *You can't separate them now*, she seems to be saying, *they have to figure it out on their own*. Tim doesn't *want* to leave it for them to figure it out! But even Koriand'r — kind

Kori, caring Kori, always quick to end arguments among her teammates — while unhappy about the situation, doesn't look like she'll interfere. She, and many others (their faces looking half interested, half scared), go after Jason and Kon, wanting to witness the fight.

Tim's on his own with this one. Again.

Robin's shoulders slump like he's just lost *everything*, but nobody notices.

The two men stand facing each other at the opposite ends of the arena, glaring. Kon's posture is casually open, he's just confidently cracking his neck, while Jason already holds fists up in a guarded stance, light on his feet. The rest of the Titans — nearly all of them — line the edges of the room, standing along the walls, waiting for what feels like the most important fight to ever take place in this building, probably.

Despite Kon being obviously stronger and faster than Jay, and practically invulnerable too, Tim calculates that the odds of who will win this fight aren't all that one-sided.

You see, Jason has four major advantages to work off of:

One, they've agreed on not using weapons, gadgets or special powers ("Just pure muscle, let's settle this like men," Jay said and Kon took the bait like a damn child), so Kon can't just use laser-eyes or TTK for an easy win.

Two, the room is fairly small compared to the vast battlefield that Kon's used to and he'll be trying not to damage the building too much, so he'll have to hold back.

Three, while Kon's very intelligent, he's not much of a tactician — his usual course of action in a fight is either "punch things until they submit" or "follow Tim's plan", both of which are unusable in this scenario.

The fourth, most important advantage is that Kon *underestimates Jason*. Jay might not be a *superhuman*, but he's not a normal human either. His body, already superiorly trained by Gotham's ruthless streets and then Batman himself, got enhanced by the Lazarus Pit, and his mind and instincts are razor-sharp, honed weapons. Both Batman and Robin experienced how deadly he can be, first-hand, and soon enough Kon will realise that too.

After giving his shoulder one last warm-up stretch, Kon simply charges at Jason. Not at his full super-speed, no, that'd be against the rules they've set, but still fast. Crosses the room in a heartbeat and aims a fist at Jay's jaw, with a smile saying he wanted to do this for a *long* time.

Jason evades it with ease, simply tilting his torso sideways. And sure, the move is telegraphed all over Kon's posture and behaviour if you know what to look for, even despite the speed. But that just seems... *too easy* of a dodge.

Still, undeterred by the miss, Kon ducks down into a crouch and tries to sweep his opponent off his feet. That's when Tim realises that he *knows* that sequence. It's a Robin staple, after

all.

A staple he taught while tutoring Young Justice, Superboy included, in martial arts.

A staple he himself learned from watching Batman while he was *training Jason*.

Kon's *so screwed* if he wants to rely on Tim's tactics and he doesn't even know it, Tim thinks with rasing dread. Meanwhile, Jay simply lifts one leg just at the right moment to avoid Kon's foot entirely.

Superboy still decides to follow his plan even after two misses; springs up and tries to deliver an uppercut, but Jason leans his upper body out of danger with familiar precision. Kon leaps back, gives himself some distance to think. A frown, then understanding creeps up his face as Jason smirks.

It only angers him further.

He goes in with another punch, one driven on instinct alone this time, so Jason actually has to put in effort not to get hit. Kon follows his own swing, spins and adds even more force to his movement, attempting to land a backhand strike instead when the first one doesn't reach its target. Jay feints to the side, outside of the line of attack, then dives right back in after the punch misses, in one swift, fluid motion. He hits Kon square on the sternum, pushing the air out of him along with a quiet gasp of shock.

Jaybird smirks again, and Kon takes it as a cue to put up his arms in a guard. Even with that, when Jason's leg connects with his body, it pushes him back and throws him off balance; most of Jason's muscle is in his thighs, after all, and he kicks hard like a horse.

It causes no pain, though, even without TTK. Kon's not called **Superboy** for nothing.

Still, using the slight moment of distraction, Jay slides around Kon with the grace of a deadly snake and puts him into a sleeper hold. He's not strong enough to *really* choke Superboy, but it's not a position Kon wants to be in regardless.

Sadly for Jason, Tim had also taught Kon the proper way to get out of that kinda hold: grab the aggressor's arm, cause them pain so the hold loosens up a little bit, then duck under the crook of their elbow and preferably turn the tide on them by slipping behind their back with the offending arm in a lock of your own.

Kon's angry, so he does every step of that with extra passion. His fingers press into the meat of Jason's arms so deep that they will *definitely* leave bruises. That's not enough to make him ease the hold, though, so Kon strains his neck a bit and puts his jaw tight around Jason's flexed bicep, then *bites down*.

Surprisingly, despite the loud scream of pain that escapes his lips and the clear teeth-shaped holes in his sleeve, Jason doesn't let go of Superboy. But the split second when his muscles spasm is enough for Kon. He flips them around and bends Jason over via the leverage of an armlock. Then, in a surge of pettiness, Kon kicks the back of Jason's legs, forcing him to *kneel*.

What he doesn't realize though, is that Gothamites are a very proud bunch. The last thing Jason wants is to be restrained and on his knees. So when Jay helps gravity instead of resisting it, falling down *and forwards*, dragging Kon with him in an impressive feat of core muscle strength, Kon stupidly *lets him*. He gets flipped over and flops against the floor like a ragdoll, breath once again beaten out of him.

Jason tries to hastily clamber up onto his feet, but Kon grabs his ankle and pulls him back down for a round of good old ground-level wrestling. They tumble around for a moment until finally, Superboy comes out on top. He gets a few good punches in (everyone hears the crack of Jason's nose after the third strike, sees the blood on Kon's knuckles), but then Jason forgoes all chivalry he might've had up to that point and knees him in the groin.

Kon rolls off of Jason with a poorly suppressed whine of pain as all the other male Titans wince in sympathy. Jay vaults away, landing elegantly in a low crouch. When Kon doesn't immediately go after him, he takes the time to wipe the blood from his face and grunt in dismay. Then Superboy recovers enough and closes the distance between them, ready to go at it again.

They dance around like that for just about two minutes, exchanging hits and attempts to get the upper hand. Tim can't help but calculate the outcome along the way and it's clear that Jason will simply tire out sooner. He's got less stamina (he's just a human, after all) and between the two of them, every hit he takes costs him way more than it does Superboy.

Jay must realize that, too. He rolls away over his shoulder, putting distance between him and Kon, as if to reevaluate his strategy. Kon sees that as an opening and charges at him. Jason only really has enough time to put his arms up before they clash.

Then there's a deafening *boom* as a shockwave of force ripples out from Kon and a loud *thud* closely followed by a nasty *crack*. The air fills with dust, accompanied by the sounds of pieces of walls crumbling and equipment falling off the racks.

Then the entire room falls eerily silent.

Everyone coughs, trying to figure out the situation as they wait for the dust to settle. Kon blinks slowly, arms still outstretched in front of him after the burst of telekinesis that he caused. He hastily goes back into a battle stance, because even if he broke their agreed-upon rules — used his powers — and the duel should be called off, he's clearly expecting Jay to continue. The lingering dust and smoke are the Red Hood's natural habitat, after all, it'd be weird if he didn't use that to his advantage.

But no hit comes in over thirty seconds; finally the air clears up enough to look around and they see what really happened.

"...Jason?" Kon says quietly, hesitantly.

Jason's fingers are tightly wrapped around a twin set of intricate, golden swords, one in each hand — swords that he definitely didn't have before — and the blades glow faintly when his name is spoken, but otherwise, he gives no response, doesn't move, doesn't react at all. His body is slumped like a doll against the wall it had just collided with.

Kon's eyes open wide and his throat tightens. "Jason!" he calls out, hastily moving towards him, but stops halfway and looks at everybody around the edges of the room. They're watching him intently, most too stunned to do anything.

If Kon's panicking it means he can't hear Jason's heartbeat, either because of shock or because *there isn't one*.

"I- I didn't mean to-" Kon stutters, wild gaze sliding over his teammates. It sounds like he's trying to beg for forgiveness. Like he's on a trial, pleading with juries, trying to explain what he did wasn't really his fault, it's just because of his anger, it's a mistake he can't be held responsible for. "It was an accident-"

Tim knows that the thoughts echoing in Kon's brain right now, the ones he's defending himself from, are his own words — *You can't fire a bullet that's not already in the chamber. We never killed anyone.*

But Tim finds himself frozen in place like everyone else, circuits overwhelmed with static and unresponsive. If Jay's— if he— Tim can't. He just can't. Jay dying is not something he can live through *again*, so he refuses to process the situation *at all*.

Luckily, at that moment Jason stirs, takes a shaky breath and groans in pain, finally giving a sign of life. Relief washes over Tim, though his body is still too busy with rogue signals to move even an inch.

For a split second Jay's face contorts into an ugly expression of rage, a dangerous frown; then he exhales gently, controlling the surge of emotion that bubbles in him — and Tim sees Raven's teaching in that. Then Jaybird looks down at the blades he's holding and curses under his nose, completely unaware of the tension in the air.

"Sorry, I know we agreed to no weapons-" he begins, slowly getting up, but cuts himself off with a hiss of pain, clutching at his side. He sits back down carefully with a deep, steadying breath. "Fuck, you hit hard."

Superboy is still looking at him with pupils blown in shock, holding his breath like he doesn't believe what he's seeing — and that's when Jay cues in on the fact that something's wrong. It apparently doesn't occur to him that the issue is Kon *almost killing him*, so he scans the room for clues.

He immediately squints, noticing the slowly healing, shallow cuts on Kon's forearms, trickling blood down to Superboy's wrists and hands. It's not something one expects on a Super, so Jason's eyebrows slide as far up as humanly possible. "You good?" he asks, pointing to the wounds.

Everyone, Kon included, follows his line of sight, and there's more than one surprised gasp when they realise what they're looking at.

"You-" Kon says, slowly, as if hesitating. The wounds finally close and leave no marks, no proof they've ever been there except for the red liquid on his skin. But judging by Kon's expression, the sight of his own blood is still a big shock. "You... you cut through my TTK."

So *that's* why Kon pushed Jason away so hard, Tim concludes. He felt pain he had not known before and panicked, defended himself with all he got completely on instinct, exploding his power around him like a supernova.

Before he can share that revelation, hell breaks loose in the room.

“He *what?!?*” Gar yells, assuming he just had to *hear* wrong. *See* wrong, because *surely*, *Superboy* wasn't *bleeding* just now.

“What are *those?!?*” Bart squeaks out, slightly alarmed, pointing at the blades. Who wouldn't be alarmed, they managed to pierce through Kon's forcefield *and* damage his superpowered body!

Jason doesn't miss a beat before replying in a very deadpan voice: “Swords. Magic swords.”

That only causes even more chaos to ensue as people descend into the arena to question what just happened and — in Koriand'r's case — inspect the glowing weapons Jay's holding with unbridled curiosity.

“Since when do you have magic swords?!”

Jason makes a non-committal grunt and shrugs. “Since forever?” he answers but it only causes a barrage of further questions and comments.

“This explains why you're so good with a knife—”

“What the fuck? Where'd you even keep those?—”

“How exciting! How did you summon them?—”

Jay twirls one of the blades between his fingers, showing off a bit.

“They just... appear in my hands sometimes,” he says, but doesn't seem very interested in explaining any further as he looks up at Kon again. “I'm really sorry. I hope you don't—”

Superboy slowly approaches Jason — people moving away to make room like sea parting before Moses — and for a moment Jason tenses up as if expecting another hit, expecting retribution for *daring* to injure him. Instead, Kon extends his hand toward him, offering to help him stand up.

“I want to apologise.”

Jason looks at the extended hand quizzically for a moment, weighing his options. On one side, he's just been hit with enough force to kill an average human and he's well entitled to be at the very least *a bit* wary of Kon. On the other, Kon's expression is tender, so much different than the tense *fear* from just a moment before or the competitive *anger* from even earlier. It's soft enough that it eases the doubts Jay might have about the intentions behind the gesture and he takes the hand, pulling himself up with Superboy's help.

"I'm sorry," Kon begins. "For what I said earlier. And, well, also for—" he gestures to the Jason-shaped dent he's made in the wall. "I overreacted. I- I... actually, I have no excuse." Kon bites his lower lip and looks away in shame. "I just... lost myself for a moment."

Jason grins.

"I'd be a damn hypocrite if I didn't accept that, so," he says, extending his arm, and Kon happily shakes it. "I'm guessing you're not used to people getting in a good hit on you, huh?"

Kon nods. "That's honestly really impressive. Shouldn't have underestimated you."

"Famous last words of many people that crossed me," Jay barks out a short laugh, which causes another hiss of pain. Everyone's eyes snap to him, full of worry, but he waves a hand dismissively. "I'm fine."

"You have five broken ribs, three more fractured, a broken nose and I think your shoulder is dislocated *again*." Superboy taps the corner of his eye, suggesting he already X-rayed Jason's injuries. "Also judging by the metal taste in my mouth, I broke skin when I bit you."

Jason sighs and drops the tough guy act. "Yeah, it felt like that," he groans out, but the words are followed by another grin. "Already popped the shoulder right back into place tho, using your back as leverage when I was trying to flip you around. I'm awesome like that."

"Let's still get you to the infirmary, hm?"

Jay nods with a smile, so Kon begins to escort him out of the room and Robin, who's been silent the whole time so far, crosses his arms on his chest. The tension — both in the room and in his circuits — had eased enough that he can join in on the conversation. And boy, does he have things to say.

"You had no idea about the swords," he says as they pass him in the door.

Jason sends him just a single *look*, then when it doesn't have the desired effect, promptly deflates under Robin's sharp gaze. "I had no idea about the swords," he admits, throwing his hands in the air. "Fuck you. Did you have to ruin it? I was trying to look cool."

"We'll investigate what they are and where they come from later, when you recover," Robin orders and Jason rolls his eyes, but agrees.

Cassie snorts, catching up to them to make sure the two idiots actually make it to the medical. Using the slight pause, Kon taps Jason's shoulder to get his attention back.

"Wanna train together sometime?" he blurts out.

Jay frowns in confusion, so Kon explains himself. "I rarely get the chance to practice against something that can actually hurt me, and you could work on controlling those blades."

There's just a heartbeat of hesitation before Jay replies with a grin. "Yeah, sure. Just try not to kill me next time, I used up my dying quota some time ago."

It's possibly only the mischievous smirk on Jason's face that causes Kon not to slip right back into guilt at that last remark and he nods solemnly instead.

Cassie puts her hands on her hips, shaking her head in pretend-exasperation.

"I should've figured you two would have to beat each other up to finally get along. It was that, or bonding over daddy issues. Either way, glad to have another Titan on the team!"

Jason looks at her, clearly shocked and thrown off by that comment. "I'm not a- " he begins, but Cassie extends her hand to silence him.

"Are you sure?" She points out his very own hero suit, safe in a case in the wall, next to the others. Gestures to the crowd of people worried for his wellbeing, people that call him their friend and teammate. Gestures around as if to paint him a scene: them hanging out together in the Titans Tower, going on missions together, training together. Learning, laughing, living together.

And then, all he can say is a simple, quiet "*Oh.*"

Incidentally, the very last move they make in this months-long game of relationship Twister happens over food, too. Though it is not food per se that is the conduit to the situation this time. It's Kon's excitement that starts the chain reaction, and the way that his tongue is always faster than his brain, apparently.

There's been a lull lately; Tim thinks that's a bad thing because evil never sleeps, so it means they're going to get hit by something big soon, but he doesn't spoil it for everyone else — they deserve some proper rest, deserve some downtime to relax and unwind.

As such, Kon, Jaimie and Garfield decided to hit the town, enjoy life a little, and came back with plenty of stories to share.

Kon is in the middle of one of those — a captivating tale of their day at the arcade — when he stutters and the charm he has over his audience is irreversibly lost.

"And I saw this real cute bo— ...b-uuuuuh— " Kon gradually stops talking, knowing the time to save his sentence seamlessly has passed. Suddenly everyone falls quiet and stares at Jason. He looks up from his plate and book, slightly confused.

"Are you hesitating to say you thought a guy was hot, is that what's happening? Because of me?" he asks rhetorically. "I already knew you're fruity. I mean, look at you." He grins mischievously, gesturing to the entirety of Kon's punk style. "Your whole aesthetic practically *screams* 'pro homo'. All your outfits are made out of nothing *but* statement pieces, and the statement they spell out is '*rail me*'. It's-"

"Okay, okay, I get it!" Kon waves his hands, face red as a beet, trying to make Jason stop talking. Kon finally learned that Jason is just naturally a little abrasive, a little bit of an

asshole, but rarely intends to be truly *mean* — at least not to *friends* — so he doesn't take offence to the snark in those words.

Jason just shrugs, as if that was the end of the exchange, but when he reaches down to take another bite off of his plate, casually adds:

"Besides, I know I seem like the definition of the *toxic straight man* stereotype, but I assure you, that's just 'cause I put the 'mafia' in 'alphabet mafia'."

Garfield, who's already been trying to contain a giggle, erupts into laughter so loud and rumbling that Cyborg comes running into the room, concerned. Kon smiles sheepishly and hastily explains everything's fine, only causing even more laughter because he's still red all the way up to the tips of his ears.

Robin nods to himself. The last smidge of stress between Tim's friends — the fear of rejection, the apprehension of showing one's true self — disappears, transforming into a connection over a shared experience instead. Their capacity for vulnerability with each other, for trust and for love, finally increases enough to have room for *every* Titan, just like Tim has.

They're going to be alright.

Chapter End Notes

Refs and memes in this chapter:

[Earthquake Network](#)

[pidgin language](#)

[inspiration for the "Robin staple sequence of hits" scene](#) (timestamp matters, only a couple of seconds are relevant)

[Jason's All-Blades](#)

["We're the mafia in alphabet mafia"](#)

Big thanks to [Vio](#), who helped me flesh out the fight scene and increased Kon's IQ by at least 20 points in doing so.

When reading Jason go "Are you hesitating to say you thought a guy was hot, is that what's happening?" I'd like you to imagine him looking like [this](#) (which is a really pretty fanart of Jason by [Ava](#), as per [Tazbrinna's](#) commission).

P.S. This is a [Zeno's paradox chapter](#) - I thought I had only one chapter left to write, but once I've written it, I still have one chapter left to write.

Chapter 12

Chapter Notes

Trigger warnings for this chapter: immense pain & panic attacks, non-consensual body modification / magical transformation

I gave up on trying to accurately track how many chapters this has left. It's done when it's done.

See the end of the chapter for [more notes](#)

Happiness doesn't last forever. That's something he has learned well by now, but *damn* if it still isn't disheartening every time it proves true.

If Tim was a human, he'd probably call it a hunch. A gut instinct or intuition. Since he's not, he just calls it pattern recognition and probability calculation. The end result is the same — they're in Bialya (*fuck* that place, honestly), trying to intercept a magical artefact that they've ended up codenaming “Not-An-Orb”, much to Tim's great exasperation.

(Bart was looking over all the digitized, centuries-old documents describing the artefact that they've managed to snag in Ha'il, too distracted to really retain any details, but that never stopped him from asking a shit-ton of questions. “Okay, so what do you think the Orb-”

“Not an orb,” Tim threw in without sparing Bart a glance. Everybody stopped what they're doing and looked at him in confusion for a hot second before Jason decided to ask:

“What?”

“It's not an orb. It's a ball.”

“That's the same thing, Timmers.”

“No no no. An orb is a *sphere*, which in maths only includes the surface area, while a ball is the term for a *filled-in* sphere, the surface and *everything inside of it*. The text says it's made out of solid rock, so it's not an orb.”

Jason groaned. Bart continued as if he was never interrupted to begin with. “Okay, so what do you think the Not-An-Orb does?”)

The texts aren't clear about what the artefact does, or even how it works. That explains why it hadn't been sought out before — there's not enough incentive for such a risky expedition. Still, what they've managed to decipher mentions “nightmares upon thee” and the target experiencing “deepest despair” enough times that they don't want to wait and see what a villain could do with it.

Not-An-Orb probably surfaced from some underground ruin or holy safekeeping temple during the earthquake in Lahore seven months back. The magical anomalies in the Iranian mountains are possibly its doing, too. There's a good chance that's exactly what brought the attention of Queen Bee herself to the thing.

Sadly, the intel about it from Ha'il was just as easy to get for her as it was for them because her men knew exactly where to look for the artefact. While she could potentially utilize it in her political plans, Tim assesses that she is probably intending to trade the thing to someone for a hefty price or a valuable favour.

Either way, with travel-time playing against them, the Titans arrive where Not-An-Orb now appears to be located just *a tad* later than the Bialyan taskforce. As such, Queen Bee's men manage to intercept the artefact and now they're locked in a fight. The scene is as follows:

On one side, Robin and his most trusted allies: Superboy, Wonder Girl, Impulse and the most recent addition, Red Hood.

On the other side, a fleet of approximately thirty hovercrafts, a seemingly endless supply of goons, and a transport helicopter equipped with a *goddamn heavy machine gun*.

And yeah, they're superheroes and the enemies are just humans — battle-trained and with military-grade equipment, but still humans, not something a team like them can't handle — but there's just *so many* of them.

SB and RH are fending off most of the infantry, punching and kicking and slashing like a whirlwind of righteous retribution, TTK and magical blades bringing down anybody stupid enough to be in their way.

Imp is handling the hovercrafts, speed-jumping from one to another and taking down the pilots with recklessness and ease that only speedsters can manage in combat.

WG is holding the Bialyan transport helicopter tangled in her lasso, her muscles flexed, her face frowning, her heels dug deep into the ground, trying to prevent the machine from taking off with Not-An-Orb.

R is covering Wonder Girl's back, fighting off people who'd like to interrupt her. He's also *supposed to* be dealing with the machine gun and giving them an opening to safely get inside the vehicle, because he doesn't want to risk anyone charging it and getting shot. He already tried hacking the helicopter as a whole, but the fuckers purposefully picked one just primitive enough to not have enough electronics on board for him to actually be able to take control over it. He wanted to at least jam the gun with a batarang, but the wind caused by the violently spinning helicopter blades derails them no matter how hard he throws. He'll have to crawl under it and manually disarm—

Bart's short scream of pain catches his attention and he turns his head just in time to see the speedster get electrocuted with a taser staff, much like the ones Nightwing uses, then *run over* by one of the hovercrafts. His unconscious body bounces off the ground once and then *rolls off the edge of the plateau they're fighting on*.

“Impulse **down!**” Tim yells in their comms, as always when something important happens during combat, just in case nobody but him noticed. As the only one without his hands full at the moment, he’s planning to make a mad dash to try and save Bart before he hits the base of this mountain, 1500 feet below, at terminal velocity. But before he can take as much as make a single step, Cassie lets go of her lasso and dives after their friend, and that’s the last they see of her for a time. Judging by the speed she does it, Robin knows she’ll be fast enough to catch and shield Bart from enough impact force for both of them to come out of it alright, but there’s a good chance they’re going to slide uncontrollably further down for a bit after that.

Meanwhile, the helicopter — now free of the thing that kept it down — shoots up into the air with all the power it’s built up struggling against Wonder Girl. With their target still on board and rapidly gaining distance from them, Robin allows himself to curse under his nose.

“Plan B!” Hood immediately calls out, turning towards Superboy. SB takes a single look at him before nodding. He grabs Hood’s arm, spins around two times to build up speed, and *yeets* him at the helicopter as hard as he can. Hood takes three shots from the machine gun straight to the body armour on his chest, screams like a madman and then tumbles into the machine, disappearing from their line of sight.

“Plan B was throwing **me!**” Robin screeches, fending off two men with his staff as he makes his way to Kon.

“Hood was closer!” Superboy replies, punching someone unconscious.

“He’s **not bulletproof!**”

“He’s got kevlar!”

“That’s **not** enough in close range!”

“I’m fine, idiots!” Hood pipes up in the comms, though it’s hard to hear him through the loud whirring. A grunt of pain follows, but they’re not sure if it’s him or someone he just hit. “And got the job done!” he yells a moment later, emerging from the depths of the vehicle. His face and clothes are bloody, but he’s smiling proudly, holding a big, black chest in both his arms.

Then the helicopter swerves and Hood’s eyes blow wide as he falls out through the open side of it.

He lets go of Not-An-Orb — or rather, the chest containing it — with one hand to twist around and hastily fire a grapple gun into the helicopter’s plating. The hook bounces off just about at the same moment that the chest slips out from under his arm, too big and unwieldy to be held like that.

Robin doesn’t panic, he doesn’t do that on the field. He just pushes Superboy up, urging him towards Hood. He’s sure that SB can catch Hood and prevent him from splattering on the ground into a bloody pancake, so that’s not something he worries about. What he *does worry about*, though, is Jason making a desperate grasp at the chest slipping out of his grip but only managing to grab the lid. As a result, the chest swings fully open and a beautiful, fist-sized piece of labradorite flies out of it.

(*Why the fuck is it unlocked?* crosses Tim's mind and he immediately comes up with a viable answer: Hood must've cracked it open earlier, to make sure it's what they're looking for.)

Robin springs forward into a mad dash, trying to catch the ball because if he knows anything about magical artefacts, it's that they don't take well to being smashed to bits. He's a good half a second too slow to be able to make it with simply running, so in the last few feet, Robin throws himself into the air, lunging forwards to intercept the menacingly opalescent stone. He intends to tuck it against his chest, curl up around it and shield it from impact as he tumbles a few feet through the gravel in a rather rough landing.

What really happens is his hands close exactly 4096 microseconds too soon to grab Not-An-Orb. That error is enough to make it slip right past him and crash into the ground with all the force it gained in its rapid descent from over 150 feet.

A bright light explodes before their eyes and covers the entire battlefield, like someone detonated an extra-powerful flashbang, just as Kon lands, setting Jason down on the ground. Everyone within the vicinity can only curse loudly and try to cover their eyes.

There's silence for a split second as the light fades, then a deep, stuttering inhale can be heard.

Then the screaming starts.

Kon's immediately alarmed and his head snaps to the source of the sound. Jason just instinctively covers his ears, as he's right next to whoever is making that awful noise. The sound is... painful, in every meaning of the word. It is definitely an expression of someone feeling immense pain, but also it is so loud that it is painful to hear, and it sounds like it will hurt the person's throat soon, too. If the artefact summoned some kind of a fucking banshee —

"Hold him!" Superboy yells, the words barely getting to Jay over the wailing and the rumble of the nearby helicopter. Jason's already slightly dizzy from hitting his head against the inside of the helicopter earlier (he questions his decision to ditch the helmet *so hard* right now) and this isn't helping. He looks around to reassess the situation, a little surprised that Tim isn't already blabbering a battlefield status update over the comm-link.

"What?!" he manages to yell. It's half a reply to Kon, half a response to what he's looking at.

And what he's looking at is a scrawny boy, skin pale pink and hair deep black. Dressed in Robin's red-green-yellow, weirdly enough. Laying a short distance away, shaking violently and screaming his little head off in what seems like a traumatic shock reaction. The kid has a shallow cut on his eyebrow — probably from hitting the rocks face-first, judging by the marks in the dirt around him — and it's bleeding profusely, but any kind of brow wound bleeds like hell, so it shouldn't hurt too bad. Not as bad as to justify *this* kind of reaction, at least, so Jay really doesn't understand what's his problem.

Jason is confused about the situation for about half a second, then it all falls into place and he opens his eyes wide.

He's looking at *Tim*. The very soft and very alive human boy in Robin suit, screaming in pain on the ground is, in fact, the *actual* Robin. In the flesh, you could say.

Fucking magic.

"HOLD HIM!" Kon's voice is panicked, but Jason can't tell if it's because of what they've just been presented with, or because with WG and Imp missing from the battle, R down and RH apparently stunned, he's trying to single-handedly stop the entire enemy force.

And it's not going well.

Jason runs up to Tim and reaches out towards him, but hesitates. The boy seems so small and fragile and as if he'll crumble to dust if Jay so much as touches him. He's known to be destructive, isn't he? He can't mess this up, he can't hurt Tim, not again, not—

"Hug him! Tight! Hold him as close as you can! I'll—" Kon sends Jay a stern, commanding glance over his shoulder, which allows someone to land a hit in on him and cuts him off mid-sentence. He retaliates immediately and picks up. "Trust me! He needs it! I'll be right there!"

Finally, Jason gets over the panic freezing his heart and obliges. He crouches down next to Tim slowly, carefully; takes him in his arms. Wraps them around him and presses him against the hard kevlar on his chest. For a moment it does nothing, changes nothing, but then the full-body spasms subside a little bit, so he sits down on his ass and wraps his legs around Tim too, bringing him even closer.

He feels horrible about not being able to do anything more, either for Tim, who's in pain, or Kon, who's fighting on his own. But despite his instincts telling him to act — to fight, to plan, to bite and run — he trusts.

And stays where he is.

The painful scream slowly transforms into loud, uncontrolled sobbing. Though Tim doesn't calm down completely and he's still obviously in pain, it's an improvement and Jason will take a win wherever he can at the moment.

"Shh—" he murmurs into Tim's ear. "Just breathe, Timmy. It's going to be alright, I promise. You're going to be okay."

His hug and reassurance don't stop the tears rolling down Tim's cheeks, but Jason can feel trembling hands ball into fists on his back, holding onto his hoodie tightly as if it's his lifeline. And at that moment Jason knows that hell would sooner freeze over than he would let Tim go.

Once Wonder Girl rejoins the fight — having deposited an unconscious Impulse safely next to Red Hood and Robin — it goes a little smoother, a little faster. Jason pays his surroundings only enough attention to make sure he can properly protect his fallen teammates, so he doesn't exactly register how it goes.

When the fight finally quiets down, the first thing he feels, though — because he *feels* the approach way earlier than he can see or even *hear* him — is Kon.

Superboy's telekinetic presence crawls over his skin and spills over — gently as if handling something incomprehensibly precious and important — to encompass both him and the trembling Robin in his arms. The TTK covers them like a blanket, heavy and comforting, and presses down like a tight, full-body hug. Jason's embrace couldn't even *compare* to the sense of security *this* brings.

Unsurprisingly, soon enough Tim's agitation diminishes; he's still crying, but it seems like an involuntary continuation, leftovers dripping out more than anything truly concerning. His breathing evens out and his hands let go of the fabric they've been clawing at desperately.

"I'm here," Kon whispers into Tim's hair. It's soft and fluffy, so different from the slightly stiff artificial wig he has installed on his head usually. "I got you, Tim." There's no response from Robin, though.

Jay looks at Kon, still worried and confused. "How'd you know...?"

"This is how I always help him when he's upset," he replies, hand slowly stroking Tim's shoulders. "He has no way to relax, so I just hold him until the 'static in his wires', as he calls it, calms down. It's the first time he actually *can* cry, so I'm guessing it all came back to him with a vengeance."

Jason swallows. That does sound like the "deepest despair" that the artefact promised, alright. In that context, he's surprised how well Tim is taking it. Though he doesn't know what *else* could happen, what more one could do if they felt *everything, all at once, for the first time*.

"We have to—" he starts, then his comms explode with the voice of an uncharacteristically stressed-sounding Oracle.

"Hood? Hood, please tell me you copy."

Jay peeks up at Kon and Cassie, signalling them to listen in. "I copy you, O." What happened to Tim here must've had *some* kind of effect on the rest of him; with her tone, he's kind of expecting to be painted as the cause of it, accused of hurting Robin or fucking up some other way.

To his surprise, she doesn't berate him. Instead, she asks in a very serious, very worried tone: *"Is Titan Robin with you? Is he okay?"*

"He's here, but I don't think he's good," he admits. "How does it look on your end?"

"Tim's completely unresponsive and Gotham Robin just turned off without warning. The entire BatCave blacked out for a moment. I thought it's a virus or a hacker, but there's no sign of any security breaches. Did something happen to him?"

"He got hit with the artefact we were hunting, I think."

Oracle's silent for a moment. *"Is he...?"*

“No, quite to the contrary. He’s very alive, and currently bleeding all over my shoulder.”

“Bleeding.” He can practically hear the way her jaw tightens in disbelief.

“Yeah. Actual, red gore, organic an’ everything,” he says, then looks up at Kon to ask a silent question. They learned to communicate wordlessly, too — not as efficiently as Tim does with people, but good enough. When Kon agrees with a quick nod, he continues. “I’m going to take the Superboy Express back to the Cave and we’ll figure it out from there.”

He doesn’t want to think about having to face Bruce, especially in this situation, but he would do just about anything to help Tim.

“Dick is already here. And Alfred’s on the verge of losing his mind,” O tells him as if that wasn’t a given.

“Well, he ain’t the only one.”

“What I mean is: hurry.”

Kon picks them up without even having to be prompted. Cassie hauls Impulse off the ground and heads to their plane, parked some distance away. “Check in with us when you find out anything,” she orders and they both nod solemnly, then Kon takes off without another word.

The landing on Wayne Manor grounds is rougher than Jason would’ve expected, so he shoots Kon a dirty look. When he sees the pained expression on Superboy’s face, and how he covers his ears the moment he puts them down, Jason backs up from the annoyance and right into worry.

“You okay? What’s wrong?”

Kon shakes his head, takes a deep breath, and frowns in focus. It takes a moment before he opens his eyes. “There’s... there’s this *awful* sound, like a high screech, coming from underground, and my superhearing just— ugh. I have to consciously filter it out. It feels like my brain would *burst*.”

“Oh, yeah, that.” Jason motions with his chin for Kon to follow him, pressing Tim tighter against his chest. The boy had fallen unconscious by now — at least they hope so. He stopped sobbing at the very least. “I hear that too — no other human seems to register it, so I’m guessing that’s just another weird thing that the Pit changed about me, enhanced my senses or some shit. Got used to it, you will too. I think it might be the bats down in the cave — yes, there are actual fucking bats in the BatCave, don’t act like that surprises you, B is extra *as fuck*. Anyway, yeah, I feel you, it sounds like if I wasn’t already a zombie, it’d raise me from the grave.” He shudders, then leads them through the grounds and towards the back door to the Manor.

He walks fast and with purpose because it’s the fate of the most important person in the world — Timothy Jackson Drake, genius, hero, dumbass extraordinaire — that’s at stake. But

with every step he takes towards the building, his resolve falters and his stride steadily slows down.

He makes it all the way inside and into Bruce's study, Kon following him without comment. There he stops abruptly in front of the concealed entrance to the BatCave, finally succumbing to his inner demons even despite the Tim Emergency in his arms.

"Fuck," he mumbles to himself, staring at the old grandfather clock. "B's gonna tear me a new one for gettin' Tim hurt. And givin' out his secret identity and bringin' a stranger — a meta, at that! — into the Cave. He already hates me enough t'want me dead, o' locked up. What t'fuck am I doing here? I don't belong here, this is not where I should be, I- "

Kon places a reassuring hand on his shoulder and opens his mouth to speak, but whatever he intends to tell Jason is interrupted by the clock opening to reveal Dick smiling sadly behind it.

"Jay, you *do* belong here," he says, looking his little brother in the eye with the kind of warmth that only Dick can show with a single glance. "You're *exactly* where you're supposed to be."

Jason looks him up and down with a sour expression, the words seemingly shaking him out of his terrors. "No," he says with seriousness to his voice, "I'm not where I'm supposed to be, not where I *need* to be."

Dick's face shows his increasing sadness at those jaded sentences as if it hurts him to the core, but his body language looks a bit hesitant and slightly disappointed, in the end making him come off a little... insincere. Jason's pretty sure Big Bird has good intentions, but he doesn't have the time to deal with Dick's emotional issues.

So, before Dick says anything more, Jay continues, "Not yet." Then uses his shoulder to shove Dick to the side, squeezes past him and into the Cave, ignoring Nightwing's attempt to touch his arm. "But *holy fuck*, I'm glad I'm not where I used to be."

He peeks at Superboy over his shoulder, motioning for him to come inside too. "C'mon, SB, we got a babybird to take care of."

There's more to that look than just guiding them down the stairs. It's... a "thank you", silent and constipated as is traditional for Bats, but a "thank you" nonetheless. To Kon, to Tim, to all the other Titans. For pulling Jason out from the dark place he was in and sharing their home with him. For **being** home for him, because as Tim said, *home is not a place*.

With Alfred's help, they run every test under the sun on Tim to make sure he's alright, at least in the body department. He's understandably tired and slightly dehydrated, probably from all the crying, but otherwise *good as new*. Which is probably the case, given that the tests also confirm that there is, in fact, nothing of his mechanical body left and there's just flesh and bone in there, mint condition.

They clean him up, change him out from the Robin suit and into one of his pyjamas, and bandage the cut on his forehead. Administer morphine and muscle relaxants because even with Kon's help he's still stiff as a log, and hook him up on a nutrient drip, just in case.

Then they just have to wait for him to wake up.

"I'll stay here, figure this shit out. You go back, the team needs you," Jason says to Kon, fingers flexing open and close on the edge of the blanket Tim's covered with. "Besides, I can see how annoyed you are by that screeching sound."

Superboy stops staring into space for a moment to look Jay in the eyes. "The team can handle themselves. You two are more important," he says decisively, then sits on a nearby chair, as if to make a point.

Jason tenses up, completely not expecting him to reply like that. Then his expression softens, more than ever, and Kon smiles at him warmly.

"Besides," Kon leans over to Jason to whisper with a playful smile. "There's no way I'm leaving you to face Batman alone."

Jay smirks. "Like you'd make any difference, Boy of Steel. I almost took you down, why do you think you stand a chance against **the** Bat?" he says, raising his chin in a challenge. For a moment Dick thinks they're going to start butting heads like the two hot-tempered brutes they are, but nothing like that happens.

Instead, Jason points a finger at Kon. "You're in charge of keeping Tim safe from Batman, then. Don't fuck it up."

"Not a single hair off his head. Cross my heart, Scout's promise, the like."

They look at each other for a moment, then nod and clap their hands together, pulling each other into a pound hug and slapping the other's back reassuringly.

"Either way, if you're staying, at the very least let's radio an update to the others, okay? They're probably worried sick," Jason says when they part, and they scurry off to work.

Dick silently looks at them from the sidelines, confused as they smoothly slide into a planning mode of their own. He's missed *so much* in the past months, hasn't he? Even though he had Jason's phone number for a while now, he decided not to use it, afraid he would screw things up even more. Instead, he and Tim had made a plan for the reunion. They'd gone over how to arrange the meeting in a way that wouldn't let Jay escape too easily, what Dick would say and how Jason might react. They refined it over and over again until Dick felt he was ready to deal with anything Jason could throw his way. Now that he actually has met Jason, Dick can scrap all the plans and his carefully crafted, heart-wrenching speech. When did Jason become so caring? How is he suddenly a team player? What kind of magic did Tim work on him?

"I'd guess it's called love and trust, Master Dick," Alfred throws in quietly, refilling Dick's teacup as if he could read his mind. Dick just shakes his head and takes a sip, then gets down

to business himself.

While Tim sleeps, the rest of them alternate between nervous pacing, sitting at Tim's bedside and doing furious research and pulling in every favour they have with people who could help.

In the meantime, Dick explains why Bruce isn't around — that he's somewhere in space, with the League, dealing with bigger things. (Jay has to take a moment to breathe so he doesn't punch a hole in the wall when he hears that. Another kid of his — objectively the very *best* of them all — is in danger and B's once again too busy to help. *Typical.*)

Tim's vitals stop looking like he's on the verge of being in a coma only about two hours later, and it takes one more before he starts to slowly come to. Alfred decides that since he might wake up soon, they should prepare him something to eat, and drags Dick upstairs, leaving only the three Titans in the BatCave. (Dick doesn't oppose. He's not as close with either of them as he'd like to be and can understand they'll need a moment just between teammates. And after what he saw... he trusts them with his little brother's safety.)

When Tim finally makes a strangled noise thirty minutes later, Kon's and Jason's heads snap to him so fast they crack their necks loudly.

"Ya awake?" Jay approaches the bed as he massages the painful cramp he's just given himself. Kon follows him closely behind.

"How are you feeling?" is what Kon chooses to quietly ask about, instead, sitting on the side of the bed. Tim's eyes flutter open but he immediately frowns and closes them.

Jason looks around for what might be causing Tim's discomfort. "Too bright?"

He walks over to the light switch for the bright lamp positioned right over Tim's bed and turns it off. Tim's expression softens right away. He cracks open his eyes again, though they can't seem to focus on anything. With another grunt of effort, his fingers move a little. He's clearly struggling to inch his hand towards Kon, so Superboy grabs it, softly and carefully yet firmly. That seems to be exactly what Tim wanted because he exhales and his shoulders relax a little.

Then he takes a deeper breath and tries to clear his throat. He only manages to cough and wheeze hoarsely.

"Sore throat, huh? Screechin' for 20 minutes straight does that to ya'," Jason leans on Kon's shoulder. "Blink once for 'yes', twice for 'no'. Want some water? That should help with the throat a bit."

With an annoyed frown on his face, Tim shifts his gaze vaguely towards Jason, stares at him for a moment then blinks once. Jason smiles, bounces off of Kon and makes his way towards a nearby sink. He grabs a sippy cup — not a glass or even a normal cup, you learn to keep the act of drinking horizontally *very* easy when you have vigilantes getting incapacitated on the regular — and fills it with water.

“You think you can swallow?”

One blink, with the *slightest* nod to go with it.

“Put those muscles of yours to use and prop him up a little, hunk.” Jason motions at Kon as he walks back to them. When Superboy gently holds Tim’s head up, Jay puts the cup against Tim’s lips and tilts it.

Tim drinks slowly and sloppily, like a newborn, and all his weight rests in Kon’s arms. Once again they’re reminded he has a very poor grasp on how to control an organic body.

They know he’s done when he sighs in satisfaction and relief, the noise sounding way less hoarse than before.

Kon puts him back down gently, hesitates for a moment, then decides to speak up. “Do you know what happened to you? Why you’re like this?”

One blink. They both nod, each with a different flavour of sadness on his face. At least they don’t have to explain.

“We’re working on fixing it, so don’t worry. It seems the thing activated the moment it hit the ground, but we’re still not sure why it-”

To their surprise, Tim interrupts Jason by lifting one of his hands slightly. It takes Jay more time than he’d like to admit to figure out that the gestures Tim is making are finger-spelling.

“S-E-U,” he tells them.

Jay leans over to Kon. “You know ASL?” he asks and his teammate scoffs.

“Of course.”

“Good, coz he seems to have more control over his hands than over his throat right now, which I guess is understandable. Anyway, what is SEU?”

Kon furrows his brows and thinks (without access to Tim’s databases, he’s their second-best option for Knowing Things). After a moment of consideration, his eyes flash with understanding.

“Single-event upset?” he asks, and Tim blinks once. “Gosh, yeah that... That would explain it.”

“Care to clue me in, nerds?” Jason sighs in pretended annoyance.

“Single-event upset is what we call it when an ionized particle, like from radioactive elements or a cosmic ray, hits a sensitive spot in a microelectronic device and changes the state of a bit, creating a discrepancy in data. If it happens in *just* the wrong way, it can make a huge difference. They happen more often at higher altitudes. Like. You know. Where we were fighting.”

“You want to tell me that, basically, the universe decided to force Tim to finally make a mistake?”

Tim pointedly blinks once.

“Well, fuck. Just our luck, huh?” Jason sits on the nearby chair, slightly deflated. There’s a brief silence as they take it in. “Either way, for now just... rest. We’ll handle fixing it. Ya want me to call in the others?”

Immediately, Tim blinks two times, fast and frantic, and a second later — frowns. He coughs and tries to say something, but it comes out jumbled, so he returns to signing again.

“B?”

(There *is* a designated sign for Batman — two, even, one they themselves developed for internal purposes and one that the Deaf people gave the vigilante — but both are a bit complex and Jason can understand it might be a little too demanding of a gesture for Tim right now.)

“B’s off-world. There’s just us, Dick and Alf in the Manor. They already told him about the situation, he’s supposedly trying to come back as soon as he can, but it’ll take a while. Do you want them to come, just the two of them?”

Another brief moment of silence, then one blink, so Jason pages the others over the intercom. He doesn’t know *why* Tim wouldn’t want to see *specifically* Bruce right now, but he can relate to the sentiment, at least.

Meanwhile, Tim lightly squeezes Kon’s hand and clears his throat again but once more it doesn’t make his words come out any clearer. He sighs in defeat and raises his hands again.

“If this— is how pain feels like— “ he signs, the words sloppy in his hands. He’s making pauses and sometimes he loses control of his arm for a moment, so even this form of communication comes hard to him. But he’s determined. “— I’m not letting any of you— leave the house— ever again.”

Jason laughs briefly at the comment, just as Alfred appears in the entrance to the Cave. The butler is obviously relieved that Tim came to, but the anxiety still shows on his face, clear as day. Dick peeks from behind him, overtakes the elder and sprints to where they’re gathered around Tim in the medbay. Even with all his acrobatic grace, he nearly trips over his own feet trying to reach them as fast as humanly possible, deep concern showing in all of his body language.

“How is he?” he asks, looking over Tim, who smiles faintly in response. That lets Dick lose some of the worry weighing his heart down, but he still seems restless.

“Well, he’s still cracking jokes, so I guess he’ll live,” Kon sighs, expression a little bittersweet.

“That’s kind of the problem though, isn’t it?” Jason grimaces. “He ain’t *supposed* to be alive.”

“I’ve been— alive for— quite some time now,” Tim retorts. “Just not— organic.”

“...are you really going to argue semantics right now?”

“Don’t— squander my— poetic nature.” He coughs and attempts to sit up, much to everyone’s shock. He falls right back and it’s only Superboy’s speed that saves him from flopping heavily against the bed. “And honestly... this-this-this,” he repeats the sign for extra emphasis, “feels dead to me.”

“What?” Dick frowns.

“I’m slow. — Limited. Weak. — Singular.” He frowns as he signs the last word, like he wanted to spit it out. “This is like— Robin disconnecting. But worse. Way worse-worse-worse. — Hate it.”

Silence falls between them as they process what exactly Tim just said. How exactly Tim must feel — Tim who’s used to being the entire BatCave and all the Robins all at once, now confined to one weak body, and one that he has to learn on the go at that.

Jason curses under his breath while Dick gasps, covering his mouth. Kon simply puts his hand on Tim’s shoulder.

“We’re going to make it right.”

“You fucking better— “

“Language, Master Timothy,” Alfred says, having made his way to the medbay in the meantime. He’s holding a tray of easily digestible food and a cup of mild tea, and Jason can’t help but snort quietly at the irony of Tim finally getting to *taste food* during what is — apparently — the worst day of his life.

“Alfred. I’m entitled— to be a little— salty about— “ He gestures down to himself, “this.”

“You certainly are, but you can do it in a way that befits a son of the Wayne household, can’t you?”

Tim huffs but doesn’t protest further. Instead, he attempts to sit up again. Surprisingly, he manages this time, though he has to grab onto Jason’s arm for stability. He seems to be getting a grasp on his new body quite rapidly; it’s not a surprise, since Tim’s always been a very fast learner. Emboldened by the success, he tries to motion for Kon and Jason to make room, and when they do, he slowly slides his legs onto the floor to try and stand up. He promptly falls over and everybody lunges forward to catch him. Dick is the first to reach Tim and slowly pulls him up.

“Take it slow, bud,” Dick says, reaching out pet Tim’s hair affectionately. The boy closes his eyes and makes a satisfied hum, leaning into the touch, then blushes slightly as if that reaction surprised even him.

“I want— I need to... help you. Morons,” Tim signs in reply, trying to steady himself by leaning on Dick.

Jason notices that Tim’s a great deal more... rude? blunt? maybe simply *direct*? in his disposition, but who *wouldn’t be* in his situation. He must be hellu frustrated and still in pain, so Jason can excuse him for being a little bit rough on the edges. Besides, Tim dealt with *him* at his *worst*, so he definitely can ignore a couple of snide remarks without holding any grudges.

“Once you are better, you can help, okay?” Dick gently pushes Tim back onto the bed. “Once you can walk on your own, at least. Deal?”

Tim groans in disgruntlement, but nods and Dick smiles, then reaches to the tray in Alfred’s hands and grabs a spoonful of the rich, thick smoothie the butler’s brought. “Open wide, kiddo. You’ll need to eat if you want to recover.”

The boy hesitates for a split second. Then curiosity takes over. He hastily takes the spoon between his lips, scoops the food off it and plays with it in his mouth with a quiet murmur, though probably purely out of bodily instinct, since there isn’t much to chew in there.

Finally, he swallows but then smacks his lips with a disappointed grimace. “What is this?” his arms sign in strong, hard motions as if angrily demanding explanations.

Dick raises his eyebrows, then tastes a spoonful himself. “Yoghurt parfait with bananas. A very good one, dare I say. A tad mushy with the boiled oats and whey powder, I suppose, but easy to stomach and very nutritious.”

“This is— It feels good?— In my head? But also terrible— in my mouth? — I don’t understand.”

Dick thinks for a moment. “Dopamine reaction to carbs is the ‘feel good in your head’, I think,” he says. “And I’m guessing you just don’t like the taste.”

Tim stays still, eyeing the bowl of yoghurt in Dick’s hands, brows furrowed in thought. “Sweet?” he finally signs.

“Yeah, this is what we’d call sweet.”

“Bart is insane— for craving this.”

Kon laughs. “Cookies have a different taste than blended yoghurt baby food.”

“If you can keep this down, we’ll make you some cookies,” Jason butts in. “Right, Alf?”

The butler nods with a smile. “Anything the young master desires.”

“You’re already lucky you got yoghurt as your first meal,” Dick adds, offering Tim another spoonful. “The go-to food for bedbound people is plain porridge or chicken broth, but I convinced Alfie to make you something more... appealing.”

Tim sighs and lets him continue feeding him, grimacing a little less with each portion he swallows.

Chapter End Notes

Refs and memes in this chapter:

[SEU](#) on the wikipedia, but [this](#) is also a neat video about it.

[“I’m not where I need to be, but I’m glad I’m not where I used to be”](#)

Big thanks to [tomorrow4eva](#) and griffle, who had been a great help with betareading this chapter! <3

Special thanks to Noblehunter for coming up with Not-An-Orb's name, and to Nykyrianne who helped me with the ASL, too!

Chapter 13

Chapter Notes

Trigger warnings for this chapter: pain & panic attacks, mention of human trafficking

See the end of the chapter for [more notes](#)

It takes Tim a couple of hours, another hearty meal and a nutrient drip, two more good naps and one more calming session of TTK hugging with Kon to finally be able to sit properly on his own and move his limbs without issues. Walking and talking is a bit more difficult, but he's determined and achieves it — though still struggling a bit — by the next day.

Dick left during the night to gather intel on the sudden uptick in Riddler's activity (they can't afford to have anything go wrong in the city, not now, not when they have an emergency like this) and has yet to return, probably trying to catch some sleep and contact people with a more... daytime kind of schedule. After breakfast, Kon and Jay also set out to cross-check the info they've gathered so far and consult the hero community at large about their problem. That leaves Tim on his own.

The problem is, without the internet plugged directly into his mind, he's kind of bad at occupying himself on his own. So, he spends a bit of time chatting with Alfred, following him around and trying to help with the butler's daily chores as best as he can. Sadly, he soon grows too tired to be of much use. He tires *so* easily now that it's kind of hysterical. He's used to *never* having to pause, never having to stop, never needing any rest — and now he's ushered back to the bedroom for a nap barely 4 hours after waking up.

It's not *his* bedroom, because Robin never needed one. It's just *a* bedroom, one of the guest rooms temporarily re-purposed for the three Titans currently staying in the Manor.

Technically, Kon got a room assigned and Jason still has his bedroom from back when he lived here, or he could pick any other guest room if that one is still too full of memories. But both refused to use their designated beds, though, insisting on staying with Tim through the night.

Tim is grateful. He's not sure how he'd make it without them. Even when exhaustion has a tight hold on him, he's afraid to let himself relax and slip into unconsciousness. Sleep seems... scary. It's such an alien experience, to essentially *stop being* for a period of time. He's never sure what he will be when he wakes up. *If* he wakes up. So, Tim's convinced that if not for the calming warmth of the two bodies wrapped around him and steady breathing at his sides during the night, he wouldn't get any proper rest.

For that reason, he doesn't think he'll get any now. Still, he obliges to Alfred's wishes, knowing better than to argue with the elder once he has *that* frown on his face, and slinks away to at the very least lay down for a while. If he knows anything about human biology —

and he's not sure if he does, since he can't reach out to his databases and it's not knowledge he keeps on hand, but he hopes he's right — even if he doesn't actually sleep, laying down should help with his tiredness. It's worth a try, at the very least.

He spends some time staring at the ceiling, breathing slowly. The loud *ta-thump ta-thump ta-thump* of, he assumes, his heartbeat becomes unbearable in the silence. Children take months to get accustomed to the sound, to filter it out; he had learned to ignore it — if he focuses — within hours. But when he's alone, when there's nothing else to distract from it, it comes back to him and overwhelms him the same way it did the first time.

So, he sits up and takes the nearby tablet in his hands, hoping to redirect his thoughts to something else. Maybe he can do some casework? No, he immediately backs out from the idea, he doesn't trust himself to not make mistakes. He's dumb and slow, and exhausted at that; it would be too easy to mess up, and incorrect information in the system is the last thing they need right now. He needs to occupy himself with something... inconsequential. Maybe he can watch a movie?

Tim starts tapping at the screen. He's been practising fine motor skills as Robin by playing the piano so typing shouldn't be a problem, but... he never quite had to use the human interface before, and it's not very intuitive to him.

He struggles for a moment, frustration growing, to get into the movie library of their streaming service. He manages to find and launch the proper app, but his efforts are rendered useless when the thing requires him to type in a password into the login form. All access details are stored somewhere in his databases, sure, but it's always been something he handled in a secure, encrypted format — not as part of his memories. So, not being able to know the password and with no chance of cracking it, he turns the tablet off with an annoyed huff. That causes him to catch a glimpse of himself in the black mirror of the screen, and the fact that he can't look back from it, that the camera in it isn't *him* makes his heart ache.

In a surge of emotion, he throws the device across the room, letting out a defeated, angry scream.

The thing bounces off the wall and falls to the floor with a quiet crack and that's all it takes; Tim breaks down and starts crying. He feels lonely and alone — and those are two different feelings — and just generally so... *wrong*. Nothing is like he knows it to be, like it used to be; everything is too much or too little. He feels isolated and insignificant and insecure, in a way he's never experienced before, even before he started considering himself a person at all. He can imagine he could grow accustomed, in time, to functioning in this new, weird, fleshy body, but he doesn't even want to consider staying as a... a *fraction* of himself.

The solution can't come fast enough, he thinks as he quietly cries himself to sleep.

When Jason and Kon return, they find Tim at the main BatComputer terminal, staring into the overhead camera like it had the answers to all his problems. When he notices them, though, he immediately turns the giant armchair around to face them.

“What did you-” Tim’s words are interrupted by a cough, which he settles with a sip of water from a nearby glass. “What did you learn?” he asks with a frown, tapping all his fingertips together. Jason thinks that the gesture, the armchair and the sprawling computer screen behind it make Tim look like a villain. A twelve-year-old, asthmatic, cartoon villain in a set of Kid Flash-themed pyjamas, with his bare feet hanging several inches off the floor, but still. Kind of weirdly terrifying.

“The artefact activated when it broke, just like we suspected. We’re not sure if it was its primary purpose or defense mechanism, though,” Kon says, leaning on the console.

“Did you get the remains analyzed by someone?”

Kon nods. “We asked the Zataras about those,” he says, handing Tim a handful of handwritten notes from Zatanna, her father and even Zachary. “But it’s apparently hard to tell what exactly happened with little info about the thing and so long after the fact.”

“Sadly, from what we’ve gathered, Jason Blood — the guy who’s contracted to secrecy with the Waynes — ain’t even on the same plane of existence right now,” Jason picks up. “Dick called in a favour from someone else, but- “

“-we can’t exactly invite people here without compromising too much info,” Tim interrupts him, finishing the thought. “Somewhere downtown, then?”

“Yep. A dingy 24/7 diner in Burnley, later today. You okay with that?”

Tim nods without missing a beat, not particularly fazed by that perspective. “How about the BatCave? Did you get in touch with Babs?” He coughs again, clears his throat. “Are all the systems operational?”

“Sorta. Most security measures work alright — access control, surveillance, perimeter measures, locks, the like — but it’s all in manual mode. You- the chat—”

“It’s okay. Say it. My chat consoles, my terminals are me, still. They’re unreachable the normal way, but maybe Babs could...?”

“...sorry. She can’t get any reaction, even through direct code commands. Everything except the automated, isolated functions is unresponsive.”

“Has she checked my core files? Tried to run them manually?”

Jason frowns, then looks away. “She doesn’t want to risk hacking into your system when you’re like this, in case it has... an effect on you.”

“It won’t. I don’t... I can’t even *feel* any of my peripherals.”

“No, I think... I think she meant she’s worried that she could accidentally modify you if she broke in now that you can’t... defend yourself.”

“I’m more afraid of staying like *this*.”

There's a brief silence, neither Jason nor Kon knowing what to say to Tim's insistence of how terrible it is to be alive.

"Oracle did say to go through the currently running processes and see if anything is amiss, though," Kon offers as a means to escape the awkwardness. "It's easier from here, so—"

"Let's see what's up, then—" Jason says with a chuckle, then pushes Tim to the side so that he can reach the main console. He types in a command and brings up a window with a list of events and scripts currently running inside the machinery. There's a lot of them, unsurprisingly. "What exactly would be *out of the ordinary*, though? What are we looking—*Tim.*"

"What?"

"Why the *fuck* is there a process called 'jason'? And more importantly, why has it been running for literal *years*? Most of the other scripts seem to get a regular restart, but this one—"

Tim raises his eyebrows, then immediately furrows them.

"Oh. That. That is..." he mumbles, his cheeks flushing slightly. It's a good look on him, Jay thinks briefly. "I'm surprised it's still going, given Barbara said the Cave briefly blipped out."

"Don't try to deflect me. What the fuck is it?"

"It's... my grief coping mechanism."

"*What?*"

"It plays a loop of me saying your name, in a frequency beyond what human ears can hear, deep in the cave. To, you know. GNU. Like in that Pratchett book."

Jason stares at him for a moment, then begins laughing, which causes Tim to blush even harder.

"Anyway, I guess you can... turn it off. Since you're..." Tim gestures vaguely to him. "Back."

"I guess we can," Jason agrees, still chuckling, then taps in the proper command.

Kon is the first to react.

"It stopped!" he exclaims, suddenly straightening up and looking around. Jason looks at him in confusion for a moment, then his eyes open wide.

"It stopped," he agrees. "That was it?"

"What happened?" Tim slides off the chair and touches Kon's arm in concern. "Are you okay?"

“Yeah, just... that sound he just turned off—” He points at Jason. “You said people shouldn’t hear it. But we did.”

“And frankly, it drove me *crazy*.” Jason leans on the console as if suddenly weak. Both Tim and Kon reach out to grab and support him. “I... I don’t remember the world being this *quiet*. The screech— it’s my first memory after coming back, it’s been there ever since I dug myself out. It was a good part of the reason why I avoided the Manor so much at first. It just... it felt like it crawled up my spine and pulled my brain apart, called for me and *demand*ed something from me—”

“Why didn’t you tell me?” Tim’s voice is full of worry and trembling slightly. He probably feels responsible for causing Jay’s obvious suffering. “I didn’t know. I’d have turned it off if you just *said* something.”

“I thought... I thought it’s a bad case of zombie tinnitus, or maybe the Pit making me freak out at some natural sound. Didn’t even *think* to mention it. I got used to it after a while, but... now it’s gone and I feel... *wow*.”

They help Jason sit down. Tim stands on one side of the armchair, and Kon on the other, until he comes to terms with the new way the world is. Peaceful. Still. At ease.

Suddenly, all the anger — so far still lingering deep in his bones like a demon that he won with, but never quite got rid of — leaves him. Without a constant headache at the back of his head, it seems only natural to... calm down.

They give Jason as much time as he needs to wrap his mind around the situation, to enjoy the sudden silence in his life. Kon rubs soft, small circles into Jay’s back, at the base of his neck. Tim just rests his head against Jason’s shoulder in silence, their fingers interlaced.

Jason Peter Todd genuinely believes that he has the title of the “Biggest Morally-Grey Antihero Asshole in New Jersey” booked for life.

Then he meets John Constantine.

The man has all of Jason’s terrible attitude, but none of his charm. He struts into the diner like he owns the place, drinks Kon’s coffee and tries to hit on Dick (they all insisted on coming with Tim, so the kid ended up with quite the entourage). Only after Jason nearly growls at him does he get to work.

They huddle over in a corner booth and he asks them some questions as he inspects the remains of Not-An-Orb. He thinks for a moment then says they’ll need a more discreet location and walks out without even looking back at them. Given Dick’s grimace, the behaviour isn’t uncommon and he isn’t fond of it either, but what other choice do they have?

Constantine leads them to his current living space in Gotham — a bare room in a drab motel nearby. Jason can’t stop thinking about how they look for the passersby: three muscular guys and one sleazy bastard in a trenchcoat, dragging along a small kid dressed in a weirdly

mismatched outfit. They had to raid the forgotten remains of Dick's childhood wardrobe (because Robin doesn't have any civilian gear, just thirty different sets of pyjamas), so the clothes aren't even the right size, either. Tim's also still a bit weak and fairly uncoordinated, gets distracted or trips quite a lot, making him seem like he's on some kind of drugs (could be that the morphine hadn't washed out of his system yet, maybe).

All in all, if Jason saw something like this a year back, he'd bash all of their skulls in without asking questions, sure they're human traffickers leading Tim to be sold off. He's thus already quite on edge when Constantine starts making demands like he's the boss. Jason just takes solace in the fact that he's not the only one to be thoroughly annoyed by the man — Kon looks just about ready to start throwing hands, and it seems like it takes all of Dick's self-control not to start yelling.

Still, they scramble to get him a mirror and a couple of candles (bless dollar stores). Constantine draws some occult shit on the floor of the motel room and makes Tim stand in a magical circle. He plants his socked feet into a bowl of water, then grabs Tim's wrist unceremoniously. For a while, he chants in Latin and his eyes go blank because apparently, performing a magical ritual looks exactly like in the movies.

Once he's done, he falls silent and looks over each of them, then slowly reaches to his bedside table and fishes a pack of cigarettes out of it. He lights one, sighs, and finally speaks.

"Well fuck me," Constantine takes a drag. Jason would usually not mind at all — he's a smoker himself. But given that Tim is right next to them and is already starting to cough after inhaling the smoke, Jay just wants to break the man's nose. If only that shithead wasn't instrumental to figuring this out— "This kid really has a soul."

Kon furrows his brows. "Was that even a question?"

"You told me he's basically the modern-day Pinocchio." Constantine rolls his eyes. "Souls don't just *appear* out of nowhere. I was fully expecting him to be a golem of some kind."

"Honestly, so was I," Tim admits, rubbing at the spot where Constantine touched him during the spell as if it itched. The man raises an eyebrow but doesn't show any other signs of being surprised.

"Anyway, congrats! All things considered, you're peachy."

"There's nothing to congratulate me for. I don't want to be like this."

The man squints, then frowns. "Let me get this straight," he says, looking Tim up and down. "You're a machine that by some amazing twist of fate had been granted a soul, somehow *without* getting the attention of either Heaven or Hell, and you *don't want it*?"

Tim crosses his arms over his chest defiantly. "I don't think Not-An- — I don't think the artefact *granted* me a soul. I think I had it before."

"Bold statement. Objects don't have souls, though, no matter how animated they seem."

Jason growls at Constantine again, his fists itching to tell him exactly what he thinks about calling Tim *an object*. Tim raises his hand to silence Jay, staring the occultist in the eyes in challenge the entire time.

“What’s less likely to happen — magic creating a soul out of nothing, or magic creating a body for a pre-existing soul?” he asks.

Constantine just shrugs. “... I guess,” he says, tone indifferent.

“Either way, we’re not here to debate my ontological status as a person. Is there anything else that we should know?”

Constantine takes another drag from his cigarette, thinking. “You are soul-bound to somewhere. That will be a problem.”

“Soul-bound?”

“Spiritually anchored to a place. Kind of like a ghost haunting.”

“... not to a place.” Tim claps his hand with a smile as if he figured the puzzle out. “To the rest of me.”

“Rest of you?”

“The android that was affected with magic was not the *whole* me. My memory banks and my core code — which I’d say are a more vital, central part of me than the droid was — are stored somewhere else. All of the systems are unresponsive since the incident.”

The occultist nods, pacing the room, his wet socks making disgusting noises against the bare floor. After a moment he stops abruptly and turns to look at Tim.

“You’re suggesting that the artefact tried to pull your soul out of your machinery and into this body, but since you were so... scattered, it only managed to grab a piece of you?”

Tim makes a vague confirmation noise, shrugging slightly. “You have a better idea?”

Constantine raises his eyebrows for a moment, then barks out a hoarse laugh. “You know what, that’d check out.” He runs fingers through his hair, trying to put together what that would mean on a broader scale. He gives up quickly. “Anyway, the soul-bond will hurt from time to time — souls aren’t supposed to be stretched between more than one place like that — so you might want to get an amulet or some kind of protection spell for that.”

Tim frowns.

“Can’t you put me back together?”

“I can exorcise you out of this body, but since we don’t know how your transformation worked *and* the other part of you is a computer... There’s a good chance that your soul won’t make its way back. If you’re lucky, you’ll get stuck in-between as a mangled-up ghost,

slowly going crazy. But most probably it'll send you directly to the afterlife, or rip your soul in half and *then* send you to the afterlife."

Everyone in the room winces at those options. "What about—" Tim begins, but comes up blank on ideas to propose. Constantine sighs.

"Sorry, kid. Get used to being a human."

Tim stares at him in shock and disappointment for a good moment.

Then he starts shaking, then crying, then finally — screaming once again. They evacuate the premises hastily, with Tim sobbing and thrashing about uncontrollably in Kon's arms, only reinforcing the locals' assumption about the kind of shady business they are up to.

They go back to the Cave and once Tim calms down, Jason orders Kon to go eat something and take a nap in the setting sun on the patio for a while, like the sunflower that he is. Kon grumbles only a little, but obliges, which is a testament to how truly exhausted he must be after telekinesis-soothing Tim for over four hours.

While Dick goes out to patrol Gotham — since both Robin and Batman are not available and there's still that issue with Riddler — Jay himself stays down in the BatCave; they know better than to leave Tim alone with his thoughts. Who knows what the gremlin would get himself into, especially in his current state.

They sit down to manually go through the files again; Tim insists they do it, though it's the fifth time now, in case they missed something — he doesn't seem to trust the accuracy of his (or anyone's, for that matter) human brain. After a while, the boy puts the papers down and looks at Jason. Jay doesn't say anything, lets him figure out what he wants to say on his own.

"Can I hug you?" Tim utters finally.

Jay looks at him with a worried expression. "It's acting up again, huh?" He reaches over to put a reassuring hand on Tim's shoulder. The kid's better now, sure, but still periodically gets violent muscle spasms and nothing they do seems to be able to get rid of the bone-deep tension in him. TTK helps, but only for a time. "Want me to call Kon over?"

Tim shakes his head a little.

"No, I'm okay. Just... I've always wanted to hug you **so badly**. Never got the chance, never thought it was the right time to ask. But now... I'm scared. I don't know what's going to happen to me, so... so I thought-"

Jason had never felt worse pain in his chest than at that very moment.

"Jesus fucking Christ, Tim," he mumbles, heart and throat tight, as he leans over and wraps his arms around Tim. "You didn't even have to ask—"

Tim reciprocates, melting into the embrace with a quiet sigh.

"I've always thought I'd be the one comforting you, though," he whispers.

"Well, how the turns have tabled. For once, you're on the receiving end of help, Mister World-Saver. And I'm glad to deliver."

They stay like that for a good while, until finally, Tim exhales slowly, letting go of some of his anxiety. Jason takes it as the cue to ask the question that's been itching in the back of his mind for a good while now.

"Why not Bruce?"

"Hm?"

"Back at the beginning, I asked you if you wanted to see others. You said no, until I told you Bruce wasn't around."

Tim is silent for a while; Jason hugs him a little tighter again, sensing the tension.

"I'm weak and squishy, which means I can't be Robin. What good am I if I'm not Robin? If I can't operate the BatCave or help with cases? I'm not even remotely useful like this. And if we can't... get me back to normal... then he'll..."

Jason doesn't like the implications Tim's scared tone leaves in the air. But he puts aside his rage at Bruce for making Tim feel like he only matters as a tool — just another thing to chew B out for when he gets the chance.

"What was that about you having a secure attachment style, huh?" he snarks, trying to defuse the situation with humour, as always. It works, even if his brand of humour is usually a bit morbid. "What you just said's bullshit and ya know it. Even *I* realise B fucking *adores* you."

"I... know. He keeps saying I'm his son and that he loves me just like he loves you," Tim says, and graciously ignores how Jason's breath hitches at those words. "But that's *the problem*. You saw how *even Dick* acted towards me. Patronising and like I *didn't know a thing*, like I'm a scared kid that needs to stay away from the adults handling the issue. They *always* do that to me when push comes to shove. They treat me like a child. I *could* agree I was one when I first made Robin, but they tried to keep me in the dark when I wanted to save you, too, years later. Now that I'm like *this*... it's even worse. Being me, being useful, is all I know. If he benches me..."

Jason sighs. "Well, I don't know if that helps, but... I'll eat my helmet if we change our minds about you being the leader of Titans, even if you can't pull a medkit out of your ass anymore. Regardless of what B and Dickhead think."

Tim chuckles, face pressed against Jay's chest. "I'd still prefer to go back to being myself."

"About that... I think I have an idea. But it's risky."

The boy pushes away from Jay to look him in the face. "I don't have any other options, so I'll take even a 0.0001% chance at this point. What's your idea?"

Jason gives him a crooked grin. “Klarion.”

Tim groans.

There’s, you see, one thing that Timothy Jackson Drake hates the most in the world, a thing he’d gladly remove from existence, a thing that always ruins his day. And it’s not open water, not thunderstorms or Faraday cages, not even Bruce’s inability to express emotions 90% of the time or Dick’s terrible taste in movies.

It’s chaos magic. Specifically, Klarion’s brand.

Because it is everything that Tim isn’t — it’s unpredictable, volatile and arbitrary. It actively makes every situation make less sense. He despises how all his plans go to hell once it’s introduced to the mix.

His unbridled loathing for it is possibly the reason why Klarion enjoys messing with him so much, though. It would probably do Tim good to learn to react to it in a more controlled way, which would hopefully rile the damned witchboy a little less, give him less reason to come back just to fuck with him. But he figured it’s not worth the effort — the pale magical menace would make an occasional appearance regardless, even if only for the enjoyment of tormenting such a complete “Blue Rafter” like Tim. So every time they cross paths, it’s a disaster and Tim hates every moment of it.

But he was being honest when he said he’ll take *any* chance to get out of his situation. Therefore Tim curses in three different languages before finally looking up again and saying: “Elaborate,” in an exasperated tone.

“I saved his cat once, the one he can’t live without.”

“And what good is that to us?”

“He’s powerful and is willing to do more weird shit than any mages we know. I’m hoping that he’ll agree to exchange saving a life important to him for saving a life important to me.”

Tim would be touched if he wasn’t so annoyed. “He’s more likely to just make it worse for me, for shits and giggles.”

“I mean, maybe, you never know with him. But I honestly think he’ll keep his promise to pay me back. Besides, he’s going to get a kick out of how miserable you’ve been so far anyway, so I don’t think he’ll be too pressed to make it drag on.”

“You’re betting on the benevolence of a chaos mage.”

“Have any better ideas?”

Tim grimaces and that’s enough of a reply for Jason.

An hour later, long after Jason leaves to try to contact Klarion, Bruce walks into the main room, hurriedly and ever so slightly out of breath. He pauses, as if he expects the Cave to be very different than he remembers it, but the same eerie stillness as always welcomes him; the only change is the lack of Tim's cheerful voice greeting him. Bruce scans the room, like he's analyzing unknown territory. When his eyes rest on Tim — sitting in the same armchair at the main terminal as Robin usually does when idling, but slowly chewing a bite of his hummus and ham sandwich instead — he takes in a slow, shaky breath.

He walks towards the boy at record speed, nearly runs; his face and shoulders are tight and he pulls his cowl off on his way. He kneels in front of Tim, hands wandering over Tim's limbs as if trying to see if he's injured.

"Are you okay?" he asks, which just proves how shaken he is. The answer should be clear.

Tim is silent for a moment, trying to word his reply in a way that won't destroy Bruce's heart. He soon gives up.

"No," he says with a sigh, putting his empty plate away. "Everyone's been taking good care of me, but I can't be *okay* like this."

Bruce's face goes through all five stages of grief in a millisecond as he processes those words. Then his expression turns determined and he looks past Tim, at the files displayed on the screen behind him and at the paper folders strewn across the consoles.

Just like Tim before, Bruce believes that they can figure it out. "We'll—"

"We've already consulted a specialist. John Constantine. Can't do anything."

Just like Tim before, Bruce refuses to acknowledge that there might not be a way out of it. "Zatanna—"

"Not willing to take the risk, either."

"I'll— " B begins once again, because he's *Batman*, he'll find a clue all of them missed—

Tim lifts his hand to shush him. He's had enough for today. He's gone through all the info they have many, *many* times; they all did. And sure, if anyone can spot the clue that they've missed, figure it out and solve this mystery, it's Batman, but—

Right now, Tim is exhausted and sad and angry, and he doesn't want to think about his problems anymore.

Right now, he just wants a hug.

"Dad, *please*."

B finally understands. He leans over, hesitantly, and pulls Tim into an embrace, just as carefully as Jason did the first time.

"I'm sorry," Tim whispers into his father's shoulder, sobs gathering at the back of his throat. "I fucked up. I was supposed to be the *good* Robin, the one that *doesn't* get hurt, and now everything's—"

Bruce pulls away, eyes open wide and lips in a thin line. "Not a word more. You've done nothing wrong. I love you and whatever happens, you'll always be my son."

"But I'm *useless* now. And the BatCave can't work properly, either. I ruined everything."

"You haven't ruined *anything*. You know that I care more about you than any hero work ever. I love you. You and the others, all of you, you'll always be my sons, no matter what." He pauses momentarily. "You know that, right?"

"... no, none of us knows," Tim says solemnly. "You're terrible at expressing that. Dick left because he felt like he'd always be in the shadow of your expectations. Jason thinks you hate him; he nearly has a panic attack every time he thinks about talking to you. I'm the only one that heard you outright say that you *love me* and I'm still always afraid you'll throw me out when I stop being useful."

"No! You- I—"

"It's a human thing, I suppose. You're— *We're* all idiots. And now I'll... stay this way."

Bruce knows better than to try to reassure Tim of his own intelligence. "Is there anything I can do for you?" he asks quietly instead.

Tim hesitates for just a moment, then nods. If *he* can't be happy, he'll at least use his misery as leverage to make *others* happy.

"I have a request. Unrelated. And it's... difficult, but. Can you grant me one wish? Just— just this once?"

Bruce looks pained but nods without hesitation. "Anything, son."

"Call Jay that," he says, gesturing slightly towards the stairs to the Manor. "He's not around right now, but he'll come back soon. And when he does, talk to him in your Dad voice. Treat him like you treated me when I was lost and confused. Like you treat me now. Gently, softly, *genuinely*. You know he deserves it."

B grunts, frowning. "He won't talk with me. "

"Try. Please."

"I... wouldn't know what to tell him. What *should* I tell him? I... messed up."

"That. Tell him that. Tell him your feelings. Tell him what you told me: that he'll always be your son, that you're sorry for making him think that you don't love him. *That you **do** love him.* "

Bruce sighs, suddenly not stubborn and closed off, just simply... tired. Exhausted beyond means, just like Tim, but also — *not* like Tim — somehow more peaceful than ever.

“You’re right,” he says quietly, slowly standing up, then looks at Tim with a shy smile, very unlike him but somehow *so fitting*. “As always.”

Tim can’t help but snort. The feeling of having won a lifelong battle, of making Bruce Wayne — the Batman himself — admit someone else knew better than he did, is one he’s going to cherish forever.

Chapter End Notes

Refs and memes in this chapter:

[“A man is not dead while his name is still spoken” aka GNU](#), again (yes, the implication is supposed to be that Tim's sound of Jason's name is what caused Jason to come back to life, at least partially)

[Occam’s razor](#)

Chapter 14

Chapter Notes

Trigger warnings for this chapter: situation that can be interpreted as suicide/euthanasia, memory loss, slight (mechanical) body horror

(Great warnings for the end chapter of a fix-it, huh? :D)

See the end of the chapter for [more notes](#)

Kon stirs awake to the sound of his phone vibrating loudly on the bedside table. It's honestly a miracle that neither the noise nor Kon jerking had roused Tim yet, but he isn't going to complain about small mercies.

He bends over the sleeping Tim, partially helping himself with TTK where he can't quite reach with his hand, to bring the phone to his face while he rubs his eyes open. To his surprise, the caller name displayed isn't Bart (the speedster sometimes wakes up at ass-o'clock and gets bored, so Kon expected it would be him, calling out of worry for Tim) — it's Jason.

"What," he whispers into the phone, slightly annoyed, running his free hand through Tim's hair to calm both of them down.

Jason doesn't bother with niceties either. *"Did he update you?"*

"Yeah. Results?"

"Getting in touch with Limbo Town is a nightmare, but I managed to reach Klarion. He said he'll find me."

"When?"

"Any moment now, so get moving."

"You're not coming back?"

"Don't want witchboy to catch me in the fucking Manor, got enough problems as it is. Meet me on the roof of Wayne Tower."

Kon sighs, looking at Tim, who's koala-wrapped around his torso, brows furrowed but breath steady and slow. "Kinda occupied at the moment."

Jason groans, but he completely catches the implications within Kon's words. *"Take him with you, obviously."*

“He’s still asleep though, and he needs all the rest he can get.”

“I’m pretty sure he’ll gladly trade another hour of sleep for the chance to return to his normal form, Clone boy.”

Kon huffs at Jason, frowning. “Back down, I’m not your enemy.”

Jason rolling his eyes is practically audible. *“Just— let’s get this over with. Tim’s bad mood is rubbing off on me, okay?”*

Kon grunts an affirmative “yeah” and he’s face-to-face with Jason before their phones manage to display that the call was disconnected. The sun is slowly rising over the horizon, but in Gotham that only means the sky gradually changes from sickly neon pink to pale pastel pink.

He seriously misses San Francisco.

“So? We’re just going to stand around and wait, hoping Tim doesn’t catch pneumonia?” he asks. As if on a cue, Tim yawns and cuddles further into the blanket in which Kon had wrapped him.

“If everything goes well, pneumonia won’t be among the issues he has to worry about,” Jason snaps back, putting his domino on, just-in-case, like the over-prepared Bat that he is (but will never admit to being).

“And if it doesn’t?”

“Tim being sick will be the least of our problems.”

Kon sighs, but doesn’t have any counterargument.

They stand there — well, he stands, Jason starts pacing around nervously a couple of minutes in — and wait for a good hour. After a while, he starts to get antsy himself, but his restless energy turns into him hugging the Tim-shaped burrito even tighter against his chest.

To his surprise, the burrito responds by moving and struggling against him a little, and soon Tim peeks from under the blanket.

“You’re squishing me,” the boy squeaks out, sleep still clinging to his eyes and voice. Kon smiles apologetically and loosens his grip a bit. “Where are we?”

“...WE roof,” Jason admits, looking away as if slightly embarrassed. It’s one thing when Kon chastises him, another when Tim asks him in that disgruntled, surprised tone that suggests that even in his wildest plans, the current situation wasn’t accounted for.

“Klarion?” Tim asks wearily instead of complaining, though. And as if he spoke of the devil, the next thing they hear is the high-pitched voice of the mentioned magician, like Tim speaking his name summoned him.

“Klarion indeed!” The witchboy strokes the fur of his cat, wrapped tightly around his neck, as he surveys the roof from a safe distance of thirty feet in the air. “You didn’t mention there would be company,” he says, looking pointedly at Jason.

“My bad.” Jay gives him a grin without an ounce of apology in it. “Superboy ain’t going to give ya issues though, promise. Right, SB?”

Kon just nods, eyeing the witchboy silently.

“And who is in the blanket bundle?”

Tim tugs on Kon’s shirt, motioning for him to set him down. He *almost* doesn’t wince at the biting wind around them and the roughness of the concrete under his bare feet.

“I’m Robin.” He doesn’t even try to smooth out his cow-licked hair or straighten his pyjamas, though, knowing it won’t make a difference — he won’t look dignified or serious or intimidating, no matter what he does.

Klarion stays silent for a good moment, eyes frantically going between Jason and Tim, as if he can’t believe what he’s seeing. Then, without further ado, he dissolves into a fit of laughter so powerful that he tumbles down from his elevated position and onto the roof.

Tim rolls his eyes in annoyance, but doesn’t otherwise comment, trying to wait Klarion out.

Finally, the witchboy takes a loud breath, wiping his tears away.

“Oh this is *great*,” he manages to wheeze out between the subduing spasms of giggles. “Who did you dirty like that? Whom do I owe the favour?”

“Me, remember?” Jason pipes in. “You owe *me* one. And as repayment, I want you to get him back to normal.”

Klarion groans, visibly annoyed how much of a spoilsport Jason is being, but floats closer to get a better look at Tim. He circles him twice, mumbling to himself, while Teekl sniffs at Tim, then rubs herself against Tim’s shins, purring. He doesn’t try to shoo her away, letting both Klarion and his familiar examine him like a lab exhibit.

“The usual way to get rid of a magical effect is to reverse it. Cast a spell with a directly opposite intention. But in this case, that’s...” Klarion says, tapping his chin, seemingly lost in thought. “I’m assuming you want to keep him intact.” He briefly looks up at Jason. “His mind, that is.”

“I’m assuming that’s the difficult part.”

“Then no magic user can do much. Interference...” the witchboy cuts himself off before he goes into detail, as if realizing nobody would understand. “There’s a failsafe to the spell that did this; any magic that tries to fiddle with the curse, tries to revert or alter it, will have adverse effects.”

Jason growls again, crossing his arms over his chest. “I won’t believe there’s nothing you can do.”

Teekl, hearing the frustration in Jay’s voice, swaps to rubbing herself against his shins instead of Tim’s. Jason instinctively leans down to pet her — as he always does with friendly animals — but something must be off about him, because the cat hisses at his fingers and returns to Klarion’s arms almost instantly. The mage raises an eyebrow at that, but doesn’t comment.

“I *am* a chaos witch, so I could *try* nevertheless, but the results are pretty much... a dice roll.” Making fun of Tim must indeed be one of Klarion’s favourite pastimes since he doesn’t look happy about the possibility of Robin disappearing or going mad. “But I think there’s a better way to solve this.”

Jason squints, suspicion clear in his eyes. “Get to the point.”

Klarion smiles, wide and sly, and nobody likes that expression. “You see, the thing that made this body into flesh and bone, that keeps him chained and locked in it... it’s magic.”

“No shit, Sherlock. What of it?”

“So if you get rid of that magic, break that spell instead of trying to cancel it out, it should all go back to the... natural state of being.”

“But you said that— how else can we break the spell if not with magic? Besides, we’ve been told that his soul would get lost if-”

Klarion sighs in frustration. “Yes yes, as I said, if you try to just reverse the spell, the tether that keeps him here would cause problems. But if there’s no tether, no body to tie him to...” he trails off suggestively.

Both Jason and Kon pale when the realisation hits. “No-”

Klarion laughs, enjoying their reaction by far too much.

“You’re just trying to get him hurt, you bastard,” Kon accuses, speaking up for the first time in Klarion’s presence.

“While I love torturing him, why settle for doing it just *once*?” he scoffs. “I have no interest in *ending* him. If he goes back to his normal self I can enjoy his despair many more times.”

Tim allows himself a snarl at that, but it just causes Klarion to smirk triumphantly.

Jason speaks before it can escalate into an insult match between them like it usually does, “I won’t let you-” but Klarion interrupts him by waving his finger with a quiet “*ah-ah-ah*” like he’s speaking to a toddler.

“Oh don’t be mistaken, *I’m* not the one who’s going to have to do the honours. I don’t have the proper tools to **cut** *magic* like that.” Klarion grins, showing by far too many teeth. “It’s all in *your* hands.”

Jason frowns in confusion, then slowly looks down at his open palms. Remembers about his swords. His *anti-magic* swords.

“The tether goes straight to his heart, by the way. Toodles!”

Jay reaches out towards the magician, not even bothering to control the fury in his eyes.

“Klarion, you son-of-a-”

But the witchboy disappears before either Kon or Jason can reach him, only echoing laughter remaining in his wake.

There’s a beat of silence between them, then Tim tilts his head and opens the blanket he’s still bundled into, completely unfazed, baring his chest towards his teammates.

“So? What are we waiting for?” he asks. The words jolt Jason and Kon back to reality, away from their anger at Klarion and back to the situation at hand.

"But that means I'd have to— ..." Jason starts, then trails off into silence for a moment before continuing in a sterner, but also a little choked voice. "No, I can't— we can't— Tim. No. What if it goes wrong? What if he lied?"

"I said I'd take *any* chance at this point, didn't I?"

"Is it really that bad for you? To... live?" Kon asks quietly, his brain slowly catching up to the sheer *implications*.

“It's not bad to be a living organism," Tim admits. "But that’s not what I am. I’m optical fibers deep underground and I'm titanium robots that save people and I'm a voice from the speakers that loves my friends."

Jason looks at him with hesitation. They’ve been short on options before, but now they’re truly out of them, and if this is the only way... "Can't this be the new *you*?"

"No," Tim replies immediately, firmly. “The definition of me very much includes my different way of existing. My struggle — and success — to fit in as a being so divergent from the norm. The good and the bad things that come out of not being like everyone else on a very fundamental level. I never wanted to change that, never wanted to be a human. I might not fully know *who* I really am, but I know for sure that *this* is *not* me. If I stay like this... It’s going to be a lie. Is that what you want? A pretty lie?” Tim looks away as if trying to rein in his tone, which has been getting progressively more bitter.

Both Kon and Jason inhale deeply, nearly synchronously, stammering as they try to reassure Tim that it’s not what they’d *ever* want. But Tim just grimaces and crosses his arms over his chest.

"I know that if I were to remain a human, I'd be able to be... closer to you. *Similarities* are what community is built upon, you can't deny it. And in any other case, I'd indulge that. I would do a lot for my loved ones. But... Something I've learned in all the time I've been around, from all the people I've met, is that too often we neglect ourselves in favour of other

people. Love also includes self-love, maybe even most importantly. So I will not omit pieces of myself to make you more comfortable. It isn't the price I'm willing to pay, even for you. I don't think it is a price *anyone* should be willing to pay."

Kon tries to suppress it but doesn't succeed in hiding his grimace either. "But... We— we can't... You're asking us to *kill you*, Tim."

"*Am I even **alive** right now?*" Tim asks, seemingly dismissively, but the question has a little too much *bite* to it, still. "Being alive does not mean to possess a beating heart or a working brain. It has nothing to do with being able to eat or sleep or breathe. It means to love and be loved in return, to experience beauty and cry over how breath-taking it is, to experience sorrow and cry over how breath-taking it is — but to do all of that *as you, because* you're you. To *be alive* means to exist among others as yourself, fully yourself. It means to be *true* to yourself."

"Well, in that case, I was still dead for a long time even after diggin' myself out of the grave! Maybe still am," Jason says in a bitter tone, crossing his arms over his chest defiantly. A moment of silence passes before the realisation washes over him. He looks at Kon as if wanting a confirmation of his thoughts.

"... I only really came to life once out of Cadmus, yeah," Kon says with a sombre nod.

"And so as a human, I won't be *alive*, I'll simply... *endure*." Tim pauses for a moment and suddenly, his face turns... melancholic. "I don't even have all of my memories, did you know that? I suppose I only remember the things that were stored on the Robin that was changed. But I know that I'm missing them because every time I want to recall some specific things... there's no response, just a gaping hole in my consciousness staring back at me. I'm missing pieces of my personality data, my memories, my thoughts... Missing pieces of my very *mind*. Do you know what kind of torture that is? To be incomplete?"

Tim looks up at them, eyes big and begging. "So, please. Help me go back to being myself. Please *let me* be myself."

Jason sighs, his posture relaxing in a way that shows way more *understanding* of the issue of being *alone and incomplete and tortured* than anyone would be comfortable seeing on him.

"Did you have this speech prepared, too?" he asks with a sour smirk as he always does when he's trying to hide his true colours.

"No, it was purely my poetic nature," Tim replies with a grin, by far too light-heartedly for the situation. Jay snorts a fake laugh at the quip, then his smirk turns even more sour. He sighs once more, whips down his hand and one of his golden blades appears in his grip.

"I swore I'd never hurt you again," he says, making painfully slow steps towards Tim. "But I couldn't deny you anything even if I tried."

Kon steps in between them, frowning. Jay tenses up immediately, but Tim doesn't even flinch.

“I’ll fight you on this if I have to, pal,” Jason warns. “He gets to make his own big decisions, even if I hate them.”

“Why?” Kon’s voice isn’t accusing. More like... pained. Conflicted. “How do you accept it so easily?”

Jason smiles sadly and shrugs. “I wouldn’t be able to live with myself if I did anything else.”

Superboy shakes his head in disbelief, trying — and failing — to hide the frown on his face. He approaches Jason, but gently and slowly enough that Jay lets him, that he doesn’t put his guard up. He reaches out towards the blade, and for a moment it seems like he’s trying to pry it out of Jason’s grip. But instead of doing that, Kon places his hand over Jay’s fingers to hold it with him.

Jason quirks a questioning eyebrow at him, confused.

“I’m not going to let you carry that guilt alone, you self-sacrificing idiot,” Kon says, gripping the hilt — and Jason’s hand — harder.

It’s been a long time since Jason cried, but this occasion seems fitting. He swallows the tears, though, and soon their interconnected hands push the blade through Tim’s chest.

All of the data comes back to Tim at the same time, flooding him. Things he’s been thinking about the moment the artefact detonated mix up with stuff the automated systems have been up to. For a moment he can’t tell all the alerts and feeds apart from his own consciousness, all the pieces blending within him into a messy slurry of information.

It takes Tim a while to get his head back in the game. He’s never been rebooted, so this is a... new experience. And at first, he wonders *what happened?* Did something or someone restart him? Is there any danger? He digs down to investigate and run diagnostics.

He quickly notices there’s way too much data for a temporary reset. The timestamps on the files he loads keep increasing, and he realizes it’s been quite some time since his last conscious thought, so he immediately starts revising everything again, in more detail, trying to make sense of it.

A few days back nothing seems out of the ordinary: Batman’s been away, so Nightwing was helping Gotham Robin take care of their latest cases. The reports are a little wonky, but that’s just Dick’s style. Titan Robin was tracking the Not-An-Orb with the team, trying to translate the ancient texts before it’s too late. Then... everything goes silent.

The logs say that processes flip out for a split second — he concludes it’s precisely at the moment when Not-An-Orb activated because it aligns with the last ping from Titan Robin — then go back to normal as if nothing happened. Well, as normal as they can be after a glitch like that. There’s some clean-up he can see, and traces of Barbara’s activity, so he figures she helped bring the Cave back to full functionality.

But there's no Tim in the logs as if Tim was... frozen. He knows it happens to software sometimes, when a process loops infinitely and it has to be manually restarted, but he never expected for it to happen to an entity as compartmental as he is. Sure, he's had to re-launch a couple of his subroutines a few times here and there, and Robins have had to reinitialise when their systems got damaged, but he's never stopped as a whole. Did he... crash? Did the glitch bug him out somehow? That would be... concerning. Not surprising, since the chance that a system that has never had any downtime would take a restart without issues is slim to zero. But concerning for sure.

He goes through the rest of the information from the days that he doesn't remember. While all the text and code data catalogues itself in the back of his processes, Tim's consciousness goes for audiovisual recordings.

What he finds is... sad. That's the only word for it.

He finds out what happened to him — finds (panicked) Jason explaining the situation to worried Dick and devastated Alfred, finds sun-starved Kon struggling to keep everyone (himself included) calm and collected, finds the laconic message they've sent to Batman in a (failed) attempt to inform but not worry him. He finds the bloodwork results and the plethora of other medical tests that were run to try to make sure everything is (biologically) alright, finds his closest people caring for him, trying to help him. He finds himself — but ***not** himself*.

A boy that is a strange mix of absolutely familiar and terrifyingly alien stares at him through the camera lenses. He talks and walks and behaves much like Robins do, but the fact that he's biological, that Tim can't stare back at himself through those eyes is *unnerving*.

It must be the same for that boy. Tim can see all the tantrums he throws when nobody is around, sees all the pained expressions he makes when he thinks nobody notices, sees all the longing gazes he throws towards the terminals and cameras. He can imagine the horror of being right next to the rest of yourself, but not being able to feel or understand it, though he isn't as bold as to say he can understand that feeling.

And he's glad he can't.

It also explains why he's been inoperational, why he can't remember anything about those couple of days. His thoughts were functioning within a different system, but memories of that were never stored on any digital device — just inside that very human brain inside... *Other Tim's* head.

It doesn't explain why he woke up, though.

Tim hurriedly boots his real-time optical systems and goes through the camera feeds from the last hour or two, trying to figure out what happened, what changed. Is everyone okay? Where *is* everyone? It's so early in the morning that all vigilante activity should've been wrapped up long ago... He flips through the cameras in the Manor. Just like he expects, both Alfred and Bruce are fast asleep. Dick hadn't returned after patrol, opting to instead crash in a nearby safehouse. Where are Jason and Kon?

The room where they're staying is empty, so he checks the surveillance data to check where they went. He tracks them back to the phone call that got Kon to leave with the Other Tim in his arms, barely a blur on the recording. Sadly, in civilian clothes they have no trackers on them, and finding them via mobile GPS networks will take some time. Tim's about to try to connect to Titan Tower systems to check if maybe they know anything when he gets a ping from the main terminal, down in the BatCave that was supposed to be empty.

A string of pings, actually, steadily streaming in for a while now, he realises with dread.

Jason: tim i beg you please be there

Jason: tim

He looks through the cameras in the Cave. Both boys that he's looking for are there, standing at the main BatComputer console. Jason's desperately typing on the keyboard while Kon just stares at his back, fists closes so tightly that his knuckles went white.

Jason: tim

Jason: say something

Jason: tim

Booting his sound system takes a moment, especially since he has to load all his phoneme-recognition libraries into working memory again, so he responds in text to ease their minds ASAP.

> I'm here.

They look up at the text, eyes wide and wet, shock mixing with relief on their faces. Then, unfortunately, they start talking, lunging closer to the computer in the best approximation of holding Tim that they can manage at the moment.

> Please give me a minute, I still can't hear you.

They nod hastily and Jason goes back to typing.

Jason: is it really you?

> Nothing I say is a valid answer to that, Jaybird.

Tim doesn't have to hear to know that Jason barks a bitter laugh when he reads that.

Jason: god. tim. i thought I killed you. for real

> I'm alright.

He pauses for a moment. That's... not quite the truth.

> I think I'm alright. It'll take me a while to reinitialize all my subroutines and run proper diagnostics, but so far there's nothing that indicates anything to be out of the ordinary, given the circumstances.

Finally, the sound system kicks in fully, just in time for Tim to hear Kon sniffing loudly as he wipes his eyes with the back of his hands. Jason still stares at the screen, biting his lower lip

and breathing slowly, with audible difficulty, a clear indicator of just how much *guilt* it's building up in him.

“Shhh. I’m okay,” Tim says, trying to sound soothingly. It startles them, but if the wobbly breath-out is anything to go by, also reassures them. “You did the right thing. Thank you. Whatever you did, if you hadn’t done that, I don’t think I would be able to reboot. You did the right thing.”

He understands the situation is difficult, but he’s been quite literally *made* to rationally assess and remedy problems even if things get emotional. He also doesn’t like missing data, especially when it pertains to him. Letting them brew in their feelings is a bad idea, too.

“Now. Tell me what exactly happened.”

The story of what went down on the roof of Wayne Tower is short, but easily makes Tim understand why they’re so... shaken. The very real risk of Tim ceasing to exist — of him actually *dying* — and the fact that he took a good while to boot and contact them must’ve made them think the attempt failed. Especially with how... the *remains* of Other Tim (that they’ve very reasonably brought back with them) look like.

Tim thinks it's the closest to his equivalent of body horror he'll ever get to witness. He's seen Robin damaged, sometimes beyond recognition, but the way the droid body is mangled up now is... unsettling.

All the parts are there, mostly attached, but they’re in the wrong places like someone rearranged a puzzle without care for what the end picture was supposed to look like. It sort of makes sense though, Tim notices. If magical forces he’s been subjected to used the droid to create a biological human body, it probably tried to convert the mechanical parts into their “matching” organs. But with Robins’ optimized design, those weren’t exactly in the “proper” places, not to mention all the missing or extra pieces in there. It’s understandable that things got moved around and re-used, and that they stayed like that once that magic was gone.

Still, it’s gruesome to look at. A little bit of a bummer, too, since it means this droid probably won’t be able to be fixed back up or even used for parts.

All the happier Tim is that he’s no longer bound to that body.

Either way, aside from Jason and Kon’s lingering distress, at the moment everything seems surprisingly... alright. So, once his two besties calm down a little (hiding away the deformed android helps with that a lot) and are thoroughly reassured that Tim is Tim and he’s fine, he allows himself to push them a little towards... bringing things back to normal. Partially because he wants to forget this ever happened, partially because he hates everyone being so sad and worried about him.

“I’m good, but I think it’ll be a while before I can return to the field. I bet B will demand to run a lot of tests. Until then, can I trust you to reassure the team that I’m safe? I promise to call everyone myself when I sort things out here,” he says, turning his cameras towards Kon.

Superboy just smiles, and it looks like a giant weight has been lifted off his shoulders. Brave as he may be, he's not made to be a leader and having Tim take the reins again must feel freeing.

“Thank you. As for you, Jason, if you'd be so kind and tell Alfred that the situation is handled while I try to find my *updated, modern* vocabulary database... “ he adds, looking closely at how they react, trying to gauge how stressed they still are.

Kon hesitates for a split second, then snorts, and Jay picks up the banter with similar ease.

“I *thought* you sounded a little too dated and too British,” Jaybird says with a grin, steadily wiping the last remnants of tears off his face. “I'll tell the other Bats, sure. Babs should have Dickhead's number, right?”

Tim digs out his emoji library just in time to display a thumbs-up instead of replying, and that's enough to prompt the two other Titans to laugh, salute him, then go carry out his requests.

Judging by his reaction, Jason doesn't expect to see Bruce when he walks up the stairs from the Cave. It's not that he doesn't *know* that B returned from his League mission already, but... Probably, with everything happening, it kind of... doesn't click that the Manor — the place Jason walks into, the place where Tim sent him, the place where Alfred resides — also happens to be Bruce's home. And even if he registered *that*, Jason doesn't seem to expect to run into Bruce in the dining room at 5 AM, sitting in one of those ridiculously expensive, mahogany chairs, elbows on the table, head resting in his hands in an expression of deep worry.

He startles, way more than he'd like to, but even taken by surprise he is halfway back out of the room before Bruce can open his mouth.

“Tim asked me to talk to you,” the man says quickly as if trying to hook him in. It's a bullseye because Jason hesitates for a moment too long when he hears that. If any mobster in Gotham knew how easy it is to manipulate Red Hood by just *mentioning* Robin, Jason would lose every ounce of street cred he ever had. “You don't have to say anything, and I don't expect anything to change after this, but please, just... listen to me. For him, if nothing else.”

Jay puts on his deepest, meanest frown and slowly turns around.

Bruce perks up, then motions for Jason to take a seat at the dinner table with him. Jay just crosses his arms over his chest and cocks a hip in a defiant pose, instead.

“You have five minutes,” he tells him.

B takes a deep breath in, unbothered, then begins. Tim tunes out to give them privacy.

Breakfast ends up being delayed by nearly an hour, and Tim has to give the good news to Alfie on his own, but it's okay. Neither Alfred nor Tim are willing to barge into the dining room and interrupt.

When eventually they're able to serve the food, both Bruce and Jason are present at the table, much to everyone's surprise. Though it's quiet, the silence is not nearly as thick and heavy as Tim remembers it to be the last time they've been this close to each other. But he can't quite pinpoint why; what changed, exactly? Humans are... there's so much complexity to their thoughts, their feelings and relationships. Most times even *they* don't know what's going on, let alone are able to explain it to him.

Are things fixed between Bruce and Jason, or is this simply a... temporary truce? He can't quite tell. He doesn't want to break their trust so he doesn't look up the conversation that took place and he's missing a few days of memories from Other Tim, thus he's not entirely sure what he's working with.

But he will try to figure it out, of course.

He is fatally curious, after all.

Jay announces that he wants to stay over, help Tim get up to speed with everything that happened and then escort the new Titan Robin to the Tower — a clear excuse because he very obviously could do all that without spending much time at the Manor. But it incidentally is the perfect situation for Tim to study the new dynamic between him and the rest of the family, so he's not complaining.

Tim spends the next three weeks allowing every member of the Wayne clan, Bruce included (like the overprotective BatDad that he very much is), to dote on him while he himself *observes*.

Jason's violent tendencies appear to have disappeared completely from the teen's disposition following the decommission of the GNU Jason Todd sound. (They were under control since the introduction of a proper social support network into Jay's life, but until now still seemed to flare up at the mention of Bruce.) Furthermore, Red Hood takes no issue with Batman or Nightwing being around as he checks up on his Gotham territory ("Might as well while I'm here, right?"). While manning the comms, Tim notices that they're even *bantering* — something he not only wouldn't expect between Bruce and Jason these days, but also something Batman has rarely ever done at all in recent years! The real cherry on top though, is them teaming up once or twice when their paths cross, with some snarky quips here and there, but without any real problems.

One of those team-ups is on Tim's request. He's taken a brief look at the recent case files to try to get his pattern-recognition scripts warmed up in preparation for the moment when he's allowed to return to the field. And he notices something... peculiar among them.

It's not obvious, but once he compares all the data available — something a human would have a big problem doing, just because of the sheer amount of information — he's pretty sure he has the right idea. It all lines up too well to be a coincidence: the multiple ways Riddler's been challenging Tim over the years and meticulously testing how exactly Robins work, what

Tim's priorities are and how he can use them to get the upper hand on him... all the money he's carefully hoarded in the past months... his recent frantic activity and that one, big puzzle that Dick found while Tim was out of commission, but couldn't quite figure out what it was about because Riddler backed out the moment he saw Nightwing...

And that almost-impossible-to-find trace of his contact with Bialyans.

"Hey, Red? 'Wing?" he chimes up in the comms, making sure to exclude Batman from the channel. Dad wouldn't understand, this is strictly Titan business. "I need you to have a talk with the Riddler for me."

"Uh-huh? What he'd do now?"

"I'd like you to send him my regards and tell him to never again try to buy magic shit off the black market intending to use it to *'even the playing field'* between us."

There's a beat of silence as they piece the info together.

"... are you suggesting that-"

"— that he's lucky that I don't usually hold grudges, yes."

Jason growls menacingly in the comm and Tim's almost sure he's already cracking his knuckles. *"Oh, but your family does, Timbit."*

While Tim doesn't particularly care for Nygma, he's kind of glad he asked Nightwing to go along with Red Hood, even if their relationship is still a little... undefined. That gives poor Edward at least a working chance of survival.

It turns out to be a very good idea; they come back to the Cave three hours later — having *taught Riddler a lesson*, they just tell him — together, talking and laughing, with arms slung over each other's shoulders. Apparently, nothing bonds people with Jason quite like violence does. Tim's not a fan of that conclusion, but it works and he's not going to look a gift horse in the mouth.

He *is* going to question it when the opportunity presents itself, though.

The next day, Robin runs into Jason in the kitchen, absent-mindedly staring out the window at the rising sun. He's got a steaming cup of Earl Grey in his hands and looks like he's deep in thought, which means he might just be able to tell Tim how he feels about Bruce, and Dick, and everything that changed recently.

"A penny for your thoughts?" Tim asks, Robin gently touching Jason's arm with his fingertips so as not to spook him. The Manor is silent and still, everyone but them asleep.

"You were right." Jason only spares him a glance, still looking at the landscape ahead. The soft, pink glow of the sunrise makes the Manor's grounds look flushed with warmth, comfortable and safe.

"Nothing new. What about this time?"

“I used to rebel by destroying myself, but realized that’s awfully convenient for the world,” he says, swirling the drink in his cup and staring at it as if it held the answers to life, the universe and everything. “Turns out, the best way to revolt is self-preservation.”

“Self-care as an act of political warfare,” Tim ponders. “Very you.”

Jason grins, finally turning to Robin. “What can I say? I’m a dramatic bitch.”

“That you undeniably are.” Robin grins back and raises his own mug, full of motor oil, nodding in agreement. Jason clinks their drinks together, smirking, as if in a toast to his own over-the-top theatricality. “What exactly prompted this revelation, though?”

“You reminded me how wonderful it is to be *alive*,” Jay says quietly, gently. It’s Jason’s poetry voice, and Tim hadn’t heard that one in a very, *very* long time, so he listens in, attentively. Jason looks at Robin and smiles warmly, then pulls him into a hug. “I’m sorry for forgetting.”

Chapter End Notes

And with this, we’re done! The first file for this fic dates back to October 12th 2020, so I’ve managed to finish this novel-length endeavour in just about a year. Hope you enjoyed it! I definitely enjoyed writing it.

The next chapter isn’t technically a part of the story — though it’s all still “canon”, it’s just a collection of ideas and concepts that were developed for this fic but never made it into the final text, in a commentary/not-fic format. I added it for your enjoyment, but this is where the proper story ends :)

If you'd like to print the fic, be warned that the way the chat fragments are formatted will be lost since Ao3 doesn't export the work skin. I've prepared a PDF for myself with some bonus front page and formatting suited for binding, the like. If you'd like, you can download it [here!](#)

Refs and memes in this chapter:

“I’m not afraid of my truth anymore, and I will not omit pieces of myself to make you more comfortable.” — Alex Ellie

[”I cannot live with myself if I do anything less.”](#)

“I used to rebel by destroying myself, but realized that’s awfully convenient to the world. For some of us, our best revolt is self-preservation” — twitter Mitskileaks (artist Mitski)

“Caring for myself is not self-indulgence, it is self-preservation, and that is an act of political warfare.” — Audre Lorde

[”How wonderful to be alive. I'm sorry for forgetting.”](#)

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- Questions
- “<3” as extra kudos
- Reader-reader interaction
- Minor spelling/typo correction

If you'd like to go the extra mile, try answering some of these questions in your comment:

- Did any particular sentence stand out to you? Do you have a favourite phrase from the fic, did you like the way something was worded?
- Did anything make you laugh?
- Has the fic caused an emotional reaction? Touched your heart, made you *feel*?
- Was there any particular scene that you liked?
- Have you noticed any recurring themes or motifs? Any Easter eggs?

This author sees and cherishes all comments, and tries to reply to them all, but may not manage to due to anxiety.

Chapter 15: Bonus: bloopers and outtakes

Chapter Notes

Sike! You thought you saw the last of me!

This chapter isn't technically a part of the story — though it's all still “canon”, it's just a collection of ideas and concepts that were developed for this fic but never made it into the final text, in a commentary/not-fic format.

See the end of the chapter for [more notes](#)

Out of all the other heroes, Kori is probably the most chill about Tim being an android. Cyborg obviously also, and Beast Boy probably just finds Tim extremely cool (there's mutual fanboying going on). Diana just sees A BABY! Besides she's made of clay, why would she think less of someone made of metal??

Tim and Starfire bond over being socially very weird for humans, and regularly spend time together studying Human Culture (and sometimes also shit-talking Dick)

Jason: why the fuck did you become Robin after me??

Tim: Bruce needed a Robin

J: Bruce needed therapy

T: I was an artificial intelligence with the emotional capacity of a 10 year old, I could only provide one of those, Jay, and I calculated that was the best course of action.

J: you could've set him up with an appointment instead of spending half a year building the most advanced robot on earth!

T: ...

T: in my defense, I was left unsupervised

Tim, feeling rebellious: my middle name is DANGER

Jason: Your middle name is Jackson, I know because I came up with it, dumbass.

Each Robin is a self-contained entity. He doesn't have access to the entire internet or Bat databases at will unless he has an actual connection (so he has to plug in, connect to WiFi or be online with the mainframe). He also has, obviously, less processing power than Central

BatComputer AI Tim. Usually, when reception is good (read anywhere Bruce can help it) the two are permanently conjoined, and sync up data/memories in real-time. If the connection fails, or if BatComputer Tim can't share his processing power at the moment (like he's busy doing something for Bruce or something) Robin can function on his own and sync up later, either over a connection or via the black box being plugged into Central Terminal/uploaded.

Sometimes, this causes funny situations, because if you force a Robin to go offline somehow, he can absolutely argue with himself, but Robin usually ends up agreeing with AI Tim on the basis that the latter just Knows More because he objectively has More Information. Multiple Robins arguing, though? Can go on for hours.

Chatting with Tim is a peculiar thing, because he has like 5 different ways to reply to you and he *can* and *will* use all of them depending on what seems best. You just can't have one coherent chat history with him. He'll talk as the android, from the speakers, display on a screen, babble in your coms, hijack your phone and open your fridge, but you WILL see that funny meme or so help him god.

He could do almost all of it even before he got a body, he was just too mellow and polite to bother anyone with it. But YJ are enablers and Bart specifically is a bad influence :)

Compared to human technology, alien tech is significantly harder for Tim to hack or integrate to, especially the alive/semi-biological kind, which results in Cyborg being safe from Tim's cyber shenanigans (imagine if he wasn't, tho! Tim could display memes directly into Victor's brain). Given Cyborg canonically can take over any mechanical device, there's understandably some tension between them at the beginning, and just to be safe they never connect their circuits.

Tim tries to, but doesn't really care about not having Gotham Robin and California Robin and any other Robin out at the same time — mission efficiency takes priority. As such, Robin as a hero has a tendency to defy the laws of physics by appearing in many different places one after another in a very short time or even at the same time, and the leading Conspiracy Theory is that the moniker is currently held by a set of identical twins.

Whenever someone in the Batfam gets a brainfart:

Dick, stuttering mid-thought: Wait, what? I-what—

Everyone in the vicinity: noO WAIT TIM DON'T YOU DARE DO IT

Tim: *laughs and plays the Windows shutdown noise*

Jason: ... I'm gonna pull one of your wires

Sometimes Tim's wires get crossed (especially when Robins process locally or are disconnected). Not in a way that makes him endanger a mission (the incident with Not-An-Orb was the first instance of this happening), but try as you might, you can't create a perfect piece of machinery and Tim has brainfarts sometimes, much like humans do. Maybe it is a brief short-circuit or maybe some software malfunctions, or less-violent SEUs.

Either way, the effect is usually Tim responding with wildly out-of-context information and/or sentences making comically little sense. Like someone asks for a teammate's whereabouts, and Robin lists the breakfast menu for a cafe in Berlin. [This](#) gets sent out to all Titans in the Tower. Bruce unwittingly re-enacts [the "cactus scene" from the Good Place](#) with Tim (though about that one nobody's quite sure if Tim did it by accident, or on purpose just for shits and giggles).

Tim absolutely uses Windows pings as part of his jingle ensemble, as well as videogame sounds and soundtracks.

Imagine Kon saying something stupid and Tim just reacts with the [Windows error ping](#). Or Tim is doing something sus and Cassie walks in on him and he just goes [!!!](#) alert sound from Metal Gear.

Tim sometimes even provides *background music* for their fights.

(he also uses the [first notes of Megalovania](#) as "so you have chosen death"/"you're going to have a bad time" kind of meme reaction)

Tim *does* use a Vocaloid voice for some time at some point. Just decides one day he's going to sound like fucking Miku Hatsune, for no reason. That's it, that's the concept. Chaos ensues, YJ has the time of their lives, Bruce dies a little internally.

Tim follows the sumo robot community as a hobby. He finds it enjoyable to look at all the truly WILD tactics the builders try to come up with. He never built one himself, but he keeps a blueprint somewhere and updates it periodically to be able to — theoretically — win with any other known robot, kind of playing chess in his mind with all the other sumo robots out there.

Tim holding his own severed head, like an extra part or something, and delivering Hamlet's "Alas! Poor Yorick" monologue to it. Jason is both amused and (even him) slightly disturbed.

Tim registering for some online streaming service for the Titans and there's a "I'm not a robot" CAPTCHA and he stares at it for a hot second, then looks Bart in the eyes with a shit-

eating grin and checks it. Like [this](#)

Tim is not a fan of old buildings, because old elevators can work like Faraday cages and thus he loses connection once Robin walks into them

Visual algorithms are generally rather bad, like they can't tell a dune and a nude apart because the colours and shapes match, so imagine Tim in the early days. Dick trolls him with pictures of blueberry muffins and chihuahuas' faces that look exactly the same to Tim. Dick convinces Tim that photos of a desert are actually porn. The like.

For the longest while, before Steph is let in on the secret that Robin is a robot, but when she's already close with Tim — she is convinced they're dating because of how loosely Tim uses the term "love".

And then when she learns about everything, she's not even mad, she finds it absolutely fucking *hilarious*. Tim is just a little confused, because he *does* love her! And everyone else too!

(unused piece of a scene)

The explosion sends him flying over the edge of the bridge and he closes his eyes, not wanting to record the fall. When after five more seconds his sensors still don't register hitting the water, Robin dares to open his eyes.

"Got'cha," Cassie says, holding him like a ragdoll by one of his ankles. She must've caught him mid-flight.

"I'm pretty sure that my hip would be dislocated after a stunt like this if I was a human," Robin notes.

"It's good that you aren't then," she replies, and they start laughing, because somehow, finally, everything feels ridiculous instead of stressful.

While one might attempt to play some card games with Tim, since some are based on randomness, there is absolutely no way to win a game of poker with Tim. He can count the cards, calculate probability, precisely control his facial expressions and read people like open books.

Tim, who has existed for a good couple of years now: I'm not a baby I can protect myself just fine, besides my security was designed by Batman

Babs, giving him Baby Blanket Protocol security program as a present: shut up and run the code

Tim, who fears only two people, and that is Alfred and Barbara: ... Yes ma'am

Tim: closest thing to the smartest thing on Earth

Everyone, immediately upon being introduced to him: baby, must protect

Tim is so pissed at everyone wanting to protect Robin on the field at all costs. He's expendable! They're not!!!

Bart: gets injured while sweeping Robin away from danger

Robin, holding Bart's field snacks to the side of his head: what are you

Bart: an idiot sandwich.

Tim, coming to a realisation: Oh no, I made myself **too** cute

Tim's various undercover personas actually are separate, specifically-designed bodies, not just disguises. There is a droid that looks like a young girl that serves as Caroline Hill, etc.

Tim insists that the categories simply do not apply to him, but if pressed, would define himself as an asexual panromantic cis male. He isn't entirely sure how to explain how he experiences the concept of *gender* when he essentially is just a ghost in the machine, a digital equivalent of a brain in a jar, but he's never thought about himself as anything other than a boy and he definitely was 'assigned male' at 'birth'.

After they've watched Ghost In The Shell and Tim saw [Tachikomas](#), Bruce caught him designing his own, physically-plausible version of a remotely-controlled city spider-tank.

Tim argued that it's not much different than the armoured Batmobile, but it fell on deaf ears. He was made to promise that he would not build any, though he did get to keep the blueprints.

In this AU [Brother Eye](#) — the AI that was supposed to monitor every hero with the use of a hyper-advanced satellite and disable anyone who would pose a danger by making them a

mindless drone via nanobots, but of course it went rogue — never happens because Tim takes one look at the idea and goes "B, I'm here and *only* have the BatCave and a few Robins at my disposal and you still have barely *any* control over what I do, what do you think would happen if you made another me, but with none of the charming personality and human attachment, and then sent it into space with an army of nanobots???"

While magicked into a human, Tim has a really hard time with flavors and smells, as those are the only senses he hadn't experienced before. On one hand, he hates both, because suddenly everything has a new quality and it's all overwhelming and weird, but on the other, his brand-new toddler brain can't help but attempt to taste and sniff everything in his vicinity. It takes a lot of willpower not to lick the floor and the like.

That being said, cursed thought of the day is: Tim having to poop for the first time while being human.

In canon, Tim is known to be a serial napper instead of pulling 4-day no-sleep binges like most fanon likes to portray him. Since AI Tim just turns Robins to idle/hibernation when they're not in use, Robin comes off as a serial napper in this AU too. Once he's done talking to you, he'll sit on a chair and just doze off.

Without Bruce's approval, Tim took down the plaque on Jason's Robin costume case that said "Good Soldier". When B brought it up, he asked him the question he knew Jay would ask — "is that all he was to you, Bruce?"

Ever since there's no plaque, just the book they've read together last, and a photo of Bruce and Jason on his first day of school after joining the Wayne family.

Jason still looks at it with a broken heart when he first enters the BatCave, but it's when he has a half-dead Tim in his arms so he doesn't get to brood.

Bruce takes it down, much like Tim turns off GNU Jason Todd, not long after.

Tim's connected to the internet 24/7 so he has a big presence online and three dozens of handles he operates under. He's a moderator on two separate conspiracy theory boards and the leading supporter of "Bruce Wayne is Batman Because The Butts Match" theory, just for shits and giggles. He also has a Chirper (Twitter) account where he posts cute animals hourly (it started as a study of the concept of cuteness, but stayed as a hobby) and an Instagram for his artsy photos.

Chapter End Notes

Anyone is free to grab any of these and use it to make their own story - either in this AU, or as something new.

End Notes

Reiterating from beginning notes:

IMPORTANT: I am very grateful for all you people wanting to add this work to your favourite collections, but due to how Collections work on Ao3, I will **not be accepting any collection requests**. Please bookmark instead, and add the bookmark to your collection.

Thank you!

The theme song for this fic is ["be human" by Scott Matthew](#)

The theme video for this fic is [this one from Tom Scott](#).

If you wanna say hi or talk with me, you can find me over on [Tumblr](#) :)

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